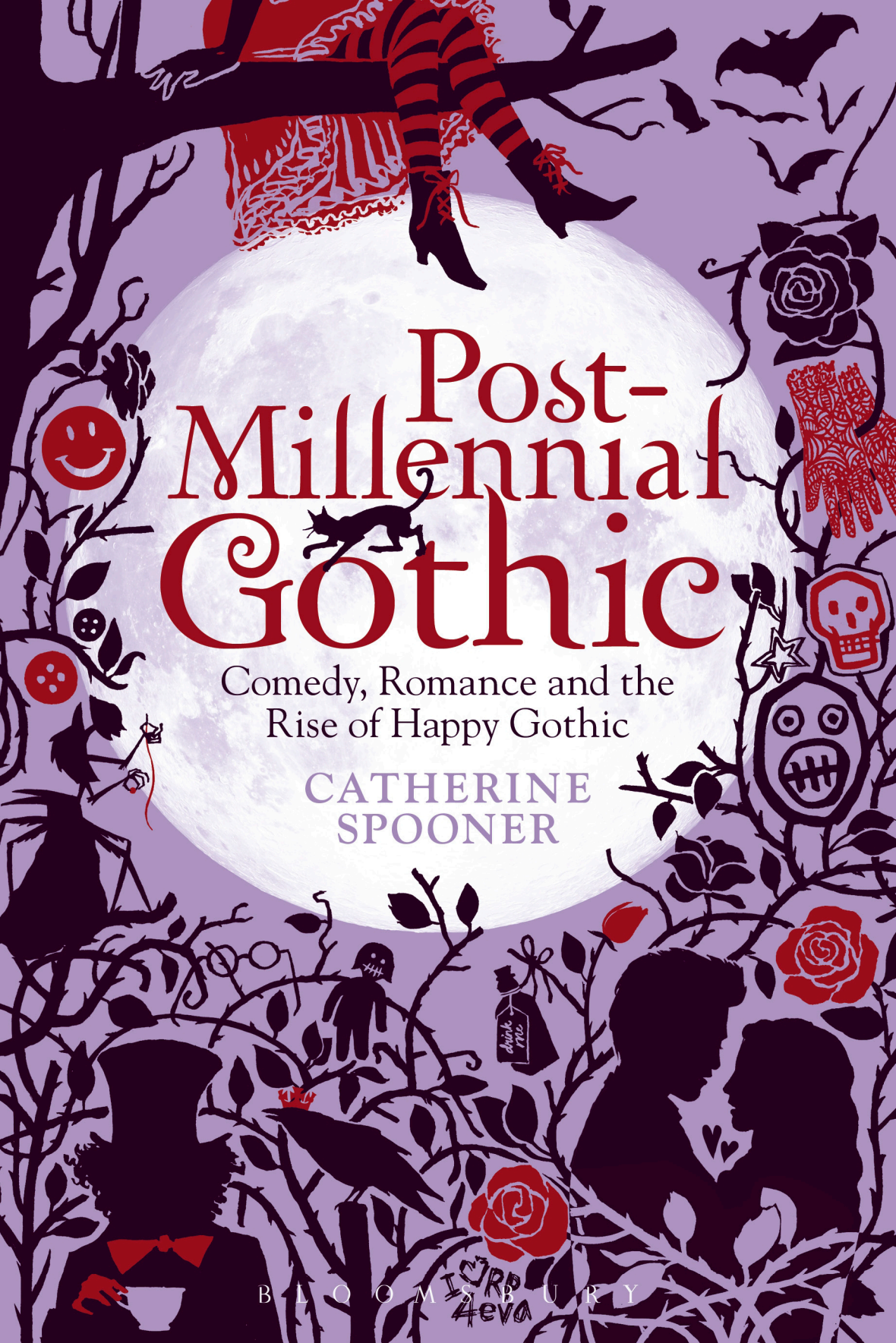
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Comedy, Romance and the Rise of Happy Gothic
CATHERINE SPOONER
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Post-Millennial Gothic

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Catherine Spooner

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For Gabriel and Jago

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Introduction: Post-Millennial Gothic

Now it is autumn. I have settled in to the gloomy, doom-laden, chintzy Gothic atmosphere of the place.
And I love it.

Paul Magrs, *Never the Bride*, 2006: 1

Gothic summer

Prime Minister David Cameron referred to the summer of 2012 as Britain's 'golden summer', a time in which national pride generated by the successes of the London Olympics would live long in the memory (Lister 2012). But the summer of 2012 was also, when viewed from the perspective of popular culture, a Gothic summer. It was bracketed by two major movie releases from the film director Tim Burton – *Dark Shadows* in May, and *Frankenweenie* in October. The latter was closely accompanied by two other pieces of big-budget animation aimed at children, *Paranorman* and *Hotel Transylvania*. Anticipation also mounted for the cinema release of the final part of Stephenie Meyer's *Twilight* saga, *Breaking Dawn Part 2*, while Christopher Nolan's final instalment in his Batman trilogy, *The Dark Knight Rises*, opened in July to become the third-highest grossing film of the year worldwide (*Box Office Mojo*). On television, Gothic-themed shows were hard to escape, with well-established series such as *True Blood, The Vampire Diaries*, *The Walking Dead*, *American Horror Story* and *Supernatural* all entering new seasons. Meanwhile in the multi-billion pound world of children's toys, Bratz dolls released their 'Bratzillaz' range, a riposte to rival company Mattel's 'Monster High', while Lego's big launch was 'Monster Fighters', featuring a band of Steampunk-styled adventurers pursuing zombies, vampires, werewolves, Frankenstein's Creature and the monster from the Black

Lagoon through a variety of spooky sets. Fashion magazines heralded the return of Gothic romance yet again in the autumn/winter season, this time with a Pre-Raphaelite inflection, and featured stars including Keira Knightley and the cast of international hit *Downton Abbey* in Gothic-inspired photo shoots. In the world of modern art, the big story was Damian Hirst's first major retrospective at London's Tate Modern, his obsession with *memento mori* possessing obvious resonance with the Gothic. Finally, the very Olympics opening and closing ceremonies that sealed Cameron's 'golden summer', watched by almost a billion viewers across the globe, featured sequences drawing on explicitly Gothic imagery, as the NHS was menaced by iconic villains of children's literature, and Annie Lennox sang *Little Bird* dressed as a vampire, from the prow of a skeletal black ship.

What was going on? While I have selected 2012 because its use of Gothic in the global spectacle of the Olympics was so striking (and which I will return to in the conclusion to this book), almost any summer this century could be read in a similar way. Gothic, it seems, has never been so popular. Despite 1990s commentators' attempts to link a rise in Gothic imagery with *fin-de-siècle* malaise and, more specifically, the approach of the millennium, Gothic did not disappear after the turn of the century. Critics' attempts to announce horror dead in the aftermath of the attacks on the World Trade Centre's Twin Towers on 11 September 2001 also proved premature (see Briefel and Miller 2012: 1). Gothic narratives, artefacts, products and images continued to hold Western audiences' attention in the new millennium, and, indeed, increased their range and impact, moving far beyond the niche interests of horror fans to become the stuff of the mainstream: on sale in Topshop and Toys R Us, broadcast to almost a billion people worldwide at the London Olympics. Between 2001 and 2010, British consumers' spending on Hallowe'en-related products rose from £12 million to £280 million, with Hallowe'en overtaking Valentine's Day to become the third most lucrative festival in the United Kingdom, after Christmas and Easter (Morton 2012: 62). Gothic also appeared to be increasingly legitimated by the cultural and educational establishment. Major exhibitions with a Gothic theme took place at the Tate Gallery (2006), the Fashion Institute of Technology, New York (2008–9) and the British Library (2013–14), while the British Film Institute ran a four-month season, its largest hitherto on any topic, of Gothic cinema in 2012–13. Gothic literature featured prominently on British A-level syllabuses, while new Gothic series and companions were issued from most of the major British academic presses, reflecting its near-ubiquitous presence in one form or another on English Literature degree programmes.

Yet Gothic did not, in the summer of 2012, perform the kind of function that culturally savvy audiences might have come to expect. It is important to resist the notion that Gothic represents the dark side of Cameron's 'golden summer', a counterpoint to the feelgood message that the Olympic games provided in times of global economic crisis and looming environmental disaster. Gothic is not a stable discourse; it is flexible and mobile and can convey different political messages at different times. No doubt Gothic imagery can be used to critique Cameron's Conservative government: former Chancellor of the Exchequer George Osborne was regularly represented by satirical cartoonists as a vampire, and appeared on the cover of the *Guardian*'s weekend magazine photoshopped to look like Tim Burton's Edward Scissorhands, a comment on his scissor-happy approach to public spending (Lanchester 2010). But Gothic was also part of the 'golden summer'; Gothic texts partook of the celebratory mood. To speak more broadly, in the twenty-first century, Gothic texts, products, imagery and artefacts can no longer be regarded as almost universally gloomy and miserable, or even scary and horrid. There are a growing number of Gothic texts that are distinctly celebratory in tone, which hybridize Gothic with comedy or romance, or which convert Gothic to lifestyle. Contemporary Gothic can increasingly be described as comic, romantic, celebratory, gleeful, whimsical or even joyous.

Academic approaches to contemporary Gothic nevertheless have a tendency to link it to trauma or cultural anxiety, in line with a tendency identified by Chris Baldick and Robert Mighall (2012) in Gothic criticism more generally, in which Gothic is understood as a means for Western society's fears to be worked through. Indeed, there are many contemporary Gothic texts that invite this reading, and many rich and sophisticated critical analyses of them in these terms. Texts and artefacts that do not obviously fit this reading, however, are less well served by Gothic criticism. To collate and address these works, I have coined the umbrella term of 'happy Gothic', a phrase that is intended to be capacious and cover a broad variety of media and inflections of mood. Working from the *Oxford English Dictionary* definition of 'Deep pleasure in, or contentment with, one's circumstances', this book uses 'happy' as a mobile, oppositional term that groups together a range of positively inclined emotions or moods that are unexpected in conventional Gothic critical discourse.

Since the publication of David Punter's *The Literature of Terror* in 1980 and the growth of Gothic studies as an academic discipline, there has been much scholarly investment in restoring Gothic to the canon, or indeed, creating a new canon of key Gothic works. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* is the quintessential example – regarded as a curio of popular culture and unlikely to have featured

on university syllabi prior to the 1980s, it has now generated a vast body of criticism, and is routinely taught to British sixth-formers studying English literature. Within Gothic studies itself, certain texts have become central to scholarly discussion, from Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) to Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000). While canon formation is an inevitable result of the focus of critical attention onto hitherto neglected areas of literature, and helps to consolidate new fields of study as well as challenge pre-existing canons, it just as inevitably constructs new principles of inclusion and exclusion. What particularly interests me in this book is what remains on the fringes of this new canon, what is left out. What are we to do with objects, texts and phenomena that are in some degree marked with the term 'Gothic' but do not conveniently fit accepted critical patterns and narratives? What sort of language or critical vocabulary can we use to make sense of Gothic as it appears in such venues as home makeover shows, high street fashion, young adult romance fiction, confectionery or advertising?

These cultural products often partake of a popular or 'debased' form of Gothic that, with a few honourable exceptions, is either tactfully ignored by critics or dismissed as lacking integrity: 'Sellout Gothic'; 'Gothic Lite'; a watered-down version of an original, more authentic Gothic culture. But we ignore these seemingly transient and insubstantial reiterations of Gothic at our peril. The limits of Gothic, the trashy, rehashed and opportunistic renderings of its narratives and aesthetics in contemporary consumer culture, may in fact tell us as much about what Gothic is or does, the work it performs in our culture, as those works of literature or cinema validated by the patina of history or by widespread critical acclaim.

Post-millennial Gothic

Post-millennial Gothic is a deliberately provocative title. It might seem premature to be calling anything post-millennial, only a little over a decade into the third millennium at the time of writing. What does it mean to be post-millennial? On the most basic level the prefix 'post' simply means 'after': after the millennium. The neologism is, however, intended to echo its obvious counterpart: pre-millennial. Before New Year's Eve, 1999, there was much media hype about so-called pre-millennial tension – cultural anxiety fixated on fears of social and technological collapse. Foremost object of fear was the 'Millennium Bug': the technical fault that would apparently cause computers' clocks to revert

to zero once they reached midnight, 31 December 1999, therefore causing mass technological breakdown and anticipated nuclear catastrophe. In the event, of course, the crisis never happened. Millennium Eve passed off without major incident across the globe. The coming of the millennium, sold to the world's population as the ultimate crisis, the end of history, turned out to be an anti-climax. The millennium was an anti-crisis, a crisis that never happened.

On the other hand, if Millennium Eve did not, in the end, mean crisis then other historical events around the same time did. The years immediately succeeding the millennium produced what might be construed as an excess of crisis, as a series of news stories predicted global disaster. Reports of SARS, avian flu, global warming, the war on terror, economic breakdown, all contributed to a cultural climate in which the threat of annihilation constantly appeared to be shadowing the human race. The palaeontologist Stephen Jay Gould argues that the periodization of history should not be pinned precisely to the arbitrary divisions of clock time, but rather to historical events that signal change. He writes,

> Many commentators have stated – quite correctly in my view – that the twentieth century did not truly begin in 1900 or 1901, by any standard of historical continuity, but rather at the end of World War I, the great shatterer of illusions about progress and human betterment … I suspect that future chroniclers will date the inception of the third millennium from September 11, 2001. (2002: xiii)

The shadow of 9/11 inevitably falls over the beginning of the new millennium, and there has been a good deal of discussion of how the 'war on terror' might be said to have shifted fictional and cinematic paradigms for the representation of terror (Briefel and Miller 2012; Wetmore 2012; Höglund 2014). Rather than a clear epistemological break, however, I would rather propose a cluster of historical events around the end of the 1990s that combined to create a series of shifts in Gothic sensibilities in Britain and America. Alongside Millennium Eve and 11 September 2001, the death of Diana, Princess of Wales, on 31 August 1997 was significant for the way that it triggered a hysterical outpouring of public grief, changing the way in which rituals of death, mourning and remembrance were carried out in modern Britain. The event to have the most impact on the rise of 'happy Gothic', however, was the Columbine High School shootings in Denver, Colorado, on 20 April 1999. The massacre of twelve of their classmates and a teacher by Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold did not only enable a Gothic tale of teenagers as monsters and victims to play out in the world's media; it

also, via erroneous American media links between the killers and Goth subculture, forced Goths to defend and publically reposition their subculture on a global stage.

In the 1990s, broadsheet newspapers and glossy fashion magazines repeatedly noted the rise of Gothic, influencing the worlds of fashion, fine art, film, and, of course, fiction. The pre-millennial sensibility seemed a particularly Gothic one. Christoph Grunenberg, one of the most persuasive commentators on the subject, wrote in 1997,

> As the end of the millennium approaches, the fascination with the dark side of the human imagination is once again rampant, indicating a full-blown resurgence of a 'Gothic' sensibility in contemporary art and culture … We are living in particularly dire times – in a Gothic period of fear, horror, moral disintegration, and indulgence in perverse pleasures. 'Gothic' has become the *quid pro quo* for somber and disturbing moods, sites, events and cultural by-products of latter-day America. (211–10; pagination runs backwards in this volume)

Grunenberg's statement poses some interesting questions. If Gothic is particularly associated with *fins de siècles*, with the pre-millennium, then what happens to it after the millennium? Does it continue the priorities and preoccupations of the 1990s, or does it change? Here I hope it will become fully clear why I am using the term 'post-millennial Gothic'. Just as the more familiar term 'postmodernism' may be used to signify a continuation of modernism or a break from it, 'post-millennial' may refer to a continuation of pre-millennial discourse or a repudiation of it – possibly both at the same time. Post-millennial Gothic demonstrates in some cases a continued preoccupation with the imminent destruction of the world as we know it, but also, in others, a significant change of mood to one of comedy or romance. This ambiguity, or ambivalence, will inform my reading of twenty-first-century Gothic as a mobile and sometimes contradictory discursive site.

Gothic in crisis

According to Fred Botting, contemporary Gothic is itself undergoing a kind of crisis. Implicitly drawing on Fredric Jameson's description of Gothic as 'that boring and exhausted paradigm' (2000: 289), Botting argues that in contemporary culture, Gothic is endlessly recycled but has lost its power of affect:

> A sense of cultural exhaustion haunts the present. An inhuman future is shrouded in old Gothic trappings emptied of any strong charge; past images

> and forms are worn too thin to veil the gaping black hole of objectless anxiety. Gothic fiction, which served as earlier modernity's black hole and has served up a range of objects and figures crystallizing anxiety into fear, has become too familiar after two centuries of repetitive mutation and seems incapable of shocking anew. Inured to Gothic shocks and terrors, contemporary culture recycles its images in the hope of finding a charge intense enough to stave off the black hole within and without, the one opened up by postmodernist fragmentation and plurality. Gothic figures, once giving form to the anxieties surrounding the transition from aristocratic to bourgeois culture, now disclose only the formlessness, the consuming void, underlying the flickering thrills of contemporary western simulations. Since they seem unable to envisage a future that is not finally cloaked in darkness, the only projections to be made offer us a weary and ominously doom-laden view. (Botting 2002: 298)

In other words, for Botting, contemporary culture is marked by a sense of exhaustion, and this has also become a defining feature of Gothic. In his estimation, Gothic is now overfamiliar and has lost its power to shock; its use is mainly aesthetic. It once served to convey specific cultural anxieties linked to the emergence of capitalism and bourgeois identity but can now only reveal generalized anxiety linked to the endless recycling of images and the absence of meaning that underlies it. For Botting, Gothic fictions can no longer offer a progressive vision of the future once the shackles of the barbaric past have been thrown off, as no future can be imagined beyond this morbid recirculation of images and effects.

Botting has put forward a similar claim in a variety of different publications, culminating in the monograph *Limits of Horror: Technology, Bodies, Gothic* (2008b). It is a richly explored and persuasive argument, but one that does not adequately account for the complexities of the post-millennial texts explored in this book, which as I have already suggested, are not anxious and do not, in the main, aim to shock or scare but are playful or even celebratory in tone. For Botting, the incorporation of the monstrous into the normal results in the flattening out of the cultural field, the dissolution of difference, so that 'identity and difference, norm and monster become indistinguishable in a proliferation of differentiations and hybrids' (2008b: 10). In such a scenario, it might be added, the alternative becomes indistinguishable from the mainstream and subcultural resistance becomes impossible, a problem I will return to in Chapters 3 and 4. In his figuring of postmodern Gothic as decline, Botting occupies a position of nostalgia, suggestively yearning for a time that once possessed more meaning and authenticity than the present: 'Beyond transgression all the paraphernalia of

Gothic modernity change: the uncanny is not where it used to be, nor are ghosts, doubles, monsters and vampires' (2008: 11). The phrasing is suggestive: the uncanny is not where it used to be, or not what it used to be? This book agrees that Gothic is no longer where it used to be, but rather than lament its passing, seeks to map its new territories.

Botting by no means dismisses popular cultural texts – however weary and overfamiliar – as unworthy of critical attention. Nevertheless, a similar stance figuring contemporary Gothic as decline plays out in a variety of other kinds of criticism, often resulting explicitly in boundary policing. Through this process a core of authentically Gothic texts are protected against the incursions of a popular discourse that is often problematically associated with women's culture, therefore implicitly defending the intellectual credibility of an emerging discipline. For Maria Beville, for example, *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* and *Interview with the Vampire* are only superficially Gothic, being founded merely on 'stylistic conventions', and fail to engage 'the true Gothic aesthetic' which she explicitly associates with the sublime and the production of terror (2009: 9, 36). A handful of hero texts by critically acclaimed, male writers (Paul Auster, Kurt Vonnegut, Salman Rushdie, Mikhail Bulgakov, Bret Easton Ellis) become Beville's standard bearers for the continuation of an authentic Gothic in the present.

The association between women's culture and a debased or diluted form of Gothic is made yet more explicit in a comic piece by journalist Stuart Heritage that appeared in the *Guardian* in 2012, discussing the fashion for vampires on film and television:

> Twilight's biggest crime – bigger than getting away with having a soggily submissive female as its lead character, bigger even than making grown women refer to themselves as 'Team Jacob' without any trace of shame or irony – is what it's done to the undead. People used to be scared of the undead. Vampires used to frighten the hell out of people. They lived in castles. They constantly adhered to an intimidatingly formal dress code. They turned into bats, for crying out loud … But now vampires are little more than sensitive glittery emo types who enjoy poetry and actually like people. It's a disgrace. (Heritage 2012)

The article is a piece of light journalism, intended to amuse, and it is tempting not to take it too seriously. However, this kind of glib dismissal is a new iteration of what critics, especially male critics, have always done to women's culture, which is typically placed at the bottom of hierarchies of cultural value. Moreover, the kind of things enjoyed by *young* women in particular have often been ranked lowest of all. Frequently, this is linked not to the literary or cinematic qualities

of the texts themselves, but to their presumed effect on their female readers. What Heritage mocks about *Twilight* is not the quality of its writing or plotting, but rather the depiction of its lead female character and, most significantly, the behaviour of its female fans. He goes on to make much the same kind of judgement about the fans of the vampire TV series *True Blood*:

> Although I've never really been a fan, I've nevertheless tried to watch it whenever I could because other people insist that it's worthwhile. Admittedly, most of those people have been women who dress their cats up as butlers and have Tumblr sites called things like Elysian Moonquaver, and only watch True Blood because there are topless men in it and it's marginally less embarrassing than admitting to liking Twilight, but that's by the by. (Heritage 2012)

He therefore implicitly suggests that there is a 'proper' way for 'grown women' to behave that does not involve lusting over fictional Native American werewolves or putting costumes on their domestic pets. What 'grown women' are principally being chastised for are unruly, excessive displays of desire.

Heritage replays in a popular register the emphasis on safeguarding an original, authentic and frightening Gothic from both a younger generation ('sensitive glittery Emo types') and a female audience ('grown women') who fails to understand it, dilutes its affectivity and converts its meaning in inappropriate ways. As such, Heritage unconsciously repeats a critical attitude to the Gothic that dates back at least two centuries. Late-eighteenth- and early-nineteenth-century critics of the Gothic novel suggested that reading these books filled young women's heads with improbable imaginings and distracted them from their duties as wives, mothers and daughters. A reviewer calling himself W. W., for example, wrote in 1802 that 'the female mind is more readily affected by the *tendency* of such works' and went on to suggest that the 'extravagant degree of love' that such novels encourage can even precipitate its young female readers into insanity – not so different, perhaps, from the accusations of hysteria levelled at *Twilight* fans (W.W. [1802]2000: 212). Many of the materials I will explore in this book – fashion, vampire romance, young adult fiction, dolls, makeover shows – are associated particularly with young female audiences and consumers, or in some cases with a camp, queer aesthetic. Taking them seriously is also about taking seriously these marginalized audiences and allowing their tastes to help shape the Gothic canon.

In order to fully appreciate the multivalent meanings of Gothic in twenty-first-century culture, it is necessary to stop thinking of Gothic as a once clearly defined genre which has suffered dilution or decline. Throughout its history,

Gothic has adapted and changed with the times and it is unclear why this process should now end. After Gothic's initial phase of popularity fizzled out around 1820, it quickly renewed itself in the form of penny dreadfuls, the ghost story and the sensation novel. Many of these forms were, significantly, derided as weakened, recycled versions of more vigorous originals. Gothic is relentlessly adaptive and will continue to find new outlets and hybrid forms. This book operates under the premise that it is less interesting to investigate what Gothic *is* than what it *does*: what different sets of writers, directors, readers and audiences make it mean in different locations and historical periods. It follows Alexandra Warwick's proposition that '[i]n the reading of a text … it is unproductive to work towards identifying it as Gothic, or identifying Gothic elements in an act of critical closure' (2007: 7). For Warwick, Gothic studies remains mired in 'subject/object confusion' in which Gothic criticism is caught between the structuralist proposition that meaning inheres in its object and the post-structuralist emphasis on meaning as open and constructed (9). As she stresses, 'Gothic criticism pretends that Gothic is inherent in its object and thus the relation between criticism and literature returns to being one of transparency and objectivity in which the texts themselves are coerced into becoming allegories of Gothic critical practice' (9). This book does not assume that Gothic is inherent in its object: the texts chosen here are ones that critics, journalists, advertisers, readers, viewers and participants have designated as Gothic – or as Goth, a distinction that I will come to in a moment. In some cases (such as comedian Andrew O'Neill, covered in Chapter 7) writers or performers may even refuse the Gothic/Goth label even as they engage with and discuss it.

Rather than checking off a list of features to pronounce whether or not a text is Gothic, then, this book asks how the term Gothic is being put to work in any given context, suggesting that the attempt to identify and describe the Gothic object has resulted in the exclusion of certain kinds of Gothic texts. It will argue that in the twenty-first century, Gothic is increasingly recognized and understood in visual terms that do not fully coincide with conventional literary definitions of Gothic and, in Chapter 2, attempts to map what these might be. In doing so, it will insist on Gothic as a discourse that is tied to historical processes and works differently at different times and in different locations. According to Robert Mighall,

> The Gothic is a process, not an essence; a rhetoric rather than a store of universal symbols … Epochs, institutions, people and places are Gothicized, have the Gothic thrust upon them. That which is Gothicized depends on history and the stories it needs to tell itself. (1999: xxv)

To extrapolate from Mighall's statement, this book poses the question: what stories does the twenty-first century need to tell itself?

Culture of fear

The persistence of Gothic in contemporary culture is often attributed to its particular suitability as a medium for the expression of cultural and social anxiety. This takes two related but subtly different forms. In the first of these, Gothic provides a kind of vocabulary or rhetoric through which fear can be produced and exploited for a variety of ideological ends. For Mark Edmundson, for instance,

> the conventions of Gothic horror are making their way into, and decisively shaping, many apparently nonfictional forms. On broadcast news, in the most respected daily papers, on TV talk shows, in our modes of therapy … in our medical and environmental discourses, and even in advanced brands of intellectual analysis, the Gothic mode is ascendant. Not only do the '90s media seem to seek out Gothic tales to bring to the center of cultural consciousness, they also sometimes rework events until they assume the proper Gothic shape. (1997: 5–6)

Edmundson goes on to analyse, for example, the Oprah Winfrey Show and the reporting of the O. J. Simpson trial in Gothic terms. Similarly, Edward J. Ingebretsen in *At Stake* explores how 'the ad hoc creation of monsters as agents of moralized fear' in political, media and religious discourse in the United States articulates a range of cultural traumas (2001: 4).

Secondly, and more pervasively, Gothic criticism has embraced the idea that Gothic texts offer a means of reflecting, expressing or processing already existing anxieties and traumas in the 'real' world. In their polemical essay on 'Gothic Criticism' ([2000]2012), Chris Baldick and Robert Mighall demonstrate how what they term the 'anxiety model', first introduced into Gothic criticism in the 1980s, tends to shore up the critic's own enlightened modernity and produce Gothic itself as a privileged agent of subversion, 'the favourite wicked uncle of counter-cultural rebellion' (269). As Baldick and Mighall point out, Gothic is perhaps the least reliable index of cultural anxiety, as its '*generic obligation*' is to be scary (280; italics in original). Indeed, a Google ngram, which surveys every online document for every instance of a given word, demonstrates that usage of the word 'Gothic' tends to fall during times of major international conflict,

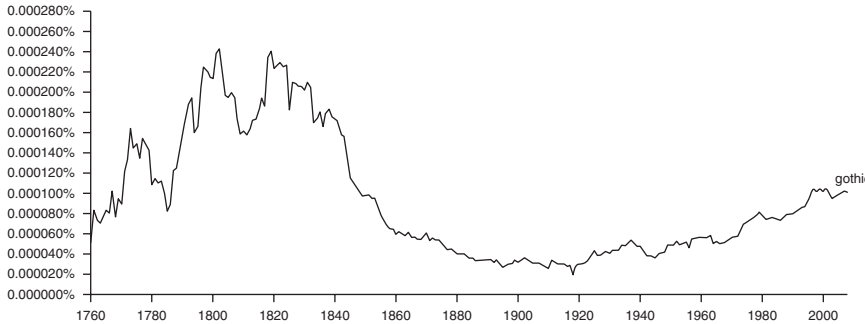

Figure 0.1. *Google ngram showing usage of the word gothic in English-language texts between 1760 and 2008.*
*Note***:** *Significant dips in usage during the Terror, the Napoleonic wars, the First and Second World Wars and immediately following 11 September 2001.*

suggesting that Gothic cannot be mapped directly onto social anxiety in any straightforward way (Figure 0.1).

Alexandra Warwick, on the other hand, turns the anxiety model on its head, suggesting not that Gothic fiction enables Western readers to deal with cultural crisis or social anxiety, but rather that it enables us to manufacture a crisis that we profoundly desire. Pointing to the proliferation of 'misery memoirs', she argues provocatively that the contemporary condition is characterized by a craving for trauma, as trauma is perceived as validating our unique sense of self:

> I would argue that contemporary cultural Gothic is a staging of the desire *for* trauma, the desire to be haunted, because we do not feel complete without it. It is a paradoxical reversion of that which is arguably at the core of eighteenth-century Gothic, the anxiety of fragmentation that threatens the fantasy of the integrated Enlightenment subject. In the contemporary experience the anxiety is not of fragmentation, but of wholeness, the sense that subjectivity is in fact not complete *unless* it has been in some way damaged. (2007: 12)

For Warwick, the proliferation of Gothic tropes through contemporary culture is symptomatic of a culture in which '[n]ormality is Gothic and Gothic is normal' (14). Gothic is everywhere; it is both continual crisis and no crisis at all.

Indeed, post-millennial Gothic texts are often suspicious of the 'anxiety model' and work to challenge or satirize it. Bret Easton Ellis's *Lunar Park* (2005) describes how Jayne, the film star wife of the main character (a fictional version

of Ellis himself), moves to a suburban Mcmansion in response to multiple nebulous fears:

> Jayne had moved out of Los Angeles and into the anonymous suburbia of the Northeast … safely distant from what she saw as the increasing horror of urban life. The attack on the World Trade Center [*sic*] and the Pentagon was the initial motivation, and Jayne briefly considered some exotically remote place deep in the Southwest or the vastness of the heartland, but her goal eventually simplified itself into moving at least two hours away from any large city, since that's where suicide bombers were blowing themselves up in crowded Burger Kings and Starbucks and Wal-Marts and in subways at rush hour … Jayne wanted to raise gifted, disciplined children, driven to succeed, but she was fearful of just about everything: the threat of pedophiles [*sic*], bacteria, SUVs (we owned one), guns, pornography and rap music, refined sugar, ultraviolet rays, terrorists, ourselves. (Ellis [2005]2006: 40–41)

In this passage, 9/11 is the 'initial motivation' for Jayne's self-imposed exile to suburbia, but this specific crisis soon becomes displaced into a wider network of fears in which 'terrorists', 'rap music' and 'refined sugar' are listed as equivalent threats. The passage deliberately parodies the inflated rhetoric of the American news media: suicide bombers are not, as suggested here, blowing themselves up in the crowded consumer outlets of major American cities on a regular basis, but the threat is constructed as general and imminent, as well as specifically targeting the icons of globalized consumption. In a vivid illustration of what Baldick and Mighall term 'fear and trembling in the bourgeois psyche', Ellis suggests that middle-class ambition – the desire to raise gifted, driven, successful children – is the reverse side of obsessive cultural anxiety and even implicitly produces it (Baldick and Mighall 2012: 279). Finally and crucially, Ellis ends his list of threats with 'ourselves': a moment of dramatic irony as it will later transpire that Ellis is the horror in his own house, but also a self-reflexive gesture to the self-created nature of the culture of fear.

A related point is made in Ben Aaronovitch's urban fantasy novel *Rivers of London* (2011). Following a riot initiated by supernatural causes,

> Nobody had a clue what had happened, so the pundits were out in force explaining how the riot was caused by whatever socio-political factor their latest book was pushing. It was certainly a searing indictment of some aspect of modern society – if only we knew what. (350–51)

Here, the media attempts to explain horror by resorting to social anxiety models, when it is actually a vampire ghost in the form of the puppet Mr Punch who

is provoking the violence. Aaronovitch satirizes the critical tendency to rationalize the supernatural and the ideologically motivated nature of such criticism, reclaiming the horror of the supernatural for its own sake. As these texts demonstrate, contemporary writers are thoroughly self-conscious about the critical links between Gothic and social anxiety and exploit it for their own sophisticated ends.

Nevertheless, the anxiety model persists in contemporary Gothic studies. It has become the *de facto* explanation for the persistent popularity of the Gothic, and permeates popular media accounts and academic criticism alike. More specifically, the twenty-first century has been marked by the rise of interest in trauma and its manifestation in literary texts. Trauma theory has provided a more theoretically sophisticated means of talking about cultural anxiety, one in which psychic disturbance is imbricated with social problems. The political valences of Gothic are freshly enhanced, stressing its capacity for commenting on the world's ills and providing a means for what Linnie Blake describes as 'the anxiety engendered by trauma' to be worked through by audiences (2008: 2).

Blake's book, *The Wounds of Nations: Horror Cinema, Historical Trauma and National Identity*, is among the most convincing and persuasive examples of this stance in twenty-first-century criticism. In it she argues that 'horror cinema is ideally positioned to expose the psychological, social and cultural ramifications of the ideologically expedient will to "bind up the nation's wounds" that is promulgated by all aspects of the culture industry in post-traumatic contexts' (2). Blake's theoretical model enables a nuanced understanding of the way horror texts both inhibit and enable the communication of trauma, and notably, she uses the term 'horror' rather than 'Gothic', a significant distinction.[1] Across the field more widely, these kinds of nuances are often overlooked to feed a popular conflation of Gothic/horror and social anxiety. A strap-line for an opinion piece in the *Guardian*, for example, is typical when it states that 'Horror films offer an inventive filter for our real anxieties – which may explain the genre's current renaissance' (Brooks 2010). This 'vulgar', pop psychological reading of horror supports the news media's insatiable demand for negative stories; it also reflects a current intellectual climate particularly affecting British universities but symptomatic to a degree of the contemporary academy more generally. The critical preoccupation with anxiety is itself historically and ideologically inflected, and as such has determined the ways in which Gothic has been defined within the academy.

The critical works I have cited here are sophisticated and important ones that add considerably to our understanding of Gothic discursive structures. Collectively, however, the rush to embrace anxiety and trauma within Gothic criticism is symptomatic of a broader crisis in the humanities. As Stefan Collini

demonstrates, since the mid-twentieth century formulation of the term 'humanities' as a collective label for academic subjects addressing human culture, 'discourse about the humanities … has been largely reactive and has thus tended to have a defensive or vindicatory edge to it' and thus 'the humanities turn out to be almost always in "crisis" ' (2012: 63). This crisis has reached new levels of urgency in the twenty-first century: the old notion of the humanities as a means of ennobling the human subject is under threat in an age that values vocational training, transferable skills and research outcomes with a measurable social and economic impact. The humanities are increasingly pressed to prove their utility, whether expressed in economic terms – stimulating the culture industries – or moral ones – creating well-rounded human beings and cultivating active citizenship. If it is difficult to defend the study of literature in this age, it is even more difficult to defend studying Gothic, with its disreputable associations and its belated entry to the canon. Lingering adherences to traditional notions of literary value persist in the public sphere if not in the academy, demonstrated for instance in then British secretary of state for education Michael Gove's Leavisite championing of *Middlemarch* over *Twilight* in a speech to school teachers in 2013 (Gove 2013). Contemporary criticism has collectively seized on the Gothic of trauma and anxiety as a way of validating study of what was in the past often considered a 'popular' genre with less intellectual worth than serious literary fiction. This practice results in a new kind of elitism that seems opposed to its original purpose. If, as Tania Modleski argues, critics and theorists tend 'to make mass culture into the "other" of whatever, at any given moment, they happen to be championing – and, moreover, to denigrate that other primarily because it allegedly provides pleasure to the consumer', then in the context of Gothic this process has the odd effect of renovating or elevating some forms of mass culture while denigrating others (Modleski 2000: 287). A Gothic linked to historical crisis produces a strong argument for the continued fertility of Gothic as a literary or cultural form and a way of validating an otherwise risky critical enterprise. If Gothic is more than just the evocation of pleasurable fear – if it touches intimately on pressing social issues – then researching it becomes easier to justify, whether to funding bodies or to critics of the humanities.

At the heart of this issue is an implicit debate about the utility of Gothic: Gothic once was useful but is no longer; Gothic finds new uses; some kinds of Gothic are more useful than others. Nothing illustrates this better than a 2013 book entitled *Zombies in the Academy: Living Death in Higher Education* in which the zombie becomes a metaphor for participation in and means of resistance to 'the corporate university' as well as 'a tool for pedagogical reflection' and a means of

restoring the embodied subject to the classroom through 'Zombie Pedagogy' (Walker and Moore: v–vi). This is the Thomas the Tank Engine theory of Gothic, in which it becomes a 'really useful engine' that can be put to work in the service of goals that are by implication more important or serious. Strikingly, this brings the debate full circle from early critics whose objections to Gothic resided precisely in their apprehension of its lack of instrumentality and inability to teach its readers anything valuable or useful. As one anonymous eighteenth-century reviewer pithily concluded, 'what instruction is to be reaped from the distorted ideas of lunatics, I am at a loss to conceive' ('Terrorist Novel Writing' [1798]2000: 184).

In response to debates about the utility of the humanities, a number of critics have put forward the argument that the humanities are valuable for their own sake. In an impassioned column in the *New York Times*, for instance, Stanley Fish refuses to justify the pursuit of the humanities in terms of their use value:

> Justification, after all, confers value on an activity from a perspective outside its performance. An activity that cannot be justified is an activity that refuses to regard itself as instrumental to some larger good. The humanities are their own good. (Fish 2008)

His argument is echoed more cautiously by Helen Small in *The Value of the Humanities*, in which she considers five different arguments for the value of the humanities and concludes that 'none … is sufficient without a supporting claim that the value of the objects and cultural practices the humanities study and the kinds of scholarship they cultivate have value "for their own sake" – that they are good in themselves' (2013: 175). This may seem like a call to aestheticism – to 'art for art's sake' – and in some senses it is. In Chapter 2, for example, I argue that Guillermo del Toro's *Crimson Peak* (2015) produces a self-reflexive Gothic that can be fully understood only through an appreciation of its visual properties on their own terms. Nevertheless, it is important to recognize that this critical manoeuvre is not an eschewal of politics or of historical context. As Small argues, quoting T. S. Champlin,

> Champlin puts it nicely in concluding that the temptation towards value 'isolationism' held out by the phrase 'for its own sake' is something we can and should guard against: when Wilde and other late nineteenth-century aesthetes adopted the phrase 'Art for art's sake' they were not 'divorcing art from life'; they were insisting that 'the artist is not in the service of religion, conventional morality, party politics, diplomacy, patriotism, the state or any of the other forces which try to reduce art to a means to their ends and to rob art of its status of an end in

> itself' (47). For present purposes, the most important part of this description is the opening clarification: that 'for its own sake' declares free-standing valuation while not isolating the thing valued 'from life'. (2013: 166)

There is a shift in object here, from 'art' to 'the humanities' to 'Gothic', and I remain alert to the distinctions between them. Wilde and his fellows' manifesto represents an ideal to aspire towards, not the condition of art in general; I do not think that there is an 'ideal' Gothic to which writers and artists should aspire or an ideal Gothic criticism that can step outside its social, political and historical contexts (this book was the subject of a successful funding bid to the Arts and Humanities Research Council and its proposal to challenge existing hierarchies of value was one of the means by which it laid claim to a 'bigger picture' beyond the niche interest in post-millennial Gothic texts). Rather, what I am arguing is that the critical need to justify Gothic through its utility has resulted in a narrow understanding of its possibilities. To echo Fish's rhetoric, Gothic does not need to be justified. We do not need to confer value on it from a perspective outside its performance. It is not instrumental to some larger good. It does not need to bear the ideological burden of the humanities in crisis and it does not need to reflect the anxieties of its critics. That is not to say that Gothic never speaks to cultural anxiety or expresses collective trauma – that would be nonsensical. Rather, it does not have to do so in order to be worthy of critical interest, or indeed to be Gothic.

The result of the critical imperative towards viewing Gothic in terms of a narrative of anxiety and trauma is that the texts that do not fit this narrative are overlooked. In the twenty-first century, the increasing prominence of images, texts, products and artefacts that do not seem remotely anxious or traumatized, that revel in their Gothicness, amounts to an entire counter-narrative which has been scarcely explored or understood. This counter-narrative is not apolitical; it engages specifically and repeatedly with identity politics but also, as my link to the Olympics ceremonies shows, with a politics of national representation. Celebration, as I will demonstrate, can itself be a political choice. In this book, my aim is to identify strands of this counter-narrative and try to explore how they might indicate a shifting site of Gothic in our culture. Inevitably, they do not tell a single story. This book will not provide a homogenous narrative, but rather explore facets of what can be identified as a single phenomenon. It certainly will not detach these narratives from the culture that produced them, or indeed cultural anxieties where they are appropriate, but neither will it assume that Gothic always and only responds to anxiety or that Gothic has no other stories to tell.

Happy Goth

One of the most significant stories that post-millennial Gothic has to tell is about Goth subculture. Baroque pop band The Divine Comedy's 2004 track 'The Happy Goth' describes a young woman who wears black clothes, white make-up, Dr Martens and a crucifix but who resists the projection of parental concern, for 'on the inside she's a happy Goth'. The happy Goth, in songwriter Neil Hannon's twist, is no longer an oxymoron. The lyric suggests a disjunction in its eponymous Goth subject between inside and outside, that Goth is a performative identity that produces a sense of internal well-being. The track is the product of external observation of the subculture rather than expressive of a self-acknowledged Goth identity. Nevertheless, Hannon has hit on an interesting point. If Goth has always been, to an extent, performative, then twenty-first-century participants in the subculture have increasingly foregrounded this in descriptions of the scene and rejected media ascriptions of violence or self-harm. The Goth look, according to the testimonies of its wearers, has no essential connection to social maladjustment, but is simply a means of creative self-expression. In the Foreword to Natasha Scharf's *The Art of Gothic*, for example, 1980s Goth veteran Andi Sex Gang writes,

> What has since become known as gothic in modern culture … was not about following a set of rules or restrictions, but about the freedom of individual expression that flowered from the love of the darker philosophical aspects of music, literature, film, and architecture … To me, 'gothic' is about being artistically challenging and culturally subversive. (Scharf 2014: 6)[2]

As I will demonstrate in Chapter 3, sociological research has tended to confirm this point, emphasizing additionally the social and communal elements of Goth. In this book I do not pretend to comment on the actual behaviour of Goths as individuals or a community: that is the job of ethnographic research conducted via survey data and participant observation. Instead the book investigates the way Goth is constructed, both by academic commentators and by members of the subculture, through the semiotic and discursive analysis of texts and cultural artefacts. This shows how images of Goth circulate in popular culture and how meanings accrue to them – meanings which cannot be divorced from the wider context of Gothic cultural production.

Goth culture, and Gothic studies, arose virtually simultaneously at the end of the 1970s, twin progeny of the 'Gothic times' that novelist Angela Carter hailed slightly earlier in the decade (1995: 460). Yet for a long time, Goth has remained

the poor relation of Gothic, its illegitimate sibling lurking in the corner of the academic party. Links between the two were, and remain, uncomfortable. Gothic studies sought to confer academic respectability on a non-canonical and hitherto disparaged genre, ultimately with a great degree of success. In stark contrast, it was not the business of Goth, as a youth subculture, to seek respectability or acceptance from its 'parent' culture, and from its inception the movement has been indifferent to or actively disregarded the approval of the establishment.

As Gothic studies flourished through the 1980s and into the 1990s, therefore, Goth remained largely overlooked by the academy. Goth subculture was regarded with bemusement by scholars. Goths may have often numbered among their students: ethnographic research has suggested that Goths are likely to be middle class and tertiary educated (Byrne 2006; Simpson 2006). However, they made no more than superficial links between these students' style and music preferences and the eighteenth- and nineteenth-century novels of their own research. As Sara Martin noted (rather sweepingly perhaps) in a comparatively early essay on the subject, 'Gothic Scholars Don't Wear Black' (Martin 2002). Martin suggests that the gap between Gothic studies and Goth was partly a methodological one, as Gothic studies in the 1980s and 90s was dependent on the kind of highly textual psychoanalytic and post-structural criticism that did not translate easily to study of social culture. Moreover, the kind of participant observation or unofficial knowledge necessary to elucidate Goth, she suggests, is unavailable to academics over thirty with no personal experience of the Goth scene. Nevertheless, the shift to a more historical approach to Gothic literature as championed by Baldick and Mighall in their influential essay 'Gothic Criticism' would necessitate the study of Goth as part of the context of contemporary Gothic.

Since the publication of Martin's article, those students have come of age and a generation of scholars more *au fait* with the Goth milieu turned their attention to the subculture, drawing on a diversity of methodological approaches from the ethnographic (Hodkinson 2002, Brill 2008) to the literary-cultural (Spooner 2004, Siegel 2005, Spooner 2006, Goodlad and Bibby 2007) and the musicological (van Elferen 2012). Additionally, three major exhibitions, *Street Style* at London's Victoria and Albert Museum (1994), *Gothic: Transmutations of Horror in Twentieth Century Art* at Boston's Institute of Contemporary Arts (1997) and *Gothic: Dark Glamour* at The Museum at Fashion Institute of Technology, New York (2008–09) made significant acknowledgements of Goth culture, further documented in the accompanying volumes by Ted Polhemus, Christoph Grunenberg, and Valerie Steele and Jennifer Park respectively. Meanwhile, mainstream publishing recognized a new niche market and commissioned a

number of books by non-academic writers including Richard Davenport-Hines (1998), Gavin Baddeley (2002, 2010), Voltaire (2004), Nancy Kilpatrick (2005) and Natasha Scharf (2011, 2014) that aimed to explicate Goth for a popular audience.

Significantly, all of these studies appeared after a definitive moment in the conversion of Goth subculture into academic discourse and the placing of Goth subculture on a broader stage. On 20 April 1999, two teenagers in Colorado, USA, arrived at school laden with assorted weapons, and proceeded to attack their teachers and classmates in what subsequently became known as the Columbine High School Massacre. Thirteen were killed and twenty-one injured, before the perpetrators turned their guns on themselves. Although Columbine was not the first time Goth had been associated with violence in the United States, it was the first case to receive full-scale global media coverage. The event provoked debate in all sorts of areas from gun control to classroom bullying, but as a watershed moment, it perhaps had most impact on the reportage of Goth culture. The two boys responsible for the shootings, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold, had tenuous claims to Goth identity – they wore black trench coats and purportedly liked some heavy metal and Industrial music. The American media, seeking to deflect attention from more controversial debates (specifically, gun control) seized on these details and transformed them into a moral panic whereby Goth was a satanic cult with Nazi sympathies, bent on creating horror and mayhem and corrupting the nation's youth. This story was repeated, in slightly varying forms, worldwide. As a result, Goths found themselves forced to address the mainstream in order to dispel these myths, thus resulting in an unprecedented level of cultural visibility. Coinciding with the broadsheets' 'revival' of the Goth(ic) aesthetic and its supposed conduciveness to a millennial sensibility, Goth was now definitively on the world stage.

The first academic studies of Goth to be published in the twenty-first century were begun well before Columbine and cannot be attributed specifically to its influence. However, it was now more difficult to dismiss Goth as simply teenagers dressing up: the link with 'serious' events legitimized and institutionalized Goth as a serious subject of study. Columbine dragged Goth from the private into the public sphere, both in that it forced what had been a self-consciously 'underground' movement under the scrutiny of the global media on an unprecedented scale, and in that it figuratively shifted the realm of Goth from private spaces associated with the feminized activities of dressing up and dancing (bedrooms, specialized club nights) to public ones associated with masculinized violence. Columbine initiated an explosion of discourse

on Goth culture in all media, and this both directly and indirectly produced academic commentary. Moreover the debates about the influence of horror films, violent videogames and extreme music that are routinely evoked in relation to such events keys directly back in to old questions about the legitimacy of Gothic.

Understanding Goth, then, is crucial to understanding post-millennial Gothic. Since the late 1970s, Gothic and Goth have existed in a kind of symbiotic relationship with each bearing traces of the other. In this respect, Goth is arguably unique among subcultures: many if not all subcultures obviously take inspiration from books and/or films and are themselves textualized, but in none except Goth is the subculture's identity so intimately bound up with a specific genre or literary aesthetic.

It is also worth pointing out that one of the things that interests me most about the relationship between Goth subculture and Gothic culture is what happens when Goth images or aesthetics enter the mainstream, or are appropriated by cultural producers and audiences who are not current participants in the subculture. Subcultural studies, for obvious and entirely justifiable reasons, is mostly concerned with the practices and identities of subcultural participants. Within subcultures, there is often a derogatory vocabulary applied to bands who are considered to have 'sold out' or participants who consume the subculture as a temporary lifestyle option: 'weekenders', 'part-time Punks' and so on. But just because an image is appropriated by what, for want of a better term, I shall call the mainstream does not mean that it stops signifying. The way Goth features in TV adverts, big budget films or high-street fashion can in itself be complex and revealing, particularly when it comes to exploring how gender constructions play out in contemporary culture.

Goth, moreover, provides an essential context for the shift in mood experienced in a wider Gothic culture in the early twenty-first century. As I will explain in Chapters 3 and 4, the ongoing renegotiation of Goth identities in response to moral panics elicited in the news media has had a major impact not only on the mood of the subculture itself but also on media which interact with that subculture, such as fashion, and in turn on representations in fiction, film and television. Descriptions of Goth in books and on websites sympathetic to the subculture have increasingly positioned it as tolerant, creative, self-expressive, articulate and more concerned with the pleasures of subcultural community than being a miserable loner. The Sophie Lancaster Foundation, a charity founded in memory of a Goth teenager murdered in 2007, is typical in its deliberate positioning of Goth as a means of 'expressing … individuality as creative artistic people' as a strategy

to combat bullying and violence against members of youth subcultures (Sylvia Lancaster, cited on *The Sophie Lancaster Foundation*). The celebration of Goth implied in these statements fed in turn into a celebratory Gothic: a Gothic in which a comic and romantic turn became increasingly apparent.

Comedy, romance and the rise of happy Gothic

If this book argues that comedy and romance have become more prominent in post-millennial Gothic, neither combination is distinctively new. Comedy has always been a crucial component of Gothic writing. In *Gothic and the Comic Turn*, Avril Horner and Sue Zlosnik establish a consistent comic thread running through the Gothic tradition, asserting that right from the beginning, Gothic has had a tendency to self-parody, and that 'it is perhaps best to think of Gothic writing as a spectrum that, at one end, produces horror-writing containing moments of comic hysteria or relief and, at the other, works in which there are clear signals that nothing is to be taken seriously' (2005: 15). Pointing out that Horace Walpole deliberately incorporated comic scenes into *The Castle of Otranto* (1764) in imitation of Shakespearean tragedy, they identify a long tradition of comic Gothic that finds particular expression in late-twentieth-century fiction. Film studies scholarship such as William Paul's *Laughing Screaming: Modern Hollywood Horror and Comedy* (1994) and Kamilla Elliott's 'Gothic—Film—Parody' (2008) establish a parallel tradition in cinema, while Lorna Jowett and Stacey Abbott identify plentiful examples of comedy in *TV Horror: Investigating the Dark Side of the Small Screen* (2013). Most of these approaches, however, either focus on parody or deploy a Bakhtinian methodology which reads bodily excess in terms of carnivalesque humour. My approach will combine close attention to specific forms and sub-genres of comedy (stand-up, sitcom and so on) while also emphasizing the term's medieval sense of a work that ends happily (as also found in romantic comedy).

Central to my understanding of Gothic and comedy is Susan Sontag's influential 1964 essay 'Notes on Camp' and subsequent engagements with this essay by other critics. Camp is, like Gothic, underpinned by what Andrew Ross calls 'a necrophilic economy' that trades in the 'resurrection of deceased cultural forms' (Ross 1989: 152). Like Gothic, camp 'has an obsession with death, flesh and decay' yet also 'adores cliché, surface, image' (Flinn 1995: 58, 61). Reading Gothic in the light of camp enables a focus on surface rather than depth, reinforcing Eve Sedgwick's contention that 'the most characteristic and daring areas

of Gothic convention' are 'those that point the reader's attention back to surfaces' (Sedgwick 1986: 141). Nevertheless, the political dimensions of camp, underplayed by Sontag but enhanced by subsequent commentators, are instructive in demonstrating an embrace of lightness does not necessarily mean a retreat from serious questions. Christopher Isherwood's description of camp as a means of 'expressing what's basically serious to you in terms of fun and artifice and elegance' could also be read as an apt description of happy Gothic (Isherwood 1954: 214).

The history of Gothic and romance is even more closely bound together than that of Gothic and comedy, with the two forms indistinguishable in the late eighteenth century, when the term romance had not yet acquired its specific connotations of courtship, signalling rather an anti-realist aesthetic. Over the course of the nineteenth century, 'romance' gradually shifted into its present meaning of a love story, crystallizing a number of stock conventions including an optimistic ending. Joseph Crawford's *The Twilight of the Gothic? Vampire Fiction and the Rise of the Paranormal Romance* (2014) maps a long imbrication of Gothic and romance that spans the works of Radcliffe and Austen, the Brontës, Daphne du Maurier and the mass-market romances of the mid-twentieth century. Crawford identifies, as I do in this book, a critical orthodoxy initiated by David Punter's field-establishing book that defines Gothic as *The Literature of Terror* (1980) and obscures other ways of reading its history. For Crawford, an alternative history may reorient Gothic back towards hitherto critically disparaged forms: 'with the … rise of paranormal romance, it has become possible to see the outlines of a different sort of history of Gothic fiction, one in which romance has *always* played a central role; and within *this* history the paranormal romance … may be less an aberration than a return to form' (5).

My own alternative history of Gothic acknowledges the importance of comedy and romance in the development of the form while insisting that Gothic is not reducible to either. While acknowledging the significance of the 'literature of terror' and the value of readings that focus on horror, fear and trauma, it asserts the presence and cultural significance of a counter-narrative of Gothic texts that combine conventional markers of the Gothic with a mood of pleasure, lightness or celebration. If these texts have increased in visibility since the millennium, they are not unique to it. The first happy Gothic text could be said to be Horace Walpole's *The Castle of Otranto* (1764), a novel that revels in its own Gothicness and possesses a curious lightness of tone. Happy Gothic is also anticipated in the Gothic parodies of the nineteenth century by Thomas Love Peacock, Eaton Stannard Barrett and Bret Harte, in Oscar Wilde's frothy

tale 'The Canterville Ghost' (1887), or in Stella Gibbons's classic *Cold Comfort Farm* (1932), in which the doom-laden Starkadder Family are tidied up and given a series of happy endings by the irrepressibly cheerful Flora Poste. Sitcoms from the 1960s *The Addams Family* (1964–66) and *The Munsters* (1964–66) are clear precedents, as is the soap opera *Dark Shadows* (1966–71), discussed in Chapter 6, and cult camp stage musical *The Rocky Horror Show* (1973), along with its subsequent film adaptation. In the 1980s, happy Gothic became increasingly widespread, evidenced in the series of woozy, delirious singles released by The Cure beginning with *Let's Go to Bed* (1982) and *The Lovecats* (1983), Neil Gaiman's cheery comic-book character Death (discussed in Chapter 3) and mid-1980s pop-Goth acts like Strawberry Switchblade. Comedy-horror romps such as *Ghostbusters* (1984) and *Beetlejuice* (1988) are happy Gothic, and director Tim Burton in particular has been instrumental in the ascendance of the mode, as Chapter 2 will establish. Children's fiction and television has long been a source of happy Gothic, from *Sesame Street*'s Count von Count (first introduced in 1972) to classic British series such as *Rentaghost* (1976–84), and the ascendancy of 'crossover' fiction in the wake of J. K. Rowling's *Harry Potter* series (1997–2007) helped stimulate a wider appetite for texts previously associated solely with child audiences. The celebration of Hallowe'en, particularly in its post-war, Americanized form is crucial to a happy Gothic aesthetic, and crops up in numerous forms throughout popular culture. What this book observes, then, is not an entirely new sensibility, but one that has, in the twenty-first century, found new conditions to flourish.

This book does not pretend to compile an exhaustive inventory of every 'happy Gothic' text that has been issued since the millennium. It does not even seek to definitively label its corpus of texts as happy Gothic, as this would perpetuate processes of canon formation and invite further boundary policing and futile debate over Gothic taxonomies. Rather, the book offers a number of case studies of ways in which twenty-first-century cultural phenomena visibly engage with Gothic paradigms but do not comfortably fit conventional definitions. While these phenomena are united by common themes of lightness, playfulness, celebration, comedy or romance, these do not all play out in the same way. Some of these texts are mainstream; some are niche interest; some may even be in the Gothic 'canon'. I have chosen to restrict my materials to those media I am most familiar with, so there is no extended discussion of theatre, music or videogames for instance, and the focus is predominantly on British and American examples. These restrictions have their inevitable shortcomings, which I invite other scholars to address. What is evident from the weight of material (and there are many, many more examples that I regrettably could not include for reasons

of space) is that these texts cannot be ignored: they too are an important part of contemporary Gothic. The cultural work they do is of crucial importance in determining what Gothic means in the twenty-first century.

The book begins by exploring the manifestation of Gothic as lifestyle, in advertising, leisure pursuits, interior design and lifestyle television. Chapter 1, 'Consuming the Edible Graveyard: Gothic Lifestyles and Lifestyle Gothic', traces the roots of Gothic as lifestyle practice in both Horace Walpole's eighteenth-century mansion, Strawberry Hill, and in Goth subculture. Covering the documentary *Goth Cruise* (2009), the Victoria and Albert Museum's 2009 exhibition *Telling Tales: Fantasy and Fear in Contemporary Design*, a 2008 episode of home makeover show *Grand Designs* and Channel 4's experimental cookery show *Heston's Gothic Horror Feast* (2010), it identifies a complex playing off of fear against fun in twenty-first century Gothic, ultimately resulting in the containment of horror and disgust and prioritization of consumption and pleasure.

Chapter 2, '"The images, for me, *are* the story": Tim Burton's Gothic Aesthetics', investigates why much of film director Tim Burton's work takes on characteristic Gothic narrative themes, yet does not fit conventional horror moulds, so that its Gothic properties are expressed in mainly visual terms. Surveying Burton's oeuvre from *Vincent* (1982) to *Dark Shadows* (2012), it argues that from the 1980s onwards, Burton's work has been instrumental in propagating a new kind of Gothic founded in visual rather than narrative motifs. This is exhibited in the 'Burtonesque' look of films such as *Lemony Snicket's A Series of Unfortunate Events* (2004) and *Crimson Peak* (2015). The increasing mediation of Gothic through the visual is intimately related to the rise of Goth subculture from the late 1970s, and the greater visibility of an identifiable Gothic style, identified in Chapter 1.

Chapter 3, '"Forget Nu Rave, We're Into Nu Grave!": High Street Style and the Uses of Gothic Romance' picks up the theme of Goth style and investigates the return of 'Gothic chic' in twenty-first-century mainstream and designer fashion every couple of seasons. It juxtaposes the resurgence of 'Gothic chic' *circa* 2007–09 with media accounts of the murder of self-identified Goth Sophie Lancaster in Bacup, Lancashire in 2007, and the trial of her assailants the following year. The defence of Goth mounted by both the mainstream media and the subcultural community in response to these events resulted in a minimizing of its otherness that left it ripe for appropriation by the mainstream on an unprecedented scale. The chapter concludes by analyzing the language and iconography of mainstream Gothic fashion, suggesting that in its evocation of fantasy and romance, it permits the mediation of other, more troubling qualities.

Chapter 4, '*Gothic Charm School*, or, How Vampires Learned to Sparkle' continues to examine the effect of major media events featuring Goths by

exploring how, just as eighteenth- and early nineteenth-century Gothic novels had a vexed relationship with the conduct book, sometimes undermining and confirming their didactic purpose within the same text, twenty-first-century vampire narratives are overtly preoccupied with questions of politeness and decorum. Stephenie Meyer's *Twilight* quartet, Charlaine Harris's *Southern Vampire Mysteries* (the inspiration for HBO's *True Blood*), and the BBC's *Being Human* present the vampire not only as sympathetic, but as desperate to assimilate. This chapter suggests that the vampire perennially operates as a kind of emblem for Goth culture, and in these narratives, the erosion of vampire otherness replays Goth culture's own conflicted desire for acceptance by the mainstream.

Chapter 5, 'Pretty in Black: The Goth Girl and the Whimsical Macabre', continues the exploration of romance fiction paradigms by focusing on the representation of teenage girls in Gothic images, texts and commodities that evoke and are often specifically marketed towards young women. It proposes a new mode of Gothic popular culture it calls the whimsical macabre, in which carnivalized images of childhood are merged with the 'monstrous/cute'. The chapter traces the formation of this mode through nineteenth- and twentieth-century texts including the children's fiction of Lewis Carroll, Heinrich Hoffmann and Edward Gorey, Tim Burton's films and 1990s interventions into representations of girlhood. It then goes on to analyze a selection of contemporary texts including graphic novels and animation, suggesting that the iconic character of the Goth girl can be read as a means of revising conventional romance. Crucially, it deploys the theory of feminist camp as a critical tool that enables the negotiation of hyper-femininity, anticipating the centrality of camp to the remainder of the book and particularly to Chapter 6.

Chapter 6, '"Happy Nights Are Here Again": Having a Laugh with Vampires and Other Monsters', explores the conjunction of comedy and the popular twenty-first-century trope of the sympathetic monster. Focusing on the vampire in particular, the chapter opens by tracing the history of its comic iterations from Stoker's *Dracula*, through twentieth-century film, to Burton's *Dark Shadows* (2013) and Sharon Needles' *Dracula* (2015). In doing so, it argues that camp has emerged as the dominant mode in its representation. It then goes on to explore two recent film comedies which explore, in very different ways, friendship between vampires: Jemaine Clement and Taika Waititi's *What We Do in the Shadows* (2014) and Amy Heckerling's *Vamps* (2012). By moving beyond the paradigms of lone outsider or romantic dyad, these films construct vampires as a subject, rather than an object, of comedy.

The theme of comic masculinity developed through Chapter 6's discussion of vampire camp continues in Chapter 7, '"I'm the Shoreditch Vampire": Making Over Goth Masculinities in Television Comedy'. This chapter turns to the representation of male Goths – usually figured as older teenagers or adults, and in a comic rather than romance register. In this context, it examines the stand-up comedy of Tim Minchin and Andrew O'Neill, who construct on-stage personas that deliberately and self-consciously engage with Gothic and Goth tropes. It then goes on to explore the trope of the Goth makeover, beginning with Goth appearances on makeover shows and continuing with the mediation of Goth in television sitcom, reading episodes of *Home Improvement*, *Frasier*, *The Big Bang Theory*, *The IT Crowd* and *The Mighty Boosh*, as well as the BBC's comedy-drama 'Goths' (2003). In *The Mighty Boosh* it finds a defence of Goth constructed through a Baudelairean emphasis on the heroism of the dandy: in the character of Vince Noir, the series renovates the figure of the feminized Goth male while also refusing to take it too seriously.

Finally, the book returns to the idea of Gothic as leisure and lifestyle practice. Chapter 8, '"Swishing about and Spookiness": Gothic Literary Tourism from Bram Stoker's *Dracula* to Paul Magrs's *Never the Bride*' queries how Whitby in North Yorkshire challenges and exceeds recent models of 'Dark Tourism' (Foley and Lennon 1996, Sharpley and Stone 2009). The twin drives of commodified heritage (Bram Stoker's *Dracula*) and subcultural carnival (the biannual Goth Weekend) function to create a space in which Gothic is celebrated as both mainstream leisure and alternative pleasure. Arguing that Gothic literary tourism is scripted first by *Dracula* and subsequently by other texts, the chapter concludes with an extended analysis of Paul Magrs's *Adventures of Brenda and Effie* (2006–12), in which – as in their setting, Whitby – the counterfeiting processes of Gothic narrative are not a source of anxiety but of humour and play, distilled and intensified by their location within closely defined spatial limits.

The conclusion of the book, 'Gothic Celebrations', returns to the point at which it began: Cameron's 'golden summer' and the Olympics opening and closing ceremonies. Offering an extended analysis of those events, it demonstrates that 'happy Gothic' has significance in terms of subcultural or niche audiences but also in the creation of national narratives. Since the millennium, Gothic has been co-opted into the language of public spectacle and in specifically celebratory terms. Post-millennial Gothic offers neither a new beginning nor the carnival at the end of the world, but a space in which shared difference can be celebrated and enjoyed.

Notes

1 Gothic and horror are overlapping genres and distinguishing between them can be difficult. By avoiding the term 'Gothic', Blake locates the object of her study in a field defined through its affectivity (its power to frighten or disgust) and sidesteps the specific associations of Gothic with revenant history and claustrophobic space identified by Chris Baldick (1992). Nevertheless, if Gothic is defined as a 'literature of terror', as it is by David Punter in his seminal 1980 work, then these distinctions dissolve.

2 Confusingly, Andi Sex Gang uses the term 'gothic' here when talking about Goth – presumably partly as a rejection of subcultural labelling.

1

Consuming the Edible Graveyard: Gothic Lifestyles and Lifestyle Gothic

Everyday Gothic

For some readers of Gothic fiction, it is not enough merely to consume Gothic narrative on the page (or latterly, the screen): they wish to live Gothically, to extend their reading or viewing experience to everyday life. As Goth musician and writer Voltaire recalls of his childhood,

> I spent countless hours watching 'monster movies' – as I called them – enveloped in a dark desire to escape to a fantasy realm such as theirs. A dark, romantic place filled with mystery and drama. A land far-removed and completely unlike the unbearably mundane location in which I lived: the sprawling suburbs of New Jersey. (Voltaire 2006: vi)

These desires are generally organised around the *mise en scène* of Gothic narrative, its 'fantasy realm', as much as the narrative itself. As in Voltaire's recollection, they are focused on recreating a Gothic atmosphere through personal style and home décor: converting the 'mundane location' of the home into a 'dark, romantic place filled with mystery and drama'. Plot takes second place to aesthetics; fantasy is extended into everyday existence through what Mike Featherstone calls 'the aestheticization of everyday life', or 'the project of turning life into a work of art' within a culture saturated with signs and images (Featherstone 2007: 65).

For Voltaire, these fantasies resulted on the one hand in a career as a stop-motion animator and then as a 'singer/performer, creator of comic books, animation and toys' on the Goth scene (Voltaire), and on the other in an impulse to decorate his living quarters in a Gothic style, documented in his 'Guide to Gothic Homemaking', *Paint It Black* (2006). In this book, Voltaire describes how to put 'A New Spin on Spooky Shelving', 'Decorat[e] With Dead Things', and

'Pimp Your Ride, Dracula Style' (Voltaire 2006: v). Using a combination of items salvaged from skips and thrift stores, cheap market-stall finds and Hallowe'en accessories, black spray-paint and a glue-gun, Voltaire constructs a 'Gothic Love Nest … that will scream, "I'm spooky!" while still being charming and subdued enough to not scare off potential dates or give your parents a heart attack when they come to visit' (96). Voltaire thus joins the army of 'lifestyle experts' that throng the Western media, offering advice on a range of everyday domestic activities including home decorating, cooking, gardening and personal appearance. In keeping with these arbiters of popular taste, Voltaire aims to educate his readers and moderate their vulgar excesses: the Gothic Love Nest strikes a balance in expressing its creator's inner spookiness while not offending significant others. The affectivity of true horror is averted: Voltaire semi-parodically draws on a conventional vocabulary of taste in suggesting that, despite its *Hellraiser* picture frames and customized baby dolls, the newly decorated apartment is just 'charming and subdued' enough to appease one's parents' criticism.

'Lifestyle' is defined loosely by David Chaney as 'the social organization of consumption' (Chaney 1996: 56). Consumption is never an unmediated event: it is structured and codified by any number of frameworks including advertising, leisure activities, commercial space and media narratives – all of which are informed by social class, gender, age, ethnicity and so on. These frameworks are converted, by means of an ethic of the individual, into a means of narrating the self. As Mike Featherstone explains, 'The modern individual within consumer culture is made conscious that he speaks not only with his clothes, but with his home, furnishings, decoration, car, and other activities which are to be read and classified in terms of the presence and absence of taste' (Featherstone 2007: 84). Taste is the means by which these individuals categorize objects and signs and in doing so categorize themselves; as Pierre Bourdieu famously said, 'Taste classifies, and it classifies the classifier' (Bourdieu [1984]2010: xxix).

If Gothic (or Goth) lifestyles signal the presence of a particular kind of taste culture with relatively consistent preferences and values, lifestyle Gothic, on the other hand, is what happens when individuals who are not committed to Goth subculture appropriate its imagery and aesthetics, or the imagery and aesthetics of Gothic fiction, in the production, marketing and consumption of mainstream material culture. Lifestyle Gothic is transient – its adherents might wear a Gothic look for a single party or a single season and then move on to the latest fashion. It is piecemeal – consumers might select a Gothic living room but a minimalist bathroom and a rustic country kitchen. It is linked to mainstream, rather than subcultural patterns of consumption – featured in high street stores

or popular television programmes rather than cult emporia or niche publications. However, it is important to recognize that it participates in similar cultural contexts and processes as 'authentic' subcultural productions, or indeed as 'original' Gothic texts.

There are two main reasons why hierarchies of value, whether cultural or subcultural, are problematic in relation to lifestyle Gothic. First, Goth is itself a commodity-based subculture, as demonstrated by Paul Hodkinson and explained in more detail below. Goth identity is dependent on consumption of clothing, accessories and music purchased partly from niche vendors, many of whom are themselves part of the subculture and indeed supported by it, and partly from mainstream shops and record stores. Many Goths, moreover, take jobs in the creative industries and therefore influence the production of Gothic products, complicating the model of 'bubble up/trickle down' popularized by Ted Polhemus in *Street Style* (1994). Second, Gothic cannot ever be said to have had an 'original' or authentic form. As Jerrold Hogle argues, the counterfeit, or indeed, 'the ghost of the counterfeit', is integral to the way that Gothic functions as a discursive site. Examining the way that images of the Middle Ages in eighteenth-century Gothic were mediated through Renaissance versions, he explains that copies of copies dominated eighteenth-century Gothic aesthetics, so that '[t]he neo-Gothic is therefore haunted by the ghost of that already spectral past and hence by its re-faking of what is already mere emblem of the nearly empty and dead' (Hogle 2012: 502). This process continues into contemporary culture with the 'ghost of the counterfeit' mediating between nostalgia for past ideologies and the freeing up or emptying out of symbols of that past for cultural exchange and profit within a capitalist system of commodities. If contemporary consumer practices continue this process of ghosting the counterfeit, in doing so they cannot dilute the Gothic, as the Gothic is always already a pale imitation of itself.

This chapter begins interrogating the process of Gothic canon-formation I evoked in the introduction by addressing the appropriation of Gothic by consumer culture and the world of commerce. It commences by exploring the mediation of Gothic into advertising, leisure and interior design products and culminates with a focus on 'lifestyle television', a mode of popular programming in which lifestyle concerns are prominently foregrounded. Specifically addressing shows that focus on homemaking and cookery, it explores what happens when Gothic is brought into close proximity with conventional markers of taste. The ways in which Gothic is put to work on these shows demonstrate that Gothic in contemporary consumer culture is more than just an empty and

desensitized repetition of tropes, and rather reveal complex and nuanced relationships between consumers and objects, 'experts' and audiences. Encounters with Gothic lifestyle often push bourgeois ideologies of individual expression and self-improvement to their limits, simultaneously confirming these ideologies while throwing their assumptions into sharp relief.

Crucial to the conversion of Gothic into lifestyle is the increasing prominence of Goth subculture as a lifestyle choice in Western culture. While lifestyle Gothic is not reducible to Goth, the subculture provides an informing context in the ascription of 'bad taste' to Gothicized products and leisure activities. Moreover, Goth itself, while never immune to lifestyle concerns, has acquired a new image in the twenty-first century, in which it is presented in increasingly upbeat terms, conducive to a mainstream ideology of pleasurable consumption and aspirational leisure.

Smiling Gothic people

In the opening decades of the twenty-first century, Gothic imagery in advertising, increasingly common since the 1990s (see Spooner 2006), took a new turn. Kodak's 'Goth' from 2001, made by Saatchi and Saatchi, showed a beautiful Goth teenager taking photographs from unusual perspectives to the soundtrack of Bobby Darin's 1967 swing classic 'Beautiful Things'. She displays the photographs to an unreceptive class – but one Goth boy looks up and they exchange smiles as the lyrics state, 'Beautiful people too' – a reference, for those in the know, answering back to Marilyn Manson's misanthropic 1996 single *The Beautiful People*. A 2006 ad for Heineken Dark showed Goths queueing miserably for a nightclub – then dancing ecstatically to Wham's 1980s pop hit *Wake Me Up Before You Go-Go*. Also in 2006, a Canadian ad for Kia Sportage saw Goths accepting a lift from a southern hick whose infectious enjoyment of Country and Western ends with the Goths joining in the hoedown. In 2013, Danish confectionery manufacturer Nørregade's ad by LoweFriends showed a Goth girl struggling not to smile as she eats their sweets. Finally, and most vividly, Irn Bru's 'Goth Holiday', developed by the Leith Agency in 2007, depicted a group of Goth teenagers frolicking on Blackpool Beach to The Undertones' Punk pop *Here Comes the Summer*. As one of the boys swigs from a can of the soft drink, the black lipstick frown painted on his mouth changes to a Joker-like grin.

Goths, of course, have featured in adverts before; the surprise is that all the Goths in this new breed of ads are smiling. It goes without saying that the idea

that a product is so effective that it can even make a Goth happy is a powerful selling point. However, there is something else also going on here. The adverts appear to be laughing *with* rather than *at* the Goths. The Kodak ad is romantic and charming. The Kia and Nørregade ads set up difference only to deflate it and show the Goths sharing a joke with 'ordinary' people. The Heineken and Irn Bru ads recall jokes internal to the subculture: the popularity of early 1980s pop and cheesy tracks like Aqua's *Barbie Girl* in Goth clubs; and the comedy website *Goths in Hot Weather: A Celebration of the Sunshine Goth*. This sympathetic mode of representation is taken up by the video for Scottish synthpop band Chvrches' 2015 track *Empty Threat*, directed by Austin Peters. The story follows a young Goth girl taking a day trip with her friends to a Fort Lauderdale waterpark. Notably, the video shows Goths as a community rather than as isolated loners, enjoying 'normal' teenage leisure activities with friends. As its subjects sunbathe with parasols and shoot down waterslides in full make-up – laughing and smiling as they do so – the video revisits the territory of both Irn Bru's 'Goth Holiday' and *Goths in Hot Weather* but without the satirical tone, offering instead a kind of euphoric nostalgia for teenage dreams. Some time around the turn of the millennium, then, a cultural turn has taken place in which Goth is less frequently positioned as gloomy and miserable, and more frequently positioned as fun loving and either romantic and attractive or able to laugh at itself. The twenty-first century has, so far, been the era of the happy Goth.

The idea of the 'Happy Goth' is multi-faceted and derives from both within and without the subculture. Here, I am using the term happiness to describe sensations of pleasure and enjoyment that are communicated through the physical phenomena of smiling and laughter. However, happiness may also refer to concepts of contentment or satisfaction that may not be outwardly communicated in this way: like the subject of Neil Hannon's 'The Happy Goth', discussed in the introduction, who finds her sense of psychological well-being in her embrace of outward symbols of misery, such as her artificially pale face and black clothes. As Hannon's lyrics emphasize, outside and inside cannot be directly mapped back onto one another, or if they can, then not always in the ways expected.

The oxymoronic portmanteau of the 'Happy Goth' informs *Goth Cruise*, a documentary by British documentary maker Jeanie Finlay, shown on US independent film channel IFC in 2009. The film follows a group of 150 British and American Goths as they join a cruise ship holding 2,500 guests in its journey around Bermuda. Characteristic subcultural activities such as dressing up and dancing to Goth music are placed in the context of the commodified leisure and 'forced relaxation' (as one interviewee puts it) of the commercial cruise. Finlay, a

self-confessed ex-Goth, allows individual guests to tell their story, and a complex picture emerges in which the diversity and internal differences of the Goth community are emphasized.

The selling feature of the documentary is, evidently, the 'perfect . . . paradox' of its title (*Things I Learnt on Goth Cruise*, 2009). The unadulterated sunshine and organized leisure associated with cruise holidays appears antithetical to the Goth aesthetic – even 'anti-Gothic', as one interviewee states in a voiceover. As the story unfolds, however, the Goths are shown participating in a wide range of typical cruise activities including playing shuffleboard on deck, fitness training, wine-tasting and paddling in the ocean. There is a copy of *Twilight* tucked under the beach towels and one Goth dresses as Ming the Merciless for the formal dinner, but on the whole the Goths are shown enjoying the same activities as the other tourists on the boat. As for the other tourists, some are mildly perturbed by the Goths' appearance, but nevertheless there are queues to be photographed with Lobster, the group's extrovert whose party costume is a red devil in full body-paint and artificial horns. The Goths become part of the exotic spectacle, readily consumed by their fellow passengers.

A significant point that emerges over the course of the documentary is the very different perception of Goth in British and American culture. The documentary presents Goth in the United Kingdom as much more of a lifestyle choice and less of an oppositional stance. British Goth Bridie reports, 'I haven't got anything to rebel against any more – I've done it – been there, done that – and I've realised that I feel comfortable.' A brief interlude at Whitby Goth Weekend (to be discussed further in Chapter 8) shows tourists and locals largely enjoying the spectacle the Goths provide. UK Goth bands interviewed by the director refute charges of miserabilism, challenging stereotypes of the Goth as outsider. A member of Rome Burns interviewed at Whitby Goth Weekend declares, 'In theory we're supposed to be a mopey, miserable, I dunno, sitting in the corner drinking snakebite and black and never smiling. But you come here and everyone's playing on the trains or playing on the arcades and everyone's got a big smile on their face.' Wayne Hussey of The Sisters of Mercy and The Mission proposes, 'There is a problem of popular conception that Goth is quite miserable, and maudlin and depressive … but I actually think that a lot of … The Mission's music, certainly lyrically, is very uplifting and very celebratory of life.'

In contrast, the American Goths on the Cruise are more subdued. 'There's more expectation in America that you will conform. There's more at stake being a Goth in America than there is in Britain', Bridie reflects. Angel Sil, the founder and organizer of the Goth cruise, concurs: 'Goth here … is seen as a more

extreme expression of self than in Britain.' Several confess that they are 'Corp' (i.e. corporate) Goths, wearing conventional office wear by day and living a kind of secret identity during evenings and weekends. In her opening address to the Goth Cruisers, Angel Sil counsels discreet behaviour, instructing all participants that 'Because of how we dress, we do stick out, a bit. If people are looking to be offended, they're likely to look at us.' The most trenchant comment is made by Sean, whose words are used as a counterpoint to the frenetic farewell parade featuring a Village People–style routine to Katrina and the Waves' *Walking on Sunshine*:

> Goth exists as a counterbalance to a shiny happy people mainstream that a lot of us just don't fit into. America I think largely tries to force people to be happy being happy. They try to comb what they perceive as negative emotions out of society like combing fleas off a dog. Goths also want to be sad, and we want to be angry, and we want to have a full range of emotions, and there's a very strong rebellion against being told that you have to be happy.

Significantly, the way in which the documentary cross-cuts Sean's monologue with scenes of the parade constructs the 'shiny happy people' he evokes as a commodified version of gay culture – another oppositional culture which has to a certain extent been assimilated into the mainstream. For Sean, a veteran of the First Gulf War, PTSD sufferer and single dad, Goth possesses a genuine countercultural charge through which he expresses his anger towards a government that he feels betrayed him. The skill of Finlay's documentary is that she does not diminish his anger or attempt to resolve the tension between his critique of American culture and the Goths' cheerful embrace of the sunshine and leisure offered by the cruise. Happiness, it is implied, is one of the 'full range' of emotions welcomed by the Goths. Angel Sil repudiates the notion that Goths fully eschew the mainstream, stressing that 'Goths have kids, and Goths have mini-vans, and Goths have mortgage payments'. The subcultural model that Finlay's version of Goth emulates is less that of an underground movement than one that exists within and alongside the mainstream, simultaneously opening up space for its critique *and* a place where alternative identities are explored and exuberantly enjoyed.

Gothic taste

Goth is an inescapable context for the investigation of Gothic in consumer culture: by the end of the twentieth century, the notion of a Gothic lifestyle had

become irrevocably blurred with the notion of a *Goth* lifestyle. Goth is generally identified by commentators as a 'subculture', in that it is distinct from or even resistant to mainstream culture and identified by a variety of markers used to distinguish subcultures, such as spectacular style and group commitment to a shared identity. It is also, however, a 'taste culture', one that overlaps with a wider group of individuals who may not identify themselves as Goths but who make choices about what clothes they wear, what music they listen to and what leisure activities they enjoy, based on a perceived Gothic aesthetic. Significantly, Goth's consolidation and expansion through the Western world coincided with the period in which Tania Lewis argues that the concept of 'lifestyle' consolidated, as 1980s consumer culture began to normalize consumption as a way of life (2008: 39).

As Paul Hodkinson (2002) shows, Goth subculture is thoroughly imbued with the processes of consumption, as participants purchase music, make-up, clothes and accessories in the process of fashioning their identities, and numerous small producers cater to their niche tastes, distributing their wares through small boutiques, market stalls and online platforms. Goth is therefore, I would argue, continuous with a broader culture of consumption in which Gothic is offered up to consumers in a variety of novel and inventive ways, from children's toys to high street fashion, sweets and chocolate to home décor. Gothic lifestyle is not confined to subcultural consumers; it is increasingly a feature of the mainstream marketplace, where it is not necessarily the dominant choice in consumers' lives, but may feature in more transient or ephemeral ways, to be enjoyed for a single evening or combined with a wide range of other stylistic preferences. Gothic fashion appears in malls and high-street shops from Hot Topic to Topshop; high-profile advertising campaigns like the ones described above draw on Gothic imagery; lifestyle television shows screen Gothic-themed episodes; toy manufacturers including brand leaders Lego and Mattel market Gothic ranges; Hallowe'en has become an international, multi-billion dollar industry.

If these modern ephemera are specific to Western culture since the 1980s, they nevertheless cannot entirely be divorced from the Gothic tradition, which has always been intrinsically related to consumption. Gothic fiction emerged at a particular point in history, when the Enlightenment conception of the individual coincided with the birth of consumer culture. As a result, it was inextricably linked to the notion of the commodity and to emerging concepts of leisure. As E. J. Clery explains, in Enlightenment discourse, 'supernatural fiction figures as the ultimate luxury commodity' (1995: 7). For many eighteenth-century

commentators, Gothic novels made representation of what was fantastic and unreal and were unredeemed by the pedagogical purpose expected of fiction. Their enjoyment was defined purely in terms of affect. As the century wore on, Gothic also spoke to an emerging Romanticism in which, as Clive Bloom suggests, 'The gothic went from being merely a set of despised literary and architectural devices to a way of life and a way of thinking about the self' (2010: 64).

At the same time, objective standards of beauty first began to be challenged by the notion that aesthetics are mediated through individual perception. As Luc Ferry establishes, in the Platonic and Christian thought that held sway prior to the Enlightenment, beauty was measured by absolute standards of truth that transcended human experience; with the birth of the individual, the measure of those standards was redefined in terms of human judgement (Ferry 1993). While it was some time before taste became considered completely subjective, an important paradigm shift had taken place. The neoclassical preoccupation with order, proportion and decorum was questioned by proponents of Gothic taste, proponents who seized on what Chris Brooks calls 'the possibility of a rival body of historically validated architectural knowledge (1999: 90). Irregularity, asymmetry and embellishment became valid aesthetic strategies, expressive of a *difference* in taste rather than *outré* barbarism.

Gothic's association with *bad* taste, however, has proved difficult to shake off. The excessive and sensational properties of Gothic novels, as well as the rejection of Gothic revival style by modernism in the twentieth century, have led to persistent associations of Gothic with the florid, trashy or overwrought. This is further complicated by the fact that Gothic may itself be divided into high and low, the highbrow and culturally legitimated stylings of Gothic Revival architecture and the 'pop Gothic' of commercial culture. Between these two poles float texts and artefacts which take on different degrees of legitimacy at any given time, so that a novel like *Wuthering Heights* (1847), for example, may have been regarded as 'coarse and disagreeable' on publication (*Spectator, 18 December 1847* 1992: 39), but has since been fully renovated to the literary canon. The adoption of Gothic as a subcultural aesthetic, moreover, deliberately deploys its reputation as a bad taste aesthetic as a mode of resistance to mainstream values.

The most significant precursor to modern notions of Gothic lifestyle was Horace Walpole, author of *The Castle of Otranto* (1764), subtitled 'A Gothic Story' in its second edition and commonly held to be the first Gothic novel. In 1750, Walpole appointed two of his friends to a 'Committee on Taste' to plan modifications of his comparatively modest riverside villa, Strawberry Hill in

Twickenham, with the aim of converting it into an imaginary Gothic castle. The resulting confection, realized in stages until 1776, was simultaneously the first Gothic Revival building to be based on authentic medieval designs, and a wild architectural fantasy. As Chris Brooks writes, 'Walpole's copies are both conscientious and cavalier. Faithful enough in form and detail, they are wildly discrepant in scale and material, and blithely ignore architectural propriety.' As a consequence, Gothic is 'Liberated into pure style' (Brooks 1999: 87). Strawberry Hill provided the stage-set for Walpole's performance of an elaborate and often eccentric persona. An avid collector of antiquities and bizarre curios, Walpole would turn up to greet guests dressed in a carved wooden cravat and elbow-length embroidered gloves that had belonged to James I.

Strawberry Hill thus inaugurated not only the Gothic literary tradition through its manifestation in *Otranto*, but also a tradition of Gothic interior design as expression of unique personal taste, a means of curating the self. Walpole was by no means the first to explore Gothic design elements in architecture, but in Strawberry Hill they became linked in the hitherto most coherent and holistic way to the fashioning of a Gothic subject through style choices. Walpole Gothicized his suburban villa by embellishing not only the exterior structure, but also the interior, with paintings, antiques, curios, china, wallpaper, stained glass, mirrors, ornate fireplaces, ceiling moulds and so on. Many of the objects on display, such as Dr Dee's scrying mirror or the suit of gilded armour believed to have belonged to King Francis I of France, were thoroughly integrated into his personal mythology. As he stated, 'Visions you know have always been my pasture … Old castles, old pictures, old histories and the babble of old people make one live back into centuries that cannot disappoint one' (Walpole 1857: 457). Nostalgia was mediated through a modern emphasis on comfort: 'In Truth I do not mean to make my house so Gothic as to exclude convenience and modern refinements in luxury' (Walpole [1784]1987: 248–9). Walpole was a connoisseur, an arbiter of taste, but many of his preferences were tangential to, or directly contradictory of, the accepted taste of the times. Subsequent Gothic Revivalists such as A. W. N. Pugin did not take Strawberry Hill seriously, criticizing Walpole for taking little heed of original scale and materials, as well as his designs' decorativeness, their lack of utility. His influence stretches beyond architecture, however: Michael Snodin, the curator of the Victoria and Albert Museum's 2010 exhibition gathering together Walpole's lost collection, suggests, 'Walpole's cultural legacy was to pioneer a kind of imaginative self-expression in building, furnishing and collecting which still inspires us today. I suppose one of the take-home messages of the exhibition is: why not try it yourself?' (Vickery 2010).

Approximately 250 years separate Walpole's Strawberry Hill and Voltaire's Gothic Love Nest, described at the opening of this chapter, but Walpole's emphasis on the rich imaginative potential offered by visions of 'old castles, old pictures, old histories' echoes through Voltaire's own lament for 'the romance and pageantry of the past' in a world of 'blue jeans and khakis and baseball caps' (Voltaire 2006: x). Voltaire may lack the economic and cultural capital – or, in modern Manhattan, the space – to achieve a Gothic vision on the scale of Strawberry Hill, but he is engaged in a similar process of 'imaginative self-expression' and a similar process of cultural remediation whereby he collects, displays and performs the Gothic and in doing so both ameliorates the Gothic with 'convenience and modern refinements in luxury' and educates his audience in the niceties of Gothic taste.

Dark arts

As with many other critical narratives about the Gothic, Horace Walpole offers a convenient moment to begin, a point at which to locate a fake origin in the history of fakery. A few months prior to their exhibition *Horace Walpole's Strawberry Hill* in 2010, the Victoria and Albert Museum staged an exhibition entitled *Telling Tales: Fantasy and Fear in Contemporary Design* that showcased some of the most striking examples of contemporary 'design art' practice. 'Design art' is a medium that uneasily straddles the border between fine art and domestic craftsmanship. The objects on display in *Telling Tales* retained a design function, such as chair or wardrobe or lampshade, but in their conceptualization, execution and marketing aspired to the condition of unique art object: Toord Boontje's *Fig Leaf* wardrobe, for example, a structure composed out of an elaborately detailed fig vine made from enamelled copper, that when opened folds back into doors shaped like angel wings, required six hours to hand-paint each side of each of the hundreds of leaves. In its title, *Telling Tales* explicitly called attention to its narrative properties. Curator Gareth Williams explains in the catalogue, 'It showcases work by international contemporary designers who make narrative, or tale-telling, an integral part of their finished objects' (2009: 9). The exhibition is curated, moreover, in such a way that it also tells a narrative:

> In this tale the beginning takes place in a forest glade. Like the garden of Eden, it is a place of symbolic innocence, symbolized by benign nature … These are stories of enchantment, and these objects are intended to enchant. For the second part of our tale we come inside, perhaps within the walls of an enchanted castle

> or palace. The scene implies we are no longer innocent, now that we are initiated into adulthood; in mid-life we may be less concerned with nature and more concerned with worldliness, decadence and symbols of status and luxury … The end of our tale contemplates death, and the trappings of material pleasures seem less relevant. Its eschatological character recalls judgment, commemoration, memento mori and reflections on the afterlife. (Williams 2009: 15–16)

What is striking about Williams's narrative is that it is implicitly a Gothic one. The transition from pastoral innocence to the enchanted castle is that of fairy tale and romance but the closure of this narrative in the contemplation of death, rather than marriage and renewal, converts it to something darker. The website attached to the show identified each section of the exhibition with a different kind of doorway – a wrought iron gate for The Forest Glade, a wooden door studded with iron for The Enchanted Castle, and a prison grille with a red glow behind it for Heaven and Hell. This emphasis on thresholds and boundary-crossing explicitly evoked the Gothic. Moreover Williams's description of his chosen objects in psychoanalytic terms as excavating and reprocessing buried psychological materials again Gothicizes them, so that in the words of Caroline Evans, quoted several times in the catalogue, 'archaeological fragments of previous historical moments work their way to the surface' (Williams 2009: 13).

The objects that appeared in the exhibition often enacted the crossing of thresholds or bringing together of two opposed states. Kelly McCallum's *Do You Hear What I Hear?,* a vintage taxidermied fox with golden maggots inserted in its ear, preserves the fleeting process of decomposition, the moment between death and dissolution. Williams considers that '[t]here is a tension between revulsion and attraction that arises from her precious rendering of shocking matter, and these ambiguities contribute to the unnatural character of the objects' (2009: 99). Design studio rAndom International's *Morse* light is constructed from 65 metres of capillary tube, through which red liquid flows in 'dots and dashes' around a light bulb, creating a writhing effect that recalls both a dialysis machine and a bowl of maggots. On their website, the designers pose the question, 'Where does decoration end and disgust start?' (cited in Williams 2009: 100–3). Revulsion and attraction, decoration and disgust, fear and fun – this difficult balance is key to contemporary Gothic aesthetics. These 'art design' works cater to an exclusive market and do not need to meet mainstream standards of beauty or utility. Their very exclusivity, however, not to mention their exquisite craftsmanship and materials, imbues them with a sense of luxury in which sensory pleasure

is the predominant value. In a work like Dunne and Raby's *Priscilla 37 kilotons Nevada 1957,* one of a series of huggable mushroom clouds, pleasure turns into comfort; even, perhaps, the comfortable.

Strikingly, however, the exhibition catalogue does not once mention the word Gothic. This is partly due to its association with a specific tradition of visual representation based in medieval revivalism and associated with Pugin, Ruskin and so on, which is distinct in many ways from literary or cinematic Gothic aesthetics. It is also symptomatic of a wider discomfort with the term in contemporary art criticism, that Gilda Williams identifies as stemming from high modernist Clement Greenberg's rejection of Gothic as fettered by the past and elevation of an ideal artwork that 'exists in a state of objecthood, unfettered by any reference beyond its own medium-specificity and experimentation' (2014: 423). 'Design art', aspiring to high cultural status, thus attempts to throw off the pejorative connotations of the Gothic, laying claim instead to the so-called universal experiences of myth and fairy tale. Middlebrow versions of Gothic consumption demonstrate no such nicety, often stripping the term 'Gothic' of the narrative associations Gareth Williams claims for *Telling Tales* and using it to signify little more than a series of style choices.

Lifestyle television

In the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, the work of educating the populace in matters of taste is increasingly taken on by lifestyle television, a term used broadly to encompass home and fashion makeover shows, cookery and gardening programmes, and other shows in which 'experts' dispense advice to weekly guests and the television viewer. Ever hungry for a new theme, British lifestyle programs such as *Changing Rooms* (1996–2004), *Home Front* (1992–2000), *Grand Designs* (1999–), *Heston's Feasts* (2009–10), *The Wedding House* (2010), *Gok's Fashion Fix* (2008–9), *Gok's Style Secrets* (2013) and *Snog Marry Avoid?* (2008–13) have all produced Gothic-themed episodes or segments. These shows have been widely franchised and/or imitated and their format will be familiar to the majority of Western viewers.

The incorporation of Gothic into lifestyle programming creates an interesting tension. Lifestyle television has a pedagogical purpose: it purports to educate the masses in the acquisition of taste and the fashioning of a 'successful' performative self. It is characteristically middle class in ethos, espousing the values of

industrious self-improvement and productive leisure. Gothic is also frequently designated a middle-class genre, written by and catering for the emerging middle classes and purveying what Chris Baldick and Robert Mighall sardonically call 'Fear and Trembling in the Bourgeois Psyche' (Baldick and Mighall 2012: 279). As explained above, however, Gothic is frequently made to represent 'bad' taste, the sort of look one should be educated out of. Rarely, though, do these shows simply reject Gothic wholesale: rather, they create arbitrary distinctions between good and bad kinds of Gothic, putting Gothic to work in different ways. Increasingly, as Emma McEvoy argues, Gothic is used in popular entertainment as 'the mark of a particular kind of cultural literacy', embedding audiences 'in a shared history of popular culture' (McEvoy 2016: 188). Each of these shows therefore struggles between a perception of Gothic as a difficult or unacceptable style choice and Gothic as a particular kind of cultural capital, imbued with literary and historical knowledge. They also struggle with the 'dark' or disruptive elements of Gothic, which are inevitably contained by an aesthetics of consumer pleasure.

Many participants in Goth subculture, far from resisting the pedagogical impulse purveyed by such programming, adopt it enthusiastically and only semi-ironically. Voltaire's guide to Goth DIY, *Paint It Black*, is mentioned above; at the time of writing he was crowdsourcing funds for a regular homemaking podcast. Jillian Venters's book and blog, *Gothic Charm School*, offers lifestyle advice modelled on the nineteenth-century etiquette book and is explored in more depth in Chapter 4. The influence of lifestyle programming is articulated most clearly, however, on a website entitled *Gothic Martha Stewart*, which has been online since the late 1990s. Run by homecraft enthusiast Trystan L. Bass, it appropriates the expertise propagated by wholesome, American, lifestyle TV celebrity Martha Stewart in the service of creating a beautiful Gothic home. As Bass explains,

> If Martha Stewart were really gothic, color is the only thing she'd have to change. Her central ideas are already well suited to the gothic subculture. Martha adores finding old linens and gently worn furniture at flea markets. She sews a lot of her own household dressings. She paints and experiments with unusual painting techniques on objects small and large. She loves flowers, live and dried. Her style flirts with Victorian, Art Deco, and modern elements and frequently mixes them into a very beautiful mishmash. (*Gothic Martha Stewart*)

She adds, 'Btw, no, I'm not a professional interior designer; I just watch too much Home and Garden TV. If I can do this stuff, anyone can.' The website is adorned

with plentiful images of Bass's home, which combines faux-Victoriana with the resolutely modern and everyday ('Media towers and entertainment center') and some overtly Gothic flourishes (mock gargoyles over the bookcase). Bass simultaneously positions herself as the audience of lifestyle television and as unofficial expert in her own right, the dispenser of subcultural lifestyle advice. *Gothic Martha Stewart* has its cake and eats it: it retains its subcultural integrity while reconciling that with the middle-class values of industrious self-improvement and productive leisure embodied in lifestyle television. Bass's description of the wide variety of leisure activities undertaken in her living room tellingly includes watching 'countless hours' of TV as well as 'stitch[ing] and bitch[ing]'.

Over the last fifteen years or so, Gothic has repeatedly cropped up on British lifestyle television. Unsurprisingly perhaps, interior design programming in particular provides a rich source of Gothic, from Liz Wagstaff's Gothic bedroom for *Changing Rooms* ('create a gothic vampires' playground with a modern twist'), to Laurence Llewellyn-Bowen's Pugin-inspired Gothic living room for *Home Front* ('create an elegantly simple room with Gothic rhythm and proportion, but without the Victorian Gothic detail') (*BBC Homes*). Gothic on these shows tends to do little more than extend the middle-class ideologies of individualism and self-expression through consumer choice that the programmes as a whole embody, offering in many instances a kind of 'limit case' for this ideology (the presenters flag the style as difficult or outrageous). Gothic design might offer a mild frisson of transgression, but this is offered up as a titillating diversion rather than anything more substantial. Gothic is presented alongside a panoply of other design styles as an aesthetics of pleasure, specifically connoting fantasy and sensual indulgence. A house resembling those more usually found in Gothic novels – one that creates discomfort or unease – cannot be countenanced. The home owners on *Changing Rooms* may recoil in a moment of uncanny recognition when they see their redecorated home for the first time, but this is tied to no more distressing feeling than having one's consumer preferences misperceived or misunderstood.

One of the most interesting instances of Gothic on a home makeover show occurred on Channel Four's *Grand Designs*, broadcast in 2008. The show, presented by architectural expert Kevin McCloud, 'follows some of Britain's most ambitious self-building projects, as intrepid individuals attempt to design and construct the home of their dreams'. Season 8, episode 4 follows professional couple Jo and Shaun Bennett as they attempt to build a family home, from scratch, in a Gothic style. The couple have no previous experience of design or construction and refuse to employ a project manager, so the narrative of the

episode focuses on their naivety in taking on such an ambitious project and the inevitable crises that ensue. The house becomes represented as something that repeatedly resists their control, figured in spiralling costs and their inability to order the correct materials. More specifically, it is depicted as being architecturally unbalanced and out of proportion. On a visit to the thirteenth-century Goodrich Castle, McCloud explains,

> The reason great big stone staircases and doorways and fireplaces work in an old castle like this is because they're all in proportion, in scale to the building, whereas put those items in a five-bedroom detached house and they just look ridiculous.

Tensions centre on a six-foot-tall fireplace that the Bennetts plan to have constructed from local stone, to adorn their modestly proportioned living room. On being shown a mock-up of the fireplace, Shaun Bennett is delighted, emphatically declaring, 'That is *exactly* what I want.' McCloud persuades him to scale it down to proportions more in keeping with the room – but visiting the finished house, is dismayed to find that the Bennetts have juxtaposed the rescaled fireplace with an equally outsized plasma TV. Walpole's combination of Gothic with 'convenience and modern refinements in luxury' is realized with a vengeance.

McCloud repeatedly criticizes the Bennetts not only for their lack of expertise but also for their presumed lack of taste. The house is slated for lacking architectural integrity, for being extravagant, for 'weird juxtapositions of scale', for fakery (resembling a film set or a theme pub), and perversely, for not being Gothic enough: 'So far, it's more executive home than Gothic fantasy.' These descriptions frame and present the house in a way that actually functions to make it more Gothic: excessive, discomforting, counterfeit. Jo Bennett sourcing fireplace designs on the web is like a modern-day version of Horace Walpole copying engravings of tombs from Westminster Abbey for fireplaces at Strawberry Hill; the expensive oak cladding over cheap pine beams is reminiscent of Strawberry Hill's papier maché ceilings.

The Bennetts' design evidently does not rival that of Walpole or possess anything like the same cultural significance. Within the milieu of lifestyle television, however, its presentation is highly revealing of the way that Gothic can be made to function as a discursive site through which competing forms of taste are produced. Two indistinctly distinguished kinds of Gothic are pitted against each other: an implicitly Ruskinian Gothic representing architectural integrity, historical nostalgia and good taste, and a modern-day Gothic associated with fakery, the middle-class *parvenu* and trashy popular culture. These two

frequently overlap, as the programme is apparently unaware that there are different strands to the Gothic Revival and repeatedly mixes them up. On the one hand, the Bennetts are cast as modern-day barbarians, disrupting the conventions of civilized middle-class taste. The more Gothic the house becomes, the more fake and out of proportion, the more transgressive it is of those taste criteria. On the other hand, the Bennetts' passion for their project is repeatedly cited as an excuse or rationale for their unconventional approach: 'It's just so personal to them.' Gothic becomes constructed as the ultimate expression of middle-class individualism and self-expression through consumer choice. Within the lifestyle television narrative, then, Gothic provides both a radical and conservative function, simultaneously disrupting its ideologies and confirming them.

The taste of Gothic

A similar double function of Gothic appears in a particularly sophisticated example of Gothic lifestyle TV, *Heston's Gothic Horror Feast*. Heston Blumenthal is the chef and proprietor of the triple Michelin-starred Fat Duck restaurant, which has won numerous awards including *Restaurant* magazine's best restaurant in the world in 2005. In 2005 he also launched a television career, presenting a sequence of cookery programmes in which he showcased his unorthodox methods of 'molecular gastronomy'. Among the most successful of these are *Heston's Feasts*, broadcast in two seasons in the United Kingdom on Channel Four in 2009 and 2010, with an additional one-off special in 2011. These shows follow a characteristic format whereby Heston and his kitchen team prepare a fabulous meal for a group of C-list celebrity guests, basing each week's menu on a different literary or historical theme. Highlights include a Victorian feast based on *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, another inspired by *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*, and most significant to this discussion, a Gothic Horror Feast with individual dishes based on *Jekyll and Hyde*, *Dracula*, *Frankenstein* and the Marquis de Sade. *Heston's Feasts* in many ways challenges the conventional format of lifestyle television, in that while retaining an ostensibly pedagogical purpose, there is no pretence that the viewer might seek to attempt the recipes shown themselves and no implied lesson of self-improvement. *Heston's Feasts* presents cookery as pure fantasy, a spectacle to enjoy but not to emulate.

What is most interesting about the *Gothic Horror* episode of *Heston's Feasts* is the way that it foregrounds the conflict between pleasure and unease that is inherent in Blumenthal's unconventional approach to cookery but which is also

endemic to 'lifestyle Gothic'. Blumenthal regularly serves dishes to his guests that push the boundaries of what is conventionally considered food – whether through unusual ingredients or through elaborately playful presentation. In other episodes, however, these are employed in service of 'pleasant' emotions such as nostalgia (in the 1970s and 1980s themed feasts) or curiosity and delight (the Alice in Wonderland episode). In the Gothic episode, Blumenthal deliberately aims to terrorize his guests – within strictly defined limits.

The contradictions the Gothic episode produces are embodied most clearly in the second course, a dish inspired by Bram Stoker's *Dracula*. Blumenthal sets out to create a dish in which blood is the main ingredient. He travels to Romania, where he samples blood sausage and hears of a traditional stew made with leeches fed on goose blood. He proceeds to attempt to recreate this dish by frying up sated leeches with parsley and lemon juice, but discovers that it is just too unappetising, concluding, 'it's got to be about the blood, but it's got to taste great.' Admitting that there's 'an element of pantomime in this whole thing', he concocts a risotto in which the blood effect is mainly created by beetroot juice, garnished with battered snails impaled on a crucifix, 'the closest thing to a leech that people enjoy eating'. Despite this amelioration of the most horrific properties of the meal, the guests remain ambivalent – some relish the dish while others are clearly disconcerted by the snails and by the idea of consuming blood.

Blumenthal appears to grasp the nuances of the Gothic very well. His recognition of a 'pantomime' element recalls Eve Sedgwick's insistence in *The Coherence of Gothic Conventions* that it is in surface décor that the most interesting and characteristic Gothic effects reside (Sedgwick 1986: 12). His emphasis on theatricality also evokes Hogle's emphasis on fakery and the ghost of the counterfeit, cited above. The theatricality of Blumenthal's cooking coincides happily with the performativity of the Gothic. At the same time, while the blood risotto is a significantly tamer version of the leech stew, it still unsettles and provokes his guests, creating a tension between sensual experience (the risotto tastes good) and psychological expectation (the disgust associated with eating blood). Blumenthal pushes just enough boundaries to make the experience of eating the risotto a challenging one, but not so many that it actually violates any taboos.

In summary then, Gothic operates rather ambivalently in *Heston's Gothic Horror Feast*. On the one hand, it is associated with horror, disgust, and violation of taboos. On the other, Blumenthal recognizes that in order to convert it into a culinary experience, horror and disgust must be contained within safe limits. As he states at one point, 'I want to keep it on the enjoyable side and not push them over into the horrific', and again at the end of the show, 'I set out to give my

guests a taste of good, old-fashioned Gothic horror, without the nightmares.' In the migration of Gothic narrative from fiction to food, sensory enjoyment must be prioritized. Like the objects in *Telling Tales*, Blumenthal's concoctions exist on the boundary between art and lifestyle. They are esoteric and exclusive, not the sort of thing that can be bought in the supermarket (despite Blumenthal's exclusive range for British supermarket chain Waitrose) or recreated at home. But their dominant value and aesthetic is one of pleasure. If they do not provide sensory gratification then they are unsuccessful as gastronomic concoctions. Fear, apprehension, anxiety, disgust are converted into part of the theatre of the feast and the apparatus of enjoyable consumption.

For the final course of *Heston's Gothic Horror Feast*, Blumenthal constructs an Edible Graveyard, ostensibly inspired by the Marquis de Sade. Composed mainly of chocolate, caramel, marzipan and ice-cream with a little bit of blood mixed in to complicate the flavour, the Edible Graveyard apparently distils the essence of Gothic gastronomy. Crucially, Blumenthal emphasises black humour in his construction of the graveyard, with graves inscribed with his guests' names and white chocolate body parts moulded on a hacked-up Barbie poking out of the soil. The orgy of excessive but harmless gustatory glee that ensues is hardly what one would expect from reading the Marquis de Sade or even a typical Gothic novel. Blumenthal is informed and articulate about Gothic, he inserts his inventions within a culinary and a literary tradition, but what happens when he recontextualizes these traditions is that Gothic subtly shifts and changes its meaning. Heston's Gothic meal offers something rich and decadent and rare, something even possibly slightly risky or challenging, but one which is not remotely traumatized, anxious or gloomy. If this chapter began with the spectacle of Goths smiling in the service of promoting consumption, it ends with a spectacle of Gothic consumption making people smile: from happy Goth, to happy Gothic. In Heston's words, 'They're eating their own coffins and gravestones – and they're still enjoying it!'

Conclusion

When Gothic becomes lifestyle, it becomes incorporated into a broader range of value judgements about consumer choice in everyday life. It is not as simple as Gothic representing bad taste: rather, Gothic becomes subject to a series of fine discriminations and internal distinctions, rendering its meaning specific and localized within different contexts. Within lifestyle programming, Gothic

is alternately celebrated as the ultimate expression of consumer individualism, and denigrated in order to shore up the particular values the programme endorses. This dichotomy is broadly repeated in Goth subculture, which produces its own internal distinctions between more or less acceptable styles and forms of behaviour. Neither Gothic, nor Goth, lifestyle can be wholly oppositional in the twenty-first century: they are subordinated to a broader culture of consumer choice, in which they become one more option in the process of styling the self. That does not, however, render them meaningless: as these examples have shown, Gothic continues to produce moments of difficulty or discomfort within the seamless manufacture of lifestyle, complicating easy judgements in the production and transmission of taste. As the participants on the Goth Cruise indicate, moreover, Goth as lifestyle does retain moments of oppositional force in specific and localized contexts. This is not exclusive of its embrace of leisure and pleasure but closely bound up with them: the Corp Goth's weekend corset is her refusal to allow the corporate world to define her, even as it is financed by her corporate wages.

This chapter has anticipated themes of several later chapters: I will return to 'mainstream' consumption of Gothic products in Chapter 3, Goth lifestyle blogs in Chapter 4, lifestyle television in Chapter 7 and the business of Gothic tourism in Chapter 8. Most significantly, however, this chapter has established a theme that the next chapter will extend and amplify: the expression of Gothic in visual terms and the importance of Goth style in establishing a popular cultural Gothic. The taste for Gothic interior décor is translated, in film, to set and production design and *mise en scène* – all of which are quintessentially realized in the films of Tim Burton.

2

‘The images, for me, *are* the story’: Tim Burton’s Gothic Aesthetics

The Gothic look

In the twenty-first century, a certain Gothic ‘look’ has become visible across media from book cover design and illustration to fashion, advertising and film, providing a kind of visual shorthand that enables products to be marketed effectively to consumers with a taste for the Gothic. This look can be identified, for example, in the Penguin Classics Deluxe book covers by Ruben Toledo for *Wuthering Heights* and *Jane Eyre* (2010); Chris Riddell’s illustrations for Neil Gaiman’s children’s novels or his own *Goth Girl* series (2013–15); Jon Klassen’s cover for the British edition of Helen Oyeyemi’s *White Is for Witching* (2009) or the numerous international covers for Erin Morgenstern’s *The Night Circus* (2011); John Harris Dunning and Nikhil Singh’s graphic novel *Salem Brownstone* (2010); numerous film advertising posters including those for *Pan’s Labyrinth* (2006) and *Dracula Untold* (2014); and the ‘Emily the Strange’ brand of t-shirts and merchandise. While demonstrating multiple variations, twenty-first-century Gothic style can be recognized by a combination of features including intensive chiaroscuro; crowded space; intricate detailing; an emphasis on line; distorted proportions; a saturated colour palette or combinations of black, white and red; ornate fonts; and deliberately retro or archaic styling. In terms of genre recognition, what Gothic *looks* like is increasingly becoming as important as the stories that it tells.

While, of course, it is impossible to reduce the visual codification of Gothic in the twenty-first century to a single influence or explanation, this chapter argues that the film director Tim Burton has been a key figure in the development of post-millennial Gothic aesthetics. It suggests that Burton produces a new kind of Gothic, one that is based as much in aesthetics as it is in narrative. Burton’s own work in illustration and animation, and the emphasis within his films on

production design and costume, significantly contribute to the Gothic qualities of his work. This emphasis can in turn be identified in films that proclaim more or less explicitly their allegiance to the 'Burtonesque', from Brad Silberling's *Lemony Snicket's A Series of Unfortunate Events* (2006) to Guillermo del Toro's *Crimson Peak* (2015). As will be seen in Chapter 5, furthermore, this visual style has had a particular impact on children's publishing and the construction of particular kinds of teen or pre-teen female protagonists. In its prioritization of the visual over narrative content, Burton's work has influenced the formulation of a visually oriented Gothic that increasingly dominates the twenty-first century.

Burton's Gothic

Just how Gothic is Burton? As a director, his name has become virtually synonymous with Gothic. Despite the fact that he has made a number of films which are not at all Gothic – *Pee Wee's Big Adventure* (1985), *Mars Attacks* (1996), *Planet of the Apes* (2001) – and others which are only debatably or intermittently so, the appellation Gothic is routinely used by the press to describe his films, personal appearance, lifestyle and even his working environment – an article in British Sunday newspaper *The Observer* referred to his 'gothic office' in Belsize Park (Adams 2012). A brief Google search on Burton reveals the term Gothic applied to him and his work over and over again. 'Explore Origins of Tim Burton's Goofy Gothic', says a headline on Burton's exhibition at New York's Museum of Modern Art, for example, the adjective drawing attention to the whimsical and cartoon-like qualities of his drawing (Zjawinski 2009). 'Tim Burton to bring a Gothic twist to the Cannes jury presidency', says another – and so on *ad infinitum* (Frosch 2010).

There are some obvious reasons why journalists and audiences understand Burton's films as Gothic: his predilection for *Frankenstein* narratives; lonely, black-clad outsiders; and B-movie horror imagery. In the context of his entire oeuvre, however, the enshrining of Burton as 'the quintessential Goth filmmaker' (Issitt 2011: 53) is not as self-evident as it may first appear. With the possible exception of *Sleepy Hollow* (1999), *The Corpse Bride* (2005) and *Frankenweenie* (1984/2012), Burton films rarely play Gothic 'straight' – they seldom adhere to stereotypical expectations of a Gothic narrative. They tend to hybridize Gothic with other genres, including comedy (*Beetlejuice*, 1988 and *Dark Shadows*, 2012); musical (*Nightmare Before Christmas*, 1993 and *Sweeney Todd*, 2011); action blockbuster (*Batman*, 1989 and *Batman Returns*, 1992); bio-pic (*Ed*

Wood, 1994) and fairy tale (*Edward Scissorhands*, 1990). Some (*Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*, 2005 and *Alice in Wonderland*, 2010) Gothicize their sources, importing traumatic personal histories that haunt their main characters, while others, as mentioned above, are difficult to describe as Gothic at all.

Burton's personal appearance – his tendency to appear in public wearing sunglasses, black clothes and tangled hair – has been instrumental in fashioning his Gothic reputation. In a volume collecting together fifteen magazine interviews published during Burton's career, almost all interviewers comment on this characteristic appearance: *Entertainment Weekly*, for example, notes his 'signature all-black Goth uniform and … enormous pair of blue-tinted wraparound shades' (Fraga 2010: 130). The term Goth, rather than Gothic, is instructive: Burton is deliberately aligned with a subcultural identity. His relationship with his ex-wife and frequent collaborator Helena Bonham Carter was conceived by the popular media in similar terms, with reports dwelling on their supposedly eccentric living arrangements in adjoining properties and paparazzi shots capturing them dressed in matching dishevelled black. A more reflective piece in the *Guardian* from 2010 suggests:

> Once she got together with Burton, Bonham Carter's image was transformed. They were often photographed together in black, their complexions equally pale, hair equally scruffy … Today, she looks as if she could have walked straight out of a Burton film – black, flowery dress, black skirt, black, flowery, knee-length socks, black boots ripe for giving someone a kicking, and so many chains and lockets and fob watches around her neck, it's amazing she can hold her head up. She is often described as a goth, but she says she isn't sure what that means. 'I don't like the music particularly, I've got no goth records. Is it the predominant black? The make-up? And the whiteness? The white thing. Yes … Tim sometimes puts grey make-up on for the press and he doesn't tell me, so afterwards I'm like, "You're ill!" He goes, nah, it's the grey make-up. Heeheeehee!' (Hattenstone 2010)

The 'Goth' label is something that Burton and Bonham Carter evidently are bemused by but also partially invite. It is also something that, crucially, is linked to appearance: 'I don't like the music particularly, I've got no goth records' Bonham Carter insists, later adding of her husband, 'He doesn't like the music either.' There is a distinction here between 'Goth', referring to a specific subculture, music genre and set of lifestyle practices, and 'Gothic', referring to a more general cultural identification associated with literature, film and so on. The couple's description by the media as Goth, as well as their own apparent

identification with Gothic, lies not in attachment to a subcultural scene or to their taste in music but rather in their adoption of a particular kind of aesthetic.

The tension between 'Goth' and 'Gothic' in descriptions of Burton reflects other ways in which his work can be something of an awkward fit with conventional critical definitions of Gothic. Gothic, in the sense that the critics and journalists I have cited are using it, is a literary tradition, one that is most often defined through narrative conventions. These often take the form of a kind of recipe or shopping list, as in a satirical article of 1798:

> *Take* – An old castle, half of it ruinous.
> A long gallery, with a great many doors, some secret ones.
> Three murdered bodies, quite fresh.
> As many skeletons, in chains and presses.
> An old woman hanging by the neck; with her throat cut.
> Assassins and desperadoes '*quant suff*,'
> Noise, whispers, and groans, threescore at least.
>
> Mix them all together, in the form of three volumes to be taken at any of the watering places, before going to bed. ('Terrorist Novel Writing' [1798]2000: 184)

Modern criticism has found more sophisticated ways of formulating the combination of elements required for a text to be Gothic. Of these, Chris Baldick's compact definition of the Gothic tale has become the most widely cited, due in part to its efficiency in condensing the Gothic formula in what amounts to a Bakhtinian chronotope. Baldick's definition is flexible enough to accommodate a very wide variety of texts from the eighteenth century to the present and to be applied across media; yet, interestingly, only a handful of Burton films fit it:

> For the Gothic effect to be attained, a tale should combine a fearful sense of inheritance in time with a claustrophobic sense of enclosure in space, these two dimensions reinforcing one another to produce an impression of sickening descent into disintegration. (Baldick 1992: xix)

More recent critical formulations have attempted to bridge the various manifestations of Gothic in the eighteenth century and beyond, describing it as a 'discursive site' (Miles 2002: 4) or even, in Michael Gamer's term, an 'aesthetic' that shifts across forms and media (2000: 4). Gamer's 'aesthetic' is deployed in the sense of a 'set of principles' and although it incorporates the visual, Gamer's primary concerns are, again, with literature. Of course the eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Gothic Revival was also an important movement in architecture and design, but as such it was about reviving medieval styles with a

nostalgic and celebratory impulse rather than the vicarious indulgence in terror entailed by Gothic literature. Although there has always been overlap and exchange between the two traditions, both art historians and literary critics have tended to preserve the two as distinct aesthetic and ideological spaces.

The Tate Gallery's *Gothic Nightmares* of 2006, curated by Martin Myrone and Christopher Frayling, directly addressed the critical lacuna in Gothic visual aesthetics and made an important intervention in establishing a visual tradition equivalent to the literary Gothic. Nevertheless with a handful of exceptions the works in this exhibition were less well known than their literary equivalents, with minimal impact on the development of Gothic studies as an academic discipline and therefore on the critical narrative it characteristically provides. Despite a scattering of recent critical interventions exploring non-literary media, notably Isabella van Elferen's *Gothic Music: Sounds of the Uncanny* (2012), narrative-based definitions of Gothic persist. As Gilda Williams asks in a trenchant exploration of the Gothic in contemporary fine art, 'How might we define the Gothic aesthetic that, as observed in … contemporary artworks and in the culture at large, ventures beyond a tiresome catalogue of motifs, from vampires to angels in black shrouds, crosses to coffins?' (2014: 413) For Williams, art critics are still mired in the vocabulary of the Gothic shopping list, reduced to identifying motifs rather than exploring how Gothic narrative themes and trajectories are played out in visual terms. Williams, however, is focused on fine art, as opposed to the more commercial forms of visual culture that are encompassed in this book.

In *The Works of Tim Burton: Margins to Mainstream*, editor Jeffrey Weinstock argues that 'what Burton primarily offers is not Gothic but "Gothic" – that is, his films celebrate the Gothic literary, cinematic, and televisual traditions, insistently referencing them and appropriating and deploying themes, motifs and images associated with the Gothic, but they do so in the context of films that persistently undercut the horror of the Gothic mode through humor and sentimentality' (2013: 26). Burton, for Weinstock, ultimately provides 'Gothic lite', in which nostalgia and irony intersect to defuse Gothic affect. Although Weinstock evidently feels great affection for Burton, the phrase 'Gothic lite' implies a critical judgement, in which Burton's oeuvre is a diluted version of a more potent original. Not Gothic but 'Gothic': those inverted commas suggest that Gothic becomes a form of citation in Burton's work, somehow distanced from a previous, more authentic source. That original is explicitly associated with 'horror' (27): Gothic, Weinstock implies, can be measured by its power to frighten. But Gothic is a form without an original, a series of citations and revivals. Horace Walpole's *The Castle of Otranto*, usually designated the first Gothic novel, was a

conscious homage to the Shakespearean admixture of the comic and the tragic, and cheerfully paraded its counterfeit nature as a supposedly 'found' manuscript composed by a fictitious medieval monk. The idea that contemporary, postmodern forms of Gothic represent a diminution or a falling off from an earlier, more vigorous form is common in Gothic studies, espoused most prominently by Fred Botting, who as I established in the introduction, has argued repeatedly for the cultural exhaustion of present-day Gothic, thus producing a kind of a kind of counterfeit nostalgia, for a more 'authentic' mode of Gothic expression that never existed. Like Weinstock, Botting measures the success of Gothic by its power of affect, and specifically its power to shock or frighten. Affectivity is a subjective phenomenon: *Frankenweenie*'s PG (parental guidance) rating indicates its power to shock the very young audience at which it is aimed. Nevertheless, as a cultural phenomenon, Gothic is not co-extensive with horror and cannot be reduced simply to its affective capabilities.

Weinstock's 'Gothic' in inverted commas, moreover, recalls Susan Sontag's famous definition of camp as 'see[ing] everything in quotation marks' (1994: 280). Camp, as Sontag recognizes, is pre-empted by the Gothic novel in the eighteenth century and its distinctively heightened yet stylized emotions are readily identifiable in Gothic texts from Matthew Lewis's *The Monk* (1796) to Francis Ford Coppola's *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (1992). The camp strain in Burton's work – the intense stylization and exaggeration, the sentimental nostalgia, the irony – is not a dilution of its Gothic qualities but an intrinsic part of them. Above all, as Sontag argues, 'Camp is the consistently aesthetic experience of the world. It incarnates a victory of "style" over "content", "aesthetics" over "morality", of irony over tragedy' (1994: 287). This statement provides an important clue to understanding Burton's Gothic and by extension the Gothic of the twenty-first century. In Chapters 5, 6 and 8, I will explore the relationship between Burton, camp and post-millennial Gothic in greater depth. For the moment, however, it is the victory of style over content and aesthetics over morality that is of paramount significance.

Critics repeatedly note that Burton is a visually oriented director and that often his films look beautiful while their scripts are weak. In a 1991 interview with David Breskin, following the commercial success of *Batman* and the critical acclaim of *Edward Scissorhands*, Burton insisted, 'The images, for me, *are* the story' (Fraga 2010: 58). His stock was riding high in Hollywood, and yet he was already on the defensive towards accusations of his so-called problem with narrative (57). These accusations have dogged his career. Most notoriously, in the case of *The Planet of the Apes*, his biggest critical flop, the script

was still being written as they were filming – a recipe for disaster. In his 1991 interview, Breskin comments, 'The fact is, English seems like a foreign language for Burton: he thinks visually' (39), while Mark Salisbury notes in a piece for *Premiere* on *Planet of the Apes* (2001) that 'Burton has been criticized in the past for disregarding script and story, even as he has been lauded for his visual style' (146). Jim Smith and J. Clive Matthews remark approvingly that Burton is 'almost *distractingly* visual' (2002: 1). Indeed, Burton himself concurs, 'I couldn't tell you a good script if it hit me in the face' (Fraga 2010: 111).

While Burton does, self-evidently, draw on Gothic narrative conventions, it is through music, costume, special effects and production design that the characteristic Burton experience is created. It is production design in particular that I will focus on here (for further discussion of music, costume and special effects see chapters by van Elferen, Spooner and Telotte in Weinstock 2013). Production design is the process which oversees the overall look of a film, co-ordinating set, props, costume, art direction, special effects and bringing together the work of individual designers as a cohesive whole. By exploring production design rather than plot and dialogue or even editing and cinematography, a different picture of the Gothic emerges, one that has become increasingly influential in twenty-first-century culture.

Burton and production design

When writing about Burton and production design it is important to clarify that while Burton as a director is particularly involved with the design elements of his films, he has forged close working relationships with a number of production designers and art directors. Particularly early on in his career, these relationships were often fluid and as a result, it is difficult to attribute many of the visual aspects of his films to any one person. For example Rick Heinrichs, Burton's most long-standing collaborator, was production designer on *Sleepy Hollow*, *Planet of the Apes*, *Dark Shadows* and the animated *Frankenweenie* but also credited in a variety of other roles including art direction, set design or visual effects on a total of ten other Burton productions. What is clear, however, is that Burton and his team produce a remarkably distinctive 'look' that is reproduced from film to film. Burton has become a lucrative brand, with several of his films inspiring highly successful spin-off merchandising ranges (notably *The Nightmare before Christmas*, which Burton produced and provided the original story and characters for, but which was directed by Henry Selick). Being

employed as production designer on a Tim Burton film is partly about recreating the Burton 'look', and the skill with which his production designers do this is demonstrated by Heinrichs's work on *Lemony Snicket's A Series of Unfortunate Events*, which looked just like a Tim Burton film.

Myrone's exploration of the Gothic in the accompanying catalogue to the *Gothic Nightmares* exhibition rests to a large degree on shared themes and subject matter with the Gothic novel: the 'Gypsies, Witches, and flying Devils' complained of by a contemporaneous critic; the preoccupations with madness and the narrow line between life and death (2006: 35). He also, however, sketches out a shared aesthetics derived from the influence of Fuseli and his 'highly linear, expressive use of drawing'. As he explains,

> The resulting representational bodies veered towards the qualities of the literary Gothic in their spatial conception and narrative associations: compressed, stretched, distorted, thrown into vast spaces or squeezed into suffocating hollows, they were disassembled, damaged, by turn incomprehensible and vivid, over-stated and extravagant. These are impossible bodies … artificial tools of rhetorical expression inhabiting a world quite of their own. (37)

Myrone's description of Fuseli's bodies has much in common with Chris Baldick's demarcation of 'claustrophobic enclosure in space' and 'sickening descent into disintegration' as key features of the Gothic, but it attempts to conceptualize these themes in visual terms that surpass the 'tiresome catalogue of motifs' identified by Williams. The emphasis on line and the qualities of compression, distortion, disassembly, over-statement and extravagance are also richly present in Burton, from his artwork and preparatory sketches to his finished films. They are perhaps most vividly evident in his animated films. Burton began his career as an animator at Disney, and as he told Mark Salisbury in *Burton on Burton*, 'Having a background in animation sort of broadens the scope of what you can do visually. Cinema is a visual medium so … everything is meaningful in terms of the look of things' (Salisbury 2008: 51). His early short, *Vincent* (1982), is particularly revealing as Burton himself took responsibility for production design, assisted by Heinrichs. The sets constructed by Heinrichs from Burton's designs similarly offer distorted spaces that alternately stretch and compress the bodies within them. The resemblance between *Vincent's* sets and the celebrated expressionist ones designed by Walter Reimann, Walter Röhrig and Hermann Warm for Robert Wiene's *The Cabinet of Dr Caligari* (1920) has been frequently noted, and although Burton denies direct influence, he shows a distinct preference for 'expressionist' over Gothic

as a descriptive term for his work. The expressionist movement is helpfully summarized by Andrew Spicer as

> a philosophical and artistic critique of bourgeois rationalism; an attempt to express the distortions, alienation, fragmentation and dislocation, the 'irrationality', of modern life. Expressionism was concerned to represent subjective experience: states of mind, feelings, ideas, perceptions, dreams and visions, often paranoid states. (2002: 11)

Crucially, expressionist film-making uses stylized external symbols to express interior disturbance. In *Burton on Burton*, Mark Salisbury writes, 'Burton remains a filmmaker whose modus operandi is based on his innermost feelings.' Burton confirms this by insisting, 'The image isn't always literal … but linked to a feeling' (Salisbury 2006: xviii). The use of visual images as an index to the emotions can clearly be seen in *The Cabinet of Dr Caligari* but also in the majority of Burton's films: in the way, for example, the landscape of *Edward Scissorhands* is not a realistic depiction of suburbia but rather a hyperbolic version, in which normality is so exaggerated that it becomes disturbing. I would argue that both *Caligari* and *Vincent* are searching for a visual language of the Gothic with inevitably similar results, and that the rhetorical language Myrone describes as a feature of eighteenth-century Gothic art is proto-expressionist in form.

Myrone's 'disassembled, damaged' bodies in alternately vast and suffocating spaces are repeated, for example, in *Edward Scissorhands*, in which the 'not finished' creation Edward is alternately positioned in the soaring, cathedral-like space of the castle and the crowded, twee spaces of suburbia; in one particularly suggestive scene, enclosed in a canopied waterbed smothered with cushions and soft toys. This juxtaposition is repeated in *Alice in Wonderland*, where rapid shifts in scale between Alice's body and the spaces containing it form a significant feature of the source material. This is particularly interesting as Lewis Carroll's *Alice* is not a Gothic text, but in Burton's hands it becomes one, to a great extent through the visual properties he imparts to it. If disjunction in Carroll's *Alice* is caused by a lack of fit between subject and landscape, Burton converts Wonderland to Underland, a world which is in itself out of joint. Burton uses extensive CGI to create what J. P. Telotte calls

> 'filled space', visually drawing the audience into that more complex spatial experience, even producing – when characters or various 'things' conventionally seem to project or tumble into the theatre – a kind of reversal of Carroll's 'Through the Looking Glass'. With such 3D effects, the movie screen itself might

> be seen as a stand-in for that permeable mirror as the theatre ironically becomes the extension and even completion of the filmed world. (2013: 87)

Underland is visually crowded, the screen filled with excessive ornamentation enabled by the computer-generated effects. Bodies are distorted, whether the Red Queen's (Helena Bonham Carter) giant head, Tweedledum and Tweedledee's (Matt Lucas) duplicate rotundity, or the Hatter's (Johnny Depp) enlarged, luridly coloured eyes and anatomically impossible dance. More conventional high and low angle shots, whether looking up from inside the rabbit-hole or down at Alice's suddenly diminished form, are also repeatedly used to present a constantly shifting and unstable relationship between Alice's metamorphosing body and the spaces of Underland. Finally, Mia Wasikowska's adoption of a series of costumes scaled to make her body look large or small emphasizes Alice's own status as 'impossible body', a tool of rhetorical expression inhabiting a world quite of her own.

Stripes and spirals: Burton's visual style

The Gothic properties of production design in Burton's films, however, go beyond Myrone's emphasis on the proto-expressionist use of bodies in space. They are also found in a heightened colour scheme, densely layered visual allusions to other Gothic films, a predilection for ornamentation and embellishment, and the repetition of stylistic motifs such as stripes and spirals. In Burton's work connections with an older Gothic tradition are seldom made directly, but rather mediated through popular cultural sources, including film, television and Goth subcultural style. The evocation of period in Burton's films, for example, never aspires to the verisimilitude of 'classic' period drama, but is instead filtered through cinematic history. *Sweeney Todd*'s production designer Dante Ferretti suggests the film attempts to evoke the London of Hollywood's black-and-white era, while Burton himself claims, 'it is kind of a fable and is slightly stylized', comparing it to Universal's *Frankenstein* movies (Salisbury 2006: 87). This creates a characteristically Gothic effect described by Jerrold Hogle as 'the ghost of the counterfeit', or the copying of what is already a copy (Hogle 2012). *Sleepy Hollow* bears a similar relationship to the Hammer films of the 1960s.

Two prominent visual motifs in Burton's work are stripes and spirals, which are particularly interesting as they are difficult to subordinate to a narrative definition of Gothic. Stripes occur in one form or another in virtually every Burton

film from *Vincent* onwards, principally in costume such as the dress worn by Katrina van Tassel (Christina Ricci) in *Sleepy Hollow* or Betelguese's (Michael Keaton) striped suit in *Beetlejuice*. On one level, they appear to reference Goth style, in which stripes are a prominent distinguishing feature, particularly on accessories such as tights and gloves. There is no single obvious reference point for this practice, although striped stockings are worn by Alice in John Tenniel's illustrations to *Through the Looking Glass* (1871) and by the Wicked Witch of the East in the film version of *The Wizard of Oz* (1939). Burton was in his early twenties when Goth subculture emerged in Britain and the United States and its development coincides almost exactly with his career. Burton's repetition of stripes therefore instantly marks his visual style as Goth, rather than Gothic: deriving from subcultural style rather than high cultural tradition. Burton's use of stripes, however, also evokes once again *Dr Caligari.* On *Caligari*'s sets, chiaroscuro was directly inscribed onto the scenery via stylized painted stripes. Burton stylizes this gesture even further by repeating the stripe motif out of context, so the play of light and dark is abstracted into a standalone visual motif. Burton's stripes distil this Gothic duality into visual form.

This process is clearly at work in the 'By the Sea' sequence in *Sweeney Todd*, in which Mrs Lovett (Helena Bonham Carter) imagines taking a romantic seaside holiday with Sweeney (Johnny Depp) and their servant boy/adopted son Toby (Edward Sanders). This sequence is striking in that it does not, at first glance, provide any of the expected signifiers of the Gothic: the sun shines brightly in a blue sky filled with puffy white clouds; the characters sunbathe on the beach dressed in stylised, brightly coloured versions of nineteenth-century bathing costumes and promenade on an impossibly pristine pier in an impeccable white suit and candy-coloured gown. Nevertheless the overall impression provided by the sequence is a Gothic one, and this is for two reasons: the make-up and performance of the actors, and the intrusion of the stripe motif onto the pastoral scene. Immediate signs of disjuncture between Lovett's fantasy and the film's 'reality' are revealed in the characters' pallid skin, black eye make-up (intentionally reminiscent of silent film stars), wayward hair and awkward physical postures. This is reinforced more subtly by the stripes, which are, on the surface, appropriate to the seaside setting: traditional striped deckchairs litter the beach; Mrs. Lovett's candy-striped dress (historically accurate to the 1890s, which is not when *Sweeney Todd* is set) recalls seaside rock; and the bathing costumes have an evidently nautical theme. However, the stripe motif is so insistent that it becomes unsettling. Sweeney's bathing costume recalls a prison uniform; a close-up on his immaculate white suit reveals that it is faintly pin-striped; the

white streak in his hair picks up and echoes the theme. Stripes permeate the landscape, echoed in the boards of the pier and the wooden spokes of the beach-side veranda. The insistency of the motif creates the impression that it is, in the same sense as *Caligari*'s chiaroscuro, 'painted on' – not organic to the *mise en scène*, but an imposition that distorts and fragments it, the stripes becoming, to recall Myrone's articulation of visual Gothic, 'artificial tools of rhetorical expression inhabiting a world quite of their own'.

Disconcertingly, Burton claims that he did not see *The Cabinet of Dr Caligari* until relatively far on into his career, and that the striking similarities in *Vincent* and elsewhere owe more of a debt to his childhood love of Dr Seuss. Stripes are, of course, a distinguishing feature of Seuss's most iconic character, the Cat in the Hat. Burton's yoking of a classic of European art cinema to an icon of American popular culture is entirely characteristic of his work, which tends to meld high and low culture reference points. His privileging of Dr Seuss over Dr Caligari suggests a deliberate iconoclasm and celebration of the popular that could be seen as disingenuous. It also filters expressionism through a comic sensibility. The striking sequence from *Caligari* where Cesare, the somnambulist, carries the heroine Jane over angular roof tops, is echoed repeatedly in Burton's films, most notably *The Nightmare before Christmas*, in which the Pumpkin King of Halloween Town, Jack Skellington, climbs a mountain peak ending in a spiral, where he stands silhouetted against the moon. This image ultimately derives from Caspar David Friedrich's *Wanderer above the Sea of Fog* of 1818, an icon of German Romanticism in which the male subject surveys the sublime natural landscape from above, in a position of precarious mastery. *Caligari* replays this image in a tortured urban landscape which threatens to overwhelm the subject. In *The Nightmare before Christmas*, the conversion of Caligari's angular lines to trailing spirals more reminiscent of Dr Seuss converts expressionist angst into whimsy, offering a form of Gothic which is disturbing yet playful. The embellishment provided by the spiral tip of the hill evokes Gothic decorativeness and elaboration but also softens the image. The close of the film sees Sally and Jack united on the hilltop, offering unity and romance rather than dissolution and fracture. If the stripes in 'Beyond the Sea' are abstracted shadows looming over the pastoral landscape, the decorative spirals of *The Nightmare before Christmas* offer a softening of Gothic into what might be called the 'whimsical macabre', which I will explore more extensively in Chapter 5. Both motifs could be said to be part of the vocabulary of happy Gothic, a means of expressing a Gothic we might think of as 'light' in the sense of bright, rather than 'lite'.

Burton to Burtonesque: *A Series of Unfortunate Events* and *Crimson Peak*

Tim Burton does not fit the conventional pattern of an *auteur* director: with the exception of *Ed Wood*, all of his films have been made within the Hollywood studio system and many have been allocated blockbuster budgets and the accompanying promotion and merchandising. Nevertheless, in other ways he could be described as an auteur: he works consistently with the same close-knit circle of collaborators, and his distinctive visual style can be copied in a similar way to that of directors like Alfred Hitchcock or Orson Welles. The adjective 'Burtonesque' was registered on the website Urban Dictionary, a catalogue of slang and colloquial expressions, in 2008 and was the stated theme of a 2012 episode of the TV game show *Face Off*. Burton's visual signature is arguably the most recognizable of any twenty-first-century film director, and nowhere are its transferable properties more visible than in Brad Silberling's *Lemony Snicket's A Series of Unfortunate Events*, a film seemingly made in deliberate imitation of Burton's style for commercial purposes, and in Guillermo del Toro's *Crimson Peak*, a film which demonstrates rather how Burton's focus on Gothic aesthetics has become a pervasive mode of post-millennial Gothic.

Lemony Snicket's A Series of Unfortunate Events is an adaptation of the first three novels of the series of children's books by Daniel Handler. These are already Burtonesque texts, with the first instalment, *The Bad Beginning* (1999), published two years after Burton's quasi-children's book *The Melancholy Death of Oyster Boy*. *The Bad Beginning* tells the story of the Baudelaire orphans Violet, Klaus and Sunny, who in a characteristically Gothic plot are persecuted by their nefarious uncle, Count Olaf, in his quest to defraud them of their inheritance. The Baudelaire orphans are suitably Burtonesque children who, like the protagonists of *Vincent*, *Frankenweenie* and *Edward Scissorhands*, are fiendishly talented, ingenious and 'miserable' outsiders forever in exile from a happy domestic world. The books helped popularize the trend in children's publishing for highly ornamented volumes that traded on the nostalgic attraction of the book as object. Brett Helquist's black and white, faux-Victorian illustrations were central to the books' appeal and an important influence on the look of the film. The illustrations are angular, stylized, highly detailed and feature a 'highly linear, expressive use of drawing' compounded by a strong upward line, often realised through pointed gables or arches. While not directly reminiscent of Burton's own illustrations, they do recall a shared source in German expressionist film.

The film adaptation, therefore, captures and intensifies the already Burtonesque qualities in the books. This was widely recognized by reviewers, with Scott Foundas of *Variety* opining, '*A Series of Unfortunate Events* suggests what *Mary Poppins* might have looked like had Tim Burton directed it' (Foundas 2004). Reviewers recognized, too, that these qualities were largely imparted by two of Burton's most persistent collaborators, production designer Rick Heinrichs and costume designer Colleen Atwood, as well as cinematographer Emmanuel Lubezki, who had previously worked on *Sleepy Hollow*. Notably, the film also features actor Catherine O'Hara, veteran of (at that time) two Burton movies. Finally, it recalls Burton's oeuvre through the use of animated sequences: the opening parody of a Disneyesque film called *The Littlest Elf* suggests the sort of film that the young Burton struggled to illustrate when working at Disney in the early 1980s, executed in Burton's preferred medium of stop motion animation; while the end credits, in contrast, are accompanied by an extended black-and-white paper cut-out sequence designed by Jamie Caliri with a strongly Burtonesque feel.

Heinrichs and Atwood infuse the film with a Burtonesque style, recalling Burton's stylistic flourishes both generally and specifically. Stripes enter the film more subtly than in Burton, but they are there on the skirt of Violet Baudelaire's (Emily Browning) gown and are suggested by the lacing of her corset and the ribs of her lace sleeves; they also appear in glimpses such as the fisherman's sweater worn by Count Olaf (Jim Carrey) in one of his disguises. Olaf's frayed, pin-striped suit is explicitly reminiscent of that worn by the animated figure of Jack Skellington in *The Nightmare before Christmas* and, combined with Carrey's wild grey hair, implicitly recalls Michael Keaton's more luridly striped suit in *Beetlejuice* (neither, it should be noted, designed by Atwood – although Heinrichs worked on both films). The plot similarity to *Beetlejuice* is striking – a manic, unsavoury older man attempts to force a teenage Goth girl into marriage against her will – and this is reinforced by costume. While Violet's faux-Victorian gown is more structured and detailed than Lydia Deetz's (Winona Ryder) trailing black robes, and Violet's costume is of a piece with the darkness of her world rather than Lydia's self-consciously resistant style, when placed beside Count Olaf in his striped suit the echoes resonate between the two films.

The production design in *A Series of Unfortunate Events*, again by regular Burton collaborator Rick Heinrichs, is also strikingly reminiscent of earlier Burton films, in particular *Edward Scissorhands*, for which Heinrichs was set designer. In *Edward Scissorhands*, the inventor's castle deliberately references previous screen castles, most notably that featured in Tod Browning's *Dracula*

(1931), but also established a distinctive style of its own. Avon Lady Peg Boggs (Dianne Wiest) crosses through a series of framing doorways and thresholds into a suite of vast rooms seemingly composed according to Horace Walpole's concept of 'sharawaggi' or lack of symmetry. This architecture is apparently constructed without right angles: the few straight lines are broken and jagged; windowpanes are irregularly spaced; the curving lines of the staircase and windows are suggestive of organic forms. The overall effect is both stark and overelaborate, creating a distinctive sense of timelessness, in which the architecture evokes Gothic precedents but cannot be matched to any specific historical style. This simultaneous evocation and evasion of period style is deliberately recreated in the world of *A Series of Unfortunate Events*. On the accompanying DVD extras, Heinrichs explains that he planned Olaf's mansion to have 'a cobbled-together feel, so that it wasn't a[n] … off-the-shelf, out-of-the-catalogue Victorian house. Everything is … twisted and subverted' ('A Woeful World' 2005). As in *Edward Scissorhands*, the *mise en scène* is characteristically over-crowded with detail and ornamentation, set off by vast interior spaces often structured around pointed Gothic arches. The Baudelaire orphans are repeatedly shown framed by metal gates or arches, emulating Helquist's illustrations but also a characteristic Burtonesque motif.

The overall effect of *A Series of Unfortunate Events* demonstrates the way that Burton's visual style has become recognizable, replicable and above all a distinctive form of Gothic in its own right. Esteemed film critic Roger Ebert declared of the film: 'there is a problem, and the problem is, everything seems to be an act. Nothing really seems to be at stake. The villains are teeth-gnashing hams, the hazards are more picturesque than frightening, and the children are unnaturally collected and capable' (Ebert 2004). Like Weinstock and Botting, Ebert uses the 'frightening' as a measure of the film's success, and views its performative or artificial qualities as a flaw. Arguably, however, the film's stylization of the 'frightening' is its aesthetic purpose; the term 'picturesque' is revealing as it suggests that the film (deliberately) resembles a painting.

While del Toro is a director with his own claims to *auteur* status, reviews of *Crimson Peak*, like those of *A Series of Unfortunate Events*, dwelt on its Burtonesque qualities. Jake Wilson of the *Sydney Morning Herald* commented, 'Tim Burton is a master of this sort of thing' (Wilson 2015), while Tom Huddleston of London *Time Out* complained that '*Crimson Peak* feels more like something Tim Burton might cook up, and not in a good way' (Huddleston 2015). The film is saturated with direct and implicit intertextual references to Gothic novels and films, Burton films among them: the ironwork gate that frames the mansion to

which Thomas Sharpe (Tom Hiddlestone) brings his new bride strongly recalls a repeated motif in Burton films including *Edward Scissorhands*, *Big Fish*, *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*, *Alice in Wonderland* and *Dark Shadows* (as well as, ultimately, the gates to Manderley in Alfred Hitchcock's *Rebecca*, 1940, and Xanadu in Welles's *Citizen Kane*, 1941); while the casting of Mia Wasikowska as heroine Edith Cushing inevitably recalls her role in *Alice*, particularly when connected with the vivid butterfly imagery in both films.

Crimson Peak nevertheless plays Gothic 'straight', eschewing generic hybridity, in a way that is seldom seen in a Burton film. Rather than innovate on Gothic formulae, it condenses them with a new intensity. A veritable compendium of Gothic tropes, all the clichés are present and correct, to the extent that they start to perform together in a new way, as described by Umberto Eco in his analysis of *Casablanca*: 'Two clichés make us laugh, but a hundred clichés move us because we sense dimly that the clichés are talking among themselves and celebrating a reunion' (1995: 11). Del Toro lacks Burton's comic sensibility; where the soapy melodrama of the comparable *Dark Shadows* is leavened with mordant wit and even farce, *Crimson Peak* ramps up the melodrama with jump scares and a piquant seasoning of gore.

What *Crimson Peak* crystallizes is a new visual language of the Gothic embodied in set, production design and costume. Del Toro's earlier films, such as *The Devil's Backbone* (2001) and *Pan's Labyrinth* (2006), use Gothic to talk about something else – specifically, the Spanish Civil War. They are beautiful and affecting examples of social conscience Gothic, of haunting as metaphor for social trauma and the ravages of history. *Crimson Peak*, on the other hand, only talks about itself – and other Gothic texts. To suggest that it is therefore vacant or superficial, however, is to miss the point. The plot is not the purpose of the movie, but a vehicle for a visual narrative. The images *are* the story.

Crimson Peak, in an even more extreme version of Burton's historically set films *Sleepy Hollow* and *Sweeney Todd*, dispenses with the verisimilitude of the costume drama and makes the costumes an end in itself. As I have argued elsewhere, Burton characteristically unsettles the conventional logic of the costume drama by deploying costumes that evoke historical period but are overtly stylized and sometimes anachronistic, ultimately serving an affective or expressionist purpose rather than that of establishing historical authenticity (Spooner 2013: 55–7). The same could be said of *Crimson Peak*, which is nominally set on the cusp of the twentieth century but whose costumes, designed by Kate Hawley, transcend historical specificity in their provision of an independent Gothic vocabulary. In the ball scene, Thomas's sinister sister Lucille (Jessica Chastain)

wears a red dress with a high collar bristling with tiny jewels like drops of blood. Edith's silhouette becomes increasingly grotesque as the film progresses, with her corset and exaggerated puff sleeves deliberately echoing the swallowtail butterfly that is her recurrent emblem in the film, particularly when realized in yellow with a long trailing black bow at the back. She appears in a range of white nightgowns that become more diaphanous as the film progresses, and at one point the moonlight illuminating the puff sleeves resembles a swollen membrane or the dry tissue of a chrysalis, an organic thing connoting vulnerability but also horror. Similarly, her final appearance in an elaborately pin-tucked white nightgown with gigantic mutton-chop sleeves lends her a peculiarly hunchbacked appearance. Even the ghosts appear trailing veils and ectoplasm – a substance traditionally faked by nineteenth-century spiritualists with a combination of muslin and luminous paint. The spirit manifests through the literally material.

The film's grand theme is the Gothic motif of the red blood stain on white fabric and it repeats this colour scheme obsessively: red marks Edith's pillow, her handkerchief, the doctor's sleeve, and ultimately Edith's archetypal white dress. Each of these stains recalls that which the audience does not see: the bedsheets from the consummation of Edith and Thomas's marriage, the film's crucial emotional pivot. The film seems to deliberately rewrite Susan Gubar's influential essay on Isak Dinesen's short story, 'The Blank Page', in which nuns display the stained marital sheets of generations of royal brides – the final, anonymous sheet remaining blank. For Gubar, this is an extended metaphor for women's creativity in patriarchal culture: 'first, many women experience their own bodies as the only available medium for their art, with the result that the distance between the woman artist and her art is often radically diminished; second, one of the primary and most resonant metaphors provided by the female body is blood, and cultural forms of creativity are often experienced as a painful wounding' (1981: 248). The brides' stories are premised on their virginity and their compliance with a patriarchal culture – the story of the mysterious final bride can only remain untold. In *Crimson Peak*, Edith is an aspirant writer who when taunted with a remark that Jane Austen died a spinster retorts that Mary Shelley died a widow. Creativity is linked not to sexual purity (or frigidity) but to death and survival. Moreover, Edith is gifted a pen by her father at the beginning of the film, recalling Gilbert and Gubar's infamous opening line to *The Madwoman in the Attic*, 'Is a pen a metaphorical penis?' (1979: 3), as well as the familiar saying, 'The pen is mightier than the sword'. Although Edith initially rejects the pen for the typewriter, a symbol of modernity and liberation from patriarchal constraints (as it conceals her feminine handwriting), the pen later becomes a

weapon. Edith learns to write in blood other than her own, and fabric/skin is the blank page on which she writes. As she uncovers the bloody stories of the brides that have preceded her, her own marital sheets remain at first blank and then unseen, but the crimson ooze will not be stopped and becomes a story that is told repeatedly, obsessively, through the marking of red blood on white fabric/skin, red mud on white snow.

Arguably, then, the film is 'about' feminism and women's creativity, but these themes are not linked to historical struggle or a world outside of the fantastical one of the text; neither are they given a conclusion that is easy to read in any terms beyond those set up by the film itself. For del Toro, as for Burton, the images *are* the story.

Conclusion

What this chapter has suggested, then, is that through his visual style Tim Burton fashions a new kind of Gothic, one in which what Gothic looks like is more important than its adherence to narrative conventions. Burton's films are clearly not without Gothic subject-matter. The *Frankenstein* story weighs heavy in many of his narratives, and monsters, the grotesque and the supernatural recur in his work alongside themes of childhood trauma and adult outsiderdom. Nevertheless, Burton's priorities are visual, filtered through a Goth subcultural sensibility, a background in illustration and animation and an enhanced concern with production design. I suggest that we need a new way of thinking about this kind of Gothic; rather than devalue it as 'Gothic lite', we need to pay attention to its visual properties and engage with the different kinds of work that they do. Burton's influence on contemporary Gothic cannot be over-estimated. His version of the Gothic has become sufficiently influential to shift popular understanding of the term in the twenty-first century. Thanks to him, we all know the Gothic when we see it, and increasingly, Gothic is defined by Burton, rather than Burton by Gothic.

3

‘Forget Nu Rave, We’re Into Nu Grave!’: High Street Style and the Uses of Gothic Romance

Defining Gothic fashion

The increasingly visual nature of post-millennial Gothic is demonstrated particularly clearly in fashion, which I here use in a broad sense to incorporate both designer-led fashion and street style. As I suggested in the previous chapter, the new Gothic aesthetic associated with Tim Burton is precisely contemporaneous with the emergence of Goth subculture in Britain at the end of the 1970s and its rapid spread to the United States and eventually worldwide. While Goth may be rooted in the Gothic literary tradition, literature is not necessarily the means through which its styles and thematic preoccupations are communicated; references are often received through films, music lyrics, album artwork, promotional videos, comics and latterly through websites and social media platforms such as Pinterest. Music aside, Goth is an overwhelmingly visual subculture. Moreover, while musical affiliations are important to members of the subculture, this is less evident to outsiders, whose perception of Goth is largely dependent on visual cues and in particular on sartorial style. If the return of Gothic was a repeated feature of fashion editorial in the 1990s, this process continued unabated into the 2000s, with some distinctive developments, which this chapter will attempt to unpack.

‘Gothic’ style has become one of the most instantly recognizable looks of the late twentieth and early twenty-first century, its distinctive combination of black and jewel colours with motifs taken from Victorian mourning wear, Punk, fetish, and other period or vintage sources repeatedly featured in subcultural blogs, broadsheet style pages and mainstream fashion magazines. A scholarly definition of Gothic fashion that transcends a list of its features and style references, however, has proved more elusive. From September 2008 to February

2009, the Museum at the Fashion Institute of Technology, New York, mounted a major exhibition entitled *Gothic: Dark Glamour* that attempted to remedy this lack through an extensive exploration of the resonance of Gothic in fashion. Catwalk ensembles by Alexander McQueen and John Galliano were juxtaposed with Victorian mourning wear, Winona Ryder's costume from *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (1992) and Goth street style from the United Kingdom, North America and Japan. The curator, Valerie Steele, suggested in the accompanying book that 'Gothic fashion is … a rejection of "normal", "natural" beauty in favor of an alternative vision of horrific, excessive, artificial and (sometimes) sexually fetishistic beauty' (2008: 79), and her choices in the exhibition, from h. Naoto's Gothic Lolita outfit to Rei Kawakubo's celebrated 'bump' dress for Comme des Garçons, bore this out. Among the highly nuanced range of meanings associated with Gothic fashion in the exhibition, Gothic as transgressive and resistant to mainstream norms was repeatedly foregrounded.

One of the most striking things about *Gothic: Dark Glamour*, however, was the way that it was pitched between two extremes – designer fashion and subcultural style. In much fashion discourse, both of these are implicitly regarded as more significant, more creative and artistic, even more 'real' and 'authentic' (in that their creative vision is less directly mediated through the apparatus of mass consumption), than the ordinary clothes the majority of the population wear every day. Even the subcultural outfits in the exhibition were, in general, beautifully crafted one-off pieces by underground and alternative designers rather than the sort of things worn by the teenagers that hang out in the market square in provincial British towns on Saturday afternoons. On one level this is completely justifiable – the business of a museum is, arguably, to collect together the most precious and exceptional artefacts of a given culture. *Gothic: Dark Glamour* was an unqualified success in artistic, critical and commercial terms. By its very nature, however, it could not encompass the full range of associations between Gothic and clothes. Clothes are often Gothicized by context: by what happens when they are worn. They are also Gothicized by the discourses that spring up around them: by their description on websites and in magazines; by the way they are marketed to consumers. *Gothic: Dark Glamour* acknowledged this by featuring a number of designer dresses that had been 'styled' as Gothic in *Vogue* while not necessarily possessing any inherently Gothic features. Steele explained that Gothic could also reside in the story told about a dress (Spooner 2010: 155). But these beautifully made, expensive items (in this case by Chanel) were still beyond the reach of the majority of consumers.

The exhibition got me thinking about the kind of Gothic fashion featured in mid-ranking, mainstream fashion magazines like *Marie Claire* and *Grazia*, and the kind of clothes available to buy in Miss Selfridge or Topshop – the kind of clothes I could see people around me wearing every day, and might even consider buying myself. High street [1] or mainstream fashion is less frequently the subject of academic research than either designer fashion or subcultural style, and is often constructed in parasitic terms as producing weak copies of designer originals or diluting subcultural innovations, but its relationship to both is more complex than this. Are these clothes Gothic? Why would retailers and the fashion media use the word Gothic to describe them, and what would they mean by it? Could a piece of clothing bought in H&M or Gap be transgressive and resistant to normative standards of beauty? What might it tell us about the state of twenty-first-century Gothic, that the middle-class, quintessentially 'English' department store Marks and Spencer named one of their collections 'Gothic Chic'? In this chapter I explore some of these questions, while demonstrating that Gothic is a mobile set of discourses, in fashion as elsewhere, constantly positioned and repositioned in different ways across the contemporary popular sphere.

The return of 'Gothic Chic'

The title of this chapter derives from a fashion headline in *Grazia* magazine from 30 July 2007.[2] According to the accompanying article, Gothic is back, yet again. Only this time round, it's different. Labelling the look 'Nu Grave', in response to the so-called Nu Rave scene of circa 2006, the article cites club-goer and editor of *i-D* magazine Fran Burns as saying 'It's extreme glamour, very catwalk … It's glossy not gothy' ('Forget Nu Rave, We're Into Nu Grave!' 2007: 17). Over the first decade of the twenty-first century, the Gothic fashion revival gathered force in mainstream culture, culminating in the autumn/winter season 2008, in which 'Gothic chic' comprehensively permeated the British high street. Symptoms of this ubiquity included celebrity stylist Gok Wan offering tips on how to achieve designer Gothic style on a budget on his Channel 4 show *Fashion Fix*, and stores including Topshop, Marks and Spencer and Miss Selfridge presenting Gothic-inspired collections. Although Gothic fashion revivals have continued since (most provocatively, perhaps, the merging of sportswear and Goth style in the 'Health Goth' trend of 2014), there are particular contextual reasons why 2008 is a key year, as this chapter will show.

Gothic has been coming back for approximately two hundred and fifty years, in one form or another – the notion of revival has always been crucial to its definition. I have argued elsewhere that these revivals took on increasing urgency within the fashion milieu in the 1990s, with fashion magazines proclaiming 'Gothic is back' at regular intervals (Spooner 2004: 186–97, 2007: 143–54). As noted in the Introduction, some critics, notably Christoph Grunenberg and Richard Davenport-Hines, sought to link a resurgence of interest in Gothic across media in the 1990s to *fin-de-siècle* decadence or pre-millennial tension. Yet these revivals have shown no signs of stopping in the twenty-first century; if anything they have gathered pace. Nevertheless, as *Grazia* and Fran Burns suggest, Gothic is, inevitably, different this time round. It always is: not only does commercial fashion constantly update and renovate 'retro' looks so that new purchases are always necessary, but manifestations of Gothic are necessarily historically and culturally specific, their relationship with the past always determined by present concerns. The 2008 Gothic revival in mainstream fashion performed a particular kind of cultural work that I identified in the Introduction as specifically *post*-millennial, as what we might think of (troping literary postmodernism) as a simultaneous and paradoxical continuation of, and self-conscious break from, the supposed pre-millennial mood. Accounts of twenty-first-century Gothic style signal a new sensibility. It is not necessarily more glamorous, as *Grazia* claims – Goth subculture has always had a glamorous element – but it is more celebratory. The collision of Nu Rave and Nu Grave in *Grazia*'s headline is more than a facetious turn of phrase. The darkness and high glamour of the look celebrated by Burns may be a reaction to the self-conscious inanities of Nu Rave, but as the echo of 'rave' in 'grave' implies, the one also implicates the other. [3] Twenty-first-century Gothic does not define itself in opposition to the pursuit of ecstasy, it has incorporated it.

Goth's longevity as a subculture, anthropologist Ted Polhemus has argued, derives from its inherent opposition to mainstream consumer ideology: 'To a majority that fetishises happiness, Goth is by its very nature off-putting' (1994: 97). Even when individual designers have appropriated Goth style – Thierry Mugler and Jean-Paul Gaultier are prominent examples from the 1990s – it has failed to become a major trend, as it supposedly remains antithetical to pleasure-seeking Western culture. In the twenty-first century, however, Goth is a subculture increasingly stripped of its darkness and ripe for incorporation, as this chapter will go on to demonstrate. At the same time, it seems that Western culture increasingly may be in search of more complex forms of gratification than mere hedonism. To recall again a point made in the

Introduction, Alexandra Warwick argues that rather than an attempt to exorcise trauma, 'contemporary cultural Gothic is a staging of the desire *for* trauma, the desire to be haunted, because we do not feel complete without it' (2007: 12). Examining the explosion of Gothic in contemporary culture and academic criticism, she concludes that 'Gothic can no longer proceed from the margins, because there is no marginality, it is where everybody wants to live' (14). For Warwick, 'feeling Gothicky' (the title of her article) is no longer the pretension of a disaffected few, but a mainstream concern. And indeed, Warwick's thesis seems to be reflected in what has happened to Gothic style in the years leading up to autumn/winter 2008.

Goth subcultural style has always had a performative element, but over the last few years, this has been increasingly emphasized in accounts authored by members of the subcultures themselves. Accusations of negatively defined behaviour – whether violence, blood-drinking, self-harm, suicidal impulses, or Satanism – are typically resisted with protestations that the subculture is about creative self-expression, and that Goths are more interested in dressing up, listening to music and enjoying the social benefits of belonging to a subculture than in fulfilling stereotypes of being miserable loners. Ethnographic research has repeatedly emphasized that a propensity for Gothic style cannot be read as an index of the wearer's personality. Paul Hodkinson's extensive research into the British Goth scene, for example, observes that 'there was a particular tendency for hostility toward the suggestion that their dark hair or clothes said anything about their character, outlook or behaviour … that style was held to be significant in and of itself as a set of enthusiastic preferences located within, and not beyond, the sphere of the aesthetic' (2002: 62). Nevertheless, many participants associated their shared style with 'general qualities … including individuality, creativity, open-mindedness and commitment' (62). Similarly, Maria Mellins's research into the London vampire community identifies a trend for self-identified vampires to dissociate themselves from blood-drinking practices and emphasize their enjoyment of wearing vampire costumes (Mellins 2013: 16). It is impossible to assess whether the behaviour of Goths has changed or whether this has been a continuous feature of Goth. It is nevertheless clear that the way the subculture is constructed, both by the mainstream media and by Goths themselves, shifted significantly over the first decade of the twenty-first century. This was triggered by two occasions when Goth received unprecedented mainstream media coverage: the shootings at Columbine High School in Colorado on 20 April 1999, and the murder of Sophie Lancaster in Bacup, Lancashire, on 11 August 2007. The defence of Goth mounted in response to

these events in turn enabled the appropriation of Goth by the mainstream on an unprecedented scale.

Goth in the media

Mainstream news stories about Goth tend to fall into two categories. Most commonly, they identify Goth as a source of violence against others, including the Columbine Massacre, Kimveer Gill's attack on students at Dawson College in Quebec, Canada, in September 2006, and the German case of the so-called Vampire Killers Daniel and Manuela Ruda in 2002. Alternatively, Goth is depicted as a cult of depression that encourages children to self-harm, as in the British newspaper *The Daily Mail*'s campaign against Emo in 2008, which collapsed the two subcultures (Sands 2006). Columbine was perhaps the first and most far-reaching of these news stories, as well as the most spurious in its association of the killers with Goth.

Initial media reportage of the Columbine shootings, in which twelve high school students and a teacher were murdered by two of their classmates, labelled the killers as Goths. The night after the massacre, ABC's *20/20* news show linked the killings to 'the Gothic Movement', describing it as a violent cult ('The Goth Phenomenon' 1999). Although this sensationalist reporting relied on only one flimsy source, it was almost immediately taken up by the global media, who seized on details of the killers' lives including a purported liking for industrial music and a peripheral association with a school clique calling themselves 'The Trenchcoat Mafia', identifying these as markers of a Goth identity. The moral panic that ensued meant that many Goths, particularly in the United States, felt impelled to engage in very public defence of the subculture. A community that until that point had managed more or less to preserve its underground status was suddenly forced to deal with the scrutiny of the global media. Sam Rosenthal on Projekt Darkwave, for example, posted five days after the shootings to allege,

> Goth grew up this week. 'Goth' has been thrown in the faces of the general public. People who never heard of this music and lifestyle are seeing it on the news and seeing it in the paper. People in our genre have talked for years about Goth being buried in the underground; we have wondered if it would ever 'break'. As a subject, Goth is now reality. It's unfortunate that a tragedy has brought it out into the open, and I don't think that anybody relishes the way that this has unfolded … however we cannot hide from the subject, or suggest that it is not worthy of

> discussion, now that it has happened. The media moves at lightning speed in this last year of the century, and we cannot let them define us. (Rosenthal 1999)

Goths were quick to point out the specious nature of the media claims surrounding Goth, insistently distancing the subculture from violent action and pointing out that Goths tend to be the victims of violence and persecution rather than its perpetrators. According to the Goths who rose to their community's defence, Goth was not miserable and certainly not violent: its values cohered around creativity, self-expression, communality, the embrace of difference and the perception of beauty in the darker side of life. Alicia Porter Smith posted a statement the day after the shootings on her well-known site, *A Study of Gothic Subculture*, to assert:

> Goths are stereotypically nonviolent people … There are no set of over-arching beliefs or values, no simple definitions, and no generalizations that are universally true within the Gothic subculture. I can't emphasize that point enough … The gothic subculture does not condone violence, much less mass slaughter and suicide. (Porter Smith 1999)

Eloni Feliciano makes a similar point as she affirms,

> I have never considered the scene to be a gateway to violence against my peers. In fact, quite the opposite – I always felt that the scene was a cohesive community that gave me support during tough times … The Goth community itself is more like Jack Skellington from *A Nightmare before Christmas* [*sic*] – gentle, inquisitive, and a little odd. (Cited in Sweeney 2004)

Here, tellingly, the Burtonesque is invoked as a model for contemporary Goth, and the community positioned in terms of what I will call in Chapter 5 the 'whimsical macabre', a mode in which Gothic becomes playful and quirky rather than a source of horror. As the initial shock turned into reflection, the positive repositioning gathered pace. Nancy Kilpatrick's *The Goth Bible* is typical when it states:

> Despite the dark current that carries Goths along, and maybe because of it, goth is also about fun … About flapping your latex bat wings in the face of convention and secretly giggling at the notion that your very existence upsets the mainstream … most of them do not consider themselves dismal. Goths, in fact, are some of the most vibrantly alive individuals walking the planet. (2005: 2–8)

Academic research also reflected this trend: Dunja Brill's PhD arguing that Goths 'aspire to middle-class values and will end up in respectable professions' received widespread press attention in 2006, with pieces in the *Guardian* and *Independent* as well as on Goth blogs (Byrne 2006, Simpson 2006).

The process of repositioning Goth as peaceable, creative and essentially performative in its embrace of darkness continued throughout the early years of the twenty-first century, culminating in the response to the murder of Sophie Lancaster's murder in 2007. This case was a major news story in the United Kingdom but did not receive the same level of international media exposure as Columbine, although accounts spread quickly online through the global alternative community. Briefly, Lancaster and her boyfriend Robert Maltby, both of whom self-identified as Goths, were attacked by a group of teenagers while walking home through the small town of Bacup, Lancashire, late at night. Both were severely injured and Lancaster later died in hospital from the injuries she sustained. This occurred less than two weeks after *Grazia*'s 'Nu Grave' article hit the newsstands: as the latest Gothic revival was being championed in the fashion press, subcultural Goths were encountering persecution on the streets. After a trial which whipped up media concern with a supposedly 'feral' youth roaming Britain's streets, two of the assailants were convicted of murder and sentenced to life imprisonment; three others were convicted of grievous bodily harm with intent and given shorter sentences.

Lancaster's murder was the opposite situation to Columbine in that individuals labelled as Goths were the victims of crime rather than the perpetrators, and the mainstream media response to it was remarkable in that it therefore presented Goths in a sympathetic light. In addition, the event occurred in the United Kingdom rather than America, where subcultures have a rather different status in the mainstream media, with a greater tendency to be incorporated through comedy or domesticization. In contrast to the demonization of Goth by the American media after Columbine, following Sophie's death the British press characteristically recuperated Goths as possibly eccentric but creative and ultimately harmless individuals, while displacing moral panic onto other social problems. For the tabloid press, this tended to settle on the debate over 'bad' parenting, so that Sophie's mum emerged as tragic heroine and the killers' parents as the true villains of the piece. Typical headlines in Britain's best-selling tabloid *The Sun*, for example, include, 'Sophie mum's plea for peace' (Patrick 2008b), 'Goth kill: mums in hiding' (Ashford 2008), 'Tearful mum flees murder trial' (2008) and even 'Sophie's dad in tattoo tribute' (Patrick 2008a). This strategy displaced any residual anxiety about subcultures onto a more specific one about working-class parents unable to control their children – or even, in this case, passing on their own anti-social behaviour to their children. It also fell back on a characteristic tabloid response to subcultures, first identified by Dick Hebdige in his seminal *Subculture: The Meaning of Style*, whereby members

of subcultures are restored to the family. Hebdige argues that features such as 'Punks and Mothers' from the 15 October 1977 issue of *Woman's Own*, depicting Punks 'with smiling mothers' in idyllic family scenes, 'minimize the Otherness so stridently proclaimed in punk style' ([1979]1988: 98). In the sequence of articles published by *The Sun*, Sophie's Goth identity is minimized in favour of her familial identity and her loss articulated not, for example, through her boyfriend or peers but rather through the universalized spectacle of her grieving parents.

The Daily Mail, a conservative mid-market publication with the largest circulation of any newspaper in the United Kingdom, took a slightly different approach. The paper positioned Sophie and Robert as 'good' children in order to tap into another current moral panic: binge drinking and 'yob' culture. Typical headlines include, 'Guilty: The teenage binge drinkers who kicked a girl to death for being a Goth' (2008), 'Mother of goth student kicked to death by binge-drinking teens attacks rise of "skunk" cannabis' (Hull 2008) and 'A mother's grief and a generation without morals' (2008). Interestingly, the *Mail* emphasizes the fact Sophie was a student, with one headline actually referring to Sophie as a 'female college student' rather than a Goth ('Boy, 16' 2008). For the *Mail*, Sophie and her killers become representatives of two sides in a class war, between well-educated, aspirational, middle-class kids and unruly, criminal, binge-drinking, lower-class teenagers. *The Daily Mail* also follows Hebdige's account of ideological incorporation by minimizing the otherness of subcultures – here by displacement, emphasizing the otherness of other kinds of unruly youth. In this variation on a Gothic narrative, Sophie is the heroine/victim, while her killers are positioned as monstrous. The horrific and excessive is associated not with Goth style and culture, but with a demonized working-class youth culture of 'hoodies', thus providing the right-wing media a platform to pontificate on what would eventually become known, in future prime minister David Cameron's phrase, as 'broken Britain'.

Crucially, however, distinguishing the case from earlier models of subcultural incorporation, both papers' reporting strategies anticipate reactions to the murder from within the subculture itself. What is distinctive in the reporting of Sophie Lancaster's murder was that in the weeks following Sophie's death, it was not only the mainstream media which sought to minimize the otherness of Goths, but Goths themselves, in a series of campaigns to promote awareness and tolerance of alternative lifestyle choices. Indirectly, these campaigns also sought to minimize the otherness of Goth, by demanding its recognition and protection by mainstream society.

These campaigns were controversial amongst Goths and it should be stressed that they were not universally adopted or admired by the subcultural community. Nevertheless, there was sufficient support for a petition to the British government calling for the legal definition of hate crime to be changed to include crimes against subcultures for it to attract 7,000 signatures. Although the petition was unsuccessful, its aims remain central to The Sophie Lancaster Foundation, a charity set up by Sylvia Lancaster in her daughter's memory, which carries out educational programmes within schools and 'work[s] in conjunction with politicians and police forces to ensure individuals who are part of subcultures are protected by the law' (*The Sophie Lancaster Foundation*). In 2013, as a result of the charity's efforts to raise awareness, Greater Manchester Police made the decision to record attacks on Goths, Emos and Punks as hate crimes, thus enabling victims access to enhanced support mechanisms ('Manchester Police' 2013). Over the next two years they were followed by forces in Durham, East Sussex, Hampshire, Lancashire, Leicestershire, Suffolk, Warwickshire and West Mercia ('Subculture Abuse Classed as Hate Crime', 2015).

The positive impact of The Sophie Lancaster Foundation's work is unquestionable. Nevertheless, the assorted campaigns to change the status of subcultures in UK law revises the ways in which subcultures have conventionally been understood, and deserves further comment. When subcultures have previously mobilized *en masse* it has always been to resist the imposition of legislature perceived to inhibit alternative lifestyles: for example, the widespread and vocal campaigning against the United Kingdom's Criminal Justice Act of 1994, which effectively outlawed raves and free parties by legislating against unauthorized public gatherings, collective trespass and amplified music with repetitive beats. In contrast, to seek to 'authorize' subculture by legislating to protect lifestyle choice is a radical repositioning of what subculture means. The 'sub' in subculture implies something hidden, underground, beneath the radar of mainstream culture. To 'protect' subculture by bringing it within the disciplinary networks of the legal system is to remove that subterranean element, bring it into the light.

At the same time, the 'resistant' element of subculture that Clarke, Hall, Jefferson and Roberts identified as symbolic in the landmark text *Resistance through Rituals* has become more than an inarticulate, 'symbolic' expression of dissatisfaction with the parent culture, but a literalized, self-conscious and articulate demand for the right to individual lifestyle choice (Clarke et al. 2003: 9–74). Resistance, moreover, is not directed at the parent culture in any

straightforward way, as no significant portion of that culture could be said to support hate crime, whether against Goths or anyone else. Resistance centres around perceived intolerant groups within that culture, most significantly 'delinquent' working-class youth, and a state that is presented as offering insufficient protection from those groups. The irony of such movements is that while wholly admirable in intention, they inadvertently function to undermine *as* subcultures the subcultures they seek to protect: the notion of legislating to protect lifestyle choice effectively 'authorizes' subculture and repositions it in relation to the dominant culture. Subcultures thrive on the concept of resistance, whether real or imagined; to become entirely tolerated by mainstream culture would also be to be fully assimilated by mainstream culture, youthful rebellion reduced to a style option. While few could be said to harbour nostalgia for a time prior to legislation against hate crime, a necessary corollary of increased tolerance is a readjustment of the relationships between subcultures and the mainstream. Goth in the twenty-first century is thus in a highly ambivalent position where it hovers on the brink of assimilation even as it has achieved a more coherent, unified and self-aware identity than ever before.

To return to the media response to Sophie Lancaster's death, the newly positive construction of Goth was reinforced by representations of Sophie herself. Significantly, stories throughout the media repeat Sophie's mother's comments about missing her daughter's smile, and the two most common pictures of Sophie circulated in all the press reports again show Sophie smiling. This is a conventional practice when releasing photographs of crime victims to the press, but in the circumstances, gains additional resonance. The version of Goth that Sophie came to represent was not depressive, miserable or Satanic, but rather the creative impulse of a normal girl with a zest for life and a love of alternative fashion: what in subcultural taxonomies is often playfully referred to as 'Perky Goth'. Initially inspired by the character 'Gilly Woods the Perky Goth' in *The Dork Tower* comic, Perky Goths, according to one online definition, 'try not to take themselves too seriously and don't brood' (Porter Smith, 'Terms and Definitions'). The term is sometimes retrospectively applied to Neil Gaiman's iconic comic book character, Death, the Grim Reaper reimagined as a cheerful Goth girl. Latterly, it might describe forensic scientist Abby Sciuto (Pauley Perrette) on American crime series *NCIS*, or clothing brand and animated children's television character Ruby Gloom, 'The Happiest Girl in the World'. Perky Goth began as a joke, but is fast becoming a dominant paradigm.

'Pretty Goth'

As the drama of Lancaster's killers' apprehension and trial played out, the Gothic revival continued apace in the fashion press. To take another example from *Grazia* magazine, the 3 March 2008 issue – again, fortuitously timed exactly one week before the trial of Sophie Lancaster's assailants opened – featured a news story entitled 'Pretty Fierce', centring on a photograph of pop star Lily Allen wearing Luella Bartley. The timing of the article was both ironic in its distance from the realities of being a (persecuted) Goth in the United Kingdom, and reflective of Goths' own move to position themselves as harmless. It explained, 'We're calling it Pretty Goth and we think it's the hippest look in fashion now … Mixing fierce-looking, slightly bondage-inspired accessories and goth make-up with a romantic dress is a perfect solution for those of us who don't want to go the whole way with this season's floral trend' ('Pretty Fierce' 2008: 29). There are many interesting things about this description – the bathos of 'slightly' bondage-inspired accessories, for example. Perhaps the most striking, however, is the way it suggests mixing two incongruous looks – romantic florals and Goth make-up. This is a staple practice of high fashion and also of subcultural bricolage – but here, Goth is seen as ameliorating a trend that is even more difficult to wear: florals. Goth is positioned not only as a style to be embraced, but as a means of mediating other even more 'difficult' styles. Fred Botting suggests in his book *Gothic Romanced*, 'in conjuring up terrors and intense effects, gothic seems to offer curious substance to an almost empty form' (2008a: 7–8). 'Pretty Fierce' visibly enacts this process: Gothic is being used to provide edge and substance to the frivolities of romance.

This partial embrace of Goth style developed into a full-blown celebration as 2008 progressed, following influential designer collections by Chanel, Givenchy and Alexander McQueen among others. The deluge of Gothic on the high street come the autumn/winter season presented Goth packaged as romantic nostalgia. High street store Miss Selfridge's website was representative in its blurb: 'Gothic Romance: In our AW08 trend preview we said this was set to be one of the biggest trends this season. We've updated the look with new key must-haves – black lace is the focal point of this darkly seductive look' ('AW08 – Gothic Romance – Miss Selfridge' 2008). Marks and Spencer's Per Una had a similar strap-line: 'Gothic Chic: A dramatic collection with a nod to historical costume, in sophisticated smokey grey, seagreen, black and dove-white' ('Gothic Chic' 2008). The collection also featured several pieces in orange. Per Una is marketed towards comfy, middle-class middle England: it is a moderately priced brand aimed at women in

their forties and fifties who do not want to relinquish their style but are not interested in looking cutting edge. For Per Una to promote a Gothic Chic collection is for Gothic style to have well and truly achieved saturation. The collection was, at basis, about smart coats and little black dresses with some period trimmings. Nothing sells like little black dresses, even in a recession.

There are revealing emphases in the language used to describe these clothes. A key feature is the evocation of the past: adjectives such as 'Victorian', 'romantic' and 'historical' are combined with the reassurance that the look has been updated and is therefore new, making it necessary to purchase. If you are a fortysomething customer coming to this look for the second time around, there can be no recycling of your 1980s Goth clothes. Moreover, Gothic is aligned with drama, costume and romance. The property of Gothic that is presented as appealing is its potential for fantasy dress-up – a form of sartorial escapism.

What *is* Gothic fashion here? It cannot be, as in the quote from Valerie Steele I cited above, 'a rejection of "normal", "natural" beauty in favor of an alternative vision of horrific, excessive, artificial and (sometimes) sexually fetishistic beauty'. This may be what *haute* designers are doing (Steele is particularly thinking of Alexander McQueen), but this is not what the high street is doing. The customers interpolated by the Marks and Spencer brand have little truck with the horrific and excessive, and their interest in the sexually fetishistic is unlikely to trespass beyond the safe limits of push-up bras and control underwear. The emphasis in the language used to sell these clothes is on femininity, glamour and romance. None of these traits are particularly different from those always valorized by mainstream fashion. Neither are they horrific, excessive or threatening in any way.

Ultimately, all of these versions of Goth style resemble Allan Lloyd Smith's description of postmodern Gothic as 'ransacking an imaginary museum of pastness' (1996: 11). They are vaguely Victorian, but not specifically so – a variety of period styles are merged into one overall look. Enjoyment of these clothes seems to be linked to what Brigid Cherry's research on female horror fans reveals as an investment in an 'imagined past', described by one respondent as 'a stylish image of dark beauty … The classically Gothic full-length dresses and cloaks … are … for me synonymous with grace and charm' (2002: 172). Cherry's respondent's comments are highly revealing: there is no specificity in the style of the clothes described, it is simply an approximation of a nostalgic vision of dark romance. Fred Botting's observations on the relationship between Gothic and romance again seem pertinent here: 'Romance, as it frames Gothic, seems to clean up its darker counterpart, sanitising its depravations; it tries to transform,

even ennoble, violent Gothic energies as a quest for love in the face of death; it recuperates Gothic excesses in the name of the heterosexual couple … repulsion cedes to attraction as horror gives way to romance' (2008a: 1–2).

'Repulsion cedes to attraction as horror gives way to romance': it could be a strap-line for Miss Selfridge's Gothic collection. There are, arguably, two things going on here. First, as Botting suggests, romance mirrors the endless deferral of satisfaction intrinsic to the working of desire: 'in never being able to satisfy or kill off desire, romance reproduces the incompletion required for more' (25). The perennial revival of Gothic as romance mimics or feeds into the imperative to consume on which the fashion industry is based. Gothic romance presents a dark image of insatiable consumer desire, an image which replays in an uncanny form the themes of credit culture and its incipient collapse.

Second, and perhaps more significantly, Gothic Chic 2008 collapses the themes of romance and mourning. Goth style has long drawn on Victorian mourning costume, as *Gothic: Dark Glamour* documented, displaying an ensemble worn to graveyard picnics by a contemporary Goth alongside an original 1870s black silk taffeta mourning dress and veil. In her book *Romance Writing*, Lynne Pearce describes how in the Gothic romance, there is a similarity 'between the states of heightened consciousness experienced during the first spell-binding moment of falling in love and those associated with mourning' (2007: 90). She explains how in the romance narrative, the separation from one's beloved is a period of grief but also one of perverse pleasure, as it enables an endless repetition of the moment of romantic discovery. For Pearce, this is most vividly illustrated by Cathy and Heathcliff's passion in *Wuthering Heights*, but a contemporary text like Stephenie Meyer's *Twilight* quartet (which contains explicit intertextual references to *Wuthering Heights*) fits the model equally well. *New Moon* (2006) in particular dramatizes this model of romance-as-mourning, as the heroine Bella expresses her overwhelming grief at her separation from her beloved Edward through self-destructive thrill-seeking, speeding on motorbikes and diving off cliffs, producing exhilarating adrenaline highs and hallucinatory episodes in which she experiences vivid memory recall and hears Edward's voice. Due to Meyer's extraordinary influence, romance-as-mourning was in vogue in 2008. Nevertheless, the object of desire/grief was more obscure: if these clothes evoke mourning wear, then mourning for what? The answer is, perhaps, nothing in particular – it is merely a staging of that desire for trauma without which, as Warwick suggests, we feel incomplete.

The notion of Gothic romance as mourning wear might seem at odds with the celebratory tone I identified earlier in twenty-first-century Gothic style. But

this is part of the paradox that I am attempting to unpack. Of course individual Goths may have a myriad reasons for adopting their chosen style – creativity and self-expression, after all, are the touchstones of contemporary Goth identity. Perhaps all Western consumers might say the same thing of their own style choices. But as a mass market phenomenon, post-millennial Gothic style is freed up from those individual identity markers and instead gathers generalized meanings from its cultural context. Because Western culture as a whole is not mourning anything in particular, is staging a desire for trauma, Gothic style becomes more about seeking that state of heightened consciousness identified by Pearce, that merging of ecstasy and loss. To return to my title quotation, and the notion of 'rave' nestled within 'grave': contemporary Gothic style does not repudiate celebration, glamour or even prettiness: it incorporates them all in its relentless striving towards the new.

A newly celebratory and romantic Gothic thus proved attractive to mainstream consumers and was further diffused through fashion design and marketing. It also had an effect on fictional narratives, in which the figure of the vampire surged in popularity, a ready vehicle for the seductive combination of ecstasy and loss. The increasing preoccupation with the assimilative vampire in particular – the vampire who wants to 'mainstream', or live as a human – has clear resonances with the construction of subcultures as equivalent to other persecuted minorities and the campaign for their assimilation. Thus, the combined preoccupations with assimilation and romance lead to one of the most controversial phenomena of post-millennial Gothic – the sparkly vampire.

Notes

1 The British high street is usually understood to refer to the range of shops found in town centres and out-of-town shopping malls throughout the country, and is composed of chain boutiques (e.g., Topshop, Miss Selfridge, River Island) and department stores (e.g., Debenhams, Marks and Spencer). These stores produce numerous collections throughout the year, often directly inspired by catwalk trends. Although the high street encompasses European and American chains (e.g., H&M, Zara, Urban Outfitters, Gap), the variety of clothes on offer and the rapid turnover produces a mainstream fashion culture that is closer to both designer fashion and subcultural style than the equivalent in the United States or Europe (with the possible exception of New York).

2 *Grazia* is the United Kingdom's best-selling premium fashion glossy, with combined monthly sales around 100,000. It is issued weekly, enabling it to respond rapidly

to emerging trends. For these reasons it provides a useful source in tracking mainstream fashion stories as they develop.

3 Nu Rave, fashionable in the United Kingdom and especially London circa 2006, reworked the music and fashion styles of the late 1980s rave scene, with Mercury-prize winning band The Klaxons the most well-known proponents. Nu Grave was a term 'briefly used by UK magazine *Artrocker* to describe bands with a dark post-punk sound' (Scharf 2014: 197).

4

Gothic Charm School, or, How Vampires Learned to Sparkle

Sparkle

'Real Vampires Don't Sparkle' announced a web campaign *circa* 2010, protesting at the pervasiveness of Stephenie Meyer's *Twilight* novels (2005–2008) and their film adaptations (2008–12), in which vampires do not avoid the sun for fear of any physical damage it might do them, but because it will expose the scintillating quality of their skin and reveal their carefully concealed difference to humans. The sparkly vampire has come to be regarded as representative of a 'de-fanged' vampire, a vampire more likely to be regarded as a desirable romantic partner than a bloodthirsty killer. These vampires have supernatural abilities and tortured souls but avoid drinking human blood, instead sating themselves on wild animals, as in *Twilight* and *The Vampire Diaries* (2009–);[1] on artificial blood substitutes, as in Charlaine Harris's *Southern Vampire Mysteries* (2001–13) and their televisual adaptation by Alan Ball, *True Blood* (2008–14); or simply by going 'cold turkey' and not drinking at all, as in the BBC Three series *Being Human* (2008–13). While scintillating skin may be unique to Meyer's vampires – her lawyers have reportedly been aggressive in attacking the appearance of sparkly vampires anywhere outside the official *Twilight* franchise – the Cullen family's sparkliness has become symbolic of critics' disillusionment with the insipid properties of these vampires. Indeed several of the series mentioned above, as they progressed, attempted to shed sparkly associations by allowing their lead vampires to revert to a nastier, more bloodthirsty image, with *The Vampire Diaries*' Stefan returning to human blood-drinking, *True Blood*'s Bill betraying Sookie and *Being Human*'s Mitchell wreaking havoc in a crowded train carriage. Despite these subsequent negotiations, however, the appearance of so many

vampires seeking to live amicably alongside humans during the first decade of the twenty-first century remains a striking cultural phenomenon.

The sparkly vampire has also come to represent the seemingly relentless *Twilight* teen-marketing machine. The sparkle effect has become a marketing tool in its own right: it is even possible to reproduce that special vampire radiance with a bit of 'First Light Face Glow' from the Luna Twilight make-up range. Vampirism has always provided an apt metaphor for consumer culture: as Rob Latham points out, 'The vampire is literally an insatiable consumer driven by a hunger for perpetual youth' (2002: 1). The sparkly vampire represents the apex of that process. The *Twilight* novels and films are not only phenomenally successful products in their own right, but also part of an immensely profitable franchise – something that *True Blood* ironically acknowledges in its fake promotional campaign for TruBlood, the beverage. The sparkly vampire is one that has been made palatable for a mass market and readily convertible into a range of consumer products, from make-up and jewellery to cars and even sex toys.

Sparkly vampires are divisive: they incite adoration from fans and loathing from their detractors. They are easy to deride, but this does not make them any the less popular or pervasive. As Hannah Priest argues,

> the reason so many of us hate sparkly vampires is because, put simply, they are not written for us … When we rail against sparkly vampires, we are railing against another generation's Gothic. We embody *Northanger Abbey*'s description of commentators who 'abuse such effusions of fancy at their leisure, and over every new novel to talk in thread-bare strains of the trash with which the press now groans' … What is significant is that the 'trash' to which Austen refers is now the 'correct' Gothic against which sparkly vampire fiction is now measured. (Priest 2011)

Rather than simply dismissing a new generation's Gothic, it is more interesting to ask why sparkly vampires have appeared in the twenty-first century, and what this tells us about shifting tastes in Gothic narrative. Over a period of about two hundred years vampires have changed from the grotty living corpses of folklore to witty, sexy super-achievers: vampires to whose condition we may aspire. Why did these changes come about? How did vampires learn to sparkle?

The following chapter attempts to demonstrate that the sparkly vampire is just one element of a wider shift in mood in Gothic fictions; one that is linked to the changing fortunes of Goth subculture and its representation in the mainstream media established in the preceding chapter. Fictional vampires, and real Goths, no longer appear so comfortable in the position of outsider as they once

did. Making peace with the mainstream is a strategy that is becoming increasingly visible in some sections of alternative culture, and this uneasy desire for assimilation is acted out in vampire narratives. Much has been written about the rise of the sympathetic monster in the second half of the twentieth century, the monster who is given a voice and an interiority and with whom the reader or viewer is invited to identify – a figure to whom I will return in Chapter 6. The twenty-first century, however, has seen the rise of the assimilative monster, the monster who is no longer a sympathetic outsider but who is, or at least attempts to be, one of us.

Rules

The seeds of today's aspirational vampires were first sown in John Polidori's *The Vampyre* (1819). Polidori's Lord Ruthven is transparently based on his employer and mentor, Lord Byron, and possesses all of Byron's mythic charisma. Byron, widely described as the first celebrity in the modern sense of the word, provides a model that informs the development of the vampire myth in the succeeding two centuries: witty, aristocratic, intelligent, tormented and wildly sexually attractive to both sexes.[2] Lord Ruthven, nevertheless, while possessing a kind of irresistible charm and a titillating novelty to the jaded aristocrats about him, never seeks to integrate himself with society or play by its rules: he stands apart, 'entirely absorbed in himself' ([1819]1997: 5). In fact his apparently social acts, such as his generous distribution of charity, appear to generate disruption rather than cohesion: 'all those upon whom it was bestowed, inevitably found that there was a curse upon it, for they all were either led to the scaffold, or sunk to the lowest and the most abject misery' (6). Vampires from Ruthven onwards possess a thrilling mixture of rebellion and charm, of social polish and deliberate defiance of socially approved morality and convention. Nineteenth-century vampires from Varney to Carmilla fascinate because they are apparently sophisticated, cultured beings while simultaneously constituting a destructive force that challenges their culture's cohesion, order and ethical premises. While in the nineteenth century this doubleness was intended to horrify, in the later part of the twentieth century the charismatic rebel became an increasingly lionized figure and the vampire began to be presented as sympathetic. In Anne Rice's influential *Interview with the Vampire* (1976), the interviewee, Louis de Pointe du Lac, is emotionally articulate and struggles with the loss of his humanity. From this lineage the sparkly vampire springs: as Priest points out, Rice's anti-hero Lestat

even pre-empts the Cullens' luminosity with his 'extremely white and highly reflective skin that has to be powdered for cameras of any kind' (Priest 2011, Rice [1985]1996b: 9).

It is Edward Cullen's radiance in particular, of course, that is of central importance to Meyer's text: he is the focal point of vampire spectacle for the heroine Bella and by extension the reader. Edward first reveals his sparkliness to Bella once their relationship has begun to develop in *Twilight*, and Meyer describes it as follows:

> His skin, white despite the faint flush from yesterday's hunting trip, literally sparkled, like thousands of tiny diamonds were embedded in the surface. He lay perfectly still in the grass, his shirt open over his sculpted, incandescent chest, his scintillating arms bare. His glistening, pale lavender lids were shut, although of course he didn't sleep. A perfect statue, carved in some unknown stone, smooth like marble, glittering like crystal. ([2005]2007a: 228)

In this passage, Edward is presented as exotic, marvellous, eminently consumable – a rare and precious object, a work of art rather than a man. He is, however, oddly asexual. The vampire body normally emphasizes the mouth as orifice and the exchange of bodily fluids; it is transformative and aligned with the bestial, and as such meets Bakhtin's descriptions of the grotesque body in *Rabelais and His World* (1984). Edward's body, on the other hand, is a 'perfect statue', permanent and unchanging; it is 'smooth', closed off, and thus more resembles Bakhtin's criteria for the classical body – not the monstrous, grotesque body of the vampire we might more conventionally expect. Edward as spectacle draws the female gaze, but also repels it. He reflects rather than absorbs light. His glittering skin is a focus for female desire while also simultaneously denying its satisfaction. The ultimate commodity, Edward's scintillating, sculptural body leaves only the desire for more.

Apollonian rather than Dionysian, Edward is in one sense anti-Gothic – he and his supernaturally enlightened family represent order, control and civilization rather than the barbaric forces that threaten to overturn it. Historically, of course, Gothic has been about the play of barbarism versus civilization and usually functions to restore order; as Fred Botting argues, 'The terrors and horrors of transgression in Gothic writing become a powerful means to reassert the values of society, virtue and propriety: transgression, by crossing the social and aesthetic limits, serves to reinforce or underline their value or necessity, restoring or defining limits' (1997: 7). The vampire, however, has almost always been on the side of barbarity: conventional critical readings tend to present the vampire as a

force disrupting social decorum, from Dracula destabilizing Victorian values to the *Lost Boys* posing a threat to Reagan's youth in the 1980s. To have the monster representing the limit, rather than the transgressive impulse, is a development stemming from the merging of the vampire narrative with a popular romance tradition in the later 1970s, most vividly illustrated by Chelsea Quinn Yarbro's *Hotel Transylvania* (1978) and its sequels. This tradition has been overlooked by those critics who have emphasized Gothic over romance, but shapes the sparkly vampires of the twenty-first century in important ways.

The idea that there are 'rules' of vampirism that must be learnt and followed derives from Anne Rice: in *Interview with the Vampire* Louis discovers too late and to his cost that the Parisian *Théâtre des Vampires* possesses a series of binding laws or social codes that govern their interactions. Rice's *Vampire Chronicles* nevertheless favour vampire iconoclasts who overturn the moribund conventions of their predecessors. Claudia attempts to murder her vampire sire; Louis burns down the theatre and incinerates its inhabitants in revenge for her death; Lestat flouts the injunction to secrecy by proclaiming his vampire identity as rock star. In twenty-first-century vampire narratives, on the other hand, the 'rules' are not just limited to the vampire community or dedicated to maintaining its continuation but go above and beyond. They appeal to a moral imperative and a sense of decorum that are not just about preserving the social contract but also a kind of self-fashioning – even, perhaps, soul-making.

Through the character of Edward Cullen, Stephenie Meyer constructs the vampire as representative of order rather than chaos. One of the defining features of Edward's personality is his self-control. Previously, this has been largely considered in the context of sexuality: Edward and eventually also the werewolf Jacob must restrain their sexual desire for Bella, out of the risk of hurting her. The concept of self-control, however, is much more far-reaching than this in the *Twilight* quartet. The Cullens' identity is produced through a discourse of self-control: their existence within human society is enabled by the daily restraint they exercise over their vampiric impulses. In *Eclipse* (2007), the third novel in the series, it is revealed that this very quality is what enables them to exist as a family. Jasper's tale of the vampire wars of the south describes the western vampire community as an uneasy balance between wild, lawless vampire gangs that kill humans indiscriminately and engage in bloody wars and vendettas against one another, and the civilized Volturi who periodically descend from Europe to assert punitive control and re-establish order. The Cullens, it transpires, are the largest group of vampires to have thus far avoided the Volturi's intervention, because they have internalized this process of control – good Foucauldian

subjects, they are docile bodies who have internalized the operations of power and operate a form of self-surveillance – of keeping a check on their own impulses through a self-imposed ethic of 'vegetarianism' (Foucault 1991: 201).

Moreover, Jasper's account of the vampire wars reveals that this internalization of control is specifically a learned process. He explains, 'Very young vampires are volatile, wild, and almost impossible to control. One newborn can be reasoned with, taught to restrain himself, but ten, fifteen together are a nightmare' (Meyer [2007]2008: 257). Newly made vampires constitute an inchoate force that either can be corralled and used as a weapon, or can be schooled, guided, to become a self-controlling being. The latter is privileged: through learning self-control, a quasi-human identity is produced. Bella, it transpires, constitutes the epitome of this process: in the fourth novel, *Breaking Dawn* (2008), her own initiation into vampirism is remarkably smooth as her special ability proves to be the power to control her bodily needs and impulses to a supernatural degree. Bella does not need to learn to be human as she never relinquishes her humanity, and in this manner becomes the most powerful vampire of them all.

Similar patterns can be found in other contemporary vampire narratives. In the first season of *True Blood*, vampire protagonist Bill sires a teenage vampire and must take responsibility for her; his failure to 'parent' her effectively leaves her dangerously out of control. Jessica's initiation into the 'adult' world of vampirism presents a microcosm of *True Blood*'s vampire community, who are enabled to control their blood-lust through an artificial blood substitute, and as a result co-exist with humans. *Being Human* repeatedly emphasizes abstention from blood-drinking through the character of Mitchell, who views his desire for blood as an addiction with which he is engaged in a perpetual struggle. In the second season, Mitchell founds a kind of 'blood-drinkers anonymous' group for his fellow vampires. As the series title suggests, 'being human' is not a pre-existent condition but a process, in which the continual effort of self-control enables a human or quasi-human subject to be produced.

In the *Twilight* quartet, the Cullens' self-control is so perfected that they not only manage to live undetected alongside humans, but exhibit an almost supernatural politeness. Although the younger members of the family do have occasional lapses, in general the family's manners are so immaculate that they are unsettling. They do not eat, but they provide Bella with appetising food when she visits. They offer lavish and beautifully wrapped gifts on her birthday. They easily charm any human who comes into their orbit – aided by vampiric skills of fascination, of course, but also by a more worldly appreciation of how to avoid causing offence, or to placate when it is already taken. Their existence within the

human world is eased by a respect for social customs and niceties that extends to Edward's insistence on marriage before sex – a position to which the initially sceptical Bella eventually comes round with the realization that she wants to 'do this right … Responsibly. Everything in the right order' (Meyer [2007]2008: 548–9).

This is articulated in a slightly different way in *The Southern Vampire Mysteries* and *True Blood*. As Bill informs Sookie, vampires are dependent on '[c]ourtesy and custom' in order to cement a kind of vampiric social contract reminiscent of Rice. 'We're all observant of custom', he informs her. 'We have to live together for centuries' (Harris [2001]2009: 251). Yet Bill's charm offensive is also a vital part of his attempt to 'mainstream', as he operates strategic politeness in order to win over the occupants of Bon Temps. Bill's manners, it is suggested, may partly be a legacy of his nineteenth-century upbringing, but are also put to good use easing his acceptance into the present-day community. In *Dead until Dark* (2001), Sookie notes that 'Bill proved as adept at social tactics as my grandmother' (51). Similarly when in *True Blood* Bill speaks to the Descendants of the Glorious Dead about his part in the Civil War, he removes the American flag from the altar where it has been concealing the crucifix, hoists it on its pole and returns it to its designated spot, declaring, 'As a patriot of this great nation, I wouldn't dream of putting myself before Old Glory' (*True Blood:* 'Sparks Fly Out' 2009). His formal display of patriotism wrong-foots his more conservative opponents and underscores his argument for assimilation. Sookie's grandmother Adele refers to him as a 'perfect gentleman' rather than a vampire: his manners confer on him humanity. Indeed, his behaviour in this scene is shown to be rather better than that of his distrustful and in some cases disrespectful audience. While not all vampires in *True Blood* or the *Southern Vampire Mysteries* display similar manners, Bill's politeness is, like Edward's, privileged by his positioning as principal romantic lead.

Goth

How, and when, did vampires learn to be so polite? In order to answer this, it is necessary once again to invoke Goth subculture as an informing context. In the twenty-first century, Goth has expanded from its roots in the UK post-Punk underground to become a massive global phenomenon. Thanks to digital communications media, its music, fashions and images can be instantaneously accessed by millions of fans around the world. Goth is periodically picked up and exploited by mainstream commodity culture, turned into the theme of the

latest fashion season or broadsheet commentary. Nevertheless it has not, in the way of the majority of other subcultures, become thoroughly incorporated by the mainstream. It is still regarded as oppositional, threatening or just plain weird by a sizeable portion of the mainstream population. This results in some very tangible effects, such as the two cases I have been invoking throughout this book: the media scapegoating of Goth for the Columbine shootings in Colorado on 20 April 1999, and in Britain, the murder of self-defined Goth Sophie Lancaster on 11 August 2007. The shifts Goth has undergone while renegotiating its identity in the twenty-first century cast an interesting light on the concurrent surge in vampire narratives.

Vampire imagery has been a prominent feature of Goth culture since its inception: the release of Bauhaus's iconic single, *Bela Lugosi's Dead*, in 1979, is sometimes credited as being the originating moment of the subculture (see, e.g., Steele and Park 2008: 117, Scharf 2014: 8). When the 1983 film *The Hunger* opened with Bauhaus performing this track as vampires played by David Bowie and Catherine Deneuve seduce a couple in a nightclub, the link between vampires and Goths was cemented in the Hollywood imagination. Although Goths themselves frequently reject associations with vampires as reductive and point to the existence of a separate, if sometimes overlapping, subculture more focused on role-playing and conventional fandom, the association has proved difficult to shake. Arguably, the most significant reason for this is dress: both subcultures subscribe to similar dress-codes, and are often difficult to distinguish visually, especially to outsiders. Moreover, in current cinema convention, costuming choices usually acknowledge Goth just as Goth style appropriates vampire looks from fiction and cinema. To cite only a brief selection of examples, Selene from the *Underworld* films (2003–12), Spike from *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* (1997–2003), the Volturi from *Twilight: New Moon* (2009) and the patrons of the vampire bar Fangtasia in *True Blood* all recognizably draw on a Goth sartorial idiom. As Maria Mellins (2013) demonstrates, vampire fans often painstakingly replicate these costumes in the fashioning of their own vampire identities, thereby completing the circle.

Goth is so visible in terms of the costuming and aesthetics of contemporary vampire narrative that in interpretative terms, it becomes invisible. In other words, it seems so obvious – even clichéd – that there is nothing to say about it. But this elides the interpretative judgements audiences make about Goth, the cultural work to which it is put in these narratives, and excludes Goths themselves, reducing them to a set of visual stereotypes rather than living individuals. The convention of costuming vampires as Goths is a relatively new one. Although it

is anticipated in 1980s films such as *The Hunger* and, to a certain extent, *The Lost Boys* (with the exception of Kiefer Sutherland's David, the vampires sport a classic American rock/biker look), it crystallized some time in the 1990s, echoing the increasing visibility of Goth aesthetics in pre-millennial culture. There are nuances in the use of Goth style as vampire costume – Goth style is not appropriated wholesale by Hollywood but consciously put to work. In *Twilight: New Moon*, for example, it is the aristocratic, hierarchical, European Volturi who are clad in black robes and red contact lenses, while the democratic, all-American Cullens dress in a preppy style. This costuming decision, of course, stems from Meyer's novels in which the Volturi are ancient and backward-looking while the Cullens represent modernity and the New World. Goth style communicates the weight of history – and identifies the 'bad' vampires from the 'good' ones. More subtly, in *True Blood*, Pam and Eric wear Goth style within their vampire bar, Fangtasia – literally putting their vampire identities to work – while opting for more mainstream styles when off duty. *True Blood* comments ironically on the expectations that customers bring to vampire bars and viewers to vampire drama: that vampires should dress Goth. The pre-credit sequence for the debut episode of the show has the camera pan slowly up the body of the pale, black-haired and tattooed clerk in the 24-hour store, lingering on apparently threatening details such as his biker boots, skull rings and piercings. The drunken young couple who enter the store in search of 'V' or vampire blood (which has hallucinogenic properties for humans) are easily taken in, along with the viewer, by his pretence of vampirism – while in fact the genuine vampire is the unassuming redneck in the corner. In the show's internal universe, vampires have as diverse taste as the humans they once were. Stereotyping according to dress is a form of prejudice suffered by vampires, but it is also a stereotype they use to their economic advantage.[3]

I do not want to suggest a reductive pattern whereby vampires embody contemporary Goth culture and vice versa. Clearly, one of the joys of the vampire narrative is that vampires provide rich and multi-layered symbols that can be interpreted in all sorts of ways, and as Judith Halberstam states in *Skin Shows*, like all Gothic monsters 'transform the fragments of otherness into one body' (Halberstam 1995: 92). Charlaine Harris has explicitly declared that vampires are 'a metaphor for alienated minorities' and that she was 'thinking specifically of the gay community' in the *Southern Vampire Mysteries* (Wright 2010: 74). The Louisiana setting and references to the history of slavery and segregation also invite comparisons with the black civil rights movement, as a number of critics including Victoria Amador (2012) and Michelle Smith (2013) have commented.

These allusions are clearly visible within the texts and have been widely commented on by critics, readers and viewers. Goth narratives, however, are taken for granted in mainstream culture; where we may be alive to the nuances of race or sexuality, how subcultures signify is often left unexamined. Goth, however, is no less a significant shaping context on these narratives than any other. Moreover, as the previous chapter established, it is an increasingly politicized context, as twenty-first-century subcultures have become mobilized around a series of campaigns to defend the right to alternative lifestyles.

A passage from the first of the *Southern Vampire Mysteries*, *Dead until Dark*, illustrates the cultural imbrication of Goths and vampires particularly effectively. Sookie's first visit to the vampire bar Fangtasia reveals the detailed striations of vampire culture:

> The bar was full. The humans were divided amongst vampire groupies and tourists. The groupies (fang-bangers, they were called) were dressed in their best finery. It ranged from the traditional capes and tuxes for the men to many Morticia Adams [*sic*] ripoffs [*sic*] among the females. The clothes ranged from reproductions of those worn by Brad Pitt and Tom Cruise in *Interview with the Vampire* to some modern outfits that I thought were influenced by *The Hunger*. Some of the fang-bangers were wearing false fangs, some had painted trickles of blood from the corners of their mouths or puncture marks on their necks. They were extraordinary, and extraordinarily pathetic.
>
> The tourists looked like tourists anywhere, maybe more adventurous than most. But to enter into the spirit of the bar, they were nearly all dressed in black like the fang-bangers … Strewn among this human assortment, like real jewels in a bin of rhinestones, were the vampires, perhaps fifteen of them. They mostly favored dark clothes too. (Harris [2001]2009: 115)

The vampire groupies' dress is mediated through popular cultural and film images of vampires, and suggestively recalls contemporary Goth style. The vampires, on the other hand, while also mainly wearing dark clothes, sparkle: 'real jewels in a bin of rhinestones'. On one level, Goth appears to be being repudiated in this passage. The groupies' attempt to mimic vampires is presented as 'pathetic', and lacks the sophistication of the real vampires. On another, however, the passage also replays strategies deployed within subcultures in general and Goth in particular with which to shore up what Sarah Thornton, adapting Bourdieu, calls 'subcultural capital' (Thornton 1995). The groupies are presented as lacking the authenticity of the 'real' vampires, a common manoeuvre in subcultural narratives seeking to distance the 'weekenders' or 'wannabes'

from those with greater subcultural commitment. In fact, groupies, tourists and vampires are all dressed in dark clothes and it is through Sookie's discerning gaze that we can distinguish the nuances between them. Moreover Sookie's sympathies in this passage are clearly aligned with the vampires – they are the closest thing to the dominant social norm in the bar. The qualities valued here are restraint, decorum and good taste – qualities possessed by the real vampires, but not the groupies. Real vampires do not seek to stand out, even if they can't help doing so by virtue of their innate superiority. Real vampires have manners – they have learned to sparkle.

Charm

And so we come to *Gothic Charm School*: a book, and blog, by self-styled 'Lady of the Manners' Jillian Venters, a kind of Goth agony aunt. Since 1998, Jillian has advised her readers on essential problems of Goth etiquette, from 'Do you have to be spooky every day?' to 'Why friends don't let friends dress like the Crow' (2009: ix, x). At the heart of the *Gothic Charm School* ethos is the notion that it is even more important for Goths to be polite than for other people, as there is more at stake when they create a bad impression. Outsiders tend to assume one Goth stands for them all, and a bad attitude can confirm negative preconceptions that lead to prejudice. Prejudice, Venters argues, has real social effects, from bullying of teenagers and difficulties in finding employment to media blame for social ills. As Venters explains,

> if everyone associated with the subculture takes up the Lady of the Manners's cause of politeness, maybe (just maybe) Goths will quit getting labelled as 'baby-eating Satanic murderers' and merely be labelled as 'those people who wear black and dye their hair funny colours'. Mass awareness can lead to more understanding and less stereotyping – we just have to work at it. (201)

And again:

> Yes, it's a bit strange to think that what started out as a shadowy refuge has become well known enough to be regarded as a profitable target demographic, but as the Lady of the Manners had said before, the more 'mainstream' awareness of what Goth really is, the fewer young babybats [*sic*] will have to go through the bullying and harassment that many ElderGoths [*sic*] suffered. The more people who have even a vague understanding about Goth, the smaller the chance that Goths will be regarded with suspicion, fear, and hostility. (229)

The mainstreaming of Goth may be annoying to a subculture committed to difference, but as Venters points out, it has its benefits. These range from increased tolerance in the workplace to being able to snap up Gothy fashion bargains in the seasonal chain-store sales. Moreover, Venters argues, being polite is the most subversive thing you can do as a Goth, as it messes with preconceptions more effectively than sulkiness and surliness.

Venters's book draws, semi-ironically, on the Victorian etiquette book and its eighteenth-century predecessor, the conduct manual. The Gothic novel has a complex and vexed historical relationship with the conduct book, which has frequently been read as an important context for eighteenth-century fiction in general, and Gothic in particular, the height of its popularity coinciding with that of the Gothic between 1760 and 1820. Eighteenth-century fiction had a presumed didactic purpose, fulfilling a similar role to the conduct book in educating its young readers into properly moral behaviour. Eighteenth-century objections to the Gothic novel frequently centred around the fact that 'terrorist novel writing', as it was infamously labelled, did not fulfil this didactic purpose: an anonymous commentator of 1797 argued,

> A novel, if at all useful, ought to be a representation of human life and manners, with a view to direct the conduct in the most important duties of life, and to correct its follies … Can a young lady be taught nothing more necessary in life, than to sleep in a dungeon with venomous reptiles, walk through a ward [wood] with assassins, and carry bloody daggers in their pockets, instead of pin-cushions and needle-books? ('Terrorist Novel Writing' [1798]2000: 184)

Indeed, when it came to Matthew Lewis's controversial bestseller *The Monk* (1796), Samuel Taylor Coleridge in the *Critical Review* considered that the presentation of sensational and salacious incident was likely to corrupt rather than educate youth ([1797]2000: 185–9). On the other hand, many Gothic novelists, most prominently Ann Radcliffe, did present their heroines undergoing an educative process parallel to that found in conduct literature of the period. This tension is often played out within individual novels: Stephanie Burley, for example, writes of how Charlotte Dacre's *Zofloya, or the Moor* (1806) combines a salacious, sensational tale with a didactic narrator, 'a good woman with a bad story to tell' (2004: 207). The 'double-consciousness' of the narrator nevertheless appears not to have convinced contemporary reviewers, one of whom deplored 'a romance so void of merit, so destitute of delicacy, displaying such disgusting depravity of morals' (cited in Burley 2004: 207). The Gothic novel plays out the binary of civility and barbarity, the latter

continually threatening to destabilize the former even as, for the most part, civility remains the privileged term.

Venters's blog plays out this dynamic in a rather different way. For a start, her emphasis is on etiquette rather than conduct – a subtle distinction, but one that shifts the emphasis from generally morally correct behaviour to appropriate behaviour in specific social circumstances. The etiquette book came to the fore in the mid-nineteenth century as a guide for the *parvenu* in an age of unprecedented social mobility. It performed a socially conservative role, preserving the mores and conventions of the upper classes against the threat of encroaching vulgarity. Venters's blog participates in a semi-ironic nostalgia for Victoriana that has become increasingly prominent in some sections of Goth subculture, embodied in loving recreations of nineteenth-century costume or latterly, in Steampunk. On one level, Venters's text does appear to be socially conservative, affirming the values and mores of mainstream culture as it suggests, for example, that a corset might not be the most appropriate garment for school after all. This is the very opposite of Goth's roots in the Punk subculture of the late 1970s, with its cultivated call to anarchy and mission to cause offence. On another level, however, *Gothic Charm School* recognizes the now clichéd nature of Punk resistance and its lack of purchase in the world of globalized media. By imagining resistance through politeness, Venters inverts the expectations not only of the so-called mainstream, but also of subcultural discourse itself, long dependent on a Punk-derived model. The light vein of self-parody that runs through the book, and the knowing incongruity of the concepts of Gothic and etiquette, subtly disarm critical accusations. The biggest Goth crime, it seems, is taking oneself too seriously.

Assimilation

In its *Northanger Abbey*–like promotion of good sense and good manners as the most effective way of dealing with prejudiced social tyrants, *Gothic Charm School* is one of the more clearly defined examples of how Goth has renegotiated its identity in the last decade in relation to the series of media-generated moral panics associated with the subculture that I discussed in Chapter 3. Many Goths responded to Columbine, the death of Sophie Lancaster and a series of other news stories linking Goths and violence by publically de-emphasizing difference and calling for improved communication and tolerance between the alternative community and mainstream culture. It is no accident that over the same period

of time, a new generation of vampire narratives emerged, in which vampires attempted, in different ways, to insert themselves within mainstream society. Meyer's vampires are wholesome all-American beings who are 'vegetarian', play baseball and refuse sex before marriage. Harris's grittier novels, and their TV adaptation, explore an American South where vampires seek their civil rights in an effort to live amicably alongside humans. *Being Human*'s flat-sharing ghost, vampire and werewolf attempt to come to terms with their otherness while 'passing' as human. There are nuances between these narratives: Meyer's 'good' vampires seek surreptitious assimilation, for example, being unable to reveal their difference to the community at large, while Harris's novels explicitly play with the imagery of the civil rights movement and gay liberation. None of these texts can be reduced to a metaphor for Goth subculture; rather, through the long-standing cultural association between Goths and vampires, they play into a general atmosphere or share a pervasive mood that evokes Goth liberation.

As such, these narratives offer a new kind of 'conduct book' for the twenty-first century. Like *Gothic Charm School*, they teach us that we can preserve our difference, our specialness, our otherness and enjoy the benefits of living in globalized consumer culture at the same time – but in order to do so, we must be unfailingly polite. Resistance to the norm can only be achieved by working *with* the dominant culture rather than aggressively against it. Inevitably, different narratives offer differently nuanced versions of this message, sometimes even presenting that 'double-consciousness' Burley identifies in *Zofloya*, where the didactic voice scarcely contains the more sensational material of the narrative. Stephenie Meyer's covert sanctioning of social convention tends to play into conservative politics, while Charlaine Harris and Alan Ball's more self-consciously political narratives espouse a more liberal worldview. Harris and Ball, too, allow more room for dissent from the assimilative position, while in Meyer the 'bad', that is, undisciplined, vampires are scarcely given a voice – and scarcely ever given the chance to sparkle.

To conclude, sparkly vampires provide a fantasy space in which the risks and rewards of subcultural assimilation can be played out. In the dilemmas they face in their respective narratives they enact the uneasy status of subcultures, and specifically Goth subculture, in the twenty-first century. Sparkly vampires have manners; they suppress their desire to snarl in order to enjoy the benefits of integrating with mainstream society. At the same time their sparkliness indicates their difference, their otherness, their specialness. As such they offer an important representation of subcultural politics, and specifically Goth politics, as they undergo a series of unprecedented changes. In

doing so, vampire narratives can show us new ways to negotiate identity politics and alternative lifestyle choices in an increasingly commodified twenty-first century.

Notes

1 The TV series developed by Alex Lloyd, Kevin Williamson and Julie Plec and broadcast on the CW Television Network is based on a series of novels by L. J. Smith, which nevertheless differ substantially from their adaptation and were written somewhat earlier than the other texts considered in this chapter (the original trilogy was published in 1991, although a second trilogy coincided loosely with the TV series, 2009–11).

2 'Byromania' was a widely discussed phenomenon from the publication of *Childe Harold's Pilgrimage* in 1812. Ghislaine McDayter is typical of critics who use the language of modern celebrity to describe this phenomenon, commenting, for example, 'What London was witnessing in the frenzy of Byromania was … a symptom of the birth of the larger phenomenon now known as celebrity culture' (McDayter 2009: 4).

3 Films and TV series that do not costume vampires as Goths are also deliberately working against this set of conventions. Usually, as in *Being Human*, they are implying that they are seeking to freshen up the genre, connoting that they are edgy, hip and realist.

5

Pretty in Black: The Goth Girl and the Whimsical Macabre

The Goth girl

In the previous chapters I proposed that Tim Burton's distinctive visual style has come to dominate contemporary popular understandings of Gothic, and explored a range of texts often associated with female consumers in the form of high street fashion and the vampire romance. This chapter brings these strands together to discuss a variant of happy Gothic I call the whimsical macabre. The whimsical macabre reconfigures the gruesome and grotesque as playful, quirky and even cute, and often draws on imagery associated with childhood. As with Burton, it is highly dependent on a visual language incorporating fashion, costume and *mise en scène*, and therefore is prominent in visual media such as illustration, comics and graphic novels, animation and fan consumables (such as dolls) as well as in literary and cinematic texts. It has become a dominant mode for representing the Goth child in post-millennial Gothic – and the Goth child is by default a girl. With her roots in the heroine of the Radcliffean Gothic and, in particular, the Brontës, the Goth girl as depicted in contemporary texts has become a recognizable trope, even a stereotype.

Traditionally, the Goth girl as viewed in the media is attractive, quirky, intelligent and sensitive but troubled, and adopts black clothing in order to express her sense of difference from her immediate community. In her isolation, she taps into a broader image of girlhood in Gothic fiction that Lucie Armitt identifies in texts from Emily Brontë's *Wuthering Heights* (1847) to Sarah Waters's *The Little Stranger* (2009):

> Repeatedly, the Gothic girl child must undergo trauma on her journey towards womanhood … If … the Gothic especially offers its heroines adventures they

> cannot find elsewhere, the price it seems they must pay for having them is learning to go it alone. (Armitt 2016: 72)

Armitt thus proposes a maturational narrative in which the Gothic girl child journeys towards womanhood, even if the traumas she undergoes (as in Stephen King's *Carrie* of 1974) means that she never gets there. Armitt's Gothic girl child is characterized by her isolation: a version of the archetypal Gothic outsider, she is at odds with her immediate community. These features of the Gothic girl child carry over to depictions of the Goth girl, who is probably most visible in film, appearing in a string of movies from the 1980s onwards including *The Breakfast Club* (1985), *Beetlejuice* (1988), *The Craft* (1996), *The Faculty* (1998), *My First Mister* (2001) and *White Oleander* (2002). Even films that portray adult women as Goths, such as *The Girl with the Dragon Tattoo* (2009) and its sequels and remakes, cannot fully resist the pull of this stereotype (and the English translation of the Swedish title, which substitutes 'girl' for 'women', is telling). The price the Goth girl pays for finding acceptance among friends or a community is usually the relinquishing of her Goth look: once she has assimilated, it appears there is no longer any need for her to signal her difference through her dress.

The whimsical macabre, however, offers an arrested childhood space in which the Goth girl is not required to grow up. Her girlhood – and therefore her Goth style and identity – can be prolonged indefinitely. A prototypical example is Violet Baudelaire of Lemony Snicket's *A Series of Unfortunate Events* (1999–2006): the open-ended structure of the series in which homecoming (and the receipt of Violet's inheritance) is perennially deferred means that while she ages from fourteen in the first novel to sixteen by the end of the series, she never comes of age. If the girl protagonist of the whimsical macabre *is* allowed to grow up, like Alice in Burton's adaptation of *Alice in Wonderland* (2010), then it is at the cost of entering a 'real' world and abandoning the childhood fantasy. The indefinite prolonging of the whimsical macabre world is often facilitated by the specific demands of series fiction, comics or television, as opposed to the more contained narratives of stand-alone novels and film. Unlike film, where the Goth girl commonly undergoes a makeover by the final credits, Goth girls in animated television series and comics retain their stylized appearance and character traits forever.

As my chosen examples will show, there is a problem with defining the whimsical macabre through the presumed age of its audience. Some of the texts are aimed at children, some at teenagers or 'Young Adults' and some at adults. There is evidently a significant crossover in these audiences, and indeed, the deliberate slippage between the childish and the adult might be regarded as one of

the defining features of the mode. Chris Riddell's *Goth Girl* books (2013–), for example, are marketed to pre-teens but are packed with jokes that only the most literate adult would fully appreciate; Roman Dirge's comic *Lenore, the Cute Little Dead Girl* (1998–) works by combining cute imagery with graphic violence. The Victorian fairground aesthetic of Gothic fantasy novels such as Juman Malouf's rococo *The Trilogy of Two* (2015) and Erin Morgenstern's *The Night Circus* (2011) deliberately appeals to an adult fashion for vintage nostalgia: the former was marketed to both adults and children, while the latter was presented as an adult novel but bears many of the hallmarks of Young Adult fiction. Similarly, the boundaries between childhood and young adulthood are often slippery within these works, and so for the purposes of this chapter I define girlhood as a temporally fluid domain located prior to marriage, maternity or meaningful career (as opposed to casual work). Although the presumed audience is important, as it affects the tone and register of the work as well as the way that it has been valued by critics, actual patterns of consumption are impossible to determine without quantitative research (the significant adult male fan base for *My Little Pony*, an animated series apparently aimed at pre-teen girls, is illustrative of this). Therefore my focus will be on the presentation of girlhood within the texts themselves and will not engage, for example, with the important phenomenon of fan fiction, which I leave to other critics deploying more appropriate methodologies.

The trajectory of this chapter, then, will be to trace the development of the whimsical macabre out of the traditional Gothic novel and new patterns of feminine representation established in the 1990s, and suggest some of the ways in which it offers unexpected, if sometimes conflicted, strategies for the exploration of youthful femininity in post-millennial culture. Some of the materials discussed in this chapter prove the most challenging to detach from conventional hierarchies of value, as the yoking together of the playful and the gruesome can result in anodyne worlds which appear to confirm Botting's claims for the exhaustion of contemporary Gothic that I discussed in the Introduction. Nevertheless, careful scrutiny reveals these texts as complex objects, and often uncovers wildly inventive spaces in which expectations of femininity and childhood are subverted and romance conventions challenged. My readings will range from subcultural clothing styles such as kinderwhore and Lolita, through films and fiction marketed to pre-teens and teens, to comics, animation and toys. In exploring what might be regarded as the lightest and most disposable items of post-millennial Gothic culture, I will show how reading happy Gothic can enable the marginalized culture of girlhood to be restored to the academic frame.

Monstrous cute to whimsical macabre

Choosing black was at one time presented as a way for girls to sidestep conventional gender identities: in 1980s films *The Breakfast Club* and *Beetlejuice*, the characters played by Ally Sheedy and Winona Ryder signal their resistance to conventional ways of being a girl by, among other things, wearing black clothes. *The Breakfast Club*'s high school 'princess' Claire, played by Molly Ringwald, prominently wears a pink top, signalling a more conventional feminine identity (although that conventionality is complicated in Ringwald's 1986 film *Pretty in Pink*, in which Ringwald's character loves pink but creatively fashions a series of original ensembles.) In the twenty-first century, the association between pink and quintessential femininity has intensified to an excessive degree: in *Living Dolls: The Return of Sexism* (2010), Natasha Walter identifies how from birth, girls are bombarded with stereotyped images of femininity, embodied in the overwhelming culture of pink for girls and blue for boys. The use of the colour pink in order to commodify pre-teen girls has been widely commented on – for example, the Pinkstinks campaign orchestrated by two young mothers who were appalled by the range of toys presented to their children has received widespread media attention (Wood 2011). Wearing black offers one route out of this gendered binary.

In the contemporary marketplace, however, black and pink no longer appear mutually exclusive. Hodkinson notes that pink, once regarded as the antithesis of Goth style, began to be incorporated ironically into Goth dress from the mid-1990s, 'usually juxtaposed with hair, make-up or other clothes more consistent with [a] sinister theme' (Hodkinson 2002: 47). In fact, as Hannah Priest suggests, this trend is concomitant with a broader one that combines Goth iconography with glitter:

> The rise of 'glitter' as an indicative marker of teen female sexuality has garnered much criticism. For some, the 'prettiness' of glitter encourages girls to aspire to princess-like femininity. What is often missed in this discourse is the concomitant rise of association of glitter with the sinister. Glitter accessories combine sparkles with skulls, poisons, weapons and other 'Goth' images. (Priest 2011)

As Priest indicates, an important context for this 'association of the "prettiness" of glitter with the sinister and violent' is the dissemination of Japanese popular culture and its fixation with what Maja Brzozowska-Brywczynska has termed the 'monstrous/cute'. Monstrous/cute style is, as Brzozowska-Brywczynska puts it, 'a cute as read through its thesaurus (endearing, loveable, delightful, darling,

pretty) and then re-read through the notion of strangeness and marvel (something that is not as it seems, that suffers from innate contradictions)' (2007: 214). It highlights the freakish nature of the cute body, its anatomical abnormalcy and its simultaneous prettiness and ugliness. The popular Japanese cartoon character Hello Kitty is illustrative: as Brzozowska-Brywczynska points out, read literally, her anatomical distortions are horrific.

If Hello Kitty is unintentionally monstrous, the twenty-first-century market in girls' toys has embraced intentional monstrosity. In the 2000s, the market for cult collectibles found a new outlet in the Gothic doll. Initially, ranges such as Living Dead Dolls (2001–) and Little Apple Dolls (2004–) were aimed primarily at adult collectors, and traded on both the uncanny nature of the doll and a humorous travesty of sentimental childhood. In 2010, however, Mattel (the makers of Barbie) launched Monster High, a multi-billion dollar, cross-platform franchise aimed squarely at pre-teen girls. The brand comprises a range of fashion dolls based on classic horror monsters, from Frankie Stein to Draculaura (the latter of whom, significantly, adopts the black-and-pink aesthetic described by Hodkinson). Its slogan, 'Be yourself. Be unique. Be a monster', superficially validates difference and the range is remarkable for including a diverse range of ethnicities including a Latina *Dia de los Muertos* doll, Skelita, and a Chinese dragon doll, Jinafire. Subsequent ranges have become increasingly inventive, challenging the conventional anthropocentric and ableist nature of the doll, including a centaur doll, a series of translucent ghost dolls, a bioluminescent, two-headed mermaid doll, and a merman in a wheelchair. The franchise also incorporates novels, web videos, a magazine, assorted merchandising and a series of animated movies.

The Monster High range is evidently influenced by Lady Gaga's celebration of monstrous subjectivity as a form of self-expression, and the original Monster High theme sounds like a diluted version of her electronic, anthemic pop. Karen Macfarlane has written eloquently on Gaga as contemporary Gothic performance in a way that explicitly evokes Mattel's strategies with Monster High, noting, 'Her evocation of monstrosity as recuperable, as potentially familiar and domesticated is part of a larger trend … couched in terms that echo equal rights advocacy' (2012: 114). Nevertheless, despite the dolls' individualized monster features created with unique moulds – Blue Lagoona, for example, has fins attached to her limbs – the series retains an emphasis on conventional feminine attractiveness, with dolls conforming to a slender ideal, with the oversized heads and eyes of traditional fashion dolls. Significantly, Clawdeen, the werewolf doll, received particular criticism in the United States for the way that her narrative focuses on the need for depilation: 'My hair is worthy of a shampoo

commercial, and that's just what grows on my legs. Plucking and shaving is definitely a full-time job but that's a small price to pay for being scarily fabulous' (Hartman 2011). In its conjunction of the monstrous and the conventionally pretty, therefore, Monster High treads a difficult path between expanding the range of feminine representation and reifying hyper-femininity. Rival brands, moreover, such as Bratzillas and Once Upon a Zombie (which reimagines familiar fairy tale characters as zombies) demonstrate less innovation or subtlety. In its most troubling manifestation, the monstrous/cute positions the feminine body, and by extension the Goth girl, as commodity.

The whimsical macabre as I define it is closely aligned with the monstrous/cute although it is not reducible to it. The whimsical, according to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, can mean 'subject to or characterised by a whim or whims; capricious', or 'fantastic, fanciful; odd, quaint'. The whimsical macabre deliberately fuses the cute, fanciful and quirky with the gloomy, gruesome and morbid. It brings together images of, or associated with, childhood, often filtered through a retro or neo-Victorian lens, with Gothic and horror iconography, to create a gently comic effect. It revels in antique toys, retro sweets, vintage children's clothes, Hallowe'en imagery, circuses, fairy tales – elements of childhood culture that when viewed retrospectively, may simultaneously seem sinister and nostalgic. However, none of these paraphernalia are essential requirements: the whimsical macabre is defined principally through its playful, quirky manipulation of Gothic style and imagery.

An instrumental text in the development of the whimsical macabre is Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865), or, more specifically, its twentieth- and twenty-first-century adaptations. Its Victorian readers considered *Alice* to be purely whimsical, a comical and playful fantasia. In the light of psycho-sexual readings from the 1930s onwards, and increasing suspicion towards Carroll's devotion to pre-adolescent girls, it has been interpreted in a darker light. As Will Brooker comments:

> There is a shared assumption … that the original text has an inherently troubled, disturbing quality beneath its lighter wordplay and banter, and that any modern adaptation failing to recognize this deeper, darker nature has actually missed the point. This is quite a shift from the apparently unanimous nineteenth-century opinion that the Alice books were a healthy dose of fun and nonsense. (Brooker 2004: 71–2)

Similarly, Chloe Buckley notes a contemporary 'trend to read *Alice* as Gothic', suggesting that 'these uncanny Gothic readings constitute a backward projection,

retroactively gothicizing, rather than uncovering or revealing what was there all along' (Buckley 2014a: 257). This retroactive gothicization of *Alice* on the one hand, as Buckley suggests, has had a huge impact on texts written for children, while on the other, it has resulted in what Catherine Siemann calls the 'sexualising of Wonderland', and the revising upwards of Alice's age (seven years and six months in *Through the Looking Glass*) to accommodate this (Siemann 2012: 180). *Alice* offers a salient example of how the girl protagonist of the whimsical macabre may shift age and audience, slippage sometimes occurring within a single text.

Other classic sources for the whimsical macabre include Heinrich Hoffmann's book of cautionary tales, *Struwwelpeter* (1845, English translation 1848), the Victorian and Edwardian children's book illustrations of Arthur Rackham, and the work of twentieth-century writer and illustrator Edward Gorey. Hoffmann and Gorey notably take a gleeful delight in flouting po-faced notions of the sacredness of childhood by subjecting the bodies of their child subjects to inventive violence. Hoffmann's tales are moral lessons in which naughty children – 'Little Suck-a-Thumb', 'Augustus Who Would Not Have Any Soup', 'Fidgety Philip', 'Johnny Head-in-Air' – are punished in kind. The rhymes are accompanied by comically horrible illustrations, in which, for example, two cats weep a pool of tears over the ashes of Harriet, who played with matches and burnt herself to death (Hoffmann [1848]1975: 112). Gorey's *The Gashlycrumb Tinies* (1963) has a similar theme but dispenses with the moral lesson to provide an almost existential meditation on child mortality. Imitating a child's primer, it takes the form of a rhyming alphabetical list of children's names and their cause of death, accompanied by stark black-and-white drawings of hollow-eyed waifs in Victorian dress, shown perishing in novel and grisly ways. The huge amounts of space around the figures both emphasizes their vulnerability and suggests the crushing weight of inevitability, so that 'BASIL, assaulted by bears', for instance is dwarfed by the giant, black beasts looming above him, while 'NEVILLE who died of ennui' is little more than two eyes peering out of a window into a vast expanse of undifferentiated grey (Gorey 1972: n.p.).

These influences are combined in the work of Tim Burton, the most influential contemporary practitioner of the whimsical macabre. Eden Lee Lackner documents Burton's debt to Gorey, suggesting they are linked by a fascination with the children on the margins found in Dickens, Kingsley and other Victorian texts, a concern with 'childish wonder [as] the necessary prerequisite to accessing fantasy worlds' and a 'shared parody of sentimental or saccharine children's literature and verse that satirically deflates the hopeful

messages of such works' (Lackner 2013: 152, 153). Burton's illustrated poetry book, *The Melancholy Death of Oyster Boy and Other Stories* (1997), reinvents Hoffmann and Gorey by combining doggerel verse and whimsical sketches to portray monstrously self-immolating children such as 'Pincushion Girl', 'Junk Girl', 'Toxic Boy' and 'The Boy with Nails in His Eyes'. Burton's children are not punished for wrong-doings but simply adrift in a hostile world for which their difficult bodies do not equip them. Lackner argues, however, that Burton revises Gorey's unremitting pessimism so that '[e]ven in his more tragic tales, the main characters have access to moments of happiness, hope and joy, transcending an unfeeling world, if only just for an instant' (2013: 163).

Moments of joy pepper Burton's work, and are often linked with childhood nostalgia, for instance in two similar sequences that create a 'snow globe' effect: Kim dancing in Edward's artificial snowstorm in *Edward Scissorhands* (1990), and Ichabod's dream of his mother dancing amidst floating dandelion clocks in *Sleepy Hollow* (1999). As Ichabod's mother (Lisa Marie) rises from the ground, this moment of happiness is literally depicted as a moment of transcendence. However, Burton's whimsical macabre is more accurately characterized by its carnivalesque glee. *The Nightmare before Christmas* (1993), the Disney stop-motion animation conceived and produced by Burton and directed by Henry Selick, is the ultimate template for the whimsical macabre. It takes audience expectations of a Disney film (cute animation, big musical numbers, a heart-warming romantic ending) and replays them in a gruesome register. Most significantly, it draws on the distinctive character of the Hallowe'en festival, as Burton identifies:

> To me, Hallowe'en has always been the most fun night of the year. It's where rules are dropped and you can be anything at all. Fantasy rules. It's only scary in a funny way. Nobody's out to really scare anybody else to death. They're out to delight people with their scariness, which is what Hallowe'en is all about and what *Nightmare* is all about. (Salisbury 2006: 124)

This Hallowe'en sensibility as Burton describes it gets to the heart of the whimsical macabre, and indeed happy Gothic. Within this sensibility, scariness is comic: it is 'fun', 'funny' and induces 'delight'. It is entertainment without real-world repercussions: 'Nobody's out to really scare anybody else to death.' It is also a suggestively Bakhtinian carnivalesque space, 'where rules are dropped and you can be anything at all'. In Burton's Halloweentown, bodies are fluid and metamorphic, enabled by the use of stop-motion animation, and the heroine is self-fashioning Sally Ragdoll the patchwork girl who continually, literally,

remakes herself. In seeking to take over neighbouring Christmastown, the denizens of Halloweentown perform a characteristically carnivalesque inversion, replacing treats with tricks and challenging the family values of mainstream American culture. Nevertheless, while the film revels in this temporary period of chaos, order is eventually restored, and Hallowe'en is re-contained within its proper boundaries. In Halloweentown, it is Hallowe'en every day, but that cannot be a universal state of affairs. Its inhabitants, moreover, may have grotesque bodies but they cannot change in any permanent or meaningful way: they are tied to their archetypal roles.

While the Americanization of Hallowe'en can be overstated, the prominence of the festival within American culture lends a particular flavour to American versions of the whimsical macabre. British versions similarly prioritize 'fun' and 'delight' over the properly scary, but tend to take a more literary approach, with Mervyn Peake's *Gormenghast* trilogy (1946–59) and its proto-Goth heroine, Fuchsia, a key influence. British variations on the whimsical macabre construct buildings and families of labyrinthine complexity, and locate its heroines more firmly in the tradition of literary Gothic parodies such as Eaton Stannard Barrett's *The Heroine* (1813), Thomas Love Peacock's *Nightmare Abbey* (1818), Jane Austen's *Northanger Abbey* (1818) and Stella Gibbons's *Cold Comfort Farm* (1932). Marcus Sedgwick's *The Raven Mysteries* (2009–11), dubbed 'goth-froth' by their author, is a good example ('Flood and Fang'). Decorated with highly stylized, monochrome illustrations prominently featuring archetypal Goth girl Solstice, the series nods to Gorey and Addams as well as Peake and a host of other literary references. The most critically and commercially successful example of a British whimsical macabre, however, is Chris Riddell's *Goth Girl and the Ghost of a Mouse* (2013) and its sequels. Riddell, a political satirist and celebrated illustrator of children's books, combines his talents in the adventures of Ada Goth, daughter of the Byronic Lord Goth of Ghastly-Gorm Hall, 'mad, bad and dangerous to gnomes' (Riddell 2013: 2). The book's delicious recombinations of Gothic literary history include the characters of Lucy Borgia, the vampire governess, and the monstrous 'Polar Explorer', who hides out in the icehouse with his albatross. The book won the 2013 Costa Children's Book Award, shortly before its author was made Children's Laureate, and Chloe Buckley suggests, 'The success of the book speaks of a renewed attention to and appreciation of the silly and the frivolous in literary circles.' As she points out, '*Goth Girl* reminds readers that pastiche and parody form a repertoire of gothic techniques themselves.' Nevertheless, in contrast to earlier parodies which point to a world outside the text, *Goth Girl* marks new territory in that it

> wilfully departs from social realities, serious moral debates, and what are commonly termed 'issues' in children's literature. *Goth Girl* is concerned with the gothic itself, which it deconstructs and reconstitutes in a way that celebrates the form and promotes a canon of literary works for readers new to gothic. (Buckley 2014b)

As a paradigmatic example of happy Gothic, *Goth Girl* constructs an autonomous and self-referential Gothic world comparable to that of *Crimson Peak*, discussed in Chapter 2. Like that film, too, its visual appeal is key to its meaning, its status as beautiful object self-consciously guiding and enhancing the reading experience (besides its lavish illustrations, the book is embellished with a gilt lining, ribbon page-marker and pull-out miniature book). The most distinctive and pertinent features of *Goth Girl*, however, are its lightness, playfulness and wit.

Kinderwhore to feminist camp

Hoffmann, Gorey, Burton and Riddell portray both boys and girls in their work. In the 1990s, however, the whimsical macabre became associated not only with childhood but with girlhood in particular, as a number of alternative artists and musicians circulated Gothicized images of girlhood. The most well-known of these is Courtney Love, singer and lead guitarist of the American rock band Hole, who along with Kat Bjelland of Babes in Toyland, popularized what she referred to as the 'kinderwhore' look. This look, which quickly spread through alternative culture around the world (and underwent a high fashion revival in 2015–16) combined baby doll dresses, peter pan collars, tiaras and mary janes with ripped tights, crudely applied make-up and mussed hair. Hole's lyrical concerns also characteristically returned to stereotyped images of girls' culture damaged, broken or otherwise travestied, as in the single *Doll Parts* (1994): 'I am doll eyes, doll mouth, doll legs/ I am doll arms, big veins, dog bait.' Courtney Love was not directly associated with Goth subculture; indeed Trevor Holmes has written interestingly about the ways in which she has attempted to shore up a particular kind of alternative credibility by repudiating Goth (Holmes 2007). Nevertheless her public image and lyrical concerns can be described as Goth*ic* in their adherence to selected themes and conventions of the genre, and arguably were influential on Goth subculture, particularly in the United States.

Another example of Gothic imagery of girlhood from this period is the alternative comic *Meat Cake* (1991–), written and illustrated by Dame Darcy. Issues of *Meat Cake* combined whimsical stories about the everyday lives of a recurring

cast of mainly female characters, including Effluvia the Mermaid and Hindrance and Perfidia the Siamese Twins, with full-blown, faux-Victorian Gothic melodramas with titles such as 'For Whom the Bell Tolls' and 'Drucilla's Awakening'. The visual style of *Meat Cake* incorporates distinctive recurring iconography of frilly Victorian clothes, girls with big eyes and braids, dolls and ponies (or 'fillies', as Dame Darcy refers to them) alongside decadent indulgence, macabre imagery and hysterical violence. In one characteristic tale, 'Dress Delirium', recurring female characters Richard Dirt and Friend the Girl need new party outfits, so dig up two corpses to steal their fabulous Victorian dresses, and have a magnificent night out but are then haunted by the ghosts of the two women who want to get their clothes back.

What unites Courtney Love and Dame Darcy is their utilization of Gothic imagery of girlhood in the service of a distinctly adult sensibility. It is no coincidence that *Meat Cake* carried the 'For Mature Readers' label, first introduced by Vertigo comics in the mid-1980s to enable its writers to flout the Comics Code and pursue adult subjects. In some ways Hole's treatment of girlhood is more Gothic in the conventional sense, as Love uses it to represent a traumatic past that continues to terrorize the present. An oppressive image of idealized girlhood is repeatedly desecrated and brutally dismembered in Hole's music. In songs from her first two albums, Love simultaneously performs the roles of victim and aggressor, ruined innocent and teenage whore, staging a horrific doubling explicitly referred to in one song as 'Good Sister, Bad Sister'. *Meat Cake*, on the other hand, has a more comic and celebratory sensibility and tends rather to undercut its fetishization of Victorian femininity with a knowing adult humour. Both girlhood and the Victorian period are revisited with comparable nostalgia, but a selective and knowing nostalgia that foregrounds their fictional quality and renders them material for overblown fantasy.

Both Courtney Love and Dame Darcy frame images of girlhood with adult sexuality, whether the outpouring of dark and unruly desires in Hole's music, or the gleeful promiscuity depicted in *Meat Cake*. Performing idealized girlhood as adults, Love and Darcy Gothicize and ironize it, opening up a critical distance on it at the same time that they celebrate its pleasures. Both, at times, enable the expression of female rage in a way that recalls Ellen Moers's description of 'the savagery of girlhood' in nineteenth-century female Gothic texts, particularly *Wuthering Heights* (1978: 107).

It is no accident that in the 2000s, Dame Darcy went on to produce a lavishly illustrated edition of Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre*. The edition is particularly interesting because it was issued in 2006, when the first two books in the

Twilight series were already bestsellers in the United States but before *Twilight* had become a massive global phenomenon. When the book first came out, one reviewer described it as 'Governess gone Goth', quoting Darcy's comment that she aimed to make the novel look 'really kind of punk rock for the new generation of goth girls'. Speculating on the book's appeal for contemporary teenagers, the reviewer concluded,

> In an era when everybody – from the Girl Scouts to guidance counsellors to the *Gossip Girl* series – peddles the 'you-go-girl' message, *Jane Eyre* is a book that evokes the struggle for self-definition as a truly harrowing one. This isn't a coming-of-age story about absorbing the counsel of wise mentors, overcoming temptation, and thus learning to 'be yourself' … Jane sets about doing something much lonelier and harder. She insists on finding 'her beliefs by herself', in her own way, as she weathers exile after exile, first from her past (a hellish home and school) and then from a future that seems, fleetingly, to await her with Rochester. She doesn't come to accept others' values as her own, as the protagonist of the traditional novel of education does … [T]he indomitable Jane has a way of enlisting her readers, especially the adolescents among them, in the dream of being recognized as an assertive original. (Hulbert 2006)

What is interesting about this is the way that *Jane Eyre* is being constructed as an antidote to mainstream images of teenage femininity – re-viewed through Dame Darcy's eyes, rebellious Jane becomes a prototypical Goth girl, uncomfortable in her own skin yet confident of her difference and dead set on self-determination. The Gothic heroine is viewed by Hulbert as a figure of resistance to patriarchal narratives, a girl who makes her own choices and her own culture rather than passively consuming that which she is offered. Dame Darcy's illustrations support this reading. The title page to Volume 1 shows a calm, collected adult Jane writing, with melodramatic vignettes illustrating her earlier life positioned above her head: as an agonized child in the Red Room, a martyred schoolgirl kneeling before a brandished crucifix, and a sad-eyed young woman departing for life as a governess (Brontë and Dame Darcy 2006: 9). Jane is presented as actively shaping her own narrative, the author of her own story. Elsewhere, Dame Darcy uses similar internal framing devices to acknowledge Jane's thoughts, dreams and desires within the realist plot, so that, for example, her weird paintings dominate the illustration of her conversation with Rochester in the drawing room and she looks through the window of Gateshead Hall directly onto an imagined image of shipwreck (colour plates, n.p.). In a striking reversal of this framing device, the image of her sleeping body entwined with the dead Helen Burns floats above

a fanciful illustration of the two girls on a picnic, suggesting the force of Jane's desire to reverse reality and fantasy (colour plate, no page number). Elsewhere, marginalia hint at repressed thoughts and desires erupting into the text and recall the Brontë sisters' own penchant for marginalia.

Dame Darcy's illustrations serve to heighten and stylize the emotions expressed in *Jane Eyre* and thus demonstrate how Gothic girlhood in the 1990s and 2000s frequently falls into the category Susan Sontag describes as camp – a 'mixture of the exaggerated, the fantastic, the passionate, and the naïve' (1994: 283) which deals in heightened emotion, but always mediated through theatricality, as if in quotation marks. The idea of a feminist camp was proposed by Pamela Robertson in her 1995 book *Guilty Pleasures*, and sought to respond to prior readings of camp that established it as an exclusively gay male sensibility, despite its dependence on female screen icons and, often, the appropriation of women's style. For Robertson, this resulted in a position in which 'women are camp but do not knowingly produce themselves as camp and, furthermore, do not even have access to a camp sensibility. Women, by this logic, are objects of camp and subject to it but are not camp subjects' (1995: 5). In contrast, Robertson draws on concepts of masquerade in order to 'reclaim a female form of aestheticism … that articulates and subverts the "image- and culture-making processes" to which women have traditionally been given access' (9). Feminist camp self-consciously performs conventional images of femininity, thus simultaneously acknowledging them as a source of pleasure while acknowledging their artificiality and opening them up to the possibility of critique. This offers a way out of the dichotomy commonly espoused by cultural criticism, in which popular cultural texts confirm dominant ideologies and can either be passively enjoyed by a compliant consumer or actively rejected by a resistant one. As Robertson argues,

> [E]xamining camp in relation to the female spectator opens up new possibilities for describing the kinds of pleasure a female spectator might take in mass-produced objects that seem to support an oppressive patriarchal sexual regime. Too often, spectatorship studies, and (sub)cultural studies more generally, tend to reify pleasure, particularly female pleasure, as either a consciously resistant activity or a wholly passive manipulation … Camp, however, reveals the porousness of pleasure, its locally overlapping features of passivity and activity, affirmation and critique. (1995: 15–16)

Both Courtney Love and Dame Darcy can be read in terms of Robertson's concept of feminist camp. Dame Darcy's Gothic pastiche in particular is a form of feminist camp in which the Victorian is always the 'Victorian' and girls are always

'girls', or indeed, 'fillies' (girls and ponies are often interchangeable in the world of *Meat Cake* – Bronwyn of 'Bronwyn and Alifair' is even born from a horse). Camp, according to Sontag, 'proposes a comic vision of the world' (1994: 288). It is, she says, 'above all, a mode of enjoyment, of appreciation – not judgment. Camp is generous. It wants to enjoy' (291). It is this generosity and enjoyment that makes *Meat Cake* an especial precursor of the comic and celebratory turn that I call happy Gothic.

Gothic Lolita

In the 2000s, the crystallization of images of Goth girls into iconic cartoon characters such as Emily the Strange and Ruby Gloom also places the strong emotions with which they are associated into quotation marks. In both cases, the defining feature of these characters is emotion: the image of Emily the Strange is frequently accompanied by words that indicate boredom or dissent, while Ruby Gloom's tag line is 'The happiest girl in the world'. This presents a marked distinction to iconic male cartoon characters from Superman and Tintin to Sonic the Hedgehog: they tend to be consistently defined in terms of action rather than emotion (one exception perhaps being *Peanuts*' Charlie Brown). The stylization and self-conscious performance of strong emotion in these girl characters can also be read as a form of female camp. However it is also influenced by Japanese manga and anime, and more particularly the street style of Gothic & Lolita as it is characterized by the influential Japanese style magazine *The Gothic & Lolita Bible* (2001–).

Lolita style began in Japan in the 1990s, but has since spread to the global Goth scene. Participants wear elaborately frilled, embroidered dresses inspired by the rococo period and Victorian children's costume. Skirts traditionally end just below the knee and are expanded with hoops and multiple lacy petticoats. Accessories include striped stockings, bloomers, fans, parasols, giant bows, ribbons and diminutive top hats. A principal aim of the style is to look like a Victorian doll; indeed, participants not only collect and make clothing for dolls but often 'parad[e] with a real doll, a smaller version of herself' (Hardy Bernal 2012: 118). The classic Gothic Lolita or GothLoli style is black and white, but this has fallen out of fashion in recent years and now black with accents of red or other strong colours is more common (Scharf 2014: 154). The variant Kuro Lolita wears only black, and the Shiro Lolita only white, commonly dressing as a pair. However, Lolita style is not necessarily Gothic – different kinds of Lolitas

are constantly emerging from the Japanese scene including, for example, the pastel-coloured Sweet Lolita and the gingham-clad Country Lolita. More pertinently, the Guro or gory Lolita aims to look like a broken doll, while Elegant Gothic Aristocrat, a style invented by musician Mana of visual-kei group Malice Mizer and worn by both sexes, is closer to European Goth. Significantly, while there is a Goth subculture in Japan, it is distinct from GothLoli, which is entirely visual and shows little interest in the musical or other elements of Goth.

The GothLoli's identity in her native Japan is a complex one. According to Kathryn A. Hardy Bernal, Lolita style is often perceived by its participants as a means of refusing adult sexuality and prolonging a childhood state of innocence, a kind of 'passive-aggressive rebellion' against patriarchal culture (2012: 129). This taps into a wider trend for the cute or *kawaii* in Japanese culture, dating back to the 1970s, that Sharon Kinsella describes as 'concerned with a sentimental journey back into an idealised childhood' (1995: 241). As Kinsella explains, 'Underpinning cute style are the neoromantic notions of childhood as an entirely separate, and hence unmaligned, pure sphere of human life' (241). This fantasy is, in its Japanese context, a resistant one. It responds to the particular social position of young women who, due to their exclusion from most forms of labour during the period that *kawaii* developed, were 'associated with an exotic and longed-for world of individual fulfilment, decadence, consumption and play' (244). Moreover, because in contrast to Western culture, mainstream Japanese culture regarded personal consumption as anti-social and immoral, 'cute youth culture went against the grain of older social values by sanctioning consumption' (246). The GothLoli, by parading her spectacular consumption outside of the home, therefore enacts a kind of gender-specific subcultural resistance loosely comparable to the bedroom culture identified in the 1970s by Angela McRobbie and Jenny Garber's pioneering study of girls and subcultures. McRobbie and Garber suggested that girls were often barred from the public spaces of the 'street' and instead constructed a private bedroom culture out of the teeny bop idols and comics presented to them by the media (McRobbie and Garber 2002). Similarly, Hardy Bernal suggests,

> In dressing themselves up, going out with their dolls, and congregating with friends on the street, gothloli transfer the notion of private play to public exhibition. In taking private girls' play outside, they therefore trespass the 'male' public domain, while transgressing the rule that the place for women is in the home. In doing so, they take ownership of the little-girl image and expose it, so that it is no longer secretive or mysterious, desensitizing the 'naughtiness associated with privately viewing *lolicon*'. (Hardy Bernal 2012: 129)

If McRobbie and Garber's teenyboppers construct a subculture from the materials provided for them by consumer culture, Lolita takes this to a new level. Lolita is a subculture that is built around, and fetishizes, the notion of girls as consumers. Lolita outfits are costly and either self-made or, more commonly, purchased from dedicated clothing labels such as Angelic Pretty. In cult film *Kamikaze Girls* (2004), the Lolita heroine Momoko wins the opportunity to design for her favourite clothing label Baby, the Stars Shine Bright, but gives it up when she realizes that her true identity lies in consumption. The act of wearing the clothes is fulfilment enough. Within the specific context of Japanese culture, Momoko's story suggests that wearing clothes can be as creative an act as making them and that young girls' performative identities have their own intrinsic value.

Revising the romance in comics and animation

In the preceding sections I have identified the major influences on the whimsical macabre leading up until the 1990s and suggested that there are a number of ways that it can be read as offering young women a space to explore the discourses of femininity in ways that are divergent from the mainstream: as carnivalesque festivity, as feminist camp, and using clothing as a creative means of establishing performative identity. I will now go on to explore a series of twenty-first-century texts that deploy these strategies in order to revise the conventional romance narrative. The stylization of the Goth girl, as I have suggested, makes her especially conducive to visual representation, and thus she has become a regular feature of graphic and animated narratives, which speak particularly to niche or cult audiences.

The template for the Goth girl in comics was set by Neil Gaiman's Death from *The Sandman* (1989–96), mentioned in Chapter 3 as a key antecedent of the 'Perky Goth' archetype. Goth comics flourished from the end of the 1990s with a range of titles published by Slave Labor Graphics including *Lenore*, Jhonen Vasquez's *Johnny the Homicidal Maniac* and most recently, Stephen Emond's *Emo Boy*. Of these titles, the one to focus most directly on Goth girls was *GloomCookie* (2001–07), written by Serena Valentino and initially drawn by Ted Naifeh, subsequently replaced by John Gebbia, Breehn Burns, Harley Sparx and Vincent Batignole. As the title suggests, the comic deliberately combines the 'sweet and dark' (Darick Robertson, cited in Valentino and Gebbia 2002: 4). It interweaves an Austenesque comedy of manners concerning a group of Goths who attend the same nightclub with a series of fantastical tales in which many

of the same characters have supernatural alter egos and inhabit Gothic or fairy tale worlds. Sometimes, the two sets of narratives counterpoint each other, but frequently they become directly intertwined.

The comic engages directly with romance narrative in the story of two linked couples, Lex and Damian and Sebastian and Chrys. In many ways, it pursues the conventional model of Gothic romance outlined by Fred Botting and quoted in Chapter 3: 'Romance, as it frames Gothic, seems to clean up its darker counterpart, sanitising its depravations; it tries to transform, even ennoble, violent Gothic energies as a quest for love in the face of death; it recuperates Gothic excesses in the name of the heterosexual couple' (Botting 2008a: 1). However, *GloomCookie*'s double structure of 'real' world and 'romance' world also functions to place it in a Shakespearean tradition, as Caitlin R. Kiernan points out in her introduction to the collected volume of the first six issues:

> One doesn't have to reach very far to draw a comparison between the romantic intrigues of the Athenian court, of Theseus and Hippolyta, Lysander and Hermia, Demetrius and Helena … And, as in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, the equation is quickly complicated by a second-tier narrative, the intrusion of the supernatural upon an already complex stage, with Vincent's Carnival Macabre serving much the same function as does Shakespeare's Fairy Court. Finally, just as Shakespeare lampoons bad theatre and clueless egos with the pompous antics of Tom Bottom, so Gloomcookie gives us the unfortunate Vermillion and the omnipresent spector [*sic*] of Bad Goth Poetry. (Valentino and Naifeh 2001: 4)

In *GloomCookie*, the whimsical macabre becomes analogous to Shakespeare's green world, the comedic space identified by Northrop Frye in *The Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) in which every day social tensions can be played out and resolved in fantastical form. If it is difficult to fully sustain this comparison, this is because *GloomCookie*, like many comics, rapidly develops numerous modes of storytelling in order to sustain its serial narrative. In its emphasis on social satire, *GloomCookie* both offers a more piquant version of romance than might otherwise be expected, and locates the supposedly solitary Goth girl within a community. This community offers multiple kinds of femininity: central trio Lex, Chrys and Lyndi are all physically attractive but have clearly distinguished personalities, and are complemented by a number of other female characters, most prominently queen bitch Isabella (who in early episodes bears a strong resemblance to the Marquise de Merteuil from Laclos's 1782 novel of sexual intrigue *Les Liaisons Dangereuses*). The women are not

isolated figures but are close friends located within a broader social sphere; like the Goths of *Goth Cruise* I discussed in Chapter 1, they are not exclusively miserable but experience the 'full range' of emotions. Goths who pretentiously dramatize their isolation, such as the performance poet Vermilion, are lightly mocked for claiming to be outsiders but having a wealthy family and a loyal entourage.

The graphic art by Naifeh, Gebbia, Burns and others trades heavily on the distinctiveness of Goth style, with the visual appearance of characters the main focus. The different artists use individual episodes to expand the visual repertoire more widely: Ted Naifeh makes striking use of white silhouette on black in the encounter between Chrys and the monster, when the cross-hatching of the fishnets on her arms echoes the zig-zags of his teeth, and her glowing white hair dominates the composition (Valentino and Naifeh 2001: 28). In the fairy tale pastiche, 'The Curse of the Gargoyle Queen', John Gebbia frames the page with ornate borders featuring angels and roses or gargoyles and thorns depending on whether good or evil is uppermost in the story (Valentino and Gebbia 2002: 7–38). Burns conveys the shock and grief provoked by the discovery of Lex's death by breaking the frame, dispensing with guttering between the images so that they bleed into one another, presenting fragmented perspectives on the same scene in wide angle and extreme close-up, and reversing the colour of the lettering so that the caption 'She's dead' appears in white on a large expanse of empty black space (Valentino and Burns 2004: n.p.). The main attraction, however, remains the stylized looks of the characters, reinterpreted by guest artists and fans in the 'gallery' section at the end of each volume. This is reinforced in the repeated formula describing Lex: 'She had big doe eyes that she could bat better than anyone. She had raven hair cut into a bob that curled under just right' (Valentino and Naifeh 2001: 9). If the stylization of appearance is a standard feature of comics and graphic novels, here the written text draws it explicitly to the reader's attention and underlines its performative nature.

The emphasis on the visual aspect of the Goth girl is reiterated in animation. Tim Burton's *Beetlejuice* spawned a spin-off animated series that ran between 1989 and 1991, developed and executive produced by Burton himself, and translated the distinctive visual signature of that film into a cartoon medium. Central character Lydia Deetz was perkier and more cheerful than her portrayal by Winona Ryder in the original film and became the first of a series of animated Goth girls, of which there are, to date, around fifty examples including, prominently, Raven from *Teen Titans* (2003–06), *Ruby Gloom* and

her friends (2006–08) and Gwen from *Total Drama Island* (2007–08). Many of these series are not in themselves Gothic, but use the Goth girl character as an opportunity to portray a darker sensibility or more biting wit within a larger ensemble. The animated Goth girl is generally presented in opposition to conventional romance, and is often paired with a hyper-feminine girl, Raven contrasting with Starfire in *Teen Titans*, for example, and Marceline with Princess Bubblegum in *Adventure Time* (2010–). Other series flagrantly employ a Burtonesque aesthetic: *Ruby Gloom* displays a saturated colour palette, stripes and curlicues, and is particularly worth noting here for its presentation of its heroine as a studiedly cute, perennially perky girl whose adventures revolve around resolving the problems of her monstrous friends: in 'Grounded in Gloomsville' (2006), for example, she attempts to cure Scaredy Bat of his fear of flying.

For the purposes of this chapter, I will concentrate on *Adventure Time*, a particularly inventive version of the whimsical macabre. Aired on America's Cartoon Network and syndicated worldwide, the series is a surreal, anarchic fantasy combining psychedelic imagery with wisecracking, deadpan humour that characteristically pokes fun at the clichéd conventions of genre narrative. While not a Gothic text per se, in its wildly inventive hybridizing of genre it incorporates a number of Gothic stock characters and conventions. Marceline the Vampire Queen, drawn as a bad-ass rock chick who sings and plays guitar, is the most significant and frequently recurring of these. In the episodes in which she is introduced, expectations of the vampire genre are comically overturned. In 'Henchman' (2010), for example, a series of misunderstandings lead the hero Finn to expect the worst. It is revealed, however, that Marceline drinks not blood but the colour red; instead of sacking a castle she performs a rock concert for its inhabitants; and when she instructs Finn to kill a cute and innocent-looking Dimple Plant it is for his own good – the Dimple Plant transforms into a terrifying monster from which she then has to rescue him. While she enjoys capitalizing on her evil reputation, she does so in order to play games with people rather than out of a desire to harm.

The Season 2 episode 'Go With Me' (2011) directly addresses teen romance. Finn wants to ask Princess Bubblegum to a couples movie night, but she refuses, so he resorts to a variety of tactics to win her over. Marceline plays the best friend role familiar from teen movies, and suggests that girls like fun and excitement, encouraging Finn to try wrestling Princess Bubblegum and filling her bedroom with wolves – both of which strategies backfire. In a manoeuvre familiar from the teen romance, Finn realizes that Marceline has been his dream date

all along and attempts to serenade her instead. Marceline, however, finds this hilarious and only agrees to accompany him when he makes it clear that it is just as friends. When the movie turns out to be a romance and all the other couples start smooching, Finn and Marceline make vomiting sounds and head off to ride on the wolves instead.

Within this particular episode, there is no requirement for Marceline to be a vampire: that is incidental to the narrative. Nevertheless, the rejection of the romance plot stems from her vampire identity: she is more at home riding with wolves than smooching with boys. (Significantly, the pink-haired Princess Bubblegum does not strictly conform to gender stereotype either and is a scientist and inventor.) Similarly, in 'Memory of a Memory' (2011), when a controlling ex-boyfriend tricks Marcelline into getting back together by erasing her memories of his treachery, she responds to his instructions to 'get back in the kitchen and make me dinner' with righteously violent rage fuelled by her vampire powers. In *Adventure Time*, casual violence against villains is *de rigeur*, an intrinsic part of its variation on the whimsical macabre, and here this is used as another means of revising the conventional romance plot.

Conclusion

If the most commonly denigrated elements of what I am calling happy Gothic are those features associated with femininity and childhood, reading these diverse cultural products through the whimsical macabre can help restore a sense of their cultural value. The Hallowe'en world of the whimsical macabre is one of festivity and delight, but it is not empty of meaning or of political agency. If it is impossible entirely to escape the construction of Goth girl as commodity in some of these texts and products, this belies the richness of the full range of the whimsical macabre and its more dynamic strategies for negotiating femininity. As I have demonstrated, the combination of the Goth girl and the whimsical macabre enables romance conventions to be simultaneously enjoyed, addressed and revised in a number of contemporary texts. This could be extended to other texts which I have not had the space to explore here, such as the television series *Pushing Daisies* (2007–09), a markedly Burtonesque production in which the protagonist Ned's ability to bring the dead back to life, but only for sixty seconds before someone or something else dies, facilitates both whimsical, heavily aestheticized murder scenes and

yet another reconfigured romance: in this case, the protagonists find creative means to circumvent the prohibition on physical touch. As Lorna Jowett and Stacey Abbott suggest, directly evoking the terms of this book, *Pushing Daisies* 'sugarcoats taboo subject matter in colourful conventions of comedy and romance' (2013: 147).

Jowett and Abbott's comment indicates how central the whimsical macabre is to the argument of this book. It has permeated twenty-first-century Gothic and yet it is scarcely noticed by critics. Its texts do, however, repay examination and my analysis in this chapter has offered a number of critical strategies for doing so, from the carnivalesque and parody to performativity and feminist camp. The last of these in particular strikes a key note for the remainder of the book as my attention shifts from romance to comedy, and from texts predominantly associated with femininity to those more closely associated with masculinity. Feminist camp offers a key critical strategy through which Goth hyper-femininity can be recuperated and enjoyed. In the ensuing chapters feminist camp is complemented firstly by the more 'conventional' camp of male vampires, and finally by Paul Magrs's comic camp Gothic jamboree.

6

‘Happy Nights Are Here Again’: Having a Laugh with Vampires and Other Monsters

Post-millennial monsters

Post-millennial Gothic is distinguished by a proliferation of monsters, from the familiar vampires, zombies and werewolves to the more exotic shapeshifters, fairies, angels, demons, cephalopods, golems, jinns and more: no religious or folkloric creature is safe from appropriation. A Google ngram mapping usage of the words ‘vampire’, ‘zombie’ and ‘werewolf’ shows a steep climb beginning in the late 1960s, accelerating in the early 1980s and reaching an all-time high in 2008, the most recent year for which statistics are available (Figure 6.1). This is particularly true of the word ‘vampire’, which, since the 1960s, has massively increased its lead over its monstrous siblings – indeed, since 1985, it has been much more prevalent than the word ‘Gothic’. The significance of this development is all the more marked when contrasted with the first phase of the Gothic novel in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, in which monsters were virtually unknown. In post-millennial culture monsters have become virtually synonymous with Gothic in popular identification.

In Chapter 4 I invoked the sympathetic monster, and suggested that in twenty-first-century vampire romance, this figure has evolved into the assimilative monster. In the present chapter, however, I want to return to sympathetic monsters and examine them more closely in the light of an emerging comedic discourse. Much twenty-first-century scholarship has been devoted to tracking the rise of the creature whose otherness is diminished by their ability to narrate their own suffering. There are two major archetypes or sources for this figure: the articulate, self-justifying Creature in Mary Shelley’s *Frankenstein* (1818) and the wildly attractive but damned Byronic hero. These two strands

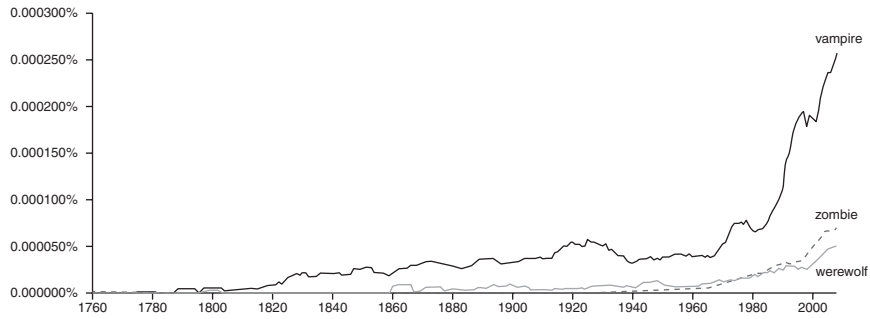

Figure 6.1. *Google ngram showing usage of the words vampire, zombie and werewolf in English-language texts between 1760 and 2008.*

converge in a number of late 1960s and 1970s texts. The television soap opera *Dark Shadows* (1966–71) repositioned vampire Barnabas Collins as romantic hero in response to audience demand; two key novels, Fred Saberhagen's *The Dracula Tape* (1975) and Anne Rice's *Interview with the Vampire* (1976), rewrote the vampire narrative as extended first-person confession. For many critics, the late-twentieth-century Gothic monster thus undergoes a shift from terrifying otherness to over-familiarity. In a 1992 interview, Jacques Derrida stated, 'Monsters cannot be announced. One cannot say: "Here are our monsters", without immediately turning the monsters into pets' (Derrida 1992: 386). For Derrida, the process of identifying and naming monsters returns them to the linguistic and social order from which they were excluded. Fred Botting riffs on Derrida's statement to claim, 'As monsters are sought out, radical difference is diminished: they become familiar, recognized, expected, "normal" rather than "monstrous" monstrosities, domesticated to the point of being pets' (Botting 2014: 500). In the previous chapter, I coined the term 'whimsical macabre' to describe texts in which the monstrous and the cute are combined. In this chapter, I seek to explore instead the ways in which the very familiarity of the twenty-first-century monster opens them up to new comic possibilities.

Sympathetic monsters lend themselves to romance narratives. As Joseph Crawford points out, by the late 1970s the ' "monster-to-hero" routine' demonstrated by Barnabas Collins 'had become virtually the standard plotline of the erotic romance' (2014: 59). He goes on to demonstrate how the vampires of contemporary paranormal romance, including *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, *The Vampire Diaries*, *Twilight* and *True Blood*, are direct descendants of Byron and his fictional avatars including Ruthven (*The Vampyre*, 1819), Heathcliff

(*Wuthering Heights*, 1847) and Rochester (*Jane Eyre*, 1847). These male vampires conform to a familiar paradigm of masculinity in which danger is signalled as attractive and the ultimate erotic challenge is to tame or redeem a morally ambiguous man. The resurgence of this paradigm in the twenty-first century, in the context of third- and fourth-wave feminist debates about harassment and consent, can seem retrograde, but can also be a deliberate means of foregrounding these particular issues. Much early feminist criticism of *Twilight*, for example, rested on the idea that vampire Edward's behaviour towards his beloved Bella mimics stalking and domestic abuse (see, e.g., Housel 2009), but this provoked extensive fan discussion in which young women were enabled to explore their concerns, and in many cases put forward divergent readings. Other texts such as *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* and the *Southern Vampire Mysteries* address similar issues while more self-consciously modelling feminist resistance.

If the sympathetic monster is clearly located within the romance tradition, much less attention has been paid to its relationship with comedy. Vampires have featured in comic texts since the early nineteenth century, almost concurrently with their entry into the English literary tradition, becoming a staple of the nineteenth-century stage. However, in these early texts, vampires are always the butt of the jokes, or the straight man in an ensemble comedy. Their otherness remains intact. The notion that vampires themselves are able to laugh is more complex and develops hand in hand with the humanization of the vampire in the later twentieth century. If historically, the vampire parody is a hugely popular sub-genre, from nineteenth-century theatre through *Abbott and Costello Meet Frankenstein* (1948) to *The Fearless Vampire Killers* (1967), the idea that we might laugh *with* the vampire is more elusive.

Parody plays an important role in the story of the comic vampire. Most of the comic vampires of the second half of the twentieth century, from George Hamilton in *Love at First Bite* (1979) to *Sesame Street*'s Count von Count (1972–), parody the overfamiliar conventions of vampire narrative to a greater or lesser extent and in more or less inventive ways. Parody, however, which Linda Hutcheon famously called 'repetition with critical difference' (1988: 26) is perhaps the form of comedy that is easiest to recuperate for academic purposes, given that it presupposes a critique of the source material. It has thus been written about most extensively, and there is some important work, for example, by Avril Horner and Sue Zlosnik (2005) and Kamilla Elliott (2008) on its role in the Gothic. For Horner and Zlosnik, 'parody can offer Gothic a comic turn. This turn frequently allows a fresh perspective on a changing world, one

of accommodation rather than terrified apprehension' (Horner and Zlosnik 2005: 12). Parody changes the contract between reader and text and enables a different kind of response, 'offering a measure of detachment from scenes of pain and suffering that would be disturbing in a different Gothic context' (13). It can therefore be seen as instrumental in the formation of a happy Gothic: it dissociates Gothic tropes and conventions from the affectivity of horror and converts them instead to laughter. For Elliott, 'Gothic film parodies go beyond simple mockery to reveal inconsistencies, incongruities, and problems in Gothic criticism: boundaries that it has been unwilling or unable to blur, binary oppositions it has refused to deconstruct, and points at which a radical, innovative, subversive discourse manifests as its own hegemonic, dogmatic, and clichéd double' (2008: 24). Elliott's article discusses a number of films including *Love at First Bite* and *Dracula: Dead and Loving It* (1995) (a film poorly received by critics) as critiques of psychoanalysis as a master narrative in contemporary Gothic criticism.

In this chapter, I will explore how contemporary monsters have themselves developed a comic sensibility. In doing so, I will consider a range of ways in which monsters might be comic, from mordant wit and gallows humour to the camp and carnivalesque. In particular, I aim to identify the monster as a comic *subject* rather than object, one who is the author of their own laughter. I will argue that there is a clear trajectory in monster comedy, from monsters we can laugh at, to monsters we laugh with, to monsters who laugh with each other. In post-millennial Gothic, monsters are not necessarily tortured loners: they belong to communities and, crucially, can be friends. In the context of the politicized equivalence between vampires and social outsiders stressed in many contemporary vampire narratives and discussed at length in Chapter 4, this emphasis on an inclusive laughter is potentially liberating.

My main focus will be on vampires, as the most popular monsters of the twenty-first century and the ones with the most coherent comic tradition. However, this specific emphasis should be placed in a wider context in which zombies, werewolves and other monsters are also increasingly presented as both sympathetic and comic, in their own right and as supporting characters in vampire texts. Edgar Wright's 'zom-rom-com' *Shaun of the Dead* (2004), while mainly taking the point of view of the human survivors, importantly ends with zombie Ed (Nick Frost) shacked up in his best friend's shed. Witty, monstrous protagonists have become a feature of contemporary fiction, including deadpan zombie Andy in S. G. Browne's *Breathers: A Zombie's Lament* (2009) and jaded werewolf Jake Marlowe in Glen Duncan's *The Last Werewolf* (2011). The interior voice of the monster in these texts is not gloomy or melodramatic but

witty and ironic, corresponding to a particular model of masculinity. Female monsters are seldom allowed comic voices in the same way. While there is a tradition of witty, world-weary vamps from Hollywood icons Mae West and Bette Davis through to the sarky Goth teenagers discussed in Chapter 5, and in a slightly different mode, camp horror hostess Elvira (Cassandra Peterson), they are usually human; being a monster is apparently a serious business for a woman. In this chapter masculinity is the main focus, therefore, from adaptations of Dracula to what I call the 'new camp vampires' of the twenty-first century, such as Johnny Depp's reworking of Barnabas Collins in Tim Burton's *Dark Shadows* (2012). Camp is deployed as a political strategy in Frank Meli's short film *Dragula* (2014) and drag artist Sharon Needles's reconfiguration of Dracula, both of which complicate gender binaries. Finally, the chapter considers vampire friendships, analysing two films that focus on male and female friendships respectively: Jemaine Clement and Taika Waititi's *What We Do in the Shadows* (2014) and Amy Heckerling's *Vamps* (2012), a corrective to the relative absence of comic female vampires. In friendship, vampire laughter becomes inclusive and potentially regenerative.

'I never drink – wine': Introducing vampire humour

Does Dracula have a sense of humour? Does he have access to the kind of witty interiority that later monsters defiantly possess? In Stoker's novel he is defiantly humourless. He tells Jonathan Harker,

> I seek not gaiety nor mirth, not the bright voluptuousness of much sunshine and sparkling waters which please the young and gay. I am no longer young, and my heart, through weary years of mourning over the dead, is not attuned to mirth. Moreover, the walls of my castle are broken. The shadows are many, and the wind breathes cold through the broken battlements and casements. I love the shade and the shadow, and would be alone with my thoughts when I may. (Stoker 1998: 54–5)

Jonathan, however, is uneasy with this speech. He considers that, 'Somehow his words and his look did not seem to accord, or else it was that his cast of face made his smile look malignant and saturnine' (Stoker 1998: 55). The disjunction between the Count's professed melancholy and his grim smile is the space where vampire humour emerges. Dracula's joke is one that neither Jonathan nor, indeed, the reader is in on – it unsettles rather than amuses.

In the novel's transferral to cinema, however, this sense of disjunction becomes reframed as deliberate irony. Hosting Renfield (Dwight Frye) in his castle, Bela Lugosi as Dracula in Tod Browning's 1931 film delivers the line, 'I never drink wine' with a beat between 'drink' and 'wine' that creates innuendo: of course the audience is meant to infer that Dracula *does* drink something else. Like the moment of disjunction in the novel when Dracula's melancholic speech contrasts with his malignant smile, the line is dependent on two meanings being present at the same time, only one of which is available to the addressee, in this case Renfield. The audience, however, is supposed to understand the innuendo: the film already presupposes a familiarity with the conventions of vampire narrative. The audience laughs with Dracula, in on the joke in the way that the hapless Renfield is not.

The line is unique to vampire cinema: it does not appear in Stoker's novel, or the 1927 stage adaptation by Hamilton Deane and John L. Balderston on which Browning's film is based. Since Browning's film it has become iconic, repeated over and over again, in a striking example of what Ken Gelder calls the 'citational' properties of vampire cinema. As Gelder explains, 'All films are systems of citation, referencing other films; but vampire films do this in a particularly visible, performative way' (2012: vi). The vampire film's dependence on 'a set of archaic "laws", or folklores' ensures that it is peculiarly bound to its foundational texts and must acknowledge its relationship to them (vi). In John Badham's *Dracula* (1979), Frank Langella omits the pause and strips the line of its comic connotations. In *Love at First Bite*, George Hamilton rejects Susan Saint James's offer of champagne and a drag on 'a little Maui-wowee, really heavy shit' with the line, 'I do not drink – wine – and I do not smoke – shit'. Dracula's abstention becomes a marker of his superior taste. 'Shit' is converted from street slang for cannabis back to its earlier slang meaning, denoting something contemptible or worthless. By the time of Gary Oldman's performance as the Count in Francis Ford Coppola's *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (1992), the audience is treated to a double layer of self-referentiality – not only the knowledge of vampire conventions that enables them to decipher the innuendo, but also the knowledge of previous vampire cinema that enables them to read the scene as referencing Bela Lugosi's performance, as well as, more indirectly, Langella's and Hamilton's. Gary Oldman has better comic timing than Lugosi – he prolongs the pause before the punchline – but paradoxically, he is also scarier. When Jonathan Harker (Keanu Reeves) sniggers at one of his comments, Oldman's Dracula spits out, 'It is no laughing matter!' Vampire humour here is purely solipsistic, requiring no reciprocity, and the inexplicability of its mores makes it potentially terrifying.

This sense of self-referentiality climaxes in *Dracula: Dead and Loving It* (1995), in which Leslie Nielsen plays the line as outright burlesque. 'I never drink – wine', he demurs, with a knowing look straight to camera, before pausing and exclaiming 'Ah, what the hell, let me try it … It's *good!* … Renfield, look at me, I am drinking wine and eating chicken!' But here the humour is less Dracula's than produced out of the contravention of audience expectations, as we see the object of our supposed terror delightedly enjoying a picnic – a quintessential example of 'incongruity theory', a staple of comic analysis since the eighteenth century. Finally, in *Dracula 2000* (2000), the line, apparently exhausted, is updated to 'I do not drink – coffee', delivered by Gerard Butler's millennial Dracula with a slackerish enervation.

The history of the comic vampire

As I established in the Introduction to this book, there has always been a comic component to Gothic, which is a distinctively hybrid genre. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* is no exception. If Dracula's humour is elusive in the novel, Renfield's debased consumption of animal lives operates parodically towards the more high-flown threat of vampirism itself. Moreover, there is a significant moment that highlights the relationship between horror and laughter following Lucy's funeral, when Abraham Van Helsing succumbs to a fit of uncontrollable laughter. Seward, the up-to-date psychiatrist, interprets Van Helsing's laughter as hysteria, but Van Helsing himself puts forward a more complex analysis. He says:

> Do not think that I am not sad, though I laugh. See, I have cried even when the laugh did choke me. But no more think that I am all sorry when I cry, for the laugh he come just the same. Keep it always with you that laughter who knock at your door and say, 'May I come in?' is not true laughter. No! He is a king, and he come when and how he like. He ask no person, he choose no time of suitability. He say, 'I am here.' … even at such a moment King Laugh he come to me and shout and bellow in my ear, 'Here I am! Here I am!' till the blood come dance back and bring some of the sunshine that he carry with him to my cheek. Oh, friend John, it is a strange world, a sad world, a world full of miseries, and woes, and troubles. And yet when King Laugh come, he make them all dance to the tune he play. Bleeding hearts, and dry bones of the churchyard, and tears that burn as they fall, all dance together to the music that he make with that smileless mouth of him. (Stoker 1998: 211–12)

Victor Sage has commented eloquently on this passage, arguing that 'King Laugh' is implicitly also 'King Death', the grinning skull of the *memento mori*, who makes the 'dry bones of the churchyard' rise up and join the *danse macabre* or dance of death (Sage 1994: 198). Van Helsing describes King Laugh as 'good' and 'kind' in enabling life to go on in the face of loss. He implicitly suggests that the body dies but the soul is resurrected and as such is the opposite of Dracula who makes the body immortal at the expense of the soul. King Laugh/Death, who comes when and how he likes, contrasts with Dracula, who must always be invited across the threshold.

Comedy plays an important role in *Dracula*, but it is not the vampire itself that is funny, rather the eternal ironies of life and death that its presence triggers. This deflection of humour from the vampire reflects a pattern across nineteenth-century culture more widely, in which vampires and comedy were often linked but the vampires were not expected to be funny themselves. In particular, vampire comedies often appeared on the stage, following the huge success in Paris of Charles Nodier's *Le Vampire, mélodrame en trois actes* (1820), an adaptation of John Polidori's *The Vampyre*. Nodier's play eschewed comedy, although Roxana Stuart (1994) shows that in some surviving versions it has a happy ending. Nevertheless, its success was such that it gave rise to six parodies within a few weeks, ranging from farce to vaudeville and burlesque. Of especial interest is Nicholas Brazier, Gabriel Lurieu and Armand d'Artois's *Les Trois Vampires ou le clair de la lune* (1820), which is based on the *Northanger Abbey*–like premise whereby characters who have read too many stories about vampires presume other characters are vampires – the source of humour is the ridiculousness of the vampire craze and no real vampires appear in the play.

Nodier's play was adapted in turn for the London stage by James Robinson Planché as *The Vampire; or, The Bride of the Isles* (1820). Planché innovated on his source by interspersing the tragic romance of the main plot with comic scenes among the 'low' characters, 'an agreeable melange of the terrific and the comic', as the preface to an 1830 edition of the play put it (cited in Stuart 1994: 85). This was a familiar convention from earlier Gothic novels (most notably *The Castle of Otranto*), themselves modelled on Shakespearean tragedy. Planché's success, like Nodier's, sparked a fashion for vampire drama in nineteenth-century London, including both serious and satirical works. In 1821, Planché himself wrote a burletta entitled *Giovanni the Vampire!!! or How Shall We Get Rid of Him?* based on the conceit that as Don Juan always returned from the dead to appear in further plays featuring his character, he must *ergo* be a vampire. Regrettably, the full script does not survive, but Stuart establishes that the lead vampire was played

by a cross-dressed woman, in the pantomime tradition of the principal boy (Stuart 1994: 99). Further comic vampire plays appeared later in the nineteenth century. In 1887 the Gaiety Theatre in London put on the intriguingly titled *Frankenstein, or The Vampire's Victim*, a musical burlesque on Mary Shelley's novel, in which the Creature falls in love with a girl called Mary Ann who turns out, after their marriage, to be a vampire. The Creature teams up with the vampire villain, Visconti, and gets a job working at his club. While Visconti at one point sings a comic song about wearing a wig, the vampires are clearly not the main focus here; the comedy functions rather by throwing in as many preposterous Gothic clichés as possible, anticipating twentieth-century monster mash-ups. Bram Stoker, who was working as stage manager at the Lyceum Theatre at the time, would undoubtedly have been aware of the play. The transient and localized nature of stage adaptations means their influence on the Gothic tradition is often occluded, but it is significant that the comic vampire was first developed on the stage, a point I will return to later.

It is Bela Lugosi's performance in Tod Browning's *Dracula* of 1931 that fully inaugurates the modern tradition of the comic vampire. Ken Gelder notes that the Tod Browning/Bela Lugosi *Dracula* is often the text with which vampire recognition begins, demonstrating how Lugosi's image has come to dominate subsequent representations of the vampire, particularly in cinema and popular culture (Gelder 1994: 91). The mass reproducibility of Lugosi's image and its iconic recognition qualities due to the visual medium of film make it available for parody in a new way. Indeed, as David J. Skal documents, Lugosi's heirs filed a claim against Universal Studios in 1963 for revenue derived from a staggering array of merchandise based on their father's image (2004: 251–7). The landmark case was initially decided in favour of the plaintiffs but was finally overturned after a series of appeals lasting a total of sixteen years, with one judge commenting that 'Bela Lugosi did not portray himself and did not create Dracula' (cited in Skal 2004: 256). Nevertheless, the astonishing list of products described by Skal, including various kinds of sweets, toys, greeting cards and apparel, distil Lugosi's image to a selection of heavily codified visual signs or gestures, replicable beyond Browning's film. Lugosi himself participated in this process when he reprised his role in the classic comedy horror *Abbott and Costello Meet Frankenstein* (1948). Kamilla Elliott writes,

> the very sequels and remakes that had constructed Lugosi as original had also contaminated him as original. Recast and typecast as Dracula in subsequent films, he was already a parody of himself as original. Imitated relentlessly by

> other actors in the role, his performance in their wake seems a further parody of himself as original. (2008: 28)

Appropriately enough, this process acquired another layer when Lugosi reprised the role again in the British comedy *Mother Riley Meets the Vampire* in 1952.

Lugosi, who was only cast in the Abbott and Costello film when it was discovered by the studio that he was not, as they had assumed, dead, was determined not to compromise his trademark character's dignity. He told the *New York Times*, 'There is no burlesque for me … All I have to do is frighten the boys, a perfectly appropriate activity. My trademark will be unblemished' (Hallenbeck 2009: 48). As in Stoker's novel, and on the nineteenth-century stage, the vampire himself is not comic, rather comedy happens around him. When Abbott insists, 'I know there's no such person as Dracula. You know there's no such person as Dracula', Costello queries, 'But does Dracula know it?' Dracula plainly does not know it – he takes himself far too seriously. Lugosi thus polices the boundaries of what is and is not acceptable for his character. Burlesque is not to be tolerated, but as in the Tod Browning film, Dracula may display a certain mordant wit: 'You young people, making the most of life – while it lasts.'

In the recourse to wit, however stilted, Lugosi's Dracula obliquely references not Stoker's novel, but an earlier tradition of nineteenth-century vampire fiction beginning with Polidori's *The Vampyre*. Polidori's Lord Ruthven is just as humourless as Stoker's Dracula: 'He gazed upon the mirth around him, as if he could not participate therein. Apparently, the light laughter of the fair only attracted his attention, that he might by a look quell it' (Polidori 1997: 3). His model, Lord Byron, however, was a renowned wit and satirist, and the image of the vampire as Byronic lady-killer carries with it traces of dandy wit. For Andrew Stott, the exercise of wit entails 'a celebration of individualism over the masses, an elitist appreciation of privilege over all that is dull and ordinary'; it is a hierarchical form of humour that we might view as complementing the aristocratic identity of the vampire (2014: 146). In later texts such as *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, however, this hierarchism is modified by a kind of democratization of wit as a weapon of the outsider regardless of social status – or, indeed, as a means of establishing status through superior proficiency in verbal wordplay.

Paradoxically, it is the seriousness of Lugosi's performance in both *Dracula* and the *Abbott and Costello* film that inaugurates the most significant development in the tradition of the comic vampire. Lugosi's performance qualifies

as what Susan Sontag identifies as camp. As Sontag writes, 'In naïve, or pure, Camp, the essential element is seriousness, a seriousness that fails.' She goes on to explain,

> Of course, not all seriousness that fails can be redeemed as Camp. Only that which has the proper mixture of the exaggerated, the fantastic, the passionate, and the naïve … Camp is art that proposes itself seriously, but cannot be taken altogether seriously because it is 'too much'. (1994: 283–4)

In Lugosi's performance, horror is mediated through theatricality, so that it fits Sontag's statement that 'Camp sees everything in quotation marks' (1994: 280). He is not Dracula, but 'Dracula'. And this makes him eminently quotable and reproducible.

Lugosi's theatricality partially derives, of course, from his experience playing Dracula in Deane and Balderston's 1927 stage version of the novel, on which the film was based. The staginess of his performance synthesizes the theatrical tradition of the vampire with that of vampire literature: the iconic screen vampire emerges from theatre *and* fictional prose. In Deane and Balderston's play, as in earlier vampire theatre, comic relief is mainly provided by the 'low' characters of Renfield and the servants in time-honoured imitation of Shakespearean tragedy. An interesting moment, however, is provided by a stage direction, in which Dracula '*faces directly front*' while observing the lack of 'opportunity' in Transylvania, thus alerting the audience to his dual meaning – social opportunity, or opportunity to prey on victims (Deane and Balderston 1960: 24). A supremely stagy moment, Dracula's brief acknowledgement of the fourth wall is a codified gesture evoking the villain of the melodrama or pantomime. As with 'I never drink – wine', a space opens up between meaning and performance, within which a nascent vampire humour emerges.

After Lugosi, the camp qualities of the vampire underscore virtually all representations. By the early 1970s this sensibility is already completely self-conscious: in cult 1972 Blaxploitation vampire flick *Blacula*, the gay antique-dealing couple responsible for buying up the contents of Dracula's castle and shipping them back to California quip, 'Where we come from now honey, the legend of Dracula – I mean that's the absolute crème de la crème of camp.' Even those vampires which are manifestly not camp are, in general, strenuously attempting to resist camp and are therefore informed by it. *Thirty Days of Night* (2007), for example, was explicitly marketed as an antidote to the sentimental, over-emoting vampires that had gained currency in the wake of *Buffy* and *Twilight*. Justin Cronin's epic, post-apocalyptic, vampire novel *The Passage* (2010) even has its exiled heroes making

sense of the predatory 'virals' who have laid waste to America by watching an old reel of the Bela Lugosi film. The film becomes participatory: the audience laughs and catcalls, even throwing knives at the screen. Despite the 'exaggerated motions and expressions' of the actors, the story is recast as realism for this audience: 'At times the movie seemed almost to be some kind of instruction manual. Peter wondered if it wasn't a made-up tale at all but an account of something that actually happened' (Cronin 2010: 656, 658). Lugosi's camp performance is granted a kind of retrospective authenticity, in which the naïve sincerity of the original takes on new meaning when placed in a fresh interpretative frame.

The new camp vampire 1: 'A very silly play'

Camp is not always funny, but it does, as I stressed in the previous chapter, 'propose … a comic vision of the world'. It is, Susan Sontag says, 'above all, a mode of enjoyment, of appreciation – not judgment. Camp is generous. It wants to enjoy' (1994: 291). This sense of enjoyment, of generosity, is crucial to what I am calling the 'new camp vampire' as well as to happy Gothic more generally. The new camp vampire is epitomized by Johnny Depp's performance as Barnabas Collins in Tim Burton's adaptation of *Dark Shadows*. The original late-1960s American television series of the same title placed supernatural characters in a daytime soap opera format, and became a cult favourite for its outlandish story lines, comically low-budget production values and swooning sincerity. Barnabas (Jonathan Frid), originally introduced as a villain and intended to be killed off once his storyline was completed, proved such a fan favourite that he ended up becoming a romantic hero and the show's central character. In Burton's adaptation, Barnabas is exhumed in 1972 and returns to his ancestral home and the oddball remnants of his family with predictably comic results. Depp is the quintessential heterosexual camp actor, renowned on the one hand as a popular pin-up with a string of high-profile girlfriends, and on the other for a series of heavily stylized performances, often with a pronounced feminine cast, in films such as the *Pirates of the Caribbean* franchise (2003–17) and *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory* (2005). He brings this heightened performative persona to *Dark Shadows*, augmenting the overblown sincerity of Frid's performance with deliberate comedy.

Dark Shadows proved divisive for critics and fans: while the visual properties of the film, from costumes to cinematography, were fairly universally praised, the film's script by Seth Grahame-Smith and its overall tone were more

controversial. Some of these criticisms rested on formal properties, such as the script being unevenly paced or Burton complacently going over familiar ground. The comments of particular interest to my argument, however, are those that explicitly objected to the film's comedy. This reaction was exacerbated by the trailer, which emphasized the comic elements of the film. In an interview with MTV, Burton declared that he had never regarded the film as a comedy, but rather as trying to capture the 'weird vibe' of the TV show, and insisted: 'It's not like I'm being campy with it or anything' (Mitchell 2012). Screenwriter Seth Grahame-Smith, however, told *Entertainment Weekly*: '[I]t's … a very entertaining, very funny movie. We wanted it to be something that paid homage to the actual series, which was campy in its own right and very sincere' (Vary 2012). Burton and Grahame-Smith's mutual use of the word 'campy' elides significant differences in their self-justification: Burton insists he is not viewing the original series through a camp lens (Sontag's 'a Camp way of looking at things' 1994: 277), while Grahame-Smith implies the series possesses inherent, discoverable qualities of camp. The distinction was lost on many viewers and variations on the term 'campy' peppered reviews and enraged fans of the original *Dark Shadows*, revealing a particular set of prejudices. As comic author Paul Magrs (whose fiction will be explored in more detail in Chapter 8) wrote on his blog in response to the trailer,

> I was cockahoop to discover that he's camped it up to a dizzying degree – with a T Rex soundtrack and a blissfully breezy rewriting of the solemnity (the 'failed seriousness') of the original … I was amazed at some of the vitriol dished out – hearing this 'campery' dismissed as 'snide' and 'vile.' To me it just looked like a lot of fun. Why does camping something up necessarily mean it's being disrespectful? … Various fandoms have a hard time with camp. They view it very distrustfully. (Magrs 2012)

Magrs is tactful in his identification of a 'distrust' of camp within certain fan communities, but his implication is that the tone of much of this criticism is homophobic. A distinction can also be made between what Seth Grahame-Smith calls the 'very sincere' tone of the original, which is camp through its naivety, its failed seriousness, and the notion of 'camping it up', or deliberate camp (what Magrs refers to as 'campery'), which Sontag claims 'is usually less satisfying' (1994: 282) as it lacks the crucial quality of failure. The film of *Dark Shadows* lies on the uneasy border between the two, as Grahame-Smith appears to be deliberately camping it up, while Burton does not. Indeed, Burton's obliviousness to the camp qualities of his own films is to a certain extent a precondition of their

campness: in an age of self-consciousness, his naïve sincerity arguably makes him the last true proponent of camp.

The uneven tone is also the result of a shift between media. Just as Tod Browning and Bela Lugosi brought the influence of print and stage to their conceptualization of the screen vampire, Burton and Depp's Barnabas Collins imports the properties of the televisual vampire to film. Stacey Abbott argues that until recently, television has been overlooked in the history of horror, as critics either considered it to be compromised by the constraints of family viewing, or before the advent of the VCR, were restricted by the practical problems of collating its transient products. She argues, however, that the televisual vampires of the 1960s and 70s were a huge influence upon our current generation of vampires, and that these vampires, from the *Sesame Street* Count through the unmasked villains of *Scooby Doo* to Barnabas Collins himself, often departed from previous vampire conventions in interesting ways, for example, situating vampires in a comic or romantic context. Barnabas Collins, she points out, was 'one of the earliest sympathetic vampires, and [the] decision to build a tragic love story into the narrative did serve to romanticize' him (Abbott 2012). Burton's film explicitly acknowledges this televisual context. In one scene, Barnabas is so alarmed by the 'sorcery' of a TV broadcast of the Carpenters that he rips the plug out of the back of the television set in a shower of sparks. More significantly, he later comments on an episode of animated mystery-of-the-week series *Scooby-Doo*, 'This is a very silly play.'

In this apparently throwaway comment, a lot of the unease that this film embodies can be located. It is a highly knowing and self-reflexive line: much the same thing could be said about *Dark Shadows* itself, whether in its original televisual form or its cinematic adaptation. The film Barnabas, emerging into 1972, is positioned not quite as a potential viewer of the original *Dark Shadows* – as that had ended a year previously – but as existing within the same viewing context. Barnabas's misrecognition of the cartoon as a play dimly invokes the shadow of the stage vampire, as well as providing a lesson on the misrecognition of genre more generally, or perhaps rather the blurring of lines between genres. The silliness of *Scooby-Doo* does not preclude our enjoyment of it; indeed it probably enhances it. In this moment we are invited to recognize and reconsider our own critical responses to silliness. In Sontag's words, 'The whole point of camp is to dethrone the serious. Camp is playful, anti-serious. More precisely, Camp involves a new, more complex relation to "the serious". One can be serious about the frivolous, frivolous about the serious' (1994: 288). Camp, in Sontag's formulation, has a kind of deconstructive purpose, which takes apart or complicates this particular binary. Approached

as a critical tool, therefore, camp enables us to explore that critical fault-line in the Gothic, the properties that lead Horner and Zlosnik, paraphrasing Chris Baldick, to identify it as being 'already halfway to sending itself up' (Horner and Zlosnik 2005: 17).

The new camp vampire 2: Drag-ula

Since its publication in 1964, Sontag's essay on camp has been critiqued by queer theorists for diminishing camp's specifically gay provenance, making it available for appropriation by mainstream, bourgeois, heteronormative culture and therefore depoliticizing it. Moe Meyer is particularly vocal in arguing that 'what emerges from Sontag's essay is the birth of the camp trace, or residual camp, a strategy of un-queer appropriation of queer praxis' (1994: 5). As Fabio Cleto elucidates, Meyer inverts Sontag's hierarchy between the prioritized 'naïve, or pure, camp' and the 'less satisfying', adulterated 'deliberate camp', thereby suggesting that true camp is the product of self-conscious political agency while 'the camp trace, or residual camp' is merely a weak imitation (Cleto 1999: 17). Meyer's stance has itself been subject to critique, for example by Caryl Flinn, who suggests that in its insistence on a single form of camp – one that erases differences of ethnicity, class and even gender – it is prone to essentialism (1995). In relation to Gothic, Meyer's argument is especially problematic given that several of the most influential first-wave authors (Walpole, Beckford, Lewis) have been claimed retrospectively as queer, and that, as George Haggerty argues, 'gothic fiction offered a testing ground for many unauthorized genders and sexualities, including sodomy, tribadism, romantic friendship (male and female), incest, pedophilia [*sic*], sadism, masochism, necrophilia, cannibalism, masculinised females, feminized males, miscegenation, and so on' (2006: 2). Even the most straightforwardly heteronormative Gothic texts cannot easily be disentangled from this tradition. Indeed Stoker's *Dracula*, a text which on the surface appears almost aggressively heterosexual in its preoccupations, has been read by Christopher Craft as possessing a vivid homosexual (homophobic) subtext: 'the sexual threat that this novel first evokes, manipulates, sustains but never finally represents is that Dracula will seduce, penetrate, drain another male' (1997: 446). Meyer's argument, in its prioritization of a true or authentic, politically subversive form of camp over a supposedly weakened, mainstream one falls uncomfortably close to that of literary critics decrying a 'Gothic lite'.

Nevertheless, while Johnny Depp's heterosexual camp could be dismissed, paradoxically, as both Sontag's 'deliberate camp' *and* Meyer's 'residual camp', there are twenty-first-century versions of Dracula that engage much more openly with a politicized version of camp, asserting queer agency and identity within a mainstream world. These include the short film *Dragula* (2014) and the music video for Sharon Needles's *Dracula* (2015). The title *Dragula* was first used by an obscure gay adult horror movie in 1973; significantly, this was also the year that *The Rocky Horror Show* was first staged in London. *Rocky Horror* brought all the latent gender confusion and sexual perversity of the Gothic novel kicking and screaming into the light, challenging boundaries of gender, sexuality, good taste, genre and even between performers and audience in its staging of the camp exploits of Frank N. Furter, a 'sweet transvestite from transexual Transylvania'. If its claims to subversion can be overstated (see Weinstock 2007), it is certainly a landmark text in terms of the explicit queering of the Gothic and its visible deployment as a tool for exploring socially divergent sexual identities. It is also key, once again, for its *theatrical* qualities. The 1975 film adaptation employed not only Richard O'Brien's music, book and lyrics but also the same director, Jim Sharman, and many of the same cast members including O'Brien himself, Tim Curry, Patricia Quinn and Little Nell. Its status as a cult film was bolstered by screenings in which the audience dressed up and heckled the characters using ritualized insults, thus joining the performance. Its influence implicitly informs the texts in this section which explicitly draw on the camp qualities of Dracula as a means of fashioning a queer identity, one which refuses to adhere to monolithic notions of sexuality or conventional gender binaries.

Frank Meli's *Dragula* uses a familiar American high school setting as the backdrop for the story of a teenage boy discovering his desire to become a drag queen. The film opens with Charles (August Roads) studying *Dracula* in an English class at school, and being asked to read aloud Van Helsing's lines,

> Do you not think that there are things which you cannot understand, and yet which are; that some people see things that others cannot? But there are things old and new which must not be contemplate by men's eyes. (Stoker 1998: 228)

Charles lacks social confidence and stumbles over Van Helsing's foreign diction, causing the class to laugh at him. Nevertheless, the lines resonate through the film with their indication that there is more to life than the social consensus. Dracula does not represent a source of horror but rather a source of possibility. This is actualized when Charles and his two friends visit a local gay club and see a drag act based on the character. The drag artist (played by Barry Bostwick,

who also played Brad in the film version of *Rocky Horror*) befriends Charles and helps him successfully realize his ambitions of appearing in the school talent show as a drag queen in black fetish wear. Dracula never operates above the level of metaphor in this text; the only real danger he represents is one of potential social exclusion, which proves illusory, as the overwhelming majority of Charles's friends and family turn out to be supportive of his newfound identity. Camp is presented as subversive here in that it enables the expression of a queer identity, but only to a point, given that scarcely anyone in the film's world really minds. Likewise, the vampire's appeal is strictly performative, a conduit to creativity and self-expression.

Needles, winner of reality competition series *Ru Paul's Drag Race* in 2012, is distinctive for her unconventional use of horror imagery in constructing her drag identity: her celebrated first appearance on Ru Paul's show was in zombie drag. Needles's *Dracula* video, directed by Santiago Felipe, is a camp distillation of the most iconic previous Dracula images, cross-dressed as women. Nosferatu's distinctive frogged coat becomes a dress. Bela Lugosi is merged with Liza Minnelli in *Cabaret*, appearing in fishnets and high-waisted black PVC hotpants, with his distinctive medal hanging over a tight-fitting, busty white blouse, and a latex widow's peak recalling Minnelli's famous bob. Coppola's Dracula, played by Gary Oldman in Eiko Ishioka's exotic, Japanese-inspired costumes, is travestied in a red satin mini-dress, her make-up and hair obliquely recalling iconic painter Frida Kahlo. Count Chocula, stirring a huge bowl of cereal in a mini-dress and white over-the-knee socks with a piled-up wig, recalls both Bette Midler stirring her cauldron in *Hocus Pocus* and the saucy female camp of Elvira, Mistress of the Dark – also acknowledged in a t-shirt worn by Needles in her video for *This Club Is a Haunted House* (2013). Only David from *The Lost Boys* – the only vampire in the video not strictly based on Dracula – retains a masculine appearance, although the addition of prosthetics resembling those worn by the vampires in *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* adds an extra layer of performativity.

In the song *Dracula* itself, Needles's breakdown of the name 'Drac-U-la!' into three distinct syllables calls attention to each of them and, in particular, gives the aural impression that she is singing 'Drag-U-la!' The repeated refrain 'La-la-la!', sung in a melodramatic baritone, references and parodies the 'Aaaah' refrain in Marilyn Manson's *The Beautiful People* (1999) – in the video for which, directed by Floria Sigismondi, Manson cross-dresses across gender and species boundaries. In Needles's video, Dracula and drag are conflated: the camp qualities of the vampire are made explicit and Dracula is reinvented as camp icon. Needles's camp vampires offer the enjoyment promised by Sontag: they are funny,

frivolous and flamboyant. They are also invested in an oppositional politics in which camp and Gothic conspire to 'expose what the powers-that-be would like to keep neatly hidden and out of sight' (Kleinhans 1994: 199) – whether that is queer identities *per se* or Gothic as comic and performative mode.

Vampire friendship in *What We Do in the Shadows* and *Vamps*

I have argued thus far that camp offers a critical tool for understanding the way that contemporary vampire texts, and by extension happy Gothic, foreground *enjoyment* and can be both silly and serious at the same time. I want to complete my analysis of comic vampires by returning to Kamilla Elliott's understanding of parody as revealing 'inconsistencies, incongruities, and problems in Gothic criticism' in order to analyze two final post-millennial vampire films: *What We Do in the Shadows* (2014) and *Vamps* (2012). These two films are markedly different. *What We Do in the Shadows* was made in New Zealand by cult directors Jemaine Clement and Taika Waititi, was released to a limited run in mainly arthouse cinemas, and received immense popular and critical acclaim. *Vamps*, on the other hand, was shot in Detroit and New York, was directed by Amy Heckerling, previously known for cult teen rom-com *Clueless* (1995), and featured a starry cast including Alicia Silverstone (also of *Clueless*) and Sigourney Weaver, yet nevertheless received a lukewarm critical reception and went straight to video in most territories. *What We Do in the Shadows* takes the form of a mock documentary, while *Vamps* is a generic hybrid in which romantic comedy is the dominant note. *What We Do in the Shadows* foregrounds men, *Vamps* women. Nevertheless, both are remarkable in that they jettison the archetypes of the solitary vampire or the romantic dyad in favour of a focus on vampire friendship.

The two films are not unique in this respect. Nina Auerbach (1995) argues that the distinguishing feature of the nineteenth-century vampire, using *The Vampyre* and J. Sheridan Le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1871–72) as models, is their capacity for friendship. She stresses that before *Dracula* crystallized conventions, vampires 'were indeterminate creatures who flourished, not in their difference from their human prey, but through their intimate intercourse with mortals, to whom they were dangerously close' (1995: 13). In contrast, twentieth-century vampires in the wake of Dracula express an individualist, capitalist ethos: they 'are empire builders who repudiate the "intimacy, or friendship" of their sentimental predecessors' (60).

Significantly, Auerbach's focus is on intimacy between vampires and humans rather than between vampires.

More recently, Anne Rice's vampires live in pseudo-families and covens, while films such as *The Lost Boys* (1987) and *Near Dark* (1987) portray close-knit gangs of vampires. Vampire communities are also a standard feature of the paranormal romance from *Twilight* to *True Blood*. Rarely in these texts, however, is friendship between vampires the primary focus: it enables the kind of 'empire building' Auerbach identifies, or forms a backdrop for the journey of the solitary outsider or the pursuit of a romantic dyad. The British TV series *Being Human* (2009–13), influenced by flat-share series such as *Friends* (1994–2004) and *This Life* (1996–97, 2007), offered a new model in its account of a vampire, ghost and werewolf sharing a flat in present-day Bristol. In this series, the friendships between the three central characters are more significant and enduring than romantic relationships developed over the course of the show; when werewolf George (Russell Tovey) enters into a more substantial romantic relationship with Nina (Sinead Keenan), she moves into the flat and becomes incorporated into the friendship group.

Similarly, in the two twenty-first-century vampire films I will consider in this section, the friendship between vampires is the *primary* focus. *What We Do in the Shadows* documents the relationships within a group of male vampires in a house-share in Wellington; *Vamps* focuses on two female vampires sharing an apartment in New York. There is a camp element to both these films, but ultimately, much of their humour derives from classic incongruity, contrasting mundane modern settings with the extravagance of vampire conventions. Where this familiar vampire joke differs from, say, *Love at First Bite* or *Dark Shadows* is that the vampires themselves are not extravagant relics of the past adrift in a mundane modern world, but rather participate in an ongoing negotiation between extravagance and mundanity. Friendships are the next logical step in the development of the sympathetic monster. No longer isolated, tormented creatures, these vampires argue about the household chores and fix each other's lipstick.

What We Do in the Shadows directly alludes to the camp vampire when a member of the local werewolf pack mutters 'Count Fagula!' as the rival groups pass each other on the street. The perception of male vampires as offering a suspect, effeminate masculinity is further accentuated in the earlier short (2005) on which the film was based, in which the vampires are shown styling each other (in the absence of mirrors), and vampire Deacon (Jonathan Brugh) sulkily returns home early from a night out after being called 'a gay' by rugby types.

What We Do in the Shadows is as much about contemporary models of masculinity as it is about vampires, and works to challenge the idea there is only one kind of masculinity, one kind of vampire, or even one kind of camp. Each of the three central vampires is camp in their own way, but each also evokes a different stereotype of vampirism and, through incongruous juxtaposition, contests it. Viago (Taika Waititi) is a 'dandy' vampire whose fastidiousness, caring sensitivity and sentimental romantic attachment to his long-lost love are played off against his incongruous callousness towards victims. Vladislav (Jemaine Clement) is a model of flamboyant cruelty and perversity who is nevertheless in thrall to his ex-girlfriend. Deacon strikes a rebellious rock star pose but also enjoys knitting to pass the time. They are joined by Petyr (Ben Fransham), an ancient, grotesque, Nosferatu-like creature who lives in the basement; Nick (Cori Gonzalez-Macuer), a newly turned vampire given to laddish drinking and bragging (and significantly lacking any camp qualities); and Stu (Stuart Rutherford), Nick's nice but dull data analyst friend who the vampires strenuously resist eating. Nick and Stu's modern masculinities throw those of the core vampires into relief. There is a classic clash of generations, recalling that of Burton's *Dark Shadows*, as Stu teaches the older vampires how to take selfies and use social media and Nick jostles with previous junior vampire Deacon for status within the group. This is further enhanced by the contrast with the werewolves, whose macho group dynamic is undercut by 'alpha' Anton's leadership, somewhere between a Boy Scout leader (appropriately enough, given that the Cub Scouts' structure is based on the wolf pack in Kipling's *Jungle Book*) and an anger management coach.

What We Do in the Shadows goes beyond previous vampire comedies in that while the conventions of vampire narrative are the ostensible target, the actual subject of the film is masculinity, and the dynamics of homosocial bonding. Women play a peripheral role in the film, although there is a satisfying sub-plot about Deacon's long-suffering 'servant', Jackie (Jackie van Beek), who finally slips his control, becomes a vampire in her own right and makes her husband into her new servant. While the characters may be camp, the film is not. Indeed, the combination of straight-to-camera interviews and fly-on-the-wall style filming emulates the illusion of stripped-back *verité* associated with the documentary, rather than the lush stylistic flourishes characteristic of much classic vampire cinema. If it exposes documentary itself as a performative genre in the characters' perfect aping of the vocal inflections common to documentary subjects, this is comic in the way it filters Gothic extravagance through a mundane idiom rather than through heightened emotion or stylistic excess.

Where *What We Do in the Shadows* foregrounds male relationships, *Vamps* foregrounds female ones. One of the reasons behind its lack of commercial success appeared to be its lack of genre identity: not a romantic comedy, or a teen movie, or a horror film, or a sentimental women's picture, it nevertheless drew elements from all of these genres. Indeed, Michael Sicinski in *Cinema Scope* described it as 'in equal measure, silly, corny, besotted by cinema, melancholy, feminist, literate, childlike, commercial, and fully auteurist … offbeat … cheeseball, heartfelt, and idiosyncratic' (Sicinski). It follows the adventures of two vampire roommates, the appropriately named Goody (Alicia Silverstone) and Stacy (Krysten Rytter), good-time girls who suck blood from rats with straws, attend a 'Sanguines Anonymous' support group and regularly dance the night away in search of cute guys. It is more *Sex and the City* than *True Blood*, but without the unbridled consumerism: Goody and Stacy wearily model the designer clothes purchased by their 'stem' or maker Cisserus (Sigourney Weaver), who cannot see her own reflection, and compile their eclectic outfits from their own fashion greatest hits – with Goody at one point incongruously teaming an Edwardian Gibson Girl jacket and boater with a 1960s miniskirt and 1970s platforms.

The film sets out its stall as a piece of happy Gothic from the outset. Narrating her life story over a montage of vintage footage, irredeemably perky, 171-year-old Goody tells the audience, 'Normally this would be one of those tales of gore and homicidal urges – but I've always looked on the bright side of life.' She goes on to extol the virtues of spending extra years with her loved ones as well as the delights of modernity embodied in electric light, the New York subway system and the advent of cinema. *Vamps*, like other vampire films, is self-consciously citational, incorporating clips from a huge array of films including *Nosferatu, A Voyage to the Moon*, *The Cabinet of Dr Caligari* and *Un Chien Andalou*. For Goody, these films induce a spellbinding nostalgia, while Cesare's violent attack on the heroine in *Caligari* is cleverly (and comically) intercut with Stacy's energetic romp with new flame Joey Van Helsing (Dan Stevens). There are plenty of jokes, too, riffing on previous vampire lore, so that the reformed Vlad Ţepeş (Malcolm McDowell) gets his impaling thrills from knitting (evidently a contemporary vampire theme) and stabbing the sticks into toffee apples. When Sanguines Anonymous successfully foil a campaign to track them down through tax audits and jury service, the vampires hold a party in which they perform dances from their favourite decades (Goody's is the Charleston) beneath a banner proclaiming 'Happy Nights Are Here Again'.

Although each of the leads has a romantic relationship over the course of the film, their primary relationship is with each other. After all, they have been best

friends for twenty years, since Goody persuaded Cisserus to turn Stacy instead of kill her. The first scene of the two women together shows Stacy playing a good-humoured practical joke on Goody by placing a table over her coffin so that she is unable to raise the lid; the two women laugh uproariously. This sets the film's key-note: these women like each other and, significantly, laugh together. This comradeship continues through their romantic tribulations. Telling her story at Sanguines Anonymous, Stacy explains she has never drunk human blood, as '[i]t's more satisfying to not hurt anybody and just have fun with your friends'. When Stacy discovers she is pregnant, she discusses the decision to keep the baby with Goody rather than Joey, assuming that the two female vampires will parent the child. At the emotional climax of the film, when the women are returned to their human ages and Goody remembers her hundred and seventy odd years of life before crumbling to dust, the camera zooms in on a close-up of the women holding hands. In the background, a Times Square ad reads 'The world belongs to those who see its potential'. The scene flouts the conventional ending of the romantic comedy as well as that of the vampire narrative: Goody dies, but her death is framed as a happy one. Indeed, it is a regenerative one, allowing the next generation to flourish. Goody's self-sacrifice both has Christ-like connotations and enables the classic comic ending, facilitating what Northrop Frye describes as 'the integration of society' (2006: 40).

Significantly, both films offer an internal critique of Botting's argument, drawing on Derrida, that twenty-first-century monsters have become domesticated to the point of being pets. In *What We Do in the Shadows*, the vampires tease the werewolves by pretending to throw sticks for them, which the werewolves (like domestic dogs) feel compelled to chase. In the masculine world the film represents, men bond together in heteronormative, tribe-like groups engaged in a constant battle for status. To liken one's opponent to a pet is an insult equivalent to 'Count Fagula': it is aimed at diminishing its object's masculine status by feminizing him, in this case through association with domesticity (a 'domestic animal'). This recalls the common 'gendered hierarchical distinction' identified by Greg Garrard, 'between wild and domestic animals in which the former are linked with masculine freedom, and often predation, while the latter are denigrated as feminine servants of human depredation' (Garrard 2004: 150). As the film demonstrates, however, the distinction between feminine domesticity and masculine wildness is false because men living without women are forced to take on domestic tasks themselves. In its depiction of vampires bickering over domestic chores, the film shows that the repudiation of domesticity is always at the expense of someone else. Historically, this 'someone else' is often a woman.

The importance of the sub-plot concerning Jackie is revealed: the catalyst for her liberating herself from Deacon's control and finally becoming a monster herself is an incident when she is compelled to clean a particularly disgusting bathroom. The film therefore shows that the domesticated monster comes into being precisely because traditional gender binaries denoting the domestic sphere as feminine have been eroded in modern culture.

Vamps also foregrounds the theme of pets and it does so in its parody of the so-called vegetarian vampire, to use Stephenie Meyer's phrase, who eschews feeding on humans and sates their hunger on animals. In Meyer's fiction, as in that of Anne Rice, the rejection of humans as food serves to emphasize the vampire's own humanity. *Vamps* takes this further: the lead vampires refuse to feed on 'humans or domestic animals', and Stacy sentimentally turns down 'pharmaceutical grade' white rats because 'they could be somebody's pet'. By extending the prohibition of human prey to domestic pets, *Vamps* implicitly places the category of the human under question, and mocks the systems through which Western culture defines otherness – a political commitment underlined by Goody's participation in various forms of political activism over the centuries. In *Vamps*, the firm division between humans and animals is eroded as humans and domestic animals are constructed as equivalent: neither is acceptable prey, because they are incorporated within familial structures and can be objects of love – or friendship. This erosion is compounded when Stacy becomes pregnant with a human baby: any species difference between human and vampire disintegrates, the more so when Stacy regains her human status at the end of the film, her youthful looks miraculously preserved by a low-fat diet and twenty years out of the sun. Friendship is presented as offering a utopian model of unity that crosses species boundaries, uniting vampires, humans and pets. If the film confirms Derrida's argument that the monster, once named, is incorporated within discursive structures it does not figure this as a decline, but as a form of social progress. Comic vampires are not a dead end, the sign of a tired and played-out tradition: rather comedy has, from the beginning, offered a way of continually interrogating that tradition, and in doing so, renewing and refreshing it.

7

‘I’m the Shoreditch Vampire’: Making Over Goth Masculinities in Television Comedy

Goth masculinities

The previous chapter established a camp model of masculinity that underscores the representation of comic monsters, particularly vampires, in the twenty-first century. Camp, it argued, is an essential critical tool for reading happy Gothic and in particular, the depiction of masculinities within it. Comic masculinities, however, are diverse and cannot be constrained by a single critical model. This chapter will shift its emphasis from Gothic masculinities to Goth masculinities – from genre to subculture – and in doing so, will explore a range of comic personae utilized in stand-up comedy, comedy-drama and situation comedy. While there are comic Goth women too, they are seldom the focus of the joke to the same extent as Goth men. While this is symptomatic of gender bias in contemporary comedy more generally, it also indicates that there are specific qualities to Goth masculinities that enable comic identities in a way that Goth femininities do not.

Goth comedy often functions around the notion of transformation: the transition from a ‘mainstream’ identity to a ‘Goth’ one and vice versa. This is rooted in the lifestyle concept of the makeover, and for this reason this chapter will also briefly consider the role of Goths on TV makeover shows. Goths on makeover shows are frequently (but not always) women, and the gendering of genre in the popular media is highly visible here. For women, Goth is constructed as a lifestyle choice – possibly a misguided one, but nevertheless one that fits conventional patterns of feminine consumption. As I have argued elsewhere, young women in Western culture are expected to experiment with dressing up, and shopping for Goth clothing and accessories is comparable with more conventional kinds of shopping (Spooner 2004, 2008). For men, Goth is constructed as

something riskier, that flouts social expectations and foregrounds the processes through which masculinity is constructed. The incongruity of a man wearing eyeliner makes him available for comic representation; his masculinity is potentially travestied in a way that evokes Bakhtin's concept of the carnivalesque. At the same time, it would be reductive to suggest that Goth simply feminizes men: the performance of masculinity for Goths is complex and gives rise to a range of responses, comic and otherwise, which I will unpack.

Virtually all of the representations I will analyse stem from the years immediately following Columbine. The increase in comic representations of Goth masculinities in that period can be attributed to the increased visibility of Goth in the mainstream media, and to the first generation of Goths coming of age and becoming comic producers themselves, but also constitutes, I would argue, an important response to that event. In the texts that I will explore, male Goths are demystified, their lofty poses brought down to earth. They are transformed from an object of fear to an object of laughter, located in an uneasy space between ridicule and heroism.

Goth stand-up and comic personae

The popularization of stand-up comedy through working men's clubs and then designated comedy clubs in the later twentieth century has meant that historically, it has not been a good fit with Gothic or Goth. The culture of masculine bonding and bravado which often permeated these venues was anathema to both. The 1980s in Britain, when Goth emerged as a subculture, were dominated by the 'alternative' comedy scene, which was overtly politicized and had more in common with Punk. In the early 1990s, however, Julian Clary and Eddie Izzard developed stage personas that explored drag and transvestism and significantly challenged the aggressively heterosexual masculine norm, and in the case of Clary, created a distinctive, camp BDSM fetish look recalling *The Rocky Horror Show*. At the same time, British comedians Robert Newman and David Baddiel popularized a combination of stand-up and sketch comedy that directly addressed contemporary youth culture. Among the regular sketches on their television show *The Mary Whitehouse Experience* (1990–92) was a series of parodies of The Cure's 'happy' new direction, in which Newman sang a series of light or comic songs including 'The Laughing Policeman', 'Tie Me Kangaroo Down Sport' and 'Ernie (The Fastest Milkman in the West)' in a pitch-perfect imitation of lead singer Robert Smith's enervated melancholy. (Indeed, Newman's cover of

the theme tune for the children's TV series *Play Away* sounded uncomfortably close to The Cure's early album track 'Play for Today'.) The duo also parodied *Edward Scissorhands* as 'Edward Colanderhands' and Robert Smith himself – apparently a fan of the show – appeared on later episodes in sketches that deliberately poked fun at his supposedly miserable public image, memorably singing 'The Sun Has Got His Hat On' in one scene and dancing a conga at Baddiel's imagined funeral in another. While these sketches were short parodies and not fully developed or sustained stand-up personae, they did demonstrate the comic potential of Goth from an affectionate perspective. They also introduced the connection to Robert Smith who has been a persistent, if unlikely, reference point for Goth comedy ever since.

In the twenty-first century, a number of comic performers have images that more or less explicitly flirt with Goth, or Gothic imagery, or both. These include 'Britain's only goth, lesbian, transsexual comedian' Bethany Black; 'occult comedian' and Steampunk musician Andrew O'Neill; 'dark cabaret' performer Voltaire (not, perhaps, technically a stand-up comedian but rather a comic musician who also sometimes tells jokes, in the tradition of vaudeville); 'Goth detectives' Noel Fielding and Russell Brand; and the Australian comedian and musician Tim Minchin. For some of these comedians, such as Black, O'Neill and Voltaire, there is a continuum between their on-stage subcultural identity and that of their everyday life. For Fielding and Brand, Goth is one of a range of subcultural references that can be playfully evoked for particular effects. Finally, for Minchin, Goth and Gothic provide the materials and techniques for a complex and carefully constructed performative persona. Needless to say, despite the increasing visibility and success of female comedians, stand-up is a notoriously male genre, and this is reflected in the array of comedians who explicitly draw on Goth and/or Gothic in their acts. Nevertheless, each of them uses Goth and/or Gothic in order to interrogate or challenge conventional models of masculinity. The exception, of course, is Bethany Black, whose act incorporates Goth into a wider discussion of queer identities. For the purposes of my argument, I will focus on O'Neill and Minchin here as representing two distinct stand-up strategies in relation to Goth and Gothic. Fielding will be discussed extensively in later sections in relation to his work in situation comedy.

One of the key problems faced by a Goth stand-up comedian is mediating between a stage persona constructed around images of outsiderdom and the need to establish a rapport with the audience – particularly when playing mainstream comedy venues. Oliver Double defines stand-up through a combination of the display of a comic persona, direct communication between performer

and audience and acknowledgement of the performance situation (2005: 19). Subcultural identities, on the other hand, demand distinction between the individual and the crowd, and Goth comedians navigate this in different ways. Andrew O'Neill refuses a Goth identity (something I will come back to in a moment) but draws extensively on Gothic materials in his 'Occult Comedian' show, in which he explores his journeys in ritual magic as well as his transvestism. His look, dressed head-to-toe in black with long, dyed-black hair, make-up and women's garments, is highly resonant of Goth. (Male Goth style often incorporates women's clothes.) O'Neill plays mainstream venues and therefore in common with Black (who self-identifies as Goth), his stage act tends to pre-empt audience hostility regarding his appearance by using it as material. Black's opening line, 'the last thing you expected in Glasgow on a Saturday night is a scruffy lesbian who looks like what would happen if Marilyn Manson fucked Harry Potter', simultaneously anticipates and out-does potential hecklers while producing a multiply queer image invoking male and female homosexuality, pederasty and male pregnancy (Black 2012). Similarly in 'Occult Comedian' (2011), O'Neill praises 'quality heckles' at the Soho Theatre, constructing an imaginary heterosexist heckler that he can diminish through incorporation, and thus anticipate and critique potential prejudice: 'none of that "oo-err! make-up!" nonsense that I often get – normally a request, I've found … OK, you can borrow it.' This precedes an extended meditation on the pleasures and trials of cross-dressing. In contrast Voltaire, who tends to play to Goth or SF and fantasy convention audiences, also tells an extended story about airport security's response to his appearance, but does so from the point-of-view of shared recognition and affirmation (Voltaire 2012).

Despite O'Neill's visual affinity with Goth, he is adamant about maintaining subcultural distinctions. His website declares:

> I'm not a goth. This is an understandable error, but there is a difference between a metaller who cross-dresses and a goth. And if need be I will fight you to demonstrate that difference. I've got nothing against goths. Some of my best friends are goths. Their food is lovely and they have natural rhythm. (O'Neill)

O'Neill's statement parodies the subcultural border-policing that occurs within the alternative scene. It begins reasonably enough, acknowledging the 'understandable' confusion between two very similar subcultural identities to an outsider. By quickly descending into violent threat, however, it simultaneously shores up the masculinity diminished by the reference to cross-dressing, reduces the demarcation of subcultural boundaries to the status of a playground

squabble and self-sabotages by 'protesting too much'. The shift into parody of the well-known line, 'Some of my best friends are black', confirms subcultural prejudice against Goths; the racist cliché, 'they have natural rhythm', ridicules it by using the obsolete language of racist essentialism and evoking a comically absurd image of Goths dancing. O'Neill thus mocks the mechanisms of racism and subcultural othering while simultaneously affirming his distinct subcultural identity. In fact, on and off stage, O'Neill shifts between subcultural identities, adopting a subtly different subcultural persona with his Steampunk band The Men That Will Not Be Blamed For Nothing ('putting the punk into steampunk'). His act is peppered with subcultural reference points, from a taxonomy of different kinds of metal bands to an account of an interview with graphic novelist and countercultural guru Alan Moore. The direct engagement with subculture enables him to critique its mores even as he celebrates it.

Tim Minchin, on the other hand, does not explicitly engage with Goth subculture and does not maintain a subcultural identity off-stage; he could more aptly be described as Gothic than Goth. His idiosyncratic mixture of stand-up and comic songs evokes traditions of vaudeville and cabaret (both recently popularized in Goth culture through the influence of burlesque artist Dita von Teese as well as bands like The Dresden Dolls). Minchin's stage look is a distinctly Gothic one, consisting of wildly backcombed hair, black eyeliner, bright blue contact lenses, unconventionally cut formal tailoring worn in a shambolic fashion, and bare feet. Critics regularly use Goth reference points to describe him, so that for *The Scotsman* he resembles 'Edward Scissorhands – all Johnny Depp prettiness and ludicrous hair' ('Tim Minchin – Dark Side' 2005) while Pip Christmass in *The West Australian* name-checks Robert Smith (2006). However, Minchin does not claim subcultural affiliation and projects a clear distinction between his on-stage persona and that adopted in his everyday life. His act, moreover, evokes both Gothic and Goth but is not reducible to those styles: if he evokes Goth reference points, he would not exactly look the part at a Goth club night. Goth(ic) is a mobile discourse in Minchin's comedy, put to work at particular moments in order to cultivate particular effects.

Goth functions in a specific way in Minchin's comic persona: it informs an aesthetic of failure. Much of Minchin's act revolves around his desire to be a conventional rock star and his inability to achieve that dream. The Goth elements of his persona in this context recall Robert Smith, lead singer of The Cure, whose huge stardom (The Cure are one of the few Goth bands to have achieved mainstream global success) is built around a performance of failure, with smudged make-up, shambling movements and mumbled lyrics, often lamenting his

inability to reach his desired love object. If musically and lyrically, Minchin's work is nothing like Smith's, he is nevertheless haunted by his performance aesthetic.

Gothic, on the other hand, provides Minchin with aesthetic of doubleness. The show that brought him to international attention, *Darkside* (2005), is premised on doubleness.[1] This manifests thematically in individual songs, but also in his performance style, in which facial expressions of embarrassment, anxiety or doubt continually punctuate overconfident or absurd statements. This is brought to a climax in 'Angry (Feet)', in which Minchin calmly recites a poem he has supposedly been encouraged to write by his therapist as an anger management technique. The metre is increasingly interrupted by interjected expletives that work to reveal the process of repression that is being enacted. Minchin's delivery plays id and superego as alternate voices warring within the same personality. Gradually, a secondary personality emerges and commandeers the narration, culminating in the brutal murder of the therapist himself. Minchin thus enacts mental illness as a kind of Jekyll-and-Hyde narrative. In doing so, he also comments on the formation of modern masculinity and its relationship with violence.

The song 'Dark Side' is the ultimate expression of the theme of doubleness in Minchin's work. Its refrain, 'I can have a dark side/ If you want me to' indicates the performative nature of the troubled rock star archetype. The first verse, in which he explains how his girlfriend rejects him for being 'so happy all the time', attacks the myth of the brooding, Byronic hero popularized by the Gothic romance. This myth, it is revealed, is a product of feminine desire rather than intrinsic to masculine identity. Similarly, the second verse describes his rejection by a major record company because his work does not appeal to the teen market. Again, the brooding rock star is revealed to be a product of market forces rather than an authentic expression of masculinity. The song's repeated, rapid shift in register from cheerful and upbeat to overblown and melodramatic reinforces the doubleness expressed in the lyrics and encapsulates Minchin's ethos. The contrast between the dark side and the happy side is fundamental to the comic persona he projects, comedy teetering on the edge of horror.

Where Black, O'Neill and Voltaire variously anticipate or diminish the process of othering, mining their subcultural identities for comic potential, Minchin is more radical, establishing a comic persona that actively revels in its uncanniness and difference. His performance of doubleness, rapidly shifting between

different aspects of a fractured and mobile subject, exploits the Gothic motif of transformation. This motif is realized in a more extended and literal sense through the makeover show and the sitcom, in which the Goth subject is made and unmade for the viewer's delectation and amusement.

Making and unmaking Gothic subjects on television

'Gothic television' tends to evoke drama serials such as *The Addams Family*, *Twin Peaks* or *Supernatural*, the mainstay of Helen Wheatley's *Gothic Television* (2006) and Lorna Jowett and Stacey Abbott's *TV Horror: Investigating the Dark Side of the Small Screen* (2013). Gothic, however, sometimes appears on television in what may seem unlikely places. In Chapter 1, I evoked lifestyle programming as one such unlikely place where contemporary Gothic has made incursions, examining interior decorating and cookery shows in particular. Here, I return to lifestyle programming to explore what happens when individuals identified as 'Goth' are brought within the conventional frameworks of the TV makeover show. The shows I will discuss are not in themselves Gothic, but in selected episodes they offer encounters with Gothic in the form of Goth subcultural style, both offering it up for consumption and mediating it for a mainstream audience. Crucially, these shows all feature Goth makeovers. Goths on television are rarely allowed to remain themselves: they must, at some point, be made over into something more conventional. This functions as a means of testing the limits of the Goth and the non-Goth: what does it mean when a Goth is transformed into a non-Goth, or vice versa? What is the distinction between a Gothic and a non-Gothic subject, and can one be made into the other, or is there something essentially Gothic that resists intervention?

In the remainder of this chapter I am going to go on to explore two different kinds of makeover: the 'real' makeover, in which subjects are made over within the confines of the TV lifestyle show; and the comedy makeover, in which regular characters in situation comedy programmes briefly adopt Goth style for comic effect. On the one hand, makeover shows, such as *Snog Marry Avoid?* and *Gok's Style Secrets*, like the episode of *Grand Designs* featured in Chapter 1, construct Gothic as a form of bad taste which television mediates and controls for its audiences. On the other, situation comedies such as *The IT Crowd*, *The Big Bang Theory* and *The Mighty Boosh* parody the makeover process, frequently by reversing it so that its characters undergo a makeover *to* Goth. Both kinds

of shows, I would argue, reveal a fundamental tension around the idea of Goth as an essential or authentic identity or one that is performative and therefore in some way 'fake'. Both ask whether external appearance makes an individual Gothic, or whether Gothic is dependent on something more fundamental inside.

Makeover shows are a common feature of contemporary television: prominent twenty-first-century examples include *What Not to Wear* (UK version 2001–07, USA version 2003–13), *Queer Eye for the Straight Guy* (2003–07) and *How to Look Good Naked* (2006–10). These shows characteristically produce a normalized bourgeois subject by teaching techniques of self-management, usually focused around the body, personal appearance and sartorial style but also sometimes incorporating social skills and emotional literacy. Like interior decorating shows, makeover shows aim to educate their audiences about taste, but they do so in a potentially more intrusive way, in that the modes of consumption they address are intimately related to the subject's self-esteem and body image. Subjects who do not meet normative criteria are subjected to judgement diegetically from the TV 'experts', friends and family and often complete strangers, as well as extra-diegetically from the TV audience.

In Chapter 3 I evoked Valerie Steele's argument that 'Gothic fashion is … a rejection of "normal", "natural" beauty in favor of an alternative vision of horrific, excessive, artificial and (sometimes) sexually fetishistic beauty' (Steele and Park 2008: 79). Gothic fashion, as she describes it, is found in the milieus of both the Goth scene and high fashion, where it becomes part of the repertoire of the avant-garde. The designers and brands celebrated by Steele, whether *haute couture* (Alexander McQueen, Gareth Pugh, John Galliano) or subcultural (Kambriel, Cyberdog, h.Naoto), disregard and often deliberately challenge mainstream perceptions of good taste, while at the same time confirming the taste preferences of their particular milieus. The more 'horrific, excessive, artificial' aspects of Gothic style are ripe for the kind of judgement and amelioration meted out on the makeover show.

An excellent example is provided by celebrity stylist Gok Wan's *Gok's Style Secrets* (2013), a show that grooms long-term singles for the dating scene. Its inaugural episode introduces Zoe, a science fiction fan with a penchant for tattoos, black clothing and cosplay. Although Zoe never describes herself as Goth, Gok repeatedly uses the word as shorthand for a look that is constructed as childish, self-indulgent, fake and off-putting to prospective romantic partners. Gok instructs Zoe that they will 'find the real you beneath the eyeliner' and makes the pop psychology assessment that one of the reasons she is attracted to 'skulls, death, vampires' is that 'when you're in that world, other people don't

want to go with you'. He repeatedly refers to Zoe's enjoyment of 'dress up' and cosplay as playing a character that implicitly inhibits, rather than aids, her self-expression. Gothic performativity is therefore constructed as psychological flaw, while the glossy looks Gok creates for Zoe are somehow more authentic to her 'real' self, a product of his superior insight into her psyche. Most troubling of all, Goth is made to oppose both adult femininity ('Hello, I'm a woman, I'm not an androgynous Goth,' Gok teases) and normal social interaction ('Who would have thought Zoe, the depressed Emo Goth, would be sitting in a bar chatting to a table of people?'). While Gok repeatedly asserts that he aims to preserve Zoe's individuality, he nevertheless effectively collapses subcultural distinctions: science fiction fandom, Goth and Emo are made to represent a homogenous mass of bad taste to be burnt off and refined into the more acceptable fashion terms of 'different … left-of-centre, avant-garde, contemporary'. What unites the three is their childish, 'androgynous' aspect, which becomes constructed in the episode as what Robert Mighall has described, in the context of Victorian Gothic, as 'anachronistic vestiges' which threaten progress – here the progress of the heroine from child to sexual maturity (Mighall 2000: 18). Hence, Goth itself is Gothicized. Zoe's heavy black boots and chokers are replaced with 1950s-inspired ensembles reminiscent of Amy Winehouse or Paloma Faith: a 'fashionable' reiteration of alternative style that erases the particular and specific subcultural affiliations of the individual and assumes that any style aslant of mainstream culture is interchangeable.

More intriguing cases of Goth makeovers occur on BBC Three's *Snog Marry Avoid?* The premise of this show is that a computer called Pod (an acronym for Personal Overhaul Device) 'makes *under*' participants with overtly artificial appearances to reveal their 'natural beauty'. Most participants sport variations of the 'WAG' look of perma-tan, hair extensions and false eyelashes, but Goth types also occasionally enter Pod for her caustic dissection. The show has an ironic dimension from the start in that its ideology of 'natural beauty' is promoted by a robot – itself obviously a fake persona for the anonymous army of stylists who actually perform the makeovers. This automated persona nevertheless frees the show from the charismatic presence of the star presenter and their requirement to control the narrative, enabling the guests, on occasion, to present counter-narratives and reclaim control over the makeover process. Guests engage in banter with Pod and sometimes refuse to accept her intervention, or conversely are rejected by her as suitable makeover subjects, particularly if they appear confident with the way they look. Contrary to the usual narrative of makeover shows, where subjects may initially express resistance but are won over by the end of

the programme, *Snog Marry Avoid?* documents resistance and sometimes even downright dissent. Modern freakshow performer Nick Painless retorts, 'I *am* naturally beautiful; this is the way I should be' (4.9). Cruella de Vil styled Angel Rose declares, 'Fake is fabulous!' (3.12). 'Military Cybergoth' Ebony insists, 'I know you couldn't do anything to make me look better in a different style' (2.9). Similarly, Goths who do undergo 'makeunders' often strongly assert their preference for their old look, which they return to at the end of the programme. Goth fashion student Tommy concedes, 'It was fun, but next time leave the styling to me, Pod' (3.11). Goth couple Emily and Karl report, 'We pretty much went back as soon as we could' (1.2). 'Gothic Punk Tranny' Kate Hughes returns in a leopard-print gimp suit so outrageous that it exceeds even her previous 'Pat Butcher meets Frankenstein' confections, concluding, 'I realized [Pod's] done me a big favour as I realized natural beauty is not for me – it's fakery, fakery, fakery all the way' (5.2).

Snog Marry Avoid? therefore enables a double discourse in relation to Goth style in a way that more conventional makeover shows do not. On the one hand, it affirms an ideology of 'natural' beauty and mainstream fashion norms, acting as a kind of contemporary freak show on which those who choose to resist the norm are paraded before a voyeuristic audience; on the other, it provides a platform for Goths and other alternative subjects to display and defend their look, 'answering back' their critics, and celebrating the 'fakery' of Gothic. Crucially, however, despite a handful of male subjects, it corresponds to the majority of makeover shows in that its chief concern is femininity. Self-transformation in contemporary Western culture is the special province of women. The television sitcom, on the other hand, imagines Goth transformation as the particular experience of men.

Introducing the sitcom Goth

The sitcom Goth is becoming a stock character in twenty-first-century television. Their first appearance is typically cued with the laughter track, and met with bemusement, disapproval or even horror by the other characters. At first glance then, it would seem that Goth style is seemingly opposed to the perennially cheerful world of the sitcom, and is characteristically ridiculed for comic effect. There is some truth to this, but I will examine exactly how and why this is so, and what it tells us about the function of Gothic in contemporary culture.

An early example of the sitcom Goth is Mark Taylor (Taran Noah Smith) in the American sitcom *Home Improvement* (1991–99), a teenager who in Season

7 (1997–98) goes through a loosely Goth phase (mostly, just wearing black – although in one episode he also appears with a shaved head and a spiked dog-collar). In the celebrated Hallowe'en episode, 'A Night to Dismember' (1997), he and his new Goth friend Ronny (Kaylan Romero) make a horror film about revenging himself on his family for their persecution of him by turning them into zombies and slaughtering them. The comic effect is based in standard sitcom conventions of misunderstanding – Mark's parents watch the video without his permission and fear he is really murderous. The episode is disturbing, however, in its anticipation of the Columbine case: the perpetrators were teenage friends who made a video about their feelings of persecution before going on their killing spree. While the episode ultimately stresses the fictional nature of horror and its generic requirement to cause fear, and dismisses any implication that Mark is really murderous in favour of some saccharine family bonding (albeit through jovially acting out the family massacre), it nevertheless demonstrates the kinds of preconceptions about Goth within American culture that led to its scapegoating in the wake of the Columbine tragedy. In the set of associations *Home Improvement* mobilizes, Goth is an outlet for feelings of ostracism; it is performed by angry young men; it threatens traditional family values; and it has an undercurrent of violence. It is difficult to see a similar story being told in sitcom format post-1999. In the final season of the show, moreover, Mark rejects his Goth look and returns to a mainstream appearance, reinforcing the popular presumption that Goth is merely a phase or form of teenage rebellion.

In contrast, the first post-Columbine appearance of a Goth on an American sitcom is more positive. In season 11, episode 11 of *Frasier*, 'High Holidays' (2003), Frasier's son Frederick (Trevor Einhorn) pays a Christmas visit, newly attired as a Goth. Transformation is implicit, happening extra-diegetically to the episode, and while it is treated as temporary by the other characters, this prompts reflection on their younger selves' own rebellions or lack of them, shifting the source of comedy from Frederick's behaviour to that of the elder generation. Aside from the insistence on Goth as temporary, the episode is relatively sympathetic: Frederick is positioned as part of a community (making friends), and while the characters start exaggeratedly every time they see his appearance, they do not censure or condemn it and Frederick does not convert back by the end of the episode. The shift in class context may be significant: *Home Improvement* depicts a blue-collar family while *Frasier* is framed as pronouncedly middle class.

A diegetic Goth makeover features in season 3, episode 3 of *The Big Bang Theory* (2007–). In 'The Gothowitz Deviation' (2010), science geeks Howard and

Raj adopt Goth style in order to impress women in a Goth nightclub. In the episode, Goth acts as an unstable site of masculine identity. Dunja Brill argues in her ethnographic study of Goth that feminine dress is frequently adopted by Goth males in order to boost heterosexual masculinity rather than subvert it, either as a 'masculine status criterion' (being man enough to wear it) or as a means of attracting women (Brill 2008: 85). Key to Howard and Raj's look are 'tattoo sleeves', see-through garments which give the false impression of real tattoos, a way of masquerading manliness. This masquerade repeatedly fails, however. When Howard and Raj do encounter Goth girls, they find themselves unwittingly accompanying them to a tattoo parlour where they are forced to admit that they are shamming. The tattoo sleeves function as a form of masculine bravado that is deflated in a sexually suggestive scene in which a grizzled biker-style tattoo artist takes a needle to Howard's exposed bottom. The joke is on the geeks: they are even less masculine than Goths. In contrast to the earlier representations, Howard and Raj are adults rather than teenagers and they are adopting Goth style as a form of fancy dress rather than an expression of self – but this lasts for the duration of the episode only. Goth is defused and contained as a temporary 'deviation' from the norm.

British sitcom presents a rather different view of Goth, partly because Goth itself is treated as less controversial and more humorous in British culture, but also because British television comedy has a more pronounced tendency towards the surreal and absurd, deriving partly from the influence of *Monty Python*. British sitcoms also dwell on the transformation motif, but they tend to do so in more playful ways. The sitcoms in which they have appeared have also been, so far, less family centred and therefore there has been less interest in representing teenage Goths or in constructing Goth as a pressure on family values. The British sitcom Goth is characteristically adult and the transformational potential of the Goth look is frequently framed as a challenge to the world of work, aspirational consumption and social conformity. This is vividly illustrated by BBC Three's stand-alone comedy thriller 'Goths' (2003), an episode in the *Spine Chillers* series – notably, not a sitcom, but employing well-known British sitcom actors and anticipating subsequent portrayals in its demarcation of a very British Goth territory. The episode mercilessly mocks Goth men's pretensions, which are neither appreciated nor shared by their female peers (who, true to stereotype, just like the clothes). The two hapless Goth protagonists, Grishnack (Mackenzie Crook) and Tim (Tim Plester) acquire a charismatic new landlord, Balfus (Mark Heap), whose successful performance of Goth masculinity far exceeds their own and is explicitly set against the world of work. Commitment to the subculture

to the exclusion of a conventional career and family-oriented lifestyle is the ultimate criterion for acceptance: 'I've lived the life for real, every day,' boasts Balfus. 'I hope you two aren't … weekenders? I hate weekenders worse than straights.' The permanency of tattooing is used by the Goths as a measure of commitment, and as they remove their clothes to display their respective designs, the episode equates a jostling for masculine status with a competition for subcultural capital (to use a term coined by Sarah Thornton). Grishnack and Tim both have 'individual' written on their inner arm in slightly different fonts; Balfus trumps them with Alastair Crowley's Satanic mandate, 'Do What Thou Wilt' in Gothic script across his back. When it transpires that Balfus's Gother-than-thou persona is a performance and he has secretly been holding down a corporate job, it is figured as the ultimate betrayal.

The IT Crowd (2006–13) likewise foregrounds the world of work, taking place in the dysfunctional IT department of generic corporation Reynholm Industries. In Season 1 episode 4, 'The Red Door' (2006), 'relationship manager' Jen (Katherine Parkinson) opens a mysterious door in their basement headquarters, to discover the server room, haunted by the sepulchral Richmond (Noel Fielding). The required transformation occurs in flashback: Richmond undergoes a moment of conversion when he first listens to 'one of the best contemporary darkwave bands in the world' Cradle of Filth (more often designated a black metal band than a Goth band, but their extremity makes for a better series of jokes). Originally a blonde yuppy, Richmond begins to adopt a metal/goth style at work, eventually leading to his exile to the basement where his 'punishment' for his transgression is to oversee a mysterious machine (presumably the server) whose purpose is unclear.

Unlike the temporary transformation of Mark or Frederick on the American sitcoms, or indeed Balfus's hyper-Goth performance, Richmond's Goth identity is presented as his permanent and authentic one. In 'The Red Door', Jen tries to recuperate Richmond and return him to his role as second-in-command at Reynholm Industries, in doing so parodying the narrative and language of assimilation. She displays a series of prejudices that are comically deflated, beginning with the stereotypical: she cuts her hand and when Richmond pays a suspiciously intense interest in it, she screams, implying he is a vampire – it turns out that he is applying a plaster. Others are surreally mundane: 'How come you never see Goths driving cars?' she asks. 'Oh, we drive cars,' Richmond replies. 'We're just like you really, except we listen to Cradle of Filth.' Later, she defiantly tells CEO Reynholm (Chris Morris), 'Goths are people too!' and he temporarily reinstates Richmond, professing that he has learnt not to judge people on the

colour of their skin – Richmond's skin being, of course, exaggeratedly pale. Goth stands in for a variety of others at this point, allowing the show to satirize both the perception that Goths are 'other' and workplace discrimination more generally. In other ways, however, Richmond acts comically true to stereotype. He uses stylized, melodramatic body language: as he recalls his past, for example, he gazes into the distance for excessively long periods of time until the other characters peer to see what he is looking at. When Richmond's hyperbolic melancholy proves contagious, the team lock him back in the server room with relief. The episode pokes fun at *both* prejudice against Goths *and* mainstream assimilationism – and Richmond's difference is preserved.

Later in the series, the makeover process is explicitly parodied in season 4, episode 6, 'Reynholm vs. Reynholm' (2010), in which Richmond returns made over as a corporate Goth lifestyle guru on an evangelical mission. His promotional video, 'Goth 2 Boss', parodies corporate motivational videos:

> Where are you going? Is it to the top? If not, why not? Go to the bloody top! Is it because you're a Goth? Did you know that Goths have some of the lowest life satisfaction levels of any subculture with the exception of traffic wardens? That's why you don't see any Goth traffic wardens. That would be a deadly combination. We at Goth2Boss work with Goths in various locations around the UK to bring out their hidden potential by encouraging them to engage in everyday, healthy pursuits such as sport, mixing with other humans, extended laughter sessions and introducing colour to your wardrobe. Just look at these results. This is Debbie – she used to hang around railway stations with her hands in her sleeves. Now she's a lifeguard in Mumbai!

The comedy functions by bringing together two diametrically opposite discourses: the fake corporate sunniness of self-help and the deliberate gloominess of Goth stereotype. Goth in this instance works to expose the ideological imperative behind the lifestyle show makeover – the drive to realize everyone as compliant consumers and economically productive members of the workforce. Goth is not understood as performative, but rather suggestively presented as a debilitating condition or illness – one that reduces your life expectancy and requires intervention for your own benefit. Significantly, Goth2Boss doesn't work out for Richmond – in a one-off final episode, broadcast in 2013, he is back to his familiar sepulchral self. Once a Goth, always a Goth, the series seems to say – in this context, a semi-subversive message as it suggests that Goth is ultimately resistant to the discourses of self-actualization and aspirational achievement prevalent in the modern corporate arena.

Makeovers in sitcoms cannot be successful as they are reliant on characters with clearly demarcated, repetitive traits, whose responses are to a certain degree predictable. As a general rule, sitcom characters do not change: in *Friends*, Monica may fall in love with Chandler but she remains as fussy and obsessive as ever – as this is what makes her funny. *The IT Crowd*'s Richmond can become a suited and booted businessman for one episode, but the comedy derives from the contrast with his regular persona, and so the change is not sustainable in the long term. In contrast to the lifestyle makeover show, which wants its changes to be permanent in order to shore up the authority of its experts and affirm its ideology of bourgeois self-improvement, sitcom makeovers are temporary and transient. Much more radical is British comedy series *The Mighty Boosh* (2004–07), in which Goth is incorporated into a wider discourse of masculine dandyism.

Comic dandies in *The Mighty Boosh*

Nominally a sitcom, *The Mighty Boosh* repeatedly challenges the boundaries of the form. It began life as a stage show, and has continued to tour in that format, although my focus here is on the television series. Working in a peculiarly British comic tradition that incorporates *Monty Python's Flying Circus* (1969–74), Vic Reeves and Bob Mortimer and *The League of Gentlemen* (1999–2002), the series also plunders a British telefantasy tradition, creating a surreal patchwork of fantasy narrative and horror iconography, inflected by subcultural music and style history. Significantly, this is not just a cult comedy but also a subcultural comedy – youth subcultures are a major source of its inspiration and aesthetic. There is a nominal 'situation' set up for each season: the protagonists, uptight, pretentious Howard Moon (Julian Barrett), and happy-go-lucky, style-obsessed Vince Noir (Noel Fielding), work together in a zoo in the first series, share a flat in the second and run a shop in the third. However, there is no laughter track, the main characters repeatedly leave the setting, dramatic sequences are interspersed with songs and the psychedelic imagery and anarchic plotting defy straightforward categorization.

Vince, who as the show's main outlet for Goth style will be my main object of attention here, sports a bewildering variety of costumes over the course of the series, many of which are explicitly derived from subcultural style. In season 1, for example, the story revolves around Mod in 'Jungle' and Electro in the eponymously titled 'Electro'. In season 3, he sports in different episodes a Punk look and a Gram

Parsons-style Nudie suit. In season 2, however, Vince's look becomes more consistently Glam Rock inspired, with a heavy debt to Goth. Significantly, the DVD blurb for the series describes Vince as a 'Goth fairy', thereby fixing the diverse range of looks he sports throughout the series to a single image. In the third episode of the series, 'Nanageddon', this undercurrent is made explicit as Vince fashions a Goth look for himself and Howard in the hope of seducing two Goth girls. (The similarity of the plot to 'The Gothowitz Deviation', which it pre-empts, is striking.)

Vince adopts a convincing Goth style throughout 'Nanageddon', revealingly not departing far from his characteristic look in this season: although his costume features less colour and some specifically Goth garments such as a leather skirt and distressed mesh top, there is an interesting continuity of visual style with his 'everyday' appearance. Parodying the Goth penchant for elaborate pseudonyms, he adopts the name 'Obsidian Blackbird McNight' for his Goth identity; significantly, however, this only hyperbolizes his regular character name, 'Vince Noir'. Goth references continue in subsequent episodes. For instance in 'Fountain of Youth', Vince declares his love of Factor 3000 sun-cream, 'tested on Goths and albinos', and stresses, 'I need to be pale, it's part of my look. I'm the Shoreditch Vampire'. The joke riffs on the infamous case of the Highgate Vampire in the 1970s, substituting the area of London associated with hipsters for the swanky middle-class Highgate.

In 'Nanageddon', Vince also gives Howard a Goth makeover in a scene that focuses on the Goth requirement for big hair. The makeover scene in film or lifestyle television normally centres around a female character. Alongside the televisual examples I have already provided, Ally Sheedy's makeover in *The Breakfast Club* (1985) is a classic example. Here it is enacted by two men, bringing a subtly different inflexion. Hair styling, not for the first or last time in the series, takes on the connotations of combat. When Howard begs Vince to help him with his terminally soft and floppy hair, Vince retorts,

> Luckily for you, there's this: Goth Juice – the most powerful hairspray known to man. Made from the tears of Robert Smith.

Goth Juice's incredible hold becomes weaponized in the climax of the episode, as Vince and Howard use it to freeze the demon Nanatoo's knitting needle mid-air. Through the power of Goth Juice, Vince saves the day, Nanatoo is returned to hell, and Vince and Howard become subcultural heroes featured on the cover of fictional magazine *Goth Weekly*.

Vince's heroism recalls Charles Baudelaire's comment in *The Painter of Modern Life* that dandyism is 'the last spark of heroism amid decadence'

([1863]1995: 28–9). Dandyism provides a useful model for reading Goth masculinities. It can be loosely defined as the cultivation of personal style above and beyond social norms, but has a complex history and has encompassed a wide variety of different looks and poses over the last two hundred years. Originating in Britain during the Regency period, it developed through dialogue between French and British culture over the course of the nineteenth century, and has frequently been associated with a particular form of British masculinity, especially in its latter-day manifestation in twentieth- and twenty-first-century pop culture. Many of what Stan Hawkins (2009) calls 'British Pop Dandies', from David Bowie to Robert Smith, are implicitly or explicitly referenced in *The Mighty Boosh*. In the first season, Vince's dandiacal heritage is established when we learn that his uncle is a 'French duke' and that as a child, he was brought up in the forest by Bryan Ferry.

For Baudelaire, the heroism of the dandy resides in his inherent opposition to complacency and dullness, in his privileging of the superior beauty of the artificial over the natural. Dandyism, for Baudelaire, is not just about one's appearance; it is an intellectual pose. Similarly it is not just the actual accoutrements of dandyism, but the spirit of it, that lies behind contemporary Goth. As in Baudelaire, Goth dandyism is not just about dressing up, but about cultivating and expressing the interior through the exterior. As I established in Chapters 3 and 4, writing by post-millennial Goths frequently posits self-expression as one of the tenets dearest to their subcultural identity. The dandy is, for Baudelaire, a rebel against mediocrity and conformity. Again, this is a sentiment with which many contemporary Goths agree. One of Nancy Kilpatrick's interviewees in *The Goth Bible*, for example, states: 'Most people in the gothic [*sic*] scene want to distinguish themselves from the world of the average, where there is not a lot of place for imagination and deviation from the norm' (Kilpatrick 2005: 1). This sentiment may be far from unique to either Goths or dandies, but is a crucial structuring principle for both. Baudelaire's dandy forms a prototype for subcultural rebels in general, but Goths in particular – Baudelaire's embrace of decadence, of beauty in decay, maps onto Goth subculture especially well. If nineteenth-century dandyism was, predominantly, about aesthetic perfection, its contemporary Goth equivalent overtly enjoys and displays its latent monstrosity, and revels in visual motifs of decadence and decay. Goth style is underworld dandyism: dandyism as dark double to the more conventionally validated pursuit of beauty (Spooner 2008, 152–3).

As I have demonstrated elsewhere, dandies were frequently presented as monstrous in Victorian culture: excessive in their pursuit of aesthetic perfection,

their willingness to make a spectacle of themselves was aligned, by the philosopher Thomas Carlyle, with the freakshow exhibit (Spooner 2004). In *Sartor Resartus* Carlyle marvels that the public 'will waste its optic faculty on dried Crocodiles, and Siamese Twins; and over the domestic wonderful wonder of wonders, a live dandy, gaze with hasty indifference and a scarcely concealed contempt!' (Carlyle [1833–4]1987, 208). Elsewhere dandies were portrayed as outwardly beautiful but morally or spiritually bankrupt. This is illustrated most clearly in Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890–91), in which the dandy is presented with his own uncanny image: an image of darkness and decay.

The freakishness of the dandy is multiply reinforced in *The Mighty Boosh*. Noel Fielding plays many parts throughout the series, so that in almost every episode, Vince's carefully groomed appearance is doubled with a monstrous and degraded counterpart. The most frequently recurring of these is the Hitcher (also played by Fielding). The Hitcher combines an excessive number of pop-cultural references into one monstrous (and frankly terrifying) package. Most significantly, his top hat and long coat present a hideous underworld parody of the nineteenth-century dandy. His cockney accent gives this a particular inflection, evoking both the nineteenth-century lower-class 'swells' who emulated their social superiors, and the twentieth-century rapper Mr C, whose 1992 hit with The Shamen, *Ebeneezer Goode*, is an evident influence for the character – the video featured comedian Jerry Sadowitz parading around a derelict landscape in a top hat, striped trousers and cape. The outsized polo mints that decorate the Hitcher's costume and those of his minions recall the mother-of-pearl buttons worn by traditional cockney Pearly Kings and Queens, but also, worn over one eye with a bowler hat, recall Victorian monocles and the droogs' costumes from Kubrick's *A Clockwork Orange* (1961). The combination of dandy imagery with that signifying the East End and violent crime becomes particularly interesting in Season 3 episode 1, 'Eels', in which the Hitcher appears and starts criticizing modern-day hipsters for sanitizing the dark, East End underworld. His role as Vince Noir's dark double is to function not only as a terrifying remnant of a fantasized past but also to critique the process of gentrification that is initiated when artists and taste-makers take over previously working-class urban districts. This is epitomized in the lyrics to his Victorian Electro collaboration with Vince and Howard: 'Elements of the past and the future, combining to make them not quite as good as either.'

If the Hitcher provides a monstrous double for Vince as dandy, then Vince's own narcissism is also presented as outlandish, and his dizzying array of looks so exaggerated as to be freakish. There are frequent references to his looking like and sometimes even being mistaken for 'an ugly woman', so that gender travesty

is added to the mix. Vince Noir is therefore a Gothicized dandy even when not specifically dressed as a Goth. Significantly, moreover, *The Mighty Boosh*'s comic treatment of dandyism parodies the notion of expressing the interior through the exterior. In 'Nanageddon', Howard tells Vince, 'Inside, I'm darker than you. There's a dark poetry to me, yes sir.' Vince responds, 'You can blag all that internal stuff, I'm talking about the look.' Here he points out an obvious truth: that while you can fake a Goth personality, you can't fake a Goth appearance. Goth style demands commitment. For all the talk of self-expression, exterior style is actually the defining feature of Goth. In recognizing this, however, Vince is perhaps all the more Gothic: as Eve Sedgwick (1986) has argued, it is surface, rather than depth, that provides the most defining features of Gothic narrative.

Vince's interior lightness is figured in the following exchange in which the two protagonists compare each other to retro British sweets:

> **Vince**: You're gonna have to get a bit dark, like me.
> **Howard**: Like you? You're the least dark person I ever met! You're like candy floss!
> **Vince**: You cut me open and I'm made of black jacks!
> **Howard**: You're fruit salad, Vince, everyone knows that.

Vince's sweetness and insubstantiality works on multiple levels here. On the most overt level, it merely signals the superficiality of his adopted Goth identity. On another, if we read Noel Fielding/Vince Noir as inhabiting a Goth continuum of which 'Obsidian' is only the most overt manifestation, then his fruity interior punctures the myth of the sinister or pretentious Goth.

The Mighty Boosh therefore renovates the figure of the feminized Goth male while also refusing to take it too seriously. Much of the show's comedy is produced out of a sense of masculinity in crisis, but Vince Noir, the most overtly and consistently feminized male on screen, remains blissfully happy in his self-identity. Nevertheless through a repeated emphasis on the dandy's monstrous doubles, the series Gothicizes his purely aesthetic pose, and in doing so subjects it to comedy. Goth men are gently ridiculed in the episode, but they are also comically heroic. Vince rescuing Howard through his superior subcultural capital or, more frequently, his hair styling skills, becomes a repeated motif: having great hair becomes a skill for life. This is a radical way of representing Goth masculinity, eschewing the more conventional representation of Goth men as either threatening or ridiculous figures: sinister misfits in the mould of Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold, the perpetrators of the Columbine Massacre; or pretentious and effeminate, as in *The Big Bang Theory*. By allowing one of its central characters to be both heroic and silly at the same time, *The Mighty Boosh* enables the

simultaneous production and deconstruction of a specifically British version of subcultural masculinity.

Crucially, *The Mighty Boosh* does not only draw on Goth subcultural style but also on Gothic. 'Nanageddon', like many other *Boosh* episodes, utilizes Gothic narrative conventions. The ludicrous, fantastic world the series creates paradoxically allows it to treat Goth seriously. In *The Mighty Boosh* Goth is part of a spectrum of masculine performativity and constantly bleeds into other areas of the series. Howard may undergo a conventional sitcom makeover in which he returns to his usual (not normal) persona by the next episode, but Vince's Goth look does not look radically different from his usual, Glam Rock inspired look; it forms part of a fluid, ongoing performance of multiple subcultural styles.

If all the shows I have discussed in this chapter test the limits of Goth and non-Goth, they come to rather different conclusions. In the majority of sitcom texts, including *Home Improvement, The IT Crowd* and *The Big Bang Theory*, Goth and non-Goth are clearly demarcated by an invisible barrier which may be crossed, temporarily, for comic purposes, but which always reasserts itself. You are either a Goth, or you are faking it. In *Gok's Style Secrets*, similarly, a line is drawn between Goth and non-Goth, but this *must* be crossed in order to demarcate taste and demonstrate personal growth. Goth is figured as a masquerade behind which a 'real' self is hiding. In contrast, *The Mighty Boosh*, like *Snog Marry Avoid?* and indeed Tim Minchin, embraces fakery and celebrates Goth as performance. In doing so, it offers a rather different and much more radical view of Goth, and indeed Gothic. Each of the shows featured in this chapter, more or less sympathetically, defines Goth as 'other' – as the opposite of the mainstream, the opposite of successful integration into society, the opposite of cheerful everyday life. They do so not because they are particularly interested in Goth but because they are interested in not being Goth – in establishing and defining a 'normal', 'mainstream' self. *The Mighty Boosh* does not define Goth as 'other' because within its hyperbolic, generically hybrid world there is no mainstream and therefore no normal. Goth is defined not in relation to a putative 'mainstream' but rather in relation to other subcultures. After 'Nanageddon', Howard goes back to being a jazz freak, Vince continues his style odyssey. *The Mighty Boosh* thus offers a comic and oddly restorative vision of Gothic beyond borders.

Note

1 Minchin re-uses songs in subsequent shows and the versions I am discussing were recorded for his *So F**king Rock Live* show in 2008 and *Tim Minchin and the Heritage Orchestra* in 2011.

8

‘Swishing about and spookiness’: Whitby and Gothic Literary Tourism from Bram Stoker’s *Dracula* to Paul Magrs’s *Never the Bride*

Gothic tourism

In a tweet from 18 September 2010, the writer Paul Magrs announced, ‘I’ve decided that my favourite genre is: swishing about and spookiness’. I have borrowed this tweet to title this chapter as not only does it encapsulate the mood of Magrs’s Whitby-based fiction, but it is also suggestive of the wider processes of Gothic tourism in Whitby, as well as of the comic turn towards happy Gothic in post-millennial Gothic culture. To swish is to move making a rustling sound as when wearing silk, but it also has connotations in the United Kingdom of being fashionable or posh, and in the United States of effeminacy. Paul Magrs bundles these meanings together to create a kind of camp performance of dressing up and parading about, which when combined with spookiness gets to the heart of Whitby’s biannual Goth Weekend as well as of happy Gothic.

Whitby, a historic port and fishing village on the north Yorkshire coast, has been a popular tourist destination since the mid-nineteenth century, when the town expanded to accommodate middle-class visitors seeking the sea air and fashionable, locally produced jet jewellery. A new wave of working-class tourists hit the town in the 1950s following the popularization of the British seaside holiday. From the 1980s, the slump in tourist traffic caused by the advent of the cheap foreign package holiday resulted in the eventual rebranding of the town ‘as heritage and festival destination’ (Spracklen and Spracklen 2014: 93). Latterly, it has become a favoured destination for what I will call the ‘Gothic tourist’, whether the literary fan in search of Dracula, or the Goth attending the biannual festival. In this chapter I consider the town itself as a kind of overdetermined

Gothic space, as well as its literary representation as a Gothic tourist site. As Nicola J. Watson argues in *The Literary Tourist*,

> literary place is produced by writing mediated by acts of literary tourism, and in that sense literary place is itself a 'text' … no author or text can be successfully located to place unless their writings model or cue tourism in one way or another … it is the text itself that invents and solicits tourism … it is a historically specific kind of text that converts readers into tourists, and … tourism is, moreover, a historically specific kind of reading. (2006: 12)

Bearing in mind Watson's analysis of the mutually constitutive nature of literary tourism and literary production, this chapter explores both Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), the text which first models Gothic tourism in Whitby, and Paul Magrs's series of *Adventures of Brenda and Effie* novels, which operate on the premise that the Bride of Frankenstein (or Brenda, as she styles herself) has settled down and set up a bed-and-breakfast in Whitby. Beginning with *Never the Bride* in 2006, the series comprises *Something Borrowed* (2007), *Conjugal Rites* (2008), *Hell's Belles* (2009), *The Bride That Time Forgot* (2010) and *Brenda and Effie Forever* (2012). Magrs's postmodern, comic texts are about a site that has already become a tourist destination; indeed, their plots are predicated on there being a tourist industry already present.

The concept of 'Dark Tourism' has become a popular one within tourism studies since the late 1990s: coined by Malcolm Foley and J. John Lennon in 1996, the term refers to the tourist consumption of sites associated with death and suffering, from the 'pale tourism' of visiting famous people's graves to the 'black tourism' of holocaust and genocide sites. Whitby's attractions are on the paler end of this spectrum, with the somewhat shabby waxworks of 'The Dracula Experience' fitting comfortably into the category of 'Dark Fun Factories' that Philip Stone identifies as the very lightest of 'dark suppliers' (2006: 146). 'Dark Tourism', however, does not adequately describe the experience of Whitby, because 'dark' does not adequately summarize the multivalences of the term 'Gothic', and because it does not engage with the literary models which script tourist encounters with this space. As Emma McEvoy stresses,

> Gothic tourism … is both more and less than dark tourism. Less, in that, though some of Stone's examples are Gothic, others are not (his list, for example, includes tourism to disaster sites, and concentration camps). More, in that there is more to Gothic tourism than 'Dark Fun Factories' of the Dungeons range type, and its concerns and content cannot be contained within a spectrum concerned with death and disaster. (McEvoy 2016: 201)

Death and suffering may be present in *Dracula*, but I suspect for most readers it is the 'un-death' of the vampire that is more compelling, a feature that is enhanced in Magrs's novels, in which few characters die never to return, and which are decidedly comic and regenerative. Accordingly, this chapter will proceed with the understanding that Gothic tourism is, as McEvoy explains, 'the act of visiting, for the purposes of leisure, a location that is presented in terms of the Gothic' and a 'tourism that is intimately connected with Gothic narrative, its associated tropes, discourses and conventions' (2016: 3, 5). The association of tourism and leisure with the Gothic is in itself an important feature of happy Gothic, but in Magrs's fiction this is distilled through a range of comic techniques into the quintessence of the mode. As such, this chapter is an appropriate one with which to end the book.

Tourism in *Dracula*

It has been frequently noted that *Dracula*'s Jonathan Harker takes on the role of tourist in his trip to Transylvania. Stephen D. Arata reads the first three chapters of the novel as imitations of the conventional travel narrative to the point of parody: 'Not only does he … gripe about the trains, he also searches for quaint hotels … samples the native cuisine … ogles the indigenous folk … marvels at the breathtaking scenery … wonders at local customs … and, interspersed throughout, provides pertinent facts about the region's geography, history, and population' (Arata 1990: 636). Jennifer Wicke is more explicit: 'The local color Jonathan drinks in, as recipes and customs and costumes, has the form of regularized tourism' (1992: 472). The Harkers' final visit to Transylvania to revisit the scene of their loss at the end of the narrative is even characterized by Duncan Light as 'a holiday overtly based on "Dark" tourism!' (Light 2012: 27) These observations on the novel's incorporation of tourist discourses have been used as a means of reflecting on its Orientalism and its aggressive modernity. They also anticipate a significant industry based around Dracula tourism in modern-day Romania, amply documented by Light in of *The Dracula Dilemma* (2012).

It has been less frequently noted that Whitby itself is interpolated as a tourist site within the novel. The Westenra family have rented rooms in the Royal Crescent, Whitby's most fashionable street overlooking the West Cliff, and Mina joins Lucy at the end of July for a summer holiday. Mina's description of the town recalls Watson's account of Thomas Hardy's deployment of 'the well-developed language of the guidebook': she constructs 'a readerly position

analogous to the stance, vantage-point and aesthetic of a tourist, melding landscape prospects with antiquarian information and "association" and geological or economic observations, architectural details and historical anecdote' (Watson 2006: 179). Mina provides extended description of the landscape, comparing it to pictures of another tourist destination, Nuremberg, and, significantly, relating both local ghost legends and a previous literary reference, to Scott's *Marmion* (1808). Whitby is, therefore, already interpolated as a literary site within the novel, as well as a source of local folklore. Both the 'romantic' legend of the white lady who appears at the Abbey windows, and the scene from *Marmion* 'where the girl was built up in the wall', prefigure Lucy's later appearance on the cliff dressed in white and her burial as a vampire (Stoker [1897]1998: 95). Within the text, Whitby is already postulated as a Gothic site, but a Gothic site presented in terms of tourist consumption of colourful local stories.

Mr Swales, the old man who Mina and Lucy befriend in their characteristic walks to admire the view from the benches in the old clifftop churchyard, explicitly critiques this process of tourist narrativization:

> They be all very well for comers and trippers an' the like, but not for nice young ladies like you. Them feet-folks from York and Leeds that be always eatin' cured herrin's and drinkin' tea an' lookin' out to buy cheap jet would creed aught. (Stoker [1897]1998: 96)

The credulous belief in folklore is explicitly constructed as a tourist activity, and moreover as an activity associated with vulgar, working-class tourism, 'feet-folks' who walk rather than ride in carriages and buy cheap jet, not the more genteel sort of visitor like Mina and Lucy themselves. For the resident Mr Swales, there are two sorts of tourist, suggestively demarcated along class boundaries. Mina herself does not appear to recognize this distinction, at least in terms of stories, although she gives the folktales an association of gentility by the literary reference to Scott. Her eager consumption of supernatural tales suggests the pleasures of 'slumming it', of indulging the amusements associated with a lower class status.

Dracula therefore models two forms of Gothic tourism: a vulgar one associated with consumption of food, souvenirs and sensational ghost stories, and a genteel one in which landscape and local colour are appreciated alongside literary associations. As such the representation of tourism in the novel underlines the text's modernity, as this 'vulgar' tourism, as John Urry points out, was a direct result of the nineteenth-century expansion of the railway network (1990: 21). The railway, of course, features prominently in the text as the primary means of

travel across Europe, and notably, Mina arrives in Whitby by train. Mina's own transitional class status threatens the distinction between these two forms of tourism, as she demonstrates an enthusiastic interest in local legends and walks to Robin Hood's Bay for a slap-up tea even as she demonstrates her more refined discernment of landscape and literature. In her avid consumption of both vulgar and genteel aspects of the local environment, Mina prefigures the figure of the modern, even perhaps the postmodern, tourist. Urry remarks on the playfulness of postmodern tourism and expands Feifer's concept of the 'post-tourist' to explain,

> The post-tourist is freed from the constraints of 'high culture' on the one hand, and the untrammelled pursuit of the 'pleasure principle' on the other. He or she can move easily from one to the other and indeed gain pleasure from the contrasts between the two. The world is a stage and the post-tourist can delight in the multitude of games that can be played. (100)

The porousness of vulgar and genteel tourism in Stoker's novel sets up the way in which contemporary Whitby stages a multitude of Gothic games for its visitors' enjoyment, including games that feature *Dracula* itself.

Tourism in contemporary Whitby

The two forms of tourism identified by *Dracula*, genteel and vulgar, are embodied today in its two main 'attractions', Whitby Abbey and The Dracula Experience. While both overtly engage with Gothic and indeed with *Dracula*, they do so in markedly different ways. In its presentation as heritage site, the Abbey foregrounds a Gothic that is rooted in an ecclesiastical and architectural history and distanced from the sensational thrills of the Gothic novel. The Dracula Experience, on the other hand, has no such intellectual qualms and plays fast and loose with historical fact, locating itself within an explicitly supernatural discourse and appealing directly to the affective experience of horror.

Whitby Abbey, managed by English Heritage, is presented to visitors as a scenic, historical and educational environment. English Heritage was a state-funded organization until 2015, when it became a charitable trust, dedicated to preserving historic sites within England and making them accessible to the public. It states its core values as 'authenticity, quality, imagination, responsibility and fun' (*English Heritage: Our Vision and Values*). As Emma McEvoy explains in relation to her investigation of Berry Pomeroy Castle in Devon, 'Traditionally

heritage sites have eschewed the Gothic' due to its sensational qualities and potentially problematic relationship to history (2016: 160). In recent years, however, its commercial appeal has made it 'an increasingly popular choice for heritage managers' (178). This shift is illustrated in the promotional materials for Whitby Abbey. When I visited in 2010 and 2012, *Dracula* was notable for its absence, with the emphasis very much on the ecclesiastical and architectural history of the Abbey, including its significance as home to the seventh-century poet Caedmon. By 2016 the *Dracula* connection was flagged much more flamboyantly on the website, with an image of the Abbey lit up at dusk overlaid with the tag line, 'Gothic splendour that inspired the creation of Dracula' (*English Heritage: Whitby Abbey*). While appearing to revel in the literary connection, the choice of words here is significant. McEvoy argues that

> heritage organizations in England … or at least the academic members of them, have a distrust of [Gothic] – especially that associated with commercial modes. Thus, many heritage sites court Gothic, using its narratives and imagery to appeal to visitors and potential visitors, but, typically, also seek to contain it. (2016: 178)

The tag line's emphasis on *inspiration*, foregrounding the historical figure of Bram Stoker rather than his fictional creation, strikes a key note. Tourists engaged in the popular search for Dracula's grave should not seek encouragement here. On the 'Things to See and Do' page, visitors are instructed to 'Imagine Bram Stoker striding through the magnificent abbey ruins, soaking up inspiration for his vampire masterpiece: *Dracula*' (*English Heritage: Whitby Abbey*). Stoker's touristic activity thus provides a prototype for the modern visitor, and in doing so models 'imagination', one of the organization's core values. In this recursive exhortation, the modern visitor imagines Stoker imagining his novel, doubly removed from the vampire itself. Visitors are offered the possibility of conversing with Stoker – rather than, for example, characters from the novel – 'through entertaining and interactive touchscreens' (*English Heritage: Whitby Abbey*). Even the cheery instruction, 'If you are feeling energetic, climb the 199 steps up from the town. These were the steps that Bram Stoker's mysterious animal bounded up after it leapt to shore from the deserted ship' makes certain we remember that this was Bram Stoker's invention, and not an authentic local superstition (*English Heritage: Whitby Abbey*). The greatest concession to the novel is a promenade theatre production of *Dracula* in the grounds of the Abbey, but significantly, this is played as a comedy for a designated family audience.

The Dracula Experience, on the other hand, is a commercial attraction sited on the harbour alongside more traditional downmarket tourist venues from ice cream and sweet shops to the seaside psychic. It shows none of the Abbey's compunction about separating fiction and fact: the website's home page appears to present the novel as a real, historical event, instructing visitors that 'In 1885 the Russian Schooner The Demeter was hit by a wild storm and ran aground in Whitby harbour on Tate Hill Sands' (*The Dracula Experience*). The date is taken not from the novel but from the newspaper account of the wreck of the *Dmitry* that purportedly inspired it: Stoker studiously avoids specifying the year in the text. Nevertheless, here it provides a ring of authenticity. The attraction itself fails to capitalize on this: the visitor is guided along a series of darkened passages to a sequence of rather dilapidated waxwork tableaux as a voiceover gives a truncated synopsis of the novel's plot, with a nod or two to Francis Ford Coppola's *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (the tag-line 'Love Never Dies' features prominently). Moving parts triggered by motion sensors and live actors add to the 'experience', which is heavily reliant on traditional ghost train techniques of sensory disorientation and jump scares. The cheesy, end-of-the-pier quality offers contemporary tourists opportunities for ironic indulgence in the modern-day equivalent of 'vulgar' tourism, but it does not project the illusion of authenticity.

The Dracula Experience website's presentation of the novel-as-history is interestingly counterpointed by the emphasis on the history of the building itself, in which the supernatural predominates: 'Several employees have witnessed strange and unexplainable events that happen long after the special effects have been turned off. Sightings of a ghost of a young girl with ringlets in her hair playing on the first floor are not uncommon' (*The Dracula Experience*). Visitors can pay to attend an after-hours experience with paranormal investigators, in which authenticity and 'evidence' is emphasized:

> We invite you to join the Most Haunted Nites [*sic*] paranormal team that will deliver to you that much needed evidence that paranormal activity is here at the most haunted Dracula experience. There [*sic*] expert paranormal crew via hi tech equipment and mediums will take you on an all night vigil of séances, capturing the paranormal goings on of this very old and haunted building. What you experience is not special effects that you see in this building during the day, but real paranormal activity waiting to be found. (*The Dracula Experience*)

The page offers video footage of paranormal activity to corroborate its claims, but the links are dead. The promotional materials thus construct the building as a strange palimpsest of supernatural phenomena. The novel is initially presented

as history but then, in a nod to the knowingness of its audience, is revealed to be special effects, which can be ripped aside like a veil to reveal the *real* history of the building, itself evidenced through supernatural phenomena. The appeal of history is located by the site primarily in its 'creepy' affectivity (*The Dracula Experience*).

Whitby Abbey and The Dracula Experience offer modern-day versions of the 'genteel' and 'vulgar' tourism modelled by the novel. Just as in *Dracula*, however, the two kinds of tourism are in danger of collapsing into one another as Gothicized folktales appeal to *both* kinds of visitors, and the modern town fails to preserve the distinction between the two kinds of Gothic space, with Gothic commodification promiscuously mixing mass-produced Dracula souvenirs with high-end jet jewellery and hand-made chocolate Dracula coffins. As McEvoy remarks, 'Sometimes, the fluidity of a small town economy is mirrored in extremely porous boundaries between official heritage management and popular ghost traditions' (2016: 181). The porousness of different kinds of tourism in Whitby might be extended to include the traditional British seaside holiday and popular forms of Gothic consumption.

Throughout the town, the combination of seaside kitsch and Gothic commodities creates some bizarre and wonderful juxtapositions. Whitby Gothic ice-cream is blackcurrant and liquorice flavour – purple streaked with brownish black. Dracula's Dream Fudge combines chocolate and Turkish Delight, which is an interesting twist given the historical Vlad Ţepeş's wars with the Turks. Chocolate Dracula's coffins, at the time I visited displayed alongside traditional Easter eggs, give a whole new resonance to the Easter theme of resurrection. Elsewhere traditional Whitby jet jewellery is clearly marketed towards Goth visitors as well as more conventional tourists, with inexpensive chokers and crucifixes mingling with high-end keepsakes. Shabby chic boutiques again suggest a dual market, with ditsy bags and frocks jostling with ornate masks and chandeliers. Oxfam's charity shop notably capitalized on Goths' inclination for vintage wear by mounting an entire window display with a Whitby Goth Weekend theme, and devoting substantial sections of the shop to black garments blatantly directed at Goth consumers. The town's retailers interpolate Goth as a market and deliberately set out to attract what could be labelled the 'black pound'.

Whitby offers an intriguing distillation of a concept that I introduced in Chapter 1: what Jerrold Hogle calls the 'Gothic ghost of the counterfeit', or the means by which Gothic texts offer a 're-faking of fakery' (2012: 500), in which notions of an original or authentic history are deferred by 'ghostings of the already spectral, or at least resymbolisations of what is already symbolic and

thus more fake than real' (2012: 498). The town presents within a compact geographical location several different, and potentially competing, kinds of Gothic. The medieval Gothic architecture of the Abbey is given a Romantic inflexion by virtue of its ruin. The town's association with Victorian mourning practices is confirmed by the prolific jet industry, originally dedicated to providing mourning jewellery. The literary Gothic associations of *Dracula* are replicated in a range of tailored tourist experiences from guided walks to the waxwork thrills of The Dracula Experience. Finally, the modern-day Goth festival, the biannual Whitby Goth Weekend, adds contemporary subculture to the mix of ecclesiastical architecture, picturesque dereliction, morbid Victoriana, vampire iconography and the darker side of end-of-the-pier entertainment. A process of perpetual reproduction, reanimation, revival of an already inauthentic form is taking place that is quintessentially Gothic. In contemporary culture, Hogle suggests that this process is allied to the Baudrillardian precession of simulacra, so that the industrial detachment of the commodity from its historical referent and its duplication and circulation eventually becomes a post-industrial realm of free-floating signifiers.

Whitby's literary Gothic associations, again, script the staging of this process of counterfeiting. *Dracula* is already, for Hogle, exemplary of the ghost of the counterfeit: the vampire drains his victims of substance and is in turn drained himself by the process of textual composition and collation, which leaves 'hardly one authentic document; nothing but a mass of type-writing' that Hogle describes as 'vampiric as its subject' (Stoker [1897]1998: 419; Hogle 2012: 504). Hogle's argument can, furthermore, be extended to the town as depicted in the text. Mr Swales presents Mina with a disquisition on the tombstones in the graveyard:

> all them steans, holdin' up their heads as well as they can out of their pride, is acant – simply tumblin' down with the weight o' the lies wrote on them, 'Here lies the body' or 'Sacred to the memory' wrote on all of them, an' yet in nigh half of them there bean't no bodies at all; an' the memories of them bean't cared a pinch of snuff about, much less sacred. Lies all of them, nothin' but lies o' one kind or another!' (Stoker [1897]1998: 98)

The gravestones are presented as counterfeit, as marking a site with no body and with no memory attached to it, a sign with no referent. Similarly, according to Mr Swales, the town's supernatural stories, its 'bans an' wafts an' boh-ghosts an' barguests an' bogles', are without substance, invented by the church to enforce moral lessons or the nascent tourist industry in the form of 'railway touters' in order

to attract trade (Stoker [1897]1998: 97). The town as Gothic tourist destination (of course, there are other forms of tourism at work in Whitby as well) is built on this lack of authenticity, whether the genteel tourist imagining Bram Stoker imagining his novel or the vulgar one enjoying the erosion of fact and fiction in The Dracula Experience. In contrast to the craft souvenirs that Light documents in Transylvania, which are unrelated to local cultural forms but are nevertheless experienced as 'authentic and meaningful for the tourist', Whitby tourism thrives on and celebrates its inauthenticity (2012: 132). As such it invites and interpolates the post-tourist who, according to Urry, 'knows … that tourism is a game, or rather a whole series of games with multiple texts and no single, authentic tourist experience' (1990: 100). Contemporary fictional representations of Whitby continue to extend this process, accelerating and in some cases carnivalizing the process of counterfeiting, while in turn scripting new tourist encounters.

Paul Magrs's Whitby

Paul Magrs's *Adventures of Brenda and Effie* novels gleefully light on Whitby's promiscuous jamboree of high and low culture, high- and low-end consumerism, celebrating the cheap and cheerful indiscriminately alongside the more rarefied pleasures of literary in-jokes. Magrs's characters, from the green-skinned 'Frank' to Brenda herself, are indiscriminately drawn from fiction, film and popular culture. Rather like *Frankenstein, or the Vampire's Victim* (discussed in Chapter 6) or twentieth-century comedies such as *Mad Monster Party* (1967) and *The Addams Family* (debuting in *The New Yorker* in 1938), they bring together characters from different Gothic texts to comic effect. This creates a dynamic and constantly shifting text in which cultural meanings are continuously changing as they rub up against new contexts. As Effie tells hotel proprietor Mrs Claus in *Hell's Belles*, 'It's like Dante's Bloody Disco Inferno in here!' (Magrs [2009]2010: 447). The collapsing together of Dante's canonical epic with The Trammps' 1976 disco hit is typical of the way that Magrs characteristically fuses classic, serious and thanatoptic texts with pop cultural levity and camp. An openly gay writer who was vocal about his sexuality and working-class roots in the controversy following the publication of *Strange Boy* (2002), his '95% autobiographical' young adult novel with a gay protagonist, Magrs's use of camp is simultaneously celebratory *and* politicized (Magrs 2002).

One of the striking properties of Magrs's novels is the way that they disclose camp already at work within the Gothic process of counterfeiting. Sontag's

'everything in quotation marks' is, in Magrs's work, coincident with Hogle's 're-faking of fakery'. To *re-fake* what is already fake, however, is implicitly to place everything in two sets of quotation marks, and Gothic is thus revealed as a quintessentially camp genre. Indeed, Sontag lists Gothic novels, artificial ruins and Walpole's Strawberry Hill as belonging to the eighteenth-century culture that formed 'the origins of Camp taste' (1994: 80). Dracula exists as a character within Magrs's novels – under the alias of Kristoff Alucard – but, in keeping with the comic vampires discussed in Chapter 6, his representation is as influenced by the film versions of the text as by Stoker's 'original' novel. Alucard is a camp old gentleman who still possesses a soft spot for the ladies: 'He even wore an evening cape', the elderly Effie swoons, 'I never thought gentlemen still carried on like that' (Magrs 2006: 193). Interestingly, given the proliferation of gay and otherwise queer identities in Magrs's work (and this is a series in which one of the protagonists has a gay relationship with a lizard-boy from the land before time), Alucard remains heterosexual. He is a model of the ladies' man: conspicuously heterosexual yet sporting feminine suavity and charm. As such he provides a clue to the appeal of comic vampires: they are frequently positioned as heroically, even aggressively heterosexual men whose campness is therefore sanctioned and becomes part of their charm.

Magrs's heroine, Brenda, is likewise multiply counterfeit. Her 'original' in Mary Shelley's novel, of course, was an artificial being composed of multiple bodies, destroyed by Victor Frankenstein while still under construction. Magrs takes James Whale's *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935), rather than Shelley, as his origin story: the iconic bride played by Elsa Lanchester does make it into physical existence but only in the climactic final scene, which famously ends with her blood-curdling scream as she awakens to life. *Bride of Frankenstein* has frequently been claimed for queer film history: David J. Skal notes that its director was openly homosexual at a time when a publically gay identity was taboo in Hollywood, and filled his films with a camp sensibility, in this case importing the sexually ambiguous character of Dr Septimus Pretorius (Ernest Thesiger) who 'tempts Frankenstein from his marriage bed with the promise of an improved method of procreation' (Skal 1994: 187). In Magrs's novels, however, this is just one layer of intertextuality; crucially, the counterfeiting of Brenda is comic and parodic. In the second novel of the series, *Something Borrowed*, it is made plain that Brenda is not only a counterfeit of earlier texts but also a counterfeit body, who when escaping from her creator, stole two cases of spare body parts with which to refresh her ageing body. As she explains to Effie, 'Things wear out, when you live as long as I do … I've become quite adept at, erm, putting myself

back together again' ([2007]2008: 302). The disembodied parts take on their own life and start to haunt her, causing spooky scratching and banging noises that she misinterprets as ghosts in the attic. Literally ghosting the counterfeit, the spare parts are comically spectralized doubles of Brenda's body. Crucially, however, they are not hollowed-out replicas but have their own agency, leading Brenda to the information that solves the mystery.

In his ascription of agency to Brenda's body parts, Magrs refutes the 'progress of abjection' that Hogle says is 'inseparable from the progress of the ghost of the counterfeit' (Hogle 2012: 500). Hogle draws on Julia Kristeva's contention in *Powers of Horror* that the human subject 'throws off' or 'throws under' 'betwixt-and-between' states in order to shore up the boundaries of the self (2012: 499). In the classic statement of her argument, Kristeva describes the experience of food loathing when encountering the skin on milk and describes how in the resulting nausea, 'I expel *myself*, I spit *myself* out, I abject *myself* within the same motion through which "I" claim to establish *myself*' (1982: 3; italics in original). The 'utmost of abjection', she goes on to claim, is the corpse, 'the most sickening of wastes' as it forces the expelling subject to confront its own negation (4, 3). Hogle explains that 'Gothic … depicts and enacts these very processes of abjection, where fundamental interactions of contrary states and categories are cast off into antiquated and "othered" beings' (2012: 499). Indeed, in another essay he goes on to discuss Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) as epitomizing this process, in that the 'counterfeit form' (185) of the Creature 'embodies *and* distances' a series of in-between and hybrid states othered in Western culture and in particular 'the maternal as the place of inside/outside' (Hogle 1998: 185, 186, 198).

Brenda's spare parts parody abjection. Their gloriously gory existence challenges the unitary, whole identity of Brenda's body and their mobile 'squelch-drag-squelch' elicits disgust in others ([2007]2008: 359). However, Brenda does not throw off these bits and pieces in an attempt to shore up the boundaries of the self, but on the contrary feels 'a weird kind of loving pride' towards them (301). Confronted with what is, essentially, her own corpse (although simultaneously belonging to other people), Brenda's ego is not extinguished but merely reconfigured. In its endless circulation of parts, Brenda's body is porous and open to otherness, made up of bits and pieces of other bodies and identities. Always already other to itself, it offers a celebratory new Gothic subject, one in which horror is regenerative. In Chapter 6, I cited Avril Horner and Sue Zlosnik's suggestion that the comic turn in Gothic 'frequently allows a fresh perspective on a changing world, one of accommodation rather than terrified apprehension' (2005: 12). This description aptly fits Magrs's fictional

practice, as through parody and play he inaugurates an atmosphere of celebration rather than dread.

Magrs also writes in the feminist tradition of restoring a voice to the silenced women of the literary canon – and specifically, aging women, who have been poorly served by literature in general. Paradoxically, by restoring substance to a character that never had any in the first place, by giving her a life denied her by Shelley and Whale, Magrs turns Brenda from an unhomely figure to a homely one, a parody of the domestic with an exaggerated passion for cleaning and cooking for her guests. Magrs repeatedly emphasizes throughout the series that Whitby is a location where Brenda is no longer transient but finally able to settle and put down roots. By juxtaposing the monstrous with the banal, the everyday routines of coffee and cake, the exercise routine Brenda employs to keep her parts in shape, the practicalities of concealing her improper appearance from the world, Magrs yokes the free-floating simulation back to the material and the mundane. The travesty or burlesquing of the horror icon, the deflation of the uncanny *frisson*, is both the source of Magrs's humour and the means by which he brings the free-floating Gothic signifier back down to earth. Simultaneously, he also inverts what A. V. Seaton (1996) characterizes as the 'thanatoptic' urge of Dark Tourism, as he shifts the emphasis from 'away' to 'home', from visitors to workers in the tourist industry, and, to a certain extent, from Whitby as a site of consumption to a representation of the labour that enables that consumption. His supernatural characters, in the main, participate in the production of a supernatural economy that facilitates the consumption of Whitby as a tourist site.

It is not only Brenda and the other horror characters in the novels who are counterfeited in Magrs's writing, but also the town of Whitby itself. Its theatrical, artificial quality is commented on by hotel manager Robert in *Hell's Belles*:

> From here he had a wonderful view of the bay and the abbey and the higgledy-piggledy rooftops of town. The moon was shining out as if through layers of gauze. There was something theatrical and fake about the whole vista tonight. It looked like a pop-up book; a perfect feat of paper engineering, opening out darkly for his delectation. ([2009]2010: 43)

In the metaphor of the pop-up book, Magrs acknowledges the town's always-already textual quality. Its counterfeit nature is pursued still further in the third novel of the series, *Conjugal Rites*, in which Brenda and her friends journey to hell, only to discover that it is a virtually identical replica of the town, only with slightly worse weather and peopled with a carnivalesque mob of Victorians,

peasants, Vikings and zombies, a 'strange historical jamboree' ([2008]2009: 252) that resembles 'Mardi Gras, or Goth weekend', the only difference from 'every Hallowe'en in Whitby' being that 'they looked just that bit more realistic' (288). As the friends discover,

> It's not the end of it. Beneath this, there is another Whitby. And beneath that, another. Layers and layers of them, getting ever darker and darker, and further away. (326–7)

Presumably, if each layer of Whitby is more intense than the last, then the fancy-dress revellers must look 'just that bit more realistic' in each successive layer, calling into question which is the 'real' Whitby and which are the counterfeits. What is really interesting about Magrs's multiple alternative Whitbys, however, is that they trope on the town as an always already counterfeit environment, a town which is already suffused with a sense of Mardi Gras, that already hosts carnival in the shape of the biannual Goth weekend.

Whitby Goth Weekend

Whitby Goth Weekend was founded by Jo Hampshire in 1996, and currently attracts more than 1,500 attendees per event (the town has a population of around 13,000), contributing £1.1 million each year to the local economy (*BBC News* 2012). The official festival consists of gigs, club nights, the 'Bizarre Bazaar' for alternative stallholders and a charity football match, but unofficial events are also staged (including, in some years, readings at Whitby Bookshop by Paul Magrs) and many visitors simply attend for the opportunity to dress up and parade through the town. During the weekend, the town is filled not only with Goths but also with members of other subcultural groups (in particular neo-Victorians and Steampunks) and people in fancy dress, all of whom become a tourist attraction in their own right as 'mainstream' tourists enjoy the spectacle and photograph the most outlandish costumes. While participants take their clothes and music very seriously, the event also has a light-hearted side, communicated through the witty and irreverent video parodies created by participants. In 2012, 'Whitby Gothic Style', a DIY parody of Psy's global hit *Gangnam Style*, showed Goths energetically mimicking Psy's dance moves while poking fun at the mores of Goth subculture. Similarly, in 2014, Alternative Modelling's parody of The Chainsmokers' *#SELFIE* sent up the Weekend as glorified photo opportunity.

If Martin Parr's photographic essay (2014) documenting the occasion emphasized its peculiarly British bathos, with Goths drinking out of plastic pint glasses and standing awkwardly with their parents, then this did not reveal something previously hidden or unknown about the event but rather captured something of its distinctive flavour.

Drawing on the unique atmosphere of the Goth Weekend, Whitby is scripted in Magrs's novels as a site of the Gothic-Carnivalesque, a term I coined elsewhere to describe the contemporary fusion of Gothic with Mikhail Bakhtin's concepts of carnival and the grotesque body in texts like Angela Carter's *Nights at the Circus* (1984). The Gothic-carnivalesque, I argued, combines 'a wholly modern notion of the individual subject with the openness to the other found within the carnivalesque' and one of its 'most prominent features … is sympathy for the monster' (Spooner 2006: 69). In carnival, regular hierarchies are overturned, and the grotesque body prioritized over classical decorum and restraint. Brenda's errant body parts are a vivid example of the grotesque body disrupting decorum and enabling an openness to the other that positions the monster as sympathetic. In Magrs's novels, furthermore, Whitby is presented as a site in which horror is inextricably linked to laughter and un-death to renewal. In this sense, Magrs's Whitby recalls in a secular mode the medieval *danse macabre* and Stoker's 'King Laugh', as discussed in Chapter 6. In Magrs's novels, as I have already suggested, few characters die never to return, and even the wickedest demon gets a chance to reinvent itself. The morbid concerns of the Gothic are co-opted into a comic and regenerative vision, one that, as Sontag says of camp, is about enjoyment and not judgement.

Terry Eagleton emphasizes that carnival is 'a licensed affair in every sense, a permissible rupture of hegemony, a contained popular blow-off' (1981: 148). He considers that as an authorized transgression, it is ineffectual in achieving political change. In the case of Whitby, the processes of modern consumption and commodified leisure authorize its existence as a carnivalesque site – Gothic tourism has proved just as lucrative as any other kind. Indeed, Karl and Beverley Spracklen argue that the rebranding of Whitby as a 'Dracula and Goth town' and the incorporation of the Goth Weekend into official tourist discourse has resulted in a commodification of 'authentic' subcultural activity (Spracklen and Spracklen 2014: 100). Nevertheless, dismissing Whitby Goth Weekend as wholly apolitical is to ignore the twenty-first-century social context for Goth foregrounded in earlier chapters of this book, in which the subculture has been forced into a political stance through ongoing persecution. The October 2007 Whitby Goth Weekend was dedicated to the memory of Sophie Lancaster (whose

murder and its ramifications was discussed in Chapter 3), a memorial bench was positioned on the West Cliff close to the Pavilion where she had attended the festival, and fundraising events continue to be held for the Foundation. The festival's increasingly welcoming attitude to outsiders is not necessarily fuelled by a commercial imperative but rather by the promotion of tolerance and social integration. Thus the weekend fits Stallybrass and White's claim that carnival is not intrinsically radical or conservative and that 'given the presence of sharpened political antagonism, it may often act as *catalyst* and *site of actual and symbolic struggle*' (1986: 14; italics in original). In the light of Lancaster's death, the festival is more than a 'contained popular blow-off', instead offering a space in which the relationship between subculture and mainstream may publically be explored and renegotiated.

Magrs's fiction cannot easily be delimited within the framework of transgression and containment provided by Bakhtin. His evocation of carnival is too knowing, too always-already parodic – too counterfeit. In *Hell's Belles*, for example, he incorporates Goth Weekend into the plot in a further self-reflexive gesture. Penny, a late-twenty-something horror film fan seeking a new life in Whitby after the collapse of her marriage, finds in Whitby a kind of utopian space of tolerance and open-mindedness, where

> she was allowed to be herself. And here, no one looked twice if Penny dyed her hair liquorice black or painted her eyes with kohl like Dusty Springfield or Nefertiti. No one bothered if she gothed up in the daytime and wore her favourite black wedding dress even when popping down to the supermarket. ([2009]2010: 12)

Whitby is a space that enables Penny to be simultaneously performative and authentic, to 'goth up' and to 'be herself'. Within this space, the transformative potential of the Goth makeover explored in Chapter 7 is figured in hopeful and quasi-spiritual terms as a rebirth: 'Here, she was reborn, with a face of China white and boots of black rubber' (13). Magrs provides Penny with a version of the coming out narrative, in which she comes to accept and publically acknowledge her inner identity as a Goth. In this manoeuvre, Magrs points to one of the possibilities and tensions of his camp aesthetic in relation to Goth subculture. The Goth community generally presents itself as a space that is welcoming to LGBT sexualities, but is nevertheless, according to ethnographic surveys, predominantly heterosexual (Hodkinson 2002; Brill 2008). In Magrs's novels, Penny is absorbed not into a Goth community but a wider one of misfits and monsters; her experience as a Goth is presented as broadly comparable to Robert's as a gay man and Brenda's as an artificial woman. In their recognition

of each other's difference while forming a supportive network, Magrs's characters offer a template for a subcultural community united in difference in which the paramount values are playfulness, tolerance and fun.

Conclusion

If *Dracula* scripts tourism in Whitby, this is rescripted by Paul Magrs's fiction: *Hell's Belles* and *The Bride That Time Forgot* contain maps of the town with key locations marked, from the factual ('St Mary's Church and Graveyard', 'Bridge Over Harbour') to the blatantly fictional ('Brenda's B&B', 'Effie's Antiques Emporium'). Often, however, the fictional locations map back onto a very similar real place, so that the fictional Christmas Hotel coincides with the real Bay Royal Hotel, and Cod Almighty with Hadleys Fish Restaurant. While Magrs's novels have yet to generate their own walking tours, in their remapping of the town they demonstrate the porousness of the boundaries between factual and fictional spaces in the construction of Whitby as Gothic tourist site.

Magrs's carnivalesque Whitby resists the rather limited categories of 'Dark Tourism', transcending the macabre thrills of the 'Dark Fun Factories' to provide a more complex range of pleasures, akin to what Urry has called 'post-tourism', the 'delight in . . . inauthenticity' and 'pleasure in the multiplicity of tourist games' in the knowledge that 'there is no authentic tourist experience' (1990: 11). The Gothic tourist in Whitby can simultaneously enjoy the serious pleasures of the Abbey and its weighty historical past and the frothy, end-of-the-pier fun of The Dracula Experience; they can consume fish and chips and seaside rock alongside jet crucifixes and Dracula toby mugs; they can dance the night away to Alien Sex Fiend or photograph Steampunks posing in St Mary's Churchyard. Whitby offers a gleeful Gothic jamboree in which different forms of Gothic, and tourism, jumble promiscuously together.

In Whitby, the twin drives of commodified heritage and subcultural carnival function to create a space in which Gothic is celebrated as both mainstream leisure and alternative pleasure. The counterfeiting processes of Gothic narrative are not a source of anxiety but of celebration, humour and play, distilled and intensified by their location within closely defined spatial limits. As such they complicate models of so-called Dark Tourism, unsettling the critical grand narrative that associates post-millennial Gothic with anxiety and trauma to produce a more celebratory – even happy – kind of Gothic space.

Conclusion: Gothic Celebrations

At the beginning of this book I invoked British Prime Minister David Cameron's 'golden summer' of 2012, and the use of Gothic imagery in the Olympics opening and closing ceremonies. To close my analysis, I want to return to these iconic events, and in particular to the opening ceremony directed by Danny Boyle, to reflect on the way that happy Gothic – a Gothic of celebration – takes multiple forms and can be deployed in ways that speak to a national narrative. The Olympics ceremonies were widely read as representing a kind of 'state of the nation' address to the world, and were explicitly celebratory in tone, supposedly offering up the best of British culture for the consumption of a global viewing audience.

Film director Danny Boyle's spectacular, literate and often irreverent opening ceremony dramatized more than three centuries of British history, with a bucolic agrarian society giving way to Industrial Revolution and ultimately the digital age. The ceremony was watched by an estimated one billion viewers across the globe and, despite a few mumblings of bemusement concerning the cultural specificity of the references, was generally hailed by critics as a triumph for providing a narrative of Britishness that seemed to please almost everyone, from British viewers to international ones. Among the sequences to attract most comment was a protracted celebration of Britain's National Health Service in conjunction with the British tradition of classic children's literature, in which children's author J. K. Rowling read aloud from J. M Barrie's *Peter Pan*, and children and staff from Great Ormond Street Hospital danced around hospital beds while menaced by giant puppets representing some of the iconic villains of children's literature: Cruella de Vil, the Child-Catcher, Voldemort. The nightmarish figures were eventually banished by flights of Mary Poppinses descending from the sky with their umbrellas, while the hospital staff birthed a giant baby.

The sequence proved one of the most controversial of the whole ceremony, with viewers quick to make political interpretations, and one Conservative MP vilified for speaking against it. International viewers also purportedly found it one of the more perplexing parts of the ceremony. One of the most striking things about it, however, was its use of Gothic imagery. The nightmarish visions conjured by giant puppets presented children's literature as a particularly dark tradition, but one in which fears could be indulged then banished. It was a peculiarly complex moment. Gothic was conjured as part of the British national narrative, and yet contained by its designation as 'children's' literature. At the same time, Gothic was used as a vehicle for a political message. The image of Cruella and Voldemort threatening the good staff of the NHS was widely read as either the ghost of former prime minister Margaret Thatcher, or a comment on the present Conservative government's controversial plans for the NHS. Gothic was both co-opted into the celebration of Britishness, as integral to Boyle's vision of the country's national identity as cricket on the village green or Sir Kenneth Branagh declaiming Shakespeare, yet was also used as a vehicle for covert critique.

At first glance, Boyle's sequence appears to confirm the contemporary critical grand narrative of Gothic as a medium through which social anxiety is coded and expressed. This superficial reading is at odds, however, with the way in which both the ceremony in general and this particular sequence was conceived, promoted and received as explicitly celebratory. The sequence was evidently not expected to induce genuine fear in viewers either at the stadium or watching the live broadcast. It did not bring to light repressed fears but used Gothic metaphorically, as a vehicle for a piece of teasing political protest that was readily decoded by commentators. Its tone was playful, nostalgic, irreverent and sentimental. Above all, it demonstrated that a Gothic of celebration and visual spectacle need not be apolitical and could be articulated in the most global of arenas.

This book has argued for a distinctive shift in Gothic sensibilities since the late 1990s, a shift that it calls happy Gothic. It understands this shift in the context of the changing representation of Goth subculture in the popular media. My reading has been governed by an acknowledgement of the increasing significance of Goth subculture as a historical context for Gothic. Scholars may distinguish between 'Goth' and 'Gothic' but the general public does not: Goth style has come to form a kind of shorthand for Gothic and is understood as such in popular cultural texts. Goth can no longer be viewed as merely an offshoot of the literary and cinematic Gothic or as a separate, if related, phenomenon. Goth now affects the *production* of Gothic texts, many of which are influenced by its aesthetic or address it as an audience. The predominantly *visual* nature of

Goth and its spectacular style, alongside its emphasis on Gothic as lifestyle, have influenced a new mode of Gothic in which visual aesthetics are prioritized over narrative. In Chapter 2, I argued for the ascendance of a visual Gothic identified by a number of stylistic features that can be found in historic works but also, *par excellence*, in the films of Tim Burton. Burton and the Burtonesque have been instrumental in the development of twenty-first-century Gothic as a visual form. In films such as Tim Burton's *Dark Shadows* or Guillermo del Toro's *Crimson Peak*, the script is of less importance than the language of production design and costume.

I have evoked both the Columbine school shootings and the murder of Sophie Lancaster as watershed events that shifted the perception of Goth in the public eye, and forced the subculture to define itself in a public arena in a way that many of its participants would not have invited. Both of these events solicited artistic responses that I have not considered here. Columbine was fictionalized in three novels and one film from 2003: Lionel Shriver's *We Need to Talk about Kevin*, DBC Pierre's *Vernon God Little*, Douglas Coupland's *Hey Nostradamus!* and Gus Van Sant's *Elephant*. Sophie Lancaster's death was explored in Simon Armitage's poem *Black Roses: The Killing of Sophie Lancaster*, dramatized on radio (2011), stage (2012) and television (2015). These responses, with the obvious exception of Armitage, did not depict their protagonists as Goth and, with the partial exception of Shriver whose novel could be read as an oblique rewriting of *Frankenstein*, did not engage with Gothic narrative tropes. These texts were governed by themes of grief, mourning, responsibility, memorialization and attempts to come to terms with trauma and the legacy of violence. Many of them explicitly tried to understand the motivations of the human beings – both villains and victims – behind the news stories. Armitage's poem, for example, was intercut in performance with extracts from an interview with Sophie's mother Sylvia, and thus sought to restore individuality to Sophie, a girl who had become an emblem of her community. In light of the suffering experienced by the victims of these events and their families, my attempt to suggest that Gothic texts responded to these horrors with a comic and romantic turn may seem frivolous or inappropriate. However, my intention is wholly otherwise. Rather, I intend to show that cultural materials that superficially appear to be light and frothy may have a serious purpose, and that celebration may itself be a political stance. In *The Mighty Boosh* or in Paul Magrs's *Brenda and Effie* novels, radical new spaces are imagined in which the absence of the 'normal' makes for the possibility of uniquely fluid identities based not in otherness but in the celebration of multiple differences. The assimilative monster stands for social inclusion and

as such we cannot be too nostalgic for the days before subcultures were assimilated by the mainstream or monsters' otherness was unadulterated by our sympathy: the sympathetic vampire (or werewolf, or zombie) is a direct result of the gains in feminism, civil rights and gay liberation since the 1960s and tolerance of alternative lifestyle choice is an extension of that process.

In defining this new Gothic as happy, I do not seek to homogenize a very diverse range of texts. Rather, I seek to suggest that the long-standing associations between Gothic and comedy and romance have become foregrounded with the effect of producing texts that recognizably engage with Gothic themes and/or visual style, but do so with a sense of lightness, playfulness, comfort, joy or even euphoria. There is more than one kind of happiness, just as there is more than one kind of Gothic. What unites the majority of my examples, however, is a sense of celebration. This celebratory attitude is reflected in and cued by a visible public culture of enjoyment of Gothic texts. The Gothic exhibitions and festivals and film seasons and academic conferences that have proliferated since the millennium are not gloomy affairs: they are full of fun and entertainment. Participants unite to celebrate the genre that they love.

This book has been mainly focused on British and American culture, with very brief excursions to Australasia and Japan. Happy Gothic exists within a global culture, however, and the meanings and affects it takes on in international contexts have yet to be uncovered. *Dia de los Muertos* or the Mexican Day of the Dead has been widely appropriated by European and American culture since the millennium and its grinning, candy-coloured sugar skulls and cheerfully capering skeletons have become thoroughly incorporated into the iconography of happy Gothic. This has been controversial, as Goths who wear sugar skull make-up to Western festivals have been accused of cultural appropriation: of cherry-picking imagery associated with a marginalized culture without paying attention to the authentic culture, or spiritual beliefs, behind it. In Mexican culture, spirits of the dead are not necessarily frightening but can be helpful or benevolent. An analysis of happy Gothic in the context of magic realism and the growing prominence of Latino culture in the United States is beyond the scope of this book, but would be a fascinating enterprise.

There are other kinds of Gothic, too, that I have had to leave out for reasons of space. There is a strand of neo-Victorian Gothic that employs many of the strategies I have described in this book, exemplified in fast-and-loose re-imaginings of canonical Victorian Gothic texts such as Guy Ritchie's *Sherlock Holmes* films (2009, 2011) or the television series *Penny Dreadful* (2014–). This is developed in further interesting ways in the Gothic/science fiction hybrid of Steampunk,

a literary mode that is also a subculture in its own right although closely related to Goth. These texts tend to eschew readings of Victorian Gothic as expressive of cultural anxiety, and propose instead a revisionary romp through the stock characters and narrative conventions of the day. Neo-Victoriana, however, is a broad and complex field and I have left this exploration for another occasion.

Finally, I do not want to give the erroneous impression that I think that the Gothic of trauma, social conscience, sublimity and terror has diminished, or that criticism of Gothic in those terms is redundant. Those kinds of Gothic are alive and well, and may be particularly important when reading Gothic in the context of post-colonialism, globalization and the formation of national identities. My point is that they are not the only kind of Gothic, and that the way that *alternative* forms of Gothic have been side-lined or excluded deserves investigation. This opens up larger questions about the way that cultural value is attributed and how that relates to the demands of the contemporary academy. The cultural valuation of Gothic has always been about taste, and as such reflects the ways that groups or individuals create and narrate distinctions and hierarchies between themselves and other sections of society. In the materials I have explored in this book, this process is accentuated. The Gothic counter-narrative I have identified is one in which the tastes of women, children, teenagers, queer and subcultural communities are of particular significance, and put the term Gothic to work in new and sometimes unexpected ways. Above all, paying attention to these neglected or derided texts provides an opportunity to investigate what is at stake when we talk about Gothic.

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